Break A Leg (And Break The Bed)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27286579.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Juliet (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Celebrity, Stuntpeople, Rivals to Lovers, Rivals With Benefits, Hurt/Comfort, Fluff and Smut, Emotional Slow Burn, Is that a thing? It's a thing now, Disaster Lesbians, Hookups, Human Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Bad Humor, POV Alternating, Sexual Tension, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Angst with a Happy Ending

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English

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Part 1 of Stunt Fuckery

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by DandyVela

Summary

After months of unemployment, Catra finally gets a role in a seqel of a popular action movie. It's just her luck that in her very first scene, she is paired with Adora, the most annoying girl in the entire industry.
Things only go downhill from there.

"Meet me at the cafe tomorrow at four. We're gonna need to set some ground rules for… whatever this is. And before you get your hopes up, it's not a-"
"Not a date," Adora said with a crooked smirk. "Don't worry. I had no intentions of dating you."
Catra turned the doorknob.
"Good, because this is just fucking. And that is a rule."
"Wait."
Catra opened the door but stayed put, waiting.
"Your name," Adora said. "Will you tell me now?"
Catra did.
She saw Adora's smile before she stepped out and pulled the door closed behind herself.

Notes

1. No one knows about us.

See the end of the work for more notes

Rule #1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra puts her earbuds in, music blasting from her phone. She blinks sleepily, resting the nape of her neck on the headrest of a raggedy-ass SUV, kicking her boots off and pulling her feet up onto the seat.

They are driving East, the auroral sun burning on her closed eyelids. She pulled the visor down but there's no use, the sun is crawling too low on the horizon.

She forgot her aviators at home, obviously.

Scorpia keeps talking to her from the driver's seat - or keeps talking, at least, whether Catra pays attention to her or not. All Catra needs to do is hum sometimes to keep the conversation going, while she slowly but steadily drops back to sleep.

She is awakened by a heavy bass solo and the light breeze that breaks through the crack of the rolled-down window by Catra's head.

Catra grumbles and pulls an earbud out, narrow eyes staring straight ahead.

"Where are we?" she asks raspily.

"Almost there," Scorpia says, maddeningly joyous as ever.

Catra will never understand how Scorpia can be so enthusiastic about early hours. Waking up at four or five AM is what Catra hates most about her job - even more than bitchy colleagues and asshole directors.

Catra lets one of her earbuds hang down, keeping the other in her ear. They have already left the highway, driving on an empty service road slithering towards the studio complex. Catra had never been to this specific outlet of the industry - her previous jobs were smaller, and took fewer days to shoot. She landed a pretty big gig with this one, although it didn't truly come free.

Which she desperately needed after she was not called back for anything for the last five months; the reason for Scorpia driving her too is not just the fact that Catra cannot be trusted behind a wheel before 11 AM, but that she couldnt pay for her own car's insurance yet.

Scorpia turns to the gates and introduces them both, handing their IDs to the security guard. The guy leans down to the window and eyes them up both, glancing between them and their plastic selves like he is watching a tennis match.

"Do you need glasses, big guy?" Catra drawls sweetly. She reads his name tag and snorts, her voice growing weak with suppressed laughter. "Sorry , *Tung*. Cool name. Your mom must love you."

Scorpia shoots the guard an awkward grin. He just grunts, which makes his face even redder if that is even possible, and gives the IDs back with two CREW cards hanging on simple black strings.

"Second building from the left," he growls and lifts the bar .

Scorpia thanks him immensely, and rolls back the window quickly . Catra lets her laughter roar, and despite her embarrassment, Scorpia joins in.

"I should've said something like, *cat got your Tung*?" Scorpia adds in a tone that would clearly need some ba-dum tss in the end.

Catra lets the pun slide, only rolling her eyes. She owes Scorpia too much to make fun of her now.

Scorpia parks the SUV in the shade. Catra staggers out of it, pushing the door closed. The hinges creak and the whole car shakes as Scorpia gets out too, and the driver's door practically falls off.

"Oh, shoot," Scorpia mumbles, holding the broken door with both hands. "It's fine. It's fine. I can put it back. Uhh. Here?" Scorpia tries to fit the door back to its place reluctantly. "No, not like that. Like this? Nope-"

Catra growls and crashes down onto the hood.

"Why won't you get rid of this piece of junk already?"

"I can't, Wildcat," Scorpia objects loudly. "She's been passed down to generations in my family!"

"Exactly . *Generations*. It's a miracle it didn't break apart under us."

"Aha!" Scorpia managed to attach the door back to its place, and she grins brightly as she straightens and dries her forehead with the back of her hand.

Catra knows she lost.

"Great. Can we go in already?"

"Lead the way!"

The entrance hall is packed to the rim with other stunt performers, background actors, extras and supporting cast members, a forever swirling and chatting crowd.

Catra makes a beeline for the side, as close to the front row as she can. Scorpia is following on her tail, cheerfully saying "*excuse me*" and "*sorry*" even when Catra does the nudging and she doesn't even touch anyone. Right when Catra halts, a woman comes up to a little

podium with a mic attached to her cheek, holding a thin white tablet that she scans through.

The woman doesn't look up to them as she says, her voice shushing the crowd:

"Welcome to the first day of shooting *Crimson Waste II*. I'm your Production Assistant. Call me Juliet. Those who were assigned a trailer can check in with me after the briefing and I'll direct you to your numbers. Now, the first ones to head to wardrobe from background are-"

Catra stops paying attention. It is still so fucking early and some assholes on the other side of the front row keep whispering and laughing quietly by themselves, with only one shaky voice shushing them. They are trying not to choke on their own chuckles.

A moment later she feels Scorpia's elbow digging into her side, whispering:

"That's you, Wildcat."

Catra looks up at Juliet and yawns. Juliet goes on:

"...paired with Adora Grayskull."

Catra scoffs loudly. It echoes from the tall, hangar-like walls.

Oh *fuck* no.

Catra steps forward and heads towards the wardrobe. Her *partner* rises from the other side, exposing herself as being one of the whisper-laughing people. Obviously.

Their eyes meet as Catra passes her. Adora follows suit hurriedly, her shoes squeaking on the floor .

Catra feels a smirk crawling on her face as she picks the pace up, not quite going for a jog but fueled by determination to lead.

"Hey , Adora."

"Catra," Adora says. Her voice is full of strength and something else, probably frustration as she walks right next to her.

"Don't sound so happy to see me," Catra teases and puts her hands into the pockets of her leather jacket. "Looks like you're not the only one who can land a gig."

"I didn't know you were gonna be here," Adora says firmly. She sounds almost offended.

"Yeah, well" Catra sighs, "turns out they needed a kickass girl for the assassin role."

Adora stumbles on nothing. Catra's smirk draws wider, especially when Adora's voice grows higher.

"You have lines?"

"Mm-hm."

"Well, I would have known before if you were at the table read."

Okay, that's a blow. Catra furrows her eyebrows but keeps going, forcing her voice to stay cool.

"You too?"

"I guess that's why we're a pair." Adora is smiling, Catra can sense it in her voice without having to look at her. "I'm the main lead's bodyguard."

"Of course you are. Always playing the good guy , aren't you?"

"It's not like we have a choice, you know that,"Adora snaps.

"Right, you just have one of those faces." Catra pauses. "And I'm not going to waste an entire day of table read for three lines."

Adora hums. Catra squints at her; Adora raises her eyebrows, cheeks round from a smug little grin.

"What?"

Adora leans in and links her arms behind her back.

"I have four ."

They reach a heavy black door. Catra halts and spins on her heels, raising her arms courteously. Adora scoffs but steps inside first, Catra following.

Catra is escorted away and dressed in tight leather leggings, combat boots, and a carmine tube top under a biker jacket. Once she is done, she has to take a seat right next to Adora again, now wearing a simple black pantsuit and a white shirt. Typical lame bodyguard costume;all business, no substance. It suits her .

The mirror they are seated in front of them is covering the whole wall, so Catra allows herself to sneak a peek at Adora.

Catra hasn't seen her in months, but not much has changed. She has known Adora for three years now, from a casting Catra didnt even want to be at.

She's hated Adora Grayskull from day one.

Everything about her is annoying. She is nothing but a boring blend of obedience and fake good-heartedness, a stick-up-her-ass goody two shoes who is always on time, always the first to go, always taking every punch thrown her way like she enjoys being a martyr .

Catra sees right through her. Adora is easily frustrated, a hotheaded, anxious mess. She wants to be the best at everything and is just as competitive as Catra is; she can be so full of herself, so smug and downright unabashed. Her jokes are terrible, her hair poof is stupid,

she always says the dumbest fucking things and she can be so clumsy which, given their professions, is *insane*

The most annoying thing about her is that she is too hot for words.

Adora catches her staring and quirks a brow. The reflection of her cloudy blue eyes burns Catra's chest, and she tears her gaze away.

"Adora!" A voice calls and a short girl appears behind them. "Long time no see!"

Catra recognizes her as well. She is quick to greet the newcomer first:

"Hi, Glitter."

"Gli*mmer*," the girl spits but ignores Catra further. She goes to work on Adora's hair and makeup, demolishing her hair poof so fast like she had been dreaming of destroying it for a while. "How have you been?"

"Did you get shorter?" Catra cuts in as an artist touches her up as well, combing her untamed hair back from her forehead.

"Did you get lamer?" Glimmer snaps back, raking through her makeup box angrily.

"Wow, what an insult. I am devastated."

"I can make you so ugly you won't recognize yourself on screen."

Catra leans back on the chair, humming.

"Good luck, I can pull off anything."

"I'm good," Adora chimes in frantically, trying to put a stop to the fun. Asshole. "How are you?"

"I've been better," Glimmer grunts, shooting a killer glare towards Catra. "But it's all good. Business is business as usual. And I'm glad to work with you again. We totally have to hang out later! I'll tell Bow."

"I'd like that," Adora says. Her voice is so gentle and quiet now; she's never talked to Catra like that. "I missed you two."

Glimmer gives Adora a quick hug from behind. Catra makes a loud retching noise, trying to dissolve the bile in her throat.

"You know, I *really* hope you break a leg," Glimmer hisses.

Adora whimpers miserably.

Things are starting to get fun.

*

Catra sprints as fast as she can, Adora following right behind her.

Explosion roars behind them from the speakers, and the machine tugs on Catra's harness. She's pulled into the air and left to fall while Adora's harness aims her to crash into Catra mid-air.

Adora curls her arms around her protectively and Catra's breath hitches. This wasn't scripted; it feels almost instinctive as she turns towards Adora in her arms and plops down onto the huge mattress laid out under her.

Adora puts a hand out, trying not to crash into Catra. She lands on top of her anyway, her face in the crook of Catra's neck. Her ridiculously muscled body is squeezing the air out of Catra's lungs and covers her fully, pressing her deeper into the rippling mattress.

Catra's chest is heaving, her insides burning.

"Cut!"

Catra shoves Adora away and staggers to her feet. It took them five takes to get the timing right, and now Adora fucks it up with whatever that improv was, just to show off.

Catra climbs off the mattress. She mentally prepares herself to do four other takes of this, probably, thanks to her idiot partner.

Adora steps right next to her, her body radiating warmth. Catra crosses her arms and glances at her now without moving her head; she knows her expression is hidden behind the face shield of the motorcycle helmet. Adora is scanning Catra's body, cloudy eyes clearing up after she has taken it all in, a faint smile tugging at the corners of her lips. She doesn't seem to realize that Catra is looking at her behind the shades.

"Are we done?" Catra asks the director loudly. It makes Adora wince and clear her throat.

The director - also screenwriter, and lead actor, number one diva, the world's worst ex, and fuck knows what else at this point - takes off their headphones. They twirl it around their index finger and tilt their hips to the side.

"Almost," they drawl. "I've just seen something… truly inspiring as I watched the tape back. Something *enthralling.*"

"Cut the crap, Dee," Catra growls and takes her helmet off. She puts it under her armpit and combs through her sweaty hair with her free hand.

"Easy, kitten. We're playing by my rules now."

Catra feels Adora grow tense next to her. Catra holds the helmet tighter with her bicep but stays quiet. They might have started off in

the industry as equals, but Dee's career skyrocketed pretty fast and they gave no shit about Catra anymore.

Not like it matters. It's *fine.* She's over them. She just wants to grab that long mop of bleached hair and tear it off of their head, or use it to shove that sharp face into a metal table repeatedly-

"So," Dee says and saunters closer, hands on their hips. "Who's your new girlfriend, again?"

Catra's laugh cuts like a knife.

"She's not my girlfriend. And she can introduce herself."

But Adora doesn't. She says nothing, actually; her body is still tense, her hands balled into fists.

Catra pokes her between the ribs.

"*Adora*."

Adora jerks.

"Yes, ma'am," she blurts and salutes. "Sir. Mx Director." Her face is burning pink, her voice weak. She buries her face into her palm. "Sorry."

Dee squints at her, showing their sharp smile.

"Aren't you a doll," they coo, and eye Adora up and down. They add, lowering their voice: "More like an action figure, I guess. Adora, was it?"

She nods.

"Adora, please tell me what inspired your touching impromptu to protect her?"

Adora licks her lips. She opens and closes her mouth, gaping like a stupid fish. Catra wants to claw her own face off.

"I'll tell you why, because she wants everyone to know she's the best," Catra says in a blank tone. "There, I figured it out for you."

"That's not why!" Adora practically shrieks, trying to tower over Catra. So she can find her voice immediately when she needs it to fight Catra. Cute.

"Oh, please. You can't go five takes without showing off, can you?"

"And you can't go five takes without insulting someone. Do you have to be so rude all the time?"

"I'm so sorry, Princess, did I offend you with pointing out your *gigantic* hero complex that's somehow even bigger than your forehead?"

"I'm not asking to be *psychoanalyzed* by stubborn brats like you."

"You don't have to. I'm doing it all for free. See, I can be nice."

"You're such a pain in the ass-"

"That's not me, that's the stick you left there."

Someone's clapping. Adora bites her words back, and her head snaps towards the sound just like Catra's. Dee is still there, slow clapping for them with the most disturbing expression Catra has ever seen on them.

"Alright, thank you both so much," they say suavely. "You have given me a lot to think about. See you both tomorrow."

Adora storms off without a word, stomping like a kid throwing a tantrum.

Catra meets Dee's eyes for one last time - dark and unsettling, as usual -, then leaves as well.

She walks in the opposite direction from Adora.

*

Catra is lounging around the cafeteria. It is still early for lunch so the area is pleasantly empty and airy, only a couple people loitering around in small groups.

Catra plops down onto a plastic chair, spreading her legs and leaning her elbows on her knees. She gets her phone out of her pocket on the way and taps on Scorpia's contact.

scorpia

i'm done for today. you?

Sorry Wildcat, I'm still in MUAH**!** 😬😬

Someone was verrrrry late so I'm still gonna be here a couple hours**!**

Just one scene for today tho ;))

ok, text me when you're done.

Will do!?

Catra sighs and puts her phone away. Well if she is stuck for hours, she might as well use her time wisely - with free food.

Catra circles the long tables packed full - trays of pasta and meat and steamed veggies, pots of soup and sauces. She makes a beeline for the coffee machine, pouring herself a huge cup. She throws her head back and gulps down the whole thing like a shot.

"You're Catra, right?"

Catra turns towards the voice and dries her mouth with the back of her hand. It's the PA again, rustling through a huge pile of papers clipped together.

Catra pours herself another cup of coffee.

"Yeah."

"You've got a trailer assigned to you. Sign this, and I'll give you the keys."

Catra's eyes widen. Her nails clink on the cup as she puts it down and smoothes the contract down onto the table as well, leaning on her elbows.

"Pen,"Juliet says, holding her hand out.

Catra takes the pen from her and signs her name above the line. She curls the end of the last *r* when she notices something suspicious at the beginning of the thick chunks of text.

Why the fuck does she never read contracts-

She straightens and flops the paper in front of the PA's face.

"Wait, this says it's a two-person trailer?"

"Yeah."

Juliet doesn't elaborate, taking the contract from Catra and sliding it between the others. She throws a tiny key in the air, expecting Catra to catch it. She turns on her heels then, looking for the owner of the next trailer.

"Who am I sharing it with?" Catra calls after her, suspicion creeping in.

The PA doesn't even look back.

"I haven't gotten to them yet. Ask Dee if you want to know."

Catra does want to know. She really fucking does, because she doesn't *share a place* with anyone, not since the second she could help it - and especially not after what happened during shooting today.

Catra leaves her second cup of coffee on the table and snatches a blueberry muffin from the nearest tray, biting off half of it.

She starts running.

*

Catra finds Dee twenty minutes later, working at a different location. Scorpia is there as well, hanging from a brick wall with one hand, green screen drawn behind her. She waves Catra enthusiastically with her other hand.

"Hi, Wildcat!" She roars. "Did you come to see me in action?"

Catra waves back, raising her voice as well.

"Looking good up there, big gal."

Dee turns around in their Director's chair, their toothy grin is all too knowing. Catra doesn't have to say anything for them to call for a break and rise from the chair as the bell rings for five minutes.

Catra turns on her heel and leads them into a dark corner further away from the spotlights. Catra hops over a bunch of wires, Dee's high heels knocking loudly and languidly behind her.

Catra turns towards them, raising her jaw.

"What are you playing at?" She hisses.

Dee shifts and crosses their arms, tilting their head slightly. They have enough courage in them to spare Catra the "I don't know what you're talking about" speech.

"Changing the script a little bit. Thanks to you and your girlfriend, I found a better direction to take your characters to."

Catra cannot control her voice anymore.

"Stop calling her my girlfriend! I hate that girl."

Dee narrows their eyes. They are gleaming with sadistic joy.

"But you're sleeping with her, aren't you?"

"That's none of your fucking business."

They chuckle deeply.

"Oh, that's a *yes* loud and clear."

"You don't know shit, Dee. What do you want to get from this, exactly?"

"Shouldn't you ask what *you* can get from this instead?" Dee steps over the wires as well. Catra takes a couple steps back but they keep drawing near, cornering her into a wall. Shadows creep on half of their figure, keeping Catra in the dark. Their teeth are shining as they talk, their voice silky. "Don't you want a bigger role? More lines, more money, more fame? Don't you like having your own trailer after three years of jumping out of burning cars and calling it *acting*?"

"It's not my own, is it," Catra grunts through gritted teeth. "You're gonna lock me up with Adora to get more of that… whatever *tension* that seems to get you off-"

Dee scoffs.

"I know, I know, you see right through my evil plan, congratulations." They lick their lips, closing the distance between them again. Catra doesn't break eye contact as Dee leans on a hand next to Catra's head and raises a shaved brow: "What about Adora?"

Catra sets her jaw, her fingers twitching.

"What about her?"

"Will she see through it?"

Adora Grayskull? Seeing through anything that's not as clear as a glass window? Catra swallows back a laugh.

"No."

Dee's free hand comes up to cup Catra's chin. Their sharp nails are digging into her skin, turning her face.

"Then we won't tell her."

Catra slaps their hand away. Every fiber of her body is pulsing with rage, hairs standing up in her arms.

Her voice is quiet again, shaking as she is trying to keep her anger deep down.

"You may be my boss now, but you don't get to tell me what I can and can't say. You don't control me."

"So eager to protect her already, aren't you?" Dee straightens, stroking their collarbone with their fingertips.

Catra reassures them again, emphasizing strongly:

"I don't give a fuck about Adora."

Dee smacks their lips and lets their hand fall from their chest.

"It seems to me that you already know what you should do. I'm giving you everything you've been working for, and you know that I can take it all away if you don't play nicely. If this is not what you really want, feel free to walk away. How hard do you think it will be to find a replacement for your original stunt role?"

Catra swallows thickly.

"That's what I thought," Dee says, and they finally step back into the light. "Work with me here, Kitten, and I'll help you get everything you've been dreaming of. Toodles."

They turn on their heel, facing away, so Catra exhales with a deep sigh she didn't know she kept in her lungs.

Her skin itches uncomfortably.

She needs to hit something, and settles for the wall behind her to punch.

She walks back to the cafeteria, even though she has lost her appetite; the lonely blueberry muffin is rocking inside her upset stomach like a ship in a storm.

*

Scorpia texts her soon after, and they meet outside after they have both changed back into their own clothes. The sun is hanging high from the sky now, shadows reaching far on the asphalt.

Catra doesnt have the heart to tell Scorpia so soon into their conversation - not when Scorpia is chattering enthusiastically about some girl she met.

They are already halfway through the drive to Catra's apartment when Catra leans on the window with her elbow, ruffling through her curls.

She blurts out:

"Scorpia, I have a favor to ask you."

"Okay , anything,"Socrpia replies immediately . "What do you need?"

"Can you take me back to set?"

"Like, what, right now?"

"No, after I can pack my stuf f at home. I'll..I'll stay at a trailer ."

"Oh wow! Really?" Scorpia whistles appreciatively. "That' s amazing, Wildcat!I knew you had it in you to charm everyone on day one!"

"It' s not that fun, actually," Catra grumbles. "Dee's just fucking with me whenever they can."

Scorpia keeps quiet for a while, waiting for Catra to elaborate. When she doesn't, Scorpia presses on gently, eyes on the road:

"What happened?"

"*Ugh*, nothing, just-" Catra scrunches her nose and buries her face into her palm. She hates how weak her voice sounds. "I'm sharing it with Adora."

Scorpia's foot slips on the pedal. The SUV buckles violently, Catra's elbow drops off the window, her forehead almost slamming into the glove compartment.

"Hey!"

"Sorry, sorry-" Scorpia clears her throat and peeks at Catra from the corner of her eye. "...Adora Grayskull?"

"Do you know any other Adoras?"

"Well, no, but-" Scorpia is clearly struggling to find the right - *safe* - words to say in the situation. "Why would Dee do that on purpose?"

"I don't know," Catra grumbles and sinks lower in her seat, deeming the conversation over and done.

She's not fucking stupid. She isn't planning on ever telling Scorpia Dee's real reasons behind their actions, yet alone Catra's own. Scorpia is a wonderful support but she can't keep her big mouth shut and she certainly wouldn't agree with Catra playing Dee's game. All she knows about Catra and Adora is that they hate each other, and take every chance to get into a fight. That's more than enough.

Being judged and told off by Scorpia, of all people, is the last thing she needs right now.

"Well, I'm sure it's not going to be that bad," Scorpia assures her then, her cheerful tone only breaking once. Catra appreciates that.

"Yeah," Catra says, crossing her arms. "Not that bad."

Fucking hell, it sounds *so* fake coming from her own mouth. She feels hysterical laughter bubbling in her lungs, ready to burst.

It takes all her remaining strength to keep it contained.

*

Scorpia helps her pack, get back, find the right trailer in the park, unpack, and keeps Catra busy. The solution is only temporary; all too soon, it is time for Scorpia to leave her alone and drive back to the city again before sunset.

Scorpia wraps Catra in a bone-cracking hug, lifting her petite body off the floor.

"Take care, Wildcat," she whines into Catra's hair, cradling her in the air.

Catra's grunts are muffled, her whole face squished into Scorpia's chest.

"Scorpia, I'm just gonna spend some nights with the most annoying girl on the entire planet, not going to war."

"Does it really make a difference to you?"

Wow, fuck. When did Scorpia get so good at reading her?

Catra pats Scorpia's shoulders, and she is gently placed back down on her feet. There are tears gleaming in Scorpia's sad eyes.

Catra smiles as fondly as she can right now.

"It' s gonna be fine, okay?"

"T ext me whenever you need," Scorpia says. "Or call. Or FaceTime. Write a letter, send it with pigeon-post. Or beep?"

"Where the fuck would I get a pigeon? Or a pager , for that matter."

"I dont know!" Scorpia whines. "I'm running out of options!"

"Okay , dude, you need to leave," Catra says, and softly turns Scorpia around, pushing her out of the trailer. "I'm gonna be fine."

Scorpia drags her body down the couple metal steps, turning back right as she steps off. Her lips part.

"I *know* ." Catra raises a hand. "I'll find a pigeon, catch it, train it and send you a strongly worded letter about how much of a dumbass Adora is."

Scorpia finally smiles, although it's faint and still a touch sad. Catra grabs the doorknob.

"See you on Wednesday," Scorpia says. "Or I can check in tomorrow too, if-"

"W ednesday sounds good." Catra pushes the door halfway closed. "Drive safe, okay? Don't freak out. Even more."

"Sleep well!" Scorpia calls through the crack, and Catra replies qietly , shutting the door.

"Y ou too."

Catra leans her back to the door, taking a deep breath that strains her lungs. Her heart is beating fast, drumming on her ribs and in her ears.

She needs to fucking calm down.

Once she is alone, Catra locks the door. She has half a mind to leave the key in the lock, but that would be low, even for her. Something tells her that after everything that happened between Adora and her today, she wouldnt take it as a lighthearted joke.

Catra is circling 'round the narrow space of the trailer. It's not much, not like she expected it to be - an ugly couch, the tiniest table hanging out of the wall with two seats on the opposing sides, a small bathroom and a cupboard over a sink that dares to call itself a kitchen. The two-person in the name calls for a bunk bed, which is probably the only exciting thing about the whole shit.

Catra grabs her backpack and throws it on the top bed. Losers weepers, fucker.

She wishes her heart would stop pit-patting, is all, because it still makes her whole body shiver. She rubs her palms with her fingers, her skin slippery with sweat. She stomps to the window above the table, trying to tear it open. It's stuck.

Catra braces herself with her foot on the wall, grunting desperately as she pulls the lock, her knuckles whitening.

She howls:

"Fo for fuck sa-"

The door is jngling. Catra' s hands slip off the sash lock, nearly losing balance but she manages to keep standing. The small of her back is pressing to the tabletop, her hands clutching it as she stares at the opening door.

Adora struggles with pulling a carry-on suitcase up the stairs, a duffel bag hanging from her shoulder. Her ponytail comes half undone and her cheeks are gleaming and flushed. Her tight jeans are practically

ripping off her muscles, her shirt emphasizes the movement of every curve as her chest is heaving.

Adora's eyes find Catra's as soon as she steps inside the trailer, and from that moment, they never leave hers again. Not when Adora slams the door loudly, not when she pushes the straps of her duffel off her shoulder, letting it lump down onto the floor. Especially not when she curls her hand into a fist and leaps towards Catra, a determined flare flickering in her eyes.

Catra comes forward as well, meeting Adora halfway. Her hands slide up to Adora's broad shoulders right when Adora grabs her thighs and scoops her up as Catra jumps.

Their lips crash.

Catra moans and opens her mouth, demanding. Adora deepens the kiss messily and tugs Catra higher on her hips. The friction leaves them both breathless, just like the kiss neither of them cares about breaking yet.

Catra tastes Adora hungrily, nails deep in her hair, pulling her ponytail loose. She presses as close as she possibly can and rocks her hips forward.

Adora grunts, low and deep; Catra can feel the rumble in her chest. Adora's knees buckle and she lets Catra's thigh go with one hand to slam it behind her, keeping steady.

Catra smirks and licks into Adora's mouth before she traps her lower lip between her teeth. She peeks up at Adora's face - she looks ruined already, her cheeks so flushed and her brows knitted, eyelashes fluttering.

Catra draws back and Adora opens her eyes, her pupils blown out. Catra kisses her again, peppering her mouth with little pecks, her hands roaming up and down her chest, urging Adora to hurry up already.

Instead, Adora mumbles into the kiss as soon as she is able to breathe:

"I can't believe we're stuck here together ."

"Stop talking," Catra reminds her, throwing her arms around Adora's neck again. Her throat is dry.

"Right, right."

Adora kisses her now, turning on her heels to press Catra into the wall. Catra gasps into Adora's mouth as her back hits the door, the trailer shaking at the impact. Adora uses her hips to keep Catra in place, grinding against her rough and desperate through their clothes, her teeth sinking into Catra's neck right where she likes it. Catra's eyes fall shut. She unlaces her arms from around Adora's neck to take a fistful of Adora's hair and her shirt, pulling them both.

Adora takes both of Catra's wrist in her grip, pinning them above her head with one hand, her other hand crumples up Catra's top. Adora's palm warm on her exposed skin, crawling higher to squeeze her breast under the bra. Then, she pushes herself away to tear her shirt off and shove it into a corner, finally giving Catra what she was asking for.

She wears nothing underneath, captivating Catra's gaze. Her hands jerk to feel, to touch as Adora's grip captures them again, but she finds no release. Adora's fingers hook into Catra's ripped jeans, unbuttoning, zipping, yanking. Catra gasps and wiggles out of her jeans and bikini as much as she can, the fabrics slipping off her ass to the middle of her thighs. Adora seems to be satisfied with that much to continue; she raises a knee under Catra's ass to keep her in place and cups her between her legs.

Catra cries out at Adora's thumb circling, her lips sliding higher on Catra's throat, kissing and nipping. Adora's huffing breath is hot on her skin, just like her curious fingers stroking her .

Catra’s legs are growing weak; her heels digging into Adora’s back are slipping as her whole body melts, completely relying on Adora’s strength to keep her pinned to the door.


CRIMSON WASTE II
Shooting Schedule
7:00 -
8:30 -
9:15 -
12:30 -
14:00 -
15:45 -

Adora draws back from kissing Catra's neck to meet her eyes as her fingertips slide lower, an unspoken question clear in her eyes.

Catra nods, chewing on her lower lip.

Adora slips in. She actually *grunts*, shutting her eyes and hiding back to the crook of Catra's neck as she works her way in, knuckles deep. She doesnt wait for anything else to pull back and thrust in rough, Catra's body welcoming her with no resistance, just needy, throbbing heat, and an embarrassing whimper escaping from Catra's throat.

Adora fucks her hard, setting a frantic pace that quite literally drives Catra up the wall. She knows exactly how Catra wants it, needs it, answering her choked sobs with more bites on Catra's neck, and a firm palm clasping tighter around her wrists.

Catra is embarrassingly close. Today was the longest fucking foreplay she's ever had, and Adora's long, boney fingers fill her so good, her teeth in her skin and her tongue flat on her pulse, Catra's hands writhing in that steady grip-

Adora's lips latch to the spot right under Catra's ear, and she comes undone with rattling moans.

Catra's back arches off the door, her legs dropping down. Her knees buckle under her but Adora's fingers dig into her waist now, pulling her back up.

Catra is gasping for air but she's not going to slow down now - she fights out of Adora's grip to pull Adora's jeans and briefs all the way down. Catra shoves her own clothes down to her knees as well, and leans back to the door then, glancing down at Adora. She's already dripping, the inside of her thigh beautifully wet and shiny.

Catra throws an arm around Adora's waist and brings her back to her with a pretentious pull. Adora props on an elbow by Catra's

head. Chest to chest, forehead to forehead, they lose their breaths at the same time.

Adora paddles into a narrow sprawl and rocks her hips forward hastily, claiming Catra's thigh. She starts grinding against her hard, *slamming* Catra back into the door.

Catra swallows back a moan as Adora's wet heat coats her skin; she tries to grind back against the force when Adora draws away. Adora growls again, deeper this time, palm flat on Catra's waist to keep her down.

Her revealing reaction is gasoline to Catra's eager need to take control - Catra brings a hand between Adora's scapulas, nails in her skin. Her other hand finds a comfortable place where Adora's ass meets her thigh and urges her to move faster.

Adora fucks herself on Catra's thigh with frantic little thrusts, dragging Catra's hips down so she finds much better friction on her sharp pelvic bone. Their foreheads are still pressed together; Catra loses herself at the sight of Adora's rosy lips and swallows every miserable, high *ah* spilling from her throat. Those wet gasps are like daggers stabbing and twisting into Catra's insides, her heart thrumming louder than thunder in her ears.

Catra digs all ten nails into Adora's shoulders. Adora's feverish rhythm doesn't fade as their eyes meet - Catra scratches down on her back hard, spilling beads of blood in their rouge paths.

Adora comes with a scream so high she can barely articulate it, her whole body tensing up in qivering spasms of pleasure. Adora is riding them out, whimpering, still grinding to Catra's hip, blue eyes drilling into Catra's.

And then, Adora halts and everything stills.

Heavy silence pours over them, broken by their loud breathing. Curls of Catra's long bangs are fluttering in front of her face as she

exhales. Adora takes a careful step back, fingers twitching as she lets her arms fall awkwardly. Catra's body feels absolutely crushed, shaking slightly, her knees and head empty.

She feels Adora's shine flowing down her thigh and her own expression mirroring Adora's - mouths agape, pupils wide, lit up by flickering, uncertain horror.

So, they've done it again; but this time, neither of them can button their jeans up, drag their shirts down, and walk away. Even if they do, there is nowhere else to go, to stay. They're *stuck* here.

Fuck.

Now what?

Chapter End Notes

Check out this absolutely wonderful illustration by @fistypaaants!

Rule #2

Chapter Summary

2. Act like nothing happened.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora shouldn't stare.

She knows she shouldn't, but Catra's horrified, mismatched eyes are so easy to drown in, pulling her in like gravity. Adora's mind is slowly clearing up, registering every little detail one by one, each of them a tiny shock in her nerves. She is naked, her clothes cramped around her ankles. Her shirt is… somewhere, around the trailer, her suitcase lying sideways, her duffel bag too.

Also, she has just slept with Catra.

Again .

Which is- Yeah. It wasn't completely planned. Not right now, not like this.

Adora finally blinks. Her eyes are dry, burning into her skull. That one little flutter seems to put off Catra as well, yanking her out of her shock. Adora's gaze wanders down on Catra's body, from her freckled shoulders to her gleaming thigh. Heat blooms in Adora's cheeks, crawling down her neck and she opens her mouth to say something, anything-

Catra pulls up her jeans and storms away. Adora turns on her heels as Catra comes round her, rushing into the tiny bathroom and slamming the door on herself.

So that’s settled.

Adora sighs. She yanks her own jeans higher on her legs as well, holding them in her fist so she can totter to her bags. She unzips the duffel and fumbles for a tissue to rub herself dry unceremoniously before buttoning up. She leans for her shirt next and puts it on too; the fabric sticks to her sweaty skin, cold and uncomfortable.

The shower is running. Adora assumes she'll have five to ten minutes of quiet alone time, so she uses it to get a gray tank top and clean briefs from her duffel and smooth them nicely on the bottom bunk. She gets on her knees then, unzipping the carry-on case as well. Some necessities are gonna be enough for tonight - tiny bottles of shampoo and conditioner in one, shower gel and toothpaste. Her hairbrush and toothbrush are in different sections, neatly separated. She places them all on the bed, putting them at the same distance from each other.

Adora halts then. She feels her fingers shake above piles of clothes, and curls them into a fist.

She swallows, dry, right when the shower stops.

Adora slips into panic mode, throwing herself on the bed with her phone in her hand. She unlocks it and forces her expression into something that shows Catra that she is seriously busy with whatever app she has opened in front of her, despite laying on her back on top of all the stuff she’s just carefully unpacked.

The bathroom door slams open now. It’s a white folding door so Catra fumbles with it a bit, pushing and growling. It shouldn't make Adora laugh, but she barely manages to gnaw on the inside of her cheek to keep it down. She snorts, anyway, puckering her lips.

She is not ready for Catra coming closer, but in order to get to her top bunk, she really has to. Adora inhales deeply before Catra’s intoxicating scent twirls around her, forcing her to not sneak a peek at Catra.

She fails.

Catra is standing right by her side, reaching up to get something out of her bag, and her tank top slides higher on her stomach, exposing soft, fuzzy skin.

"How's the shower?" Adora asks, voice high.

Catra freezes mid-air. She is still tiptoeing, slowly grounding herself, and Adora can feel her killer glare without even having to look at her, and with fully knowing that Catra also avoids looking at her.

This is torture. Adora definitely won't be able to deal with her strange, attraction-poisoned hostility towards Catra on a daily basis if she keeps acting so much like...well, herself.

"Come on, Catra," Adora tries, putting her phone down on her chest. "You have to talk to me, eventually."

Catra just grunts. She clings to the doorframe of the top bunk, pushing herself away to stare down at Adora. There's that killer glare.

"No, I don't," she hisses. "You know the rules."

Adora props herself up to a sitting position, leaning on a hand on the pillow. Her phone plops down next to her, screen first.

"The rules are for... I know... Sex. You can't possibly expect us to share a trailer for weeks without-"

"So what if I do?" Catra snaps, tilting her head. Her wet hair is sticking to her face and her neck, water dripping from the curls down to Adora's sheets. "I have nothing to say to you. Do you?"

"Well *I* just asked you a question, so I guess I do!" Adora raises her voice, huffing. She tastes bile at the back of her throat. "Why are you like this? We talk all the time on set."

Catra scoffs, walking away as far as she can - which is three steps - and she reaches the narrow chair she plops down onto. She crosses her arms, stretching her legs under the table.

"If you wanna call that talking," she mumbles.

Adora doesn't have a comeback for that, so she just grunts.

Typical Catra. She *always* does this. She ends conversations as she pleases, never treating people as partners in anything. Everything always has to be just like she wants it, and even when she gives, it feels like she takes.

Adora is so over it.

"No, I don't," she says quietly. She can't stop her voice from quivering with frustration that keeps building up in her stomach. "But if you want to have another set of rules for living in this trailer together, you could at least let me in on it before expecting me to follow them."

Catra throws her head back with a growl. She squeezes her eyes shut, a grimace tugging on her lips like even breathing the same air as Adora pains her.

"Okay, *fine*." Catra opens her eyes but keeps staring at the ceiling as she talks. "Rule number one, we're not friends."

Adora exhales through her nose.

"Don't have to tell me that twice."

"Rule number two," Catra goes on, raising her voice. "We only talk if it's about work that we are both involved in. No small talk, no stupid questions about the fucking shower. Rule number three, no one comes into this trailer except for you and me. Don't even think about inviting your idiot friends to hang out."

Adora sits on the edge of the bed now, nails digging into the mattress.

"You could just ask me to respect your privacy without insulting my friends."

Catra ignores that too.

"Rule number four." Catra squints at Adora now; her expression is even harder than before, her voice sultry and low. "You're going to fuck me on every single surface in this trailer."

Those words are burning stings, injecting desperate need into Adora's stomach. She hates how easily arousal boils up between her legs just from that, an already pooling warmth. She feels her body react in ways she doesn't want it to - her tongue darts out to wet her lips, attracting Catra's glance and she leans ahead, elbows on her knees.

"Is that all?" Adora asks, barely recognizing her own deep voice.

Catra smirks. Her button nose crinkles, the playful light is back in her eyes. It makes Adora lose her breath.

"For now," Catra says with a little shrug of her shoulder, raising an eyebrow. "Objections?"

Adora swallows against the lump in her throat.

"None."

"Good."

Catra stretches her arms slowly, a cute moan purring from her chest. She kicks the chair back - the legs screeching loudly - and saunters to the bed again. Adora leans back impulsively, half expecting Catra to pin her down to the fourth rule right here and now.

Catra doesn't look at her as she raises a foot up the ladder and climbs up to the top bunk.

Adora exhales. She chews on the inside of her cheek and pushes herself up from the bed swiftly. She grabs her clothes and her little dressing-case to monopolize the bathroom after Catra.

No words are shared between them for the night.

*

Adora is awakened by people chatting outside in the trailer park, and Catra's loud snoring.

She blinks sullenly and pulls her phone from under her pillow, clicking it. 4:06 AM. She peeks out the window above the table; the outside world is still in sepia, the sun peeking out from ribbons of clouds.

Adora rubs the last fractures of dreams from her eyes and turns to her side. Catra's arm is hanging down, her fingers twitching slightly in her sleep. The pads of her fingers look so soft, and Adora knows for a fact that they are. She reaches out, still dazed from early hours, and pokes at them gently.

Catra grumbles. Adora snatches her hand back, her heart thrumming in her chest.

...What the *hell* is she doing?

The mattress creaks above her, and the hand disappears from her sight.

Adora unlocks her phone. She has a couple notifications from Glimmer and Bow. The last one is from a couple minutes ago; Bow suggesting getting breakfast together before their day starts at 5:30.

Adora's stomach grumbles at the thought immediately, and she texts back a string of emojs.

Then, she gets out of bed as qietly as she can, putting on her clothes and washing up. She peeks at Catra again before she leaves the trailer, a hand on the knob.

Catra must know when she has to wake up, too. Maybe she doesn't even have work today. Besides, it's not Adora's responsibility to make sure she gets up in time.

Adora jngles with the door and slips out.

The cafeteria is already full. Adora waits in a line slithering out of the door. She shovels a mountain of scrambled eggs on a paper plate, gently placing some slices of bacon on top. She maneuvers her wobbly masterpiece on a tray carefully, eyes scanning the crowd for her friends.

She recognizes that pink hair poof from miles away, and makes a beeline for a huge, round table. Glimmer and Bow are not the only ones there - Adora is delighted to find her circle of some of her oldest friends from the crew, finally reunited.

Bow, the best boy from the lighting crew, jumps up as soon as he sees Adora and waves her towards them.

"Adora, we're here!"

Adora tries to wave back, but all she can manage is a slight lift of her tray and a bright grin.

"Hi, guys!"

There's the always broody Mermista, the special effects supervisor, and Seahawk, her eager, not-boyfriend assistant. Next to him is

Perfuma, the greensman from the art department, vibrating with excitement as ever, eyes closed and deep in thought.

"Hey girl," Mermista says. She rests her chin on the back of her hand and kicks the seat on her left for Adora to take.

Adora plops down gratefully.

"Long time no see, crewmate!" Seahawk chimes in.

"Yeah, we haven't seen you in like, forever."

"Where did the universe take you?" Perfuma asks.

"My last year was pretty slow," Adora says shortly, her mouth already full. "I only had a couple commercials." She swallows without chewing on the bite. "I'm glad to see you all again."

"Almost the full dream team," Bow says. "Netossa and Spinnerella are somewhere here too, but you know how they like to spend mornings together."

Glimmer scoffs, rubbing her temple.

"Ugh, they could at least keep it *down*."

"What?" Adora mumbles into the next bite.

Mermista rolls her eyes and her coffee cup on the table in front of her.

"How could you not hear them yesterday? I thought someone was being murdered." She sounds offended. "I almost got excited."

Oh.

Oh, no.

The bite is stuck in Adora's mouth. She can't bring herself to swallow, her throat so tight and dry. She feels her cheeks burning.

"I, uh," she mumbles. "I'm a heavy sleeper?"

"It was like, six."

"I-I was very tired."

Thankfully, Glimmer comes to her rescue, although the topic only changes from bad to worse.

"No wonder you were. Spending even five minutes with Catra would suck all the life and joy out of anyone. I can't even imagine sharing a trailer with her."

"Catra Weaver?" Mermista drawls. "The stunt girl you had your scene with yesterday?"

"Yeah," Glimmer replies instead of Adora. "*That* girl."

"Come on guys, don't be so mean," Perfuma says, lacing her fingers together under her chin. "Scorpia is really fond of her, she can't be that bad."

"Not all of us are gonna base our judgment on your 12-hour crush," Mermista objects with a poke of her fork in her direction. Perfuma puffs herself up, ready to snap back. Mermista is quick to continue: "Didn't you like, cuddle her mid-air?"

"I did not!" Adora yells way too loudly.

"Wait, wait, what?" Glimmer shrieks, staring at Adora like she just confessed kicking a puppy into fire.

"I did not do that," Adora repeats, stressing every word and slamming her fork down. Everyone is looking at her. "I did not! I just-" Her voice falters. She casts her eyes down. "I thought I saw her harness loosen. I didn't have time to think."

Pairs of eyes glance away from Adora's face, one by one. Adora munches on a slice of bacon, breaking the awkward silence with loud cracking.

The bacon tastes like sandpaper in her mouth. She hates how everyone knows why she couldn't let that happen, she hates to feel so seen and pitied. It happened so long ago. She was still new to this whole thing, and she was an idiot, and she made a mistake, and why can't everyone just forget about the whole thing already?!

"I think we can all agree you did the right thing," Bow says then, reaching behind Glimmer to pat Adora's shoulder. "Anyway , before you arrived Perfuma was just about to tell us about her meet-cute with this new stunt girl."

Mermista growls, sinking lower in her seat. The others encourage Perfuma on, and she continues with her story shyly. Her eyes are sparkling as she talks and she gestures excitedly, her voice chirping an octave higher than usual.

Adora cannot bring herself to listen but does her best to pretend.

Adora has a long day with not much to do; she only has a couple silent scenes with the main cast.

Adora can mindlessly go through it all, barely having to move - she stays in the background, sometimes walking across the screen, sometimes pretending to whisper something into another security guard's ear. The most exciting thing she is directed to do is make a phone call with her back to the camera.

She spends the hours between different takes to hit the gym, going through her fight choreography over and over again, until she can't feel her blood boil that much.

She hasn't seen Catra all day. She probably has a day off after all, or she works at a completely different stage than her.

The absence of her should bring Adora peace, not a whole-day migraine.

So why doesn't it?

Adora arrives at the trailer around six again. She tries her luck with opening the door without keys. The doorknob is stuck.

Catra is either away, or she keeps the door locked all the time.

Adora gets her keys out of her pocket and unlocks the trailer. She pushes the door in as quietly as she can, but the hinges creak miserably, giving her away.

There's no sign of Catra at first. Adora closes the door behind her, and almost lets out a curious "hello?" before she bites down on her lip. No talking.

She puts her bag down on one of the chairs and sneaks a peek at the top bunk. She sees a pair of long legs wrapped in ripped jeans, crossed. Catra is laying on the bed just like she was when Adora left for work this morning. The faint glow of her phone screen is the only source of light in the dim light.

Adora flicks the lights on. Catra just growls, which Adora decides not to react to.

Her body feels tired and heavy. Maybe Glimmer is right, and Catra's mere presence drinks strength out of her muscles and bones.

A phone rings. It's a heavy bass beat, coming from the top bunk. Adora tries her best not to pay attention, but her mind is so scattered

and all over the place that it latches onto everything that is louder than her heart drumming in her ears.

"Hey , Scorp," Catra says in a voice Adora didn't even think she was capable of making. She still sounds raspy, but with a touch of unfamiliar softness. "What's up?"

Adora busies herself with boiling water for a cup of tea. She finds a mug with a broken-off handle and a box with some filters of strawberry flavored black tea in the tiny cupboard.

"W ait, really?" Catra says, her voice muffled. "How did you even find him?"

The caller says something on the other side of the line and Catra giggles.

Adora freezes with the mug in her hand before slamming it down hard on the countertop. Catra's laugh is an adorable tingle, high and full of gentle appreciation.

The kettle whistles. Adora's whole body is rigid.

What's happening right now .

"Oh my God," Catra whimpers then, sniffing. "Are you kidding me? *Ashor* ?" Her voice breaks, and she giggles again. "This is the best fucking thing I've heard all day."

The caller goes on for longer now. Catra listens without cutting in, only humming softly at times, her clothes rustling as she rolls into a more comfortable position.

Adora pours the boiling water into the mug, throwing the filter in so hard it splashes drops of hot water onto her hand. She hisses.

Adora's anger comes in waves. Not even anger - frustration, the kind of black, heavy bile that sticks to her throat and drips down into her

stomach like mud. Her heart is beating fast, fingers shaking as she curls them around the mug so hard her knuckles whiten.

It makes no sense.

Of course Catra has friends. Of course she can be sweet and soft and kind to someone who isn't Adora. Of course she is more than just her sharp tongue and her sharp nails. No one, not even her, could be so prickly all the time, so full of venom to spit and rage to burn anyone who dares to get close.

"I'm- yeah, hold on."

Catra presses the phone to her other ear now, drawing a shoulder up to keep it in place. She hops off the top bunk with a tiny grunt, not bothering to use the ladder.

She sneaks out the door without acknowledging Adora in any way. Her voice is just a distant murmur now, and Adora can't make out any words.

Not like she could hear anything over the ringing of her ears.

*

When Adora awakens the next day, she feels like she was beaten half to death..

Catra's alarm is going off, a merciless rock song with a screaming guitar solo. Catra's nails click on the screen, and the music stops. Adora hears her shuffling and moaning, Catra's body complaining very loudly at the thought of getting out of bed.

Adora presses her thighs together and rolls towards the wall. She still has an hour to stay in bed, and while she has no intention of

going back to sleep, she wants to wait to get up until the coast is clear.

Catra takes longer to get ready than her. She yawns a lot and drags her body from surface to surface, bumping into things.

Adora stays still, only moving when Catra closes the door behind her twenty minutes later.

Adora gets up.

Her second scene for the day is a continuation from day one of shooting. Once her and Catra's characters survive the explosion, they shoot a closer scene of their bodies hitting the floor and scrambling to their feet, facing each other, ready to attack.

Juliet gives Adora a new script right before the first take. The new instructions are scribbled on the margins in hurried handwriting, ordering Adora to roll with Catra's body in her arms, landing on top of her. As she pushes up, she needs to keep a heartbeat of pause, staring down at Catra.

Adora reads the instructions a couple times, her lips forming words without making any sound, memorizing everything.

A sharp elbow digs into her side, making her wince.

"Ready to go, hotshot?"

Adora crinkles the script in her fist and snaps her head up. Catra stands right next to her - her costume is burnt and ripped, exposing skin sprayed ashy gray. The shade of her helmet is broken so Adora can see her face, fake blood dripping from a scar painted on her forehead.

Catra raises her eyebrows at her.

"What?"

"You're talking to me," Adora blurts out, her tone flat.

"It's work, dumbass." She comes 'round Adora, hips swaying. She practically purrs into her face: "Besides, you're gonna crush me a couple times. I think we both know how that's gonna end for you."

Adora swallows.

"Sounds like you gave it much thought already."

"Maybe." Catra shrugs nonchalantly and circles her again like prey. It makes Adora scoff. "I know how desperate you can get."

Adora's head turns with Catra.

"Says the girl who threw herself at me two days ago."

Catra jerks and halts, looking around. Her voice is a threatening hiss:

"*Shut it*."

"I will if you do."

Catra turns on her heel, mumbling to herself:

"Honestly, what did I expect?"

Catra takes her spot above the X taped on the ground and doesn't look at Adora anymore.

Catra's right to ask that question.

What *did* she expect, talking to Adora like that when they both know she's capable of being normal? Why can't she use that sweet little voice on Adora instead of this low, raspy purr that is dripping with contempt?

Adora cracks her fingers and takes her spot, too. She breathes out in a deep sigh, knees moving back and forth.

Action.

The first take goes horribly. The second one too.

Adora can't focus to save her life. Not when she's rolling on the ground with Catra's warm body pressed to hers, not when she smells so nice and she clings to Adora so tight, and she makes those grunting, throaty moans as they fight.

Adora pushes her chest up, her legs tangled with Catra's. She looks her in the eye, following the new script, and Catra sq ints back. Catra's face doesn't show on camera so she wears a smug, crooked smirk, her eyebrows arch up.

Catra sinks her teeth into her lip and rocks her hips up; the motion is barely noticeable, but does the jb alright, setting Adora's abdomen on fire, her lips part with a breathless gasp.

Adora forgets to stand up.

"Cut!T ake five, everyone."

Adora staggers to her feet and nearly falls on her ass. She manages to keep herself up and dusts off her suit with qick little slaps.

Catra rises as well, much slower than Adora. She helps herself up elegantly with a hand on her knee, her eyes find Adora's.

Catra says nothing. She doesn't have to. Adora's face is an open book, she knows that, and now it tells a story about a girl who would very much like to bodyslam a certain someone into the nearest surface to take revenge, to teach a lesson, to taste and bite and make her *scream-*

An assistant walks by them and pushes a bottle of water into Adora's hand.

Adora looks down at the bottle, then up to the assistant.

"Thank you?"

"You looked like you needed it," the assistant says, kind and innocent.

"You're right," Catra purrs, her surprise in her voice so obviously fake. "She does look thirsty ."

Before Adora could snap back, Catra leaves the game while she's winning. It's a cowardly thing to do. Even if she was called aside, that's a coward's move, running away from Adora's perfect comeback. One that she hadn't figured out yet, but she was getting there.

Adora gulps straight from the bottle, her throat burning and dry.

"You seem tense," a voice calls from her right, the director strolling before her with a concerned pout. "Is everything alright?"

"Yeah," Adora chirps desperately, clutching the bottle in her fist. "All good."

"You can tell me anything, you know," Double Trouble drawls, crossing their arms with a tilt of their hips. "The success of this movie comes from all of us feeling comfortable."

Adora swallows thickly.

"No, I- Im comfortable. Nothing about this job makes me feel bad. Really. Nothing. Nothing at all."

Double Trouble hums but doesnt pressure anything. Their eyes wander, finding Catra in the shadows as she is tapping her phone,

an SFX artist touching up on her bloody face. "I wish I could say the same."

Adora's glance follows theirs.

"What do you mean?"

Double Trouble sighs exasperatedly, their head lolling back.

"It's pretty personal, you know," they say, hands clutching their elbows. "I don't want to burden you with that stuff."

"It's no burden," Adora assures them, furrowing her brows. "I'm… I'm here to help if I can."

Double Trouble shoots her a quick glance before letting their arms fall, and they roll their shoulders as they straighten. Adora takes a couple sips again, so Double Trouble feels welcome to continue.

"Some people are just giving me a hard time right now," they sigh. "I can't blame them, honestly. It's never easy to work with your ex."

Adora nearly inhales the whole bottle. She curls her fingers into a fist before hitting her chest hard, trying her best not to choke.

Double Trouble raises their hands, panic creeping in their voice:

"Oh my gosh, are you okay?"

Adora's lungs rattle.

"Yeah! Yeahyeahyeah, just- I'm sorry, your ex?"

Double Trouble looks embarrassed now, pouting.

"I thought everybody knew by now. People talk," they say, flipping their hair back from their shoulder. "You know, Catra and I go a *long* way back. Longer than our careers, even."… A strange little smile is

tugging at their lips. It looks almost nostalgic, their voice softening. "Sometimes I can't believe I dated that girl."

Adora's stomach shrinks into a knot. She doesn't know how to reply to that, so she keeps quiet.

Double Trouble takes her silence as embarrassment, and they're quick to add:

"It's no secret, really. Almost everyone knows. I'm surprised she didn't tell you."

"We don't talk much," Adora says sourly.

"Really? You seem to be around each other a lot."

"We're-" Adora swallows, her cheeks heating up. "We really aren't. It's just work."

"Oh, I didn't mean to touch a nerve," Double Trouble says.

"You didn't."

"Well, I'm relieved," they say, crossing their arms elegantly.

"Huh?"

"That I didn't touch a nerve?"

Adora tries to speak, but no sound comes out of her throat. She isn't even sure she follows or understands what Double Trouble is implying, but-

Double Trouble's eyes release Adora's, and it feels like chains breaking off Adora's lungs. She breathes out slowly as Double Trouble turns their head towards Catra again.

Catra peeks up from her phone, staring right at them. Her upper lip curls, her teeth showing. The threatening shimmer in her eyes is

clear as day and cuts like a knife. She glances between Double Trouble and Adora before she buries her face into her phone again.

Double Trouble grins, satisfied. Their phone pings. They don't check it. It pings again.

"This probably sounds so weird" they go on, clearly not bothered by Adora's lack of participation, or their own noisy phone, "but sometimes I feel like the angrier I make her, the more she wants me back."

"That is weird," Adora blurts out before she could stop herself. "I mean-"

Thankfully, Double Trouble just laughs, throwing their head back.

"It is, isn't it? But Kiten is like that. At least that's how she was when she was mine." They pause for a couple moments. Then, they squint back at Adora above their shoulder. "Thank you, darling. You've been a great help. I feel so much better."

"No problem?" Adora says, weak and confused. Something doesn't sit well with her; maybe the phrasing Double Trouble used about *owning* Catra, or something in their tone that she cannot name or explain. Either way, she feels too tight in her own skin, her legs desperate to take her far, far away. "I didn't- I didn't do anything."

Catra's raspy voice cuts through the stage.

"Do you ever check your fucking texts? Get your ass here, Dee. Now!"

Double Trouble chuckles. They look at Adora with a raised brow as if they would say "*see? I told you*". Adora's jaw pops open a bit.

"Meow," Double Trouble drawls then, quiet enough that only Adora can hear. "Looks like I'm gonna get some kitty scratches."

They wink at Adora as they turn on their heel. Adora's skin is burning hot, the knot in her stomach tightens painfully.

The next three takes are Catra's fault. After she had a brief, but very dangerous looking conversation with Double Trouble, Catra arrived back to set with a brand new attitude that is even more insufferable than before.

She doesn't pay attention, her moves are rigid and hurried, and the angrier she gets, the more mistakes she makes.

Adora is getting tired, her skull feels too tight for her brain. When they take their places for the sixth time, Adora cannot bear the thought of doing this once more, so she does something very, very stupid.

She puts a warm hand on Catra's shoulder, squeezing gently. Catra looks at her like Adora's lost her mind, showing her teeth to bite back.

"You're okay," Adora says coyly. "We're gonna get it right this time."

Catra slaps her hand away.

"Don't touch me in front of people," Catra mutters. She sounds like she's sulking; her voice is quiet and surprisingly calm.

"Sorry," Adora whispers, and she means it.

"Action!"

They do get it right.

Their timing is perfect as their bodies hit the floor, and they bring a little pull-and-tug to the rolling that makes it look much more exciting.

Catra lets her arms fall to the ground, her body laid out under Adora's, weak and vulnerable. She tries no funny business, her face is controlled now, mirroring her characters' emotions rather than her own as she stares up at Adora.

Adora keeps her hips down, pinning Catra to the ground. She pushes herself up by her hands next to Catra's head; strings of her hair falling into her face, fluttering as she is breathing heavily.

She doesn't know how she looks at Catra. She's a little lost, actually.

But Catra is a good actress. Whatever Adora thinks she sees on her face right now, is not from her, and not for Adora.

It's just way too tempting to take it that way, even with Adora knowing what she knows now.

Double Trouble's words are pulling her down like anchors attached to her. Adora knows exactly what they meant now - Catra is still not over them.

And maybe they aren't over Catra, either.

Adora swallows thickly. She feels her fingers twitch on their own.

What even is Catra doing with her if she wants her ex back? What Catra and Adora had has never been more than sex; no strings attached, no feelings involved except for the frustration and the fury that are like gasoline to the flames of lust for them.

Adora never thought their hookups were something important enough to be even worth losing. They aren't really doing anything, so why ever stop it? It's not like she was going to find herself a girlfriend with her kind of job, and she couldn't say she was planning to anyway. She's been sleeping with Catra for more than two years now, literally whenever they meet. She's a handful. She's enough.

She *was* enough.

Maybe Adora doesn't want a relationship. But what if Catra does? What if one day she'll just sarcastically thank Adora for everything and call it off because she'll sleep with her partner from that time on?

Double Trouble seems like an interesting character, and Catra is cool, too. Maybe Adora could still touch her? Maybe the three of them could come to an agreement so Adora can spend some time with Catra trapped between her legs, writhing in her grip, moaning for more of Adora, more of her mouth and her fingers and heat. There are so many boundaries she’s willing to cross not to lose that-

"Adora!"

Adora jolts. She is still hovering above Catra, who's expression changed drastically since the last time Adora managed to pay attention to it.

Catra's eyes are glaring now, her upper lip curled into a scornful grimace.

"Get off me already," Catra snarls, pushing her palms into Adora's shoulders.

"Sorry ,"Adora mumbles and obeys. "Sorry . I just zoned out."

"Yeah, I noticed."

"I said I was sorry!"

"Whatever .”

Catra practically runs off and out of the stage door while Adora is still kneeling on the ground.

Adora curls her fingers into fists.

Catra isn't waiting for her in the trailer like Adora expected her to after all that flirting before their first take. The space is empty and unlit when Adora steps in and locks the door without giving it a second thought, and pulls the key out of the lock.

Adora is standing in the middle of the foreign space, still not used to staying here. She had grown used to staying in different places and moving around a lot, both inside and outside the system. Not once had she had a home, so there was never anything to miss. But the anxiety is still the same, the sour feeling of never being wanted, or needed, and every time she feels like she's invading the space she was given to stay in.

Now that she has her own apartment, she starts to feel little whims of that homesickness she's never known. She overpacked so she could try and cling to her possessions, if nothing else, because those are always with her, grounding her somehow.

Catra arrives before Adora could even move. She steps inside and locks the door as well.

Adora turns slowly, eyes searching for Catra's. Catra's eyelashes flutter, and there are those gorgeous irises cutting into Adora's insides. They slide down on Adora's body, coming back up, settling on her lips.

Once she's inside, Catra wastes no time. She walks straight up to Adora, arms wrapped tight around her neck. Adora's hands fly to Catra's hips subconsciously, her thoughts rushing around her mind too fast to catch up with them. She leans in for a kiss, Catra drawing back with her fingers in Adora's ponytail.

Catra presses her lips to Adora's jaw , her breath hot on her skin.

Adora's brain short circuits, her gaze flickers around the room, counting the surfaces. Her tongue darting out to wet her chapped lips, anticipation is a throbbing need between her legs. Her imagination is already wandering, all possibilities flashing up before

her eyes when reality pulls her back in, just like Catra's determined fingers pulling her head back to expose more skin for her to lick and peck.

Catra's free hand pushes on Adora's shoulder, backing her to the window and pushing her down onto the chair. Catra's lips never leave her neck as she climbs into Adora's lap with a slow, tentative roll of her hips, thighs straddling hers.

Adora blurts out, raspy and weak:

"Ch.cherry ."

Catra releases her, drawing back.

"Not in the mood?"

It would be so easy to lie, but Adora doesn't do that.

"No, I am, just-" She leaves her palms on Catra's waist. "Are you really okay with this?"

Catra snorts, ending in a short chuckle. When Adora doesnt move an inch, her expression the same as before - serious, and just a touch concerned - Catra scowls.

"Oh, youre serious." Suspicion creeps in Catra's voice. "What is this about?"

Adora could lie again.

"Just. Dont know if Im really the one you want to sleep with."

"Unfortunately , you are."

"What about Double T rouble?"

Catra jerks in her lap. She lifts herself up on her feet, sprawling with Adora and the chair trapped between her thighs. The loss of warm

contact gives Adora a heartache, already hating herself for even starting this conversation - especially when Catra's features harden as she looks down on Adora, and not in a good way. She takes Adora's hands and shoves them away from her waist, her own hand clutching the backrest above Adora's shoulder.

Catra keeps her voice as controlled as she can, lips and teeth barely moving.

"What do they have to do with anything?"

"I'm pretty sure you know ."

Catra's chest is heaving, her voice growing stronger.

"That fucking little-" Catra breathes out, a hand in her hair. She combs back her messy curls, shaking her head. "What did they tell you?"

"Just that… you were together. A while ago. Look, Catra, you don't owe me anything-"

"Damn right I don't."

Adora snaps:

"Let me finish! Im just trying to tell you that it's fine if you want to be with someone else, Im simply asking you to tell me and Ill-"

"God, stop talking!" Catra presses a palm to Adora's lips, her eyes fall shut with an agonizing squeeze. She adds, weaker now, a plea and an order: "Stop talking."

Adora swallows. Catra doesnt let her go as she opens her eyes, glaring at Adora in the most twisted, furious expression Adora has ever seen on her. Her nails dig into Adora's cheek, pretty curls falling so close to Adora's nose.

"New rule," Catra croaks, leaning closer. She waits for Adora to look into her eyes, getting lost in those gleaming, mismatched irises, air stuck in her lungs, and her expression frozen. Then, Catra says: "*Stay away* from Dee."

Adora's stomach shrinks. The way Catra spits that like a threat, voice trembling, still so firm and determined - it's clear. It's so clear now, and Adora can't keep eye contact anymore.

Catra doesn't let her look away. She cups her jaw now, rough, so Adora is able to speak but not move her head any other way.

"Say you will."

"Catra, we're working with them," Adora says faintly.

"Apart from that," Catra stresses. The light in her eyes shifts, her voice tainted with desperation now as she tugs on Adora's jaw. "Adora, say it! Say you'll stay away from them."

Adora takes Catra's wrist, pulling her hand away from her face, her thumb stroking Catra's wrist. She feels Catra's heartbeat, frantically thrumming in her veins. She must be so scared that Adora will mess this up for her, so Adora does her best to soothe and reassure her.

"Okay, okay," she says, quiet and resigned. Her body feels heavy as she lets out a sigh spouting deep from her belly, but it's worth it, because Catra's shoulders drop, tension seeping out of them. "I will."

Catra says nothing, just nods. She sits back down onto Adora's thighs, still sprawling; her hands slip under Adora's shirt, crawling up along the sharp lines of her abs, cupping her breasts.

Adora yanks her close and kisses her rough, all teeth and tongue and little, shivering gasps as her nails sink into Catra's waist and the nape of her neck.

Their days are numbered, but Adora won't go down without a fight.

She wont let Catra forget her .

Chapter End Notes

Things are starting to get fun, huh?

Thank you so much for reading, thank you for 100+ subs already, you guys are fucking awesome and I don't deserve you. I truly hope you liked this chapter, please leave me a comment if you do, they truly make my days and keep me going.

Please consider checking my socials and look out for illustrations, sneak peeks and bts annoyance from me, there will be a lot.

I love you all, stay safe, and cool, and come hang out with me on Tumblr or Twitter it's a fun time and I love talking to you. ♡

Rule #3

Chapter Summary

3. No talking.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra is a fucking idiot.

She had one job - playing Dee's game, following their rules so she can have a career she'd always dreamed of. She should have kept her distance, let them have their way, not interfered. She should have accepted whatever came her way, kept her mouth shut, and played her role whether or not the cameras were rolling.

Adora was kissing her like she wanted to steal her breath, her hands roaming up and down on Catra's back. The heels of her palms rub the tension out of Catra's muscles as curious fingers hook into her shirt and burrow under, nails first.

All Catra can do is cling to Adora's shoulders and sigh into her mouth, welcoming every flick of her tongue and those cold teeth that sink into Catra's lip. Catra feels her eyebrows knit as her thoughts keep wandering, whisking her further away from the warmth of the embrace she so desperately craves.

If Catra is a fucking idiot, then there are no words in any language to describe Adora. Catra couldn't believe how easy it was for Dee to get under her skin and poison her with their bullshit in like, what? Five minutes? Adora fell victim so fast and so hard, and Catra couldn't just *watch*.

Relationships are games to Dee, and people are objects to tinker with and break open, left to bleed. They had done that to her when

they were dating, and Catra wasnt even that invested in that relationship - she used Dee to fill a hole in her soul that was yearning for any kind of companionship, a safety net, and they were just there. She shouldn't have expected more for using them than to be used in return.

And they still managed to break her.

Adora grabs a handful of Catra's hair, pulling her head to the side. Her lips are everywhere on Catra's face, little pecks peppered here and there with a promising hint of teeth.

Catra moans weakly.

She can take Dee's shit, but Adora? Adora is different. She's a fucking puppy, and she can chew and pee on everything Catra loves, she can be as fucking annoying as she possibly can, but Catra still can't just - She can't just let that happen.

Dee will ruin Adora.

Adora's warm hand slides up Catra's stomach now, already under her shirt. Catra's whole body shivers, mouth falling open. Adora captures her parted lips again, moaning into her mouth like she found fucking salvation, like she's trying to prove a point, tugging Catra higher on her thighs.

"Cherry ."

Adora freezes. She draws back, looking up at Catra with a soft arch of her thick brows and she pulls her lower lip between her teeth.

Catra is breathing heavily; she tries her best to hide it, pressing her lips into a straight line, inhaling through her nose. She stands up from Adora's lap, her thighs weak and shaking. Adora's hands slip off of her body, leaving goosebumps and something thick and cold rushing in her veins.

"I changed my mind," Catra croaks and pulls a leg over Adora's thighs, distancing herself further. She smooths her hair back and down with both hands, fingers combing through the curls.

Adora nods solemnly. Her hands fall onto her knees, fingers digging into her jeans before she starts scratching her own nails absentmindedly.

"About… what?" She stammers, before asking carefully: "The whole thing?"

Those stormy blue eyes are shining with something Catra doesnt even dare to think about, so she turns away, avoiding looking at them.

"About tonight," she says. "I guess I'm the one who's not in the mood."

It's not fully a lie. She's not mad enough - not mad at Adora, at least. It wouldn't be safe.

"Okay ," Adora says with a huge, relieved huff of breath. "Okay ," she repeats, barely audibly. Catra isn't sure she was supposed to hear that.

Catra grabs her leather jacket and throws it on her shoulders without sliding her arms through. She taps her pocket; her phone is still there.

If Adora wants to jack off in peace, she can give her that. Catra is throbbing between her legs, too, but she needs some fresh air more than release. She fumbles with the door for a while, her palms slippery with sweat, just like the insides of her thighs. It's uncomfortable to walk while she's practically flowing down her legs, but Catra will waste no time to rush into the bathroom and deal with that.

Catra leaves her keys in the lock and slams the door behind her.

The sun is setting over the horizon; up where Catra is, on the high roof of one of the huge stage complexes, the flaming beams are still warm and blinding.

Catra shrugs her jacket off and lets it flop down onto the concrete. Her phone knocks inside her pocket at the impact but she doesn't care.

She takes a deep breath and steps up onto the high railing. It's narrow enough that if she faces ahead, her soles and toes are dangling off the sides. Catra turns to her left, arms raised in line with her shoulders. She walks like she used to walk on rope, extended high above the brightly lit floor.

She reaches the edge of the building and stares ahead. The rails on the next one are far away - but not too far. Not for her.

Catra backs up, one foot after the other, tightens her muscles to gain strength, and starts running.

Time slows down when she's flying mid-air before touching down on the other rail perfectly. Feeling high from that rush of sweet adrenaline, she twirls in the air, facing the building she jumped from. She bends backwards then, hands clasping around both sides of the rail, head hanging down.

She pushes her legs up and loops in the air, stopping elegantly when her body is straight upside down. Her arms never tremble supporting her as she bends again, heels knocking on the rail.

Catra straightens her spine, now standing, and breathes out slowly. She feels lighter, but not light enough. She needs a stronger rush that can sweep the bubbling tension out of her body and makes her forget about everything and anything - including Adora.

Adora, staring at her with that kicked puppy expression after she made her promise to keep away from Dee. Adora, asking shyly if Catra would ever want to sleep with her again like she actually gave a fuck about the answer. Adora, now left alone in the trailer, still so aroused, touching herself desperately and fantasizing about Catra the whole time-

Catra grunts and somersaults without thinking. When she lands safely, she goes again, and again, reaching the edge of this building, too.

She stops right at the last second, her supporting ankle hanging above the ten-story high abyss.

The door opens on the roof. Catra snaps her head up, losing balance for a moment. She quickly gains it back but doesn't move from her spot.

The newcomer steps into the pale yellow light, not noticing Catra at first. It gives Catra the advantage to realize who she is.

Fuck.

The newcomer takes a crumpled box of cigarettes out of her bomber jacket. There's a click as she lights one, and takes a drag. She glances up when she breathes the fume out of her nose, clouding her face.

Their eyes meet.

"Circus girl," she exclaims, sarcasm twirling in the air like smoke.

Catra hops down from the rails, forcing her features into something tame and smug.

"I know you remember my name, Lonnie," she purrs, walking closer. "You screamed it more times than I could count."

Lonnie furrows her brows and flicks ash off her cigarette. Catra goes on, her voice hardening:

"What are you doing here?"

"Smoking."

"You know what the fuck I mean."

Catra halts when she's close enough and crosses her arms. Lonnie grins, drawing the cigarette back to her lips. She takes a long drag, keeping eye contact before breathing through the smoke:

"Chill, I'm just visiting someone. I don't work here. But you do, don't you?"

"So what if I do?"

Lonnie's grin grows even wider.

"Then I would say your *method* did get you ahead. Congratulations, I guess."

Hair stands up on Catra's arms and she hisses:

"What?"

"I'm just saying you've clearly been working hard," she takes a meaningful pause, "under someone."

"You don't get to talk to me like that," Catra spits, trying to tower above Lonnie as she raises a fist between them threateningly.

Lonnie doesn't flinch. She simply opens the box of cigarettes and shakes it in front of Catra as an offering to something - anything but peace or an apology.

Catra doesn't take it.

"I *quit*," she says firmly.

Lonnie shrugs and pushes the box back into her pocket.

"Don't get so offended," she says nonchalantly. "You got what you wanted, who cares how, right? Sleeping with the director is a pretty classic move."

"I don't sleep around to get ahead," Catra snaps again, not like she owes Lonnie, or *anyone* an explanation. Her voice grows high with frustration. "I don't *need* to. I get roles because I'm fucking good at what I'm doing, and I don't need to fuck anyone to earn that-"

Catra clips her words; realization is a cold shiver running down her spine.

Adora.

Isn't that what Catra is doing to her? Didn't she let Dee offer her something bigger, better, in exchange of keeping her relationship with Adora to fuel the flames their characters need onscreen? Without Catra fucking her, they lose their dynamic, they lose what they need to keep their jobs, they lose everything they've been working hard for-

Catra feels her vision blurring.

She snatches the already lit cigarette from Lonnie and takes a long drag. She clutches her elbow with her opposite hand, letting her right fall with the cigarette pinched between her fingers. She still keeps the smoke in her lungs as she taps her foot, exhaling very, very slowly.

She wants to throw up.

Lonnie keeps quiet beside her, lighting another cigarette for herself. They smoke in silence for a couple minutes; Lonnie doesn't offer

anything to ease Catra, and Catra is grateful for that. It wouldn't be sincere anyway, they both know that much.

Catra reaches the end of her cigarette without retching, and smears the bud on the wall next to Lonnie's head.

Their eyes meet again, and Catra backs away.

She asks:

"Why did you stop fucking me?"

Lonnie blinks. She runs the tip of her tongue along her teeth, trying to find the right words.

"I never thought you took me seriously ," she says then, slow and low . "I got fed up. W anted something more. Something real."

Catra sets her jaw and nods.

"I'm in an open relationship now, though," Lonnie goes on, raising a brow suggestively. "It's up to you."

Catra considers for a moment. *Really* considers it; she's still pretty worked up from Adora's touch and the promises she made with her hands and mouth, only to turn into wasted chances and throbbing warmth between Catra's thighs.

It would be so easy to grab Lonnie and take everything she offers, right here on top of this roof like they did when they were eighteen.

Messy hookups and bad decisions were their thing already. Lonnie used to bully the shit out of Catra for starting to work as a circus artist after high school, and kept coming to her performances to wait for her and pick a quarrel.

And one time, that turned into something hot and heavy which neither of them was able to pass up.

Catra could do that again. Lonnie is still attractive - all taut muscles and heavy curves, and her features had grown sharper, more chiseled.

Lonnie's glance tangles into hers, waiting patiently for an answer.

Catra wishes her eyes were stormy blue.

"Nah," Catra says, her throat dry. "Pass."

"A'right," Lonnie says with the cigarette dangling between her teeth as she zips her jacket up. "You know best."

"Yeah. Congrats on the...relationship."

Lonnie hums.

"Congrats on the role. I mean it."

"Right."

Lonnie doesn't have to say anything more, Catra hears her thoughts loud and clear in the silence. Lonnie pities her for having less than her, for still being stuck right where she was at eighteen - meaningless hookups with no real attachments, no one who cares about her. No one to trust, to rely on, to love and be loved in return. No one to come home to.

She desperately wants to go back to the trailer.

Catra turns on her heel without a word, hopping back on the rail. She starts running, jumping above the deep end again.

She lands a little more wobbly now, and she's relieved to take her jacket from the floor and put it on. She didn't realize how chilly the air grew now that the sun is settling behind the horizon, the scenery turning dim gray.

Her feet take her back to the trailer, but she left her mind somewhere on the roof.

Catra lounges around the gym on Friday, waiting for the choreographer and Adora; neither of them are running late just yet, it was Catra who felt the unholy pull that dragged her out of bed earlier than she usually wakes up.

Adora was still asleep when she jumped off the top bunk, landing softly without a sound. Catra dressed in maroon leggings and a loose hoodie with just a sports bra underneath, washed up and left quickly like she'd done something illegal.

She shrugs off the hoodie and takes a hair tie between her teeth now, holding up her long curls. She hears laughing and chatting outside, and some sweet, hurried *bye*s before Adora walks in alone.

Catra lets her eyes wander down Adora's thighs, bare skin peeking out from under her red shorts. As she puts her hair up a ponytail, she feels Adora's gaze burning the nape of her neck.

She peeks back above her shoulder. Adora jerks her head away, pulling the straps of her backpack off her arms and puts it down on the bench.

Soon enough, Catra hears another set of heavy steps closing in. Both her and Adora turn towards the door, standing a safe distance away from each other.

A woman steps in, and Adora immediately gasps next to Catra. Catra glances at her; Adora's cheeks are flushed pink, her eyes sparkling.

Catra's glance is right back at the woman. Well, she's no woman, but a fucking unit, shoulders so broad she barely fits through the door.

She's so jacked that her muscles draw curves on her whole body, in places Catra didn't think was possible. Her features are hard, set into a scowl that quickly dissolves when she notices Adora.

"Blondie!" The woman roars. Her voice makes Catra's ears ring.

"Hi, Huntara," Adora practically *sighs* next to her, her voice growing high and weak.

Huntara leaps towards her and slams her giant palm on Adora's shoulder, patting it. Catra half expects the floor to crack under Adora's feet, but she barely winces, her whole face blooming with color.

"Good to see you again, kid!"

Catra's whole body goes rigid, her words cutting through the air, low and cold:

"Do you have to yell? We're right here."

Huntara turns to her, looking down at Catra, shadows clouding half her face.

"And you are, Curly? I've never seen you before."

"Yeah, I usually work with bigger studios," Catra purrs, raising a hand and flicking her fingers. "You know, with a top tier crew, not Party City wrestlers?"

Huntara snorts, folding those ridiculously huge arms on her chest. She smirks challengingly; a sharp tooth sinks into her bottom lip.

"Oh, you're one of those brats. Okay, I'll bite. We're starting with you, movie star. I hope you know your moves."

Catra takes a step closer.

"Do you?"

Huntara says nothing back to that; she simply raises her arms towards the mattress in the back. Catra scoffs and turns, her ponytail flapping violently behind her as she takes her position by the mattress.

Huntara steps in front of her. She gives Catra a rundown of the choreography she already knows so pays no attention to - something hot is blooming from her chest, settling down on her mind like a thick fog.

As soon as Huntara finishes talking, Catra gets to action. She leaps at her like she is supposed to, and her first blow is a right hook she needs to miss. She barely does as her timing takes Huntara by surprise, and she bends back a second too late. Catra's knuckles graze Huntara's rock hard shoulder, and Catra needs to focus to keep her balance since she went for it a little too hard.

Huntara tries to sweep Catra off her feet, arms on the floor. Catra does an elegant backflip, playing it more lazy and cool than she should. She is aware of the cocky smirk that tugs on her lips but she doesn't care to do anything about it.

Huntara makes a run at her; now it's her turn to hit and miss as Catra crouches then pushes herself up, a fist pretending to crash with Huntara's jaw.

Huntara stumbles, offering Catra the opportunity to pull her down and trap her in a headlock. Catra tightens her grip, just a little, as a warning; Huntara growls and grabs her by the waist to pull Catra's whole body over her shoulder and slam into the mattress as an endgame.

Here is where Catra is not finished playing.

As she is lifted in the air, she wraps her thighs around Huntara's neck. With the power of surprise, Catra supports herself with her palms on the floor and drags Huntara to the side. Huntara loses

balance and her body falls down the mattress with a heavy thud that shakes the whole floor.

There's a breath of heavy silence.

Catra is panting slightly, dragging her leg from under Huntara's neck and staggering to her feet. She turns and reaches an offering hand for Huntara who glares up at her, upper lip curling to show her teeth.

Catra squints and wiggles her fingers.

"So sorry," she says sweetly. Huntara takes her hand, and Catra squeezes it as tight as she can, her eyes hardening. "I got carried away."

Huntara keeps her gaze as she stands up, not relying on Catra whatsoever. She blows a long, loose thread of hair out of her face. Her voice is a quiet, raspy whisper:

"Make sure it never happens again."

Catra smiles with a little pout.

"My bad. I didn't think you'd be so easy to take down."

Huntara snatches her hand away and gestures for Catra to step back. Catra obeys, sauntering back to the bench with lazy sways of her hips.

Her eyes find Adora's for the first time since Huntara stepped inside. What she sees there is exactly what she was looking for; Adora's pupils are blown out, dilated into dark petals, her irises are just rings of sky-blue flame. She is staring at Catra like she always does before she takes her; like she wanted to grab and shove her into a dark corner and ravish her.

Catra bites the inside of her cheek and tears her gaze away. She plops down onto the bench, spreading her knees. She does her best to avoid looking at Adora as she goes through her part with Huntara,

only sparing her another look once they're both up to practice together and facing each other.

Adora's eyes are anything but tamer and calmer. Catra scrunches her nose with a smirk; Adora's lashes flutter before she forces her features into a scowl.

"Ready?" Huntara asks them, standing a couple feet away .

"Ready ," Adora says, full of confidence in her voice and in her pose.

"Curly?"

Catra raises her jaw .

"Ready ."

"Let's see how well you two work together ."

Catra surges ahead, raising her fist. Adora is more tuned to Catra's moves and rhythm than Huntara was; their timing is perfect as they play off their next moves on each other's attacks. Catra's body feels light despite her muscles straining - with Adora, the choreography turns into something similar to acro dancing which Catra is well familiar with, and sometimes still misses.

Catra numbs her body for Adora so she can lunge and slam her into the mattress a little too rough.

Catra gasps at the impact, her arms dropping down by her head, mouth hanging open.

Adora leans above her upside down, cocking her head. It's not just a gesture to make sure Catra is okay - there's a faint but visible curl of the corner of her mouth, a smug little smirk that has a different question to ask - *is that all you can take?*

Catra pushes herself up, making Adora draw back so they don't collide.

"Go again," Huntara says.

So they do. They go again, and again; with each round, things get a little more heated, their skin a little more sweaty, their ponytails a little more undone. Every fibre in Catra's body is hyper aware of how it's dragged along Adora's back and over that prettily curved shoulder. Adora gets slightly more handsy, too; during the last try, she grabs Catra where her ass meets her thigh instead of her waist.

Catra crashes into the mattress, trying to catch her breath.

Adora is standing by Catra's head, hands in fists as she's staring down at her, rosy lips parted.

Catra hears Huntara's voice muffled and quiet, like it's coming from a distance.

"Alright, let's wrap this up for today. Good job, Blondie. You're not a lost cause either, Curly."

"Wow, thanks," Catra mumbles, her eyes never leaving Adora's.

Adora chuckles at that, setting Catra's belly on fire. Huntara says something else and finally leaves - Catra counts her heavy steps fading away as Adora comes 'round her, stepping onto the mattress. Catra feels the waves of Adora walking, turning towards her.

The door of the gym closes with a loud thump.

Adora drops to her knees and throws herself on top of Catra, pressing down with her whole weight, locking her lips in a kiss that takes Catra's remaining breath away.

Adora is propped on her elbows, her hands are in Catra's hair, tugging and combing through her messy ponytail. She shoves a thigh between Catra's legs and starts rocking without hesitation.

Catra's hands crumple Adora's shorts so she can sink her nails into her ass. She rolls her hips up as much as Adora's body lets her,

meeting Adora halfway, their lips sealed on to each other's.

She comes without needing to take anything off.

Adora does, too.

The next day of shooting means Catra will have to face Dee again. She isn't sure she's ready for it, let alone being forced to work with Adora in front of their observing eyes.

But she doesn't have a fucking choice.

Adora left for breakfast early on, probably meeting her circle of stupid friends again. Catra barely steps into the cafeteria and grabs a warm pastry from the first tray, already turning on her heel.

She feels a little queasy, going through MUAH like she is a shell of a person, barely registering anything people tell or ask of her.

It doesn't get better when all of a sudden, she finds herself in position. Adora is there, too - whenever she got here Catra didn't notice.

"You alright there, kitten?" Dee purrs from their chair, crossing their legs and drawing lazy circles in the air with their foot.

Catra's blood pressure is immediately over the fucking roof.

"Fucking peachy," Catra growls, taking a deep breath and counting to ten.

She manages to get her shit together enough when the cameras start to roll, and Catra snaps back from wherever her mind was trapped.

She hunches like the script tells her to, clutching her arm covered in ripped leather and fake blood. This is a scene that comes much later than their previous ones; Catra's character is beaten half to death, at the mercy of the bodyguard who hesitates to end her life. Adora is standing in front of her with a prop gun in hand, its muzzle just a breath away from Catra's forehead.

Catra glares up, a wild grimace distorting her features.

"What are you gonna do to me?" She growls, making sure it sounds weak and pained.

Adora visibly swallows, the gun shaking in her hand.

She says nothing.

Catra is taken aback for a moment, trying to communicate with a flash of her eyes. *Come on*.

Dee calls for a cut.

Catra straightens and steps back on the X, sparing Adora a quick glance. She looks lost, confused, rolling her wrist with the Glock in her hand like she's unsure what it is and what it's for.

Adora doesn't meet her gaze when the second take starts. Catra goes over her part again, waiting for Adora to finally take over.

When she does, Catra wishes she fucking didn't.

"I haven't decided yet," Adora says, her voice flat and so strained like she's a kid at her first Christmas play with severe stage fright.

Catra snorts on a chuckle.

"What the fuck was that?" She asks, taking up on herself to ruin the shot.

She can hear Dee sigh, exasperated.

Adora furrows her brows at Catra, an offended twitch tugging on her lips.

"I said my line."

"Are *you* held at gunpoint?" Catra asks, voice trembling with suppressed laughter.

"Kids, play nice," Dee orders lazily, making a vague gesture towards them. "Go again."

Turns out, repeating only makes things worse for Adora. With every take, she gets more flustered, her voice sounding faker and faker. It's like she's never heard anyone speak normally, and can't even pretend to save her life. Her tone is all over the place, her voice breaks and trembles and jumps between octaves.

At the tenth take, Catra feels genuinely angry and reaches the boiling point. She can't keep her voice down anymore, snapping at Adora:

"What the fuck is your problem? You act like you've never done this before."

Adora grunts. She hides her face in her palm, pushing her shades higher on her nose. When she lets her hand fall, she is ready to let out whatever she managed to force down, yelling back:

"Well maybe I haven't!" She spreads her arms wide, swaying the prop gun and getting up in Catra's face desperately. "Maybe I'm used to punching people and jumping out of helicopters! I've never had lines before, okay?"

Catra throws her head back, arms crossed in front of her chest.

"Oh my God, you really are the worst," she grunts and lolls her head ahead again, leaning into Adora's space too. "You're exactly like

those assholes who give stunts a bad name. You're an *actress*, who acts for a living, so get your shit together and act!"

Dee steps between them, raising their palms so both Catra and Adora are forced to take a step back.

"Ladies, ladies, let's take a breather and calm down, alright?" Dee glances between them. Catra sees that sadistic gleam in their irises that shines clear as day, despite their concerned face. "I think we all need a little break," they say sweetly, eyes drilling into Catra's, "so we can do our very best to make today's shooting work."

Catra scoffs as Dee turns on their heel, keeping Catra's gaze as long as they can. Catra glares back, pushing her tongue to the inside of her cheek.

She walks past Adora then, speaking carefully so only she can hear:

"First meeting room on the left. Wait before you follow me."

Catra hears Adora's breath hitch. She keeps walking like nothing happened, reaching a corridor. She sneaks by a couple doors, offices and empty changing rooms, arriving at the one door she told Adora about.

Catra slides a hand on the knob and quickly looks around. There's no one in sight. Catra opens the door and slips inside, pulling it behind her very quietly.

It's dark inside, since the room has no windows or any source of natural light. Catra contemplates flipping the light switch, but she changes her mind. It's much safer like this.

So the room is dark, a little cold, and pretty empty. Catra's eyes are used to the dim light now; she can see the silhouettes of chairs around a round table, and a narrow sofa in the back. There are some potted plants here and there, and a water cooler with no water in it.

The door creaks open. Catra finds herself in the beam of warm light that pours inside from the corridor. She turns towards that, squinting.

Adora steps inside carefully, eyebrows furrowed. Her gaze flickers around the room before it settles on Catra, her confusion evident in the shining of her eyes.

She closes the door, dousing the light and muffling any sounds coming from the stage.

Catra reaches for Adora's wrist and pulls her close without hesitation. She turns them around so she can usher Adora back until her calves bump into the sofa. Catra pushes Adora down and crawls into her lap, supporting herself on her knees so her hand can freely slide between Adora's legs.

Adora jerks as Catra cups her through her clothes, her thumb pressing down.

Their eyes meet for a second - Adora's fall half-mast, lips popping open.

Catra moves her thumb, and swallows Adora's whimper when she catches her lips in a heated kiss. She draws back to grab Adora's wrists and slam her hands down onto the sofa, palms up. Catra puts her knees on them, trapping Adora so she cannot move.

"You need," Catra breathes between bites and pecks, her fingers fumbling with the buttons and zipper of Adora's pants now, "to *relax*."

Adora chokes on a noise that might as well have been a "yes." Catra lifts her palm to Adora's lips, silencing her as her right hand burrows under the waistband of Adora's briefs.

Adora moans into her hand, eyes squeezed shut. She's already wet from Catra's fingers stroking, sliding down to smear some of her shine up where she needs it. Adora huffs and squirms in Catra's grip, and Catra peeks up at the clock behind the sofa.

They only have four minutes left. She needs to make this quick; she goes heavy and rough, touching Adora with short little rubs up and down, her skin warming up from the friction. Adora is responsive, Catra's palm barely smothering her desperate moans, her knees and hands jerking to spread her legs wider where Catra's thighs straddle her.

It's not enough. A minute passes too quickly and Adora doesn't seem to get any closer to coming.

Catra grunts and sinks her teeth into Adora's jaw; her neck is covered too much by her stupid collar and they don't have *time*.

Shit. There's only one thing Catra can think of that might help.

So, she breaks a rule.

She presses her forehead to Adora's temple and whispers into Adora's ear:

"Be a good girl and just fucking come, okay?"

The reaction is even more sudden and eruptive than Catra expected - Adora growls, a deep rumble vibrating in Catra's palm and her hips buck, her heat tries to *suck* Catra's fingers in.

Catra's cheeks bloom with color, and she can't stop a giggle escaping from her.

"Oh, Adora," she goes on, her hand never slowing down, "I knew you were a people pleaser, but do you really wanna be praised that bad?"

Adora writhes under her, her nose whistling as she's out of breath. She's drenched now, flowing warm around Catra's fingers.

Finally.

"You gotta work for that, y'know," Catra teases, her voice a low, raspy purr. She licks behind Adora's ear to get closer, nuzzling. Adora's chest is heaving so hard it slams into Catra's with every rugged breath she takes.

Catra's head feels light, her skin tight and too hot, and she's spiraling out of control.

"What's it gonna be, Princess?" Catra hears herself say, coming from a distance like rain pitter-patters on the skin of a drum. "Will you earn your praise? Will you keep quiet if I draw my hand back from your mouth, so I can kiss you?"

Adora nods furiously, mumbling something unintelligible into Catra's palm.

Knowing it's nearly fucking impossible for Adora to keep the promise, and that she'll most likely get them both busted, Catra still moves her hand. She doesn't really care, at this point and - a more dangerous thought - she *wants* the whole fucking building to hear Adora scream her name.

But Adora keeps quiet. She is whimpering softly, biting down on her bottom lip so hard her pretty pink skin whitens around her teeth. She opens her eyes slowly, the blues of her irises gleaming, drilling into Catra's.

"Beautiful," Catra whispers and pulls Adora's lip with her thumb so she can keep her promise and kiss her.

Adora kisses back feverishly, her lips setting a pace similar to how Catra's hand works between Adora's legs.

Catra draws back slightly, Adora's lips still on hers.

"That's it, baby," Catra mumbles, grazing their noses together. Adora whimpers into her mouth, choking on silent sobs as her tongue strokes Catra's in a brief but desperate kiss. "*Shh*."

Catra cups Adora's cheek, her thumb stroking gently, her eyes falling shut. The words flow out of her mouth uncontrollably now, her mind barely registering what she's saying. "You're so good to me, Adora. You look so fucking pretty like this, so fucking wet for me." Catra kisses her cheek, teeth nibbling gently on her flushed skin. "My perfect little thing." Another kiss, another bite. "My good girl. Come for me, okay? Come for me."

It works again. Adora sounds like she's sobbing, but still manages to keep it low when she hides her face in the crook of Catra's neck, her mouth full of her leather jacket. Catra can feel the pressure of her teeth like this, barely biting through the layers of clothes.

Adora grinds her hips up and Catra presses back against the wave, keeping the heel of her palm for Adora to thrust up to.

"Good girl," Catra whispers again. She can feel her cheeks burning as she watches Adora's face from close when she comes. "There you go. Ride it all out, baby. You deserve it, you did so good -"

Adora looks fucking ethereal, falling apart from Catra's touch, and even better, from her words and her voice. Catra can't believe she deprived herself of this before, to drive Adora crazy with whispered little nothings, sweet or filthy alike, kissing them under Adora's flushed skin and having her writhe and whine for more.

After a couple rocks, Adora's ass plops back down onto the couch, her head rolling on the backrest. Her gasps are wet, tainted raspy with grunts.

Catra's head is pulsing, aching in the rapid beat of her heart. She slips out of Adora's briefs, staring at the pruney, shining pads of her fingers in a daze. Why the fuck is *she* out of breath?

And what the fuck has she just done? Who said all that shit? Not Catra. It couldn't be her. Fuck, it couldn't -

She stirs to get up, limbs shaking; as soon as Adora's hands are free again, they wrap around Catra's waist.

Catra freezes. Adora does nothing else; she doesn't pull her close, doesn't hug her, doesn't stroke along her spine. She just leaves her arms there, asking silently, and Catra stays until Adora's breathing slows down.

Catra looks up at the clock again. They have a minute left.

Adora lolls her head forward, back from the sofa. Their eyes meet again, the primal need stripped away, leaving nothing but bright emptiness and a thousand stupid questions.

Catra pushes back. Adora's arms fall from her waist, letting her leave and crawl out of her lap.

"Better?" Catra croaks as she stands straight, barely controlling her voice not to break.

Adora's throat bobs.

"Yeah," she breathes, her eyes too clear for someone who's just awakening from an orgasm.

"Okay." Catra turns her head away slightly, showing Adora her sharp profile without meeting her eyes again. "Don't overthink this," she warns both of them, quiet but firm.

She doesn't wait for an answer before she leaves the room, her body trembling with a fever.

Chapter End Notes

Don't worry I made sure Adora can't act, even in an actress AU.

Thank you so much for reading!! I'm so happy you guys seem to like this one too, and thank you so fucking much for 200+ subs. I truly hope this chapter was worth the wait - please leave me a

comment with your thoughts, they truly make my days and keep me going!

Please consider checking my socials (I keep my Twitter ~~1~~8 so please have your age in your bio or I will softblock you) and look out for illustrations, sneak peeks, and behind-the-scenes annoyance from me, there will be a lot :')
I love you all, stay safe, and cool, and come hang out with me on Tumblr or Twitter it's a fun time and I love talking to you. ♡

Rule #4

Chapter Summary

4. Make it quick.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is staring at the ceiling, her throat bobbing at a dry swallow. Her lips part again, breath still coming out in little huffs, despite her best efforts to calm down. Now Catra has already left, taking her warmth and her touch and that low, raspy voice that is like sweet venom injected into Adora's veins.

"*holy shit*," she breathes out loud, barely recognizing her own voice.

Too stunned and weak to move just yet, she feels like there's air inside her bones; as she tries to get up, clinging to the armrest of the sofa, her knees buckle and knock together.

Adora straightens, tapping herself up. She takes the path back to the stage like she'd be sleepwalking and twirls around in one place looking for her spot that is right in front of her nose.

"You're late," the PA tells her as she waves Glimmer over to touch on Adora's makeup.

Glimmer makes a face behind Juliet's back, making Adora snort on a giggle. She mops the sweat off Adora's face then, knitting her brows.

"Are you really this nervous?" She asks.

Oh that's such a great excuse. Brilliant. Adora is grateful for any kind of cover to hide the real reason why she's so hot and bothered, so

she rolls her shoulder awkwardly.

"You know it's my first time," she says. Which is still not a lie, considering what has just happened.

Adora endures Glimmer's brush tickling her face like a champion. She takes a deep breath to suppress a cough that strains her lungs from the powder twirling in the air, nostrils flaring.

"You got this," Glimmer chirps, her hand quickly squeezing Adora's between changing brushes. "You just need to focus! Turn off your brain and stop overthinking."

Adora scoffs, her voice low and flat: "So do I focus, or do I not think about it?"

"Yes."Glimmer gestures for Adora to close her eyes so she can work on her lids.

"Is everything alright?"Another voice asks from way too close.

Adora winces at the sudden noise, squeaking when Glimmer - who also got startled - poked her in the eye with the damn brush.

Adora blinks, and Glimmer shrieks: "Don't open your eyes!"

" *Sorry* ," Adora grumbles with an offended huff. "That's my go-to move when someone *stabs* me in the *eye* ."

"It's nice to see you've got your flare back, darling," Double Trouble continues. Adora can hear them grinning around the words. "Although you're still so flushed… isn't she so flushed? Dear God, I hope you're not sick!"

"I'm fine,"Adora says. "It's nothing."

Adora hears the rustling of Double Trouble's clothes and the shuffling of their steps as they circle her, their voice slithering from Adora's one ear to the other.

"This job puts so much pressure on you, doesn't it? Look at those shoulders, full of tension.. your broken posture, your shaky hands..."

"I'm *fine*."

"Maybe the two of us should talk, hm? You were so kind listening to me the other day, Adora. I should repay you somehow for helping me understand my feelings. Maybe I could do the same for you."

Adora opens her eyes just to meet Double Trouble's. She catches the questioning flash of Glimmer's eyes as she goes to work on the contour of Adora's cheekbone.

"That's really nice of you," Adora says, quiet but firm. "But I understand mine."

And I made her a promise.

Double Trouble's grin is all teeth and a sharp tongue they bite on.

"Whatever you say." They hold Adora's gaze as they ask Glimmer: "Is she ready?"

"Yeah, she's ready."

"Wonderful," Double Trouble says and snaps their fingers, swaying away, their attention already latching to other crew members on their way back to their chair.

As soon as they turn on their heel, Glimmer whispers:

"They're so fucking creepy sometimes."

"Yeah."Adora sets her jaw. "What the hell does Catra see in them?"

Glimmer whips her head up.

"Wait, what?"

Shit—

"What? Nothing. I didn't say anything."

"Catra has a crush on the director?" Glimmer's voice is dripping with contempt. She scoffs, rolling her eyes. "Why am I surprised? Of course she does. Well, they deserve each other."

"No, they don't," Adora says a little too loud. Shit, she really needs to get a better grip on this whole mess, but how? How can she act like nothing happened when all she hears is Catra's loving praises kissed under her skin and all she feels is the phantoms of her soft fingers stroking between Adora's thighs - and *soMEHOW* , Catra still wants to get back with her creepy ex, all the while said ex keeps asking Adora these weird, suggestive questions and they just *won't leave her alone* so it's so hard to keep her promise —

"Are you sure you're okay?" Glimmer asks, tilting her head to the side. She tries to touch Adora's hand but Adora draws back and starts backing away pointing behind herself.

"That's my cue. See you later ."

"Adora—"

Adora turns on her heel, rushing away. She quickly says her goodbye:

"Don't worry about me, okay? And please don't tell anyone what I said!"

Glimmer pinches her fingers together and seals her lips like a zipper .

Adora smiles gratefully.

Catra snarls, clutching her injured arm, hunching right in front of Adora; there are wild flames in her eyes, teeth shining bright, her

hair falling over her shoulder in the softest wave - seconds away from slipping off of it - flowing down to her chest.

She looks so beautiful.

"What are you gonna do to me?" She growls with a touch of pain, fingers twitching on her arm.

Adora exhales through her nose. Good question. She was thinking about the same thing, actually.

"I haven't decided yet," she says, earnest and dark; the dangerous promise of a sweet repercussion.

Catra's eyes widen only for Adora to see.

Adora tilts the angle of the Glock in her hand and grabs Catra by the collar of her leather jacket, tugging her close.

Catra keeps her knees weak, stumbling at Adora's pull. She raises her jaw, her snarl melting into parted lips, her body into submission.

Adora forces her features to harden. She presses the muzzle of the gun to Catra's jaw; without thinking, she improvises again. She strokes the muzzle down Catra's neck very slowly, following the path of her artery.

Catra trembles, gasping for air.

"Jus-just kill me already," she snaps. The stuttering wasn't scripted. "You won."

"I expected more from you," Adora says and pushes Catra away. Catra stumbles a couple steps and straightens, watching Adora throw the gun away, along with the broken sunglasses she snaps off her ears.

"What are you doing?"

Adora gets into position, tilting her jaw challengingly. She eases her voice, sounding playfully flirty now:

"I'm giving you one last chance to impress me."

Catra glares at her for a long time before she barks a laugh. She releases her arm; her palm is tainted red from the fake blood Adora can see under the sliced up leather jacket.

Catra mimics Adora's pose, her left foot slipping behind her.

"I'll make you regret taking pity on me."

Adora grins.

"Good."

"Cut!"

Catra drops her arms and turns on her heel, quickly slipping into the crowd.

Adora can barely stop herself from calling after her; thankfully, the round of applause that erupts around her is distracting enough. She slips a palm on the nape of her neck, grinning sheepishly. She didn't realize how the air had frozen in the room since they started rolling, drawing everyone's attention.

"Aw, come on guys," she mumbles.

"You did it!" Bow whistles from the side before he wraps Adora in his arms. "That was so dope. I held my breath the entire time!"

Glimmer comes from the other side, throwing herself into the pile.

"I believed in you!"

"Good job, darling."

Adora looks at Double Trouble, who is slow clapping as well while they approach. Their eyes shine dark and unsettling - how did Adora not notice how strange they are before?

"Thank you," Adora says carefully , unfolding from her friend's arms.

"I'm delighted that you've found a way to work through your stage fright. Your talent is exceptional, I see it now. You've got to tell us your secret."

Adora feels her cheeks flush with color. She crooks an arm around Glimmer's neck, pulling her close.

"Like my best friend said, I just needed to focus."

"Yeah, yeah, I'm always right," Glimmer says proudly .

Double Trouble squints, their grin widening.

"Isn't that lovely. Well, time for me to get back to work. See you tomorrow?"

Adora is confused for a second.

"Oh, um. I'm off tomorrow, actually."

Double Trouble strokes their face with their sharp nails, jaw popping open.

"Oh right," they drawl. "Silly me. I only have my kiss scene with Kiten."

Adora tightens the grip of her arm around Glimmer's neck subconsciously, making her choke. Glimmer croaks something weak but angry that resembles Adora's name.

"Shit, sorry." Adora stammers, drawing her arm back and grabbing it like it's a wild animal with a mind on its own. "Sorry ."

Double Trouble hums, flicking their fingers to wave at the three of them.

"Get some rest, darling. You deserve it."

Adora casts her eyes down, vision blurring. She nearly misses Glimmer calling her name, sounding like she's trying to yell at her from behind a closed door.

"What?" Adora winces at Glimmer's hand clasping around her shoulder. "I'm listening."

"Sure you are," Glimmer purses her lips. "I said we're going out to dinner with the others. Wanna come?"

Adora wets her lips quickly, her glance flickering around the stage.

Where the hell did she go?

"I—"

"You have a day off tomorrow," Bow reminds her. "Like DT said, you deserve to relax. You've been working so hard, we've barely had any chance to hang out since the production started."

"Which you promised we'd do!"

"Right. You're right, and I'm sorry, but-"

"Don't tell me you have a curfew," Glimmer jokes, poking Adora with her elbow. "Does Catra supervise when you go to bed?"

Adora lets out a curt, high little laugh that sounds totally normal. Bow and Glimmer share a quick glance before they turn their attention back to Adora, who finds herself laughing still.

Adora clears her throat, raising both hands defensively.

"I'll see what I can do, okay?" She tries a weak not-excuse excuse, not quite a no but less than a maybe. "I might join later on. I'll text you."

"Alright, weirdo," Glimmer shrugs, and yanks the strap of her makeup bag higher on her shoulder. "Well let it slide. This time. And only because Seahawk can't make it either."

"Still hope to hear from you. We'll leave at six."

"Noted," Adora says and salutes. "I'll text you anyway."

Adora walks away. Once she steps through the first door that separates her from curious eyes, she picks her pace up. By the time she leaves the building and makes a beeline for their trailer, she's running.

She finds it empty.

Adora took a shower, answered emails, scrolled through all her social media at least five times, did pushups on the floor, organized the few kitchen tools and knick-knacks in the cupboard by color, then size, then frequency of use, then did some more pushups.

Typical stuff to kill time.

She sat down then, which quickly turned into her throwing herself back on the bed.

She's staring at the bottom of Catra's top bunk now, still empty. Adora exhales with a deep sigh, raising both hands above her head on the pillow.

Where the *hell* is Catra?

Adora hasn't seen her since their scene, and that was hours ago. Even if she had other scenes to work on, she should have come

back already..right?

Catra's real last words to her are echoing in Adora's mind, mocking her. *Dont overthink this.* Yeah, right. Catra has known Adora for years. What's next? Asking her to stop breathing? Would be easier, honestly. One time, Adora held her breath for so long she passed out. It was jus t a stupid bet (that earned 12-year-old Adora twenty bucks), but she would rather do that again anywhere, anytime, than try to stop her thoughts from whirling like a vortex, pulling her down, down, down.

Adora pushes herself up again and turns towards the narrow window of the trailer. In the orange light of the setting sun, she sees people leaving the building in flocks, every department finishing up for the day.

Catra is not with them.

This is ridiculous .

Adora grabs her jacket and her keys, stepping into her worn out, red Chucks, and slips through the door without tying them.

The stage is covered in eerie, dullish half-light, slinking shadows sticking to the tripods and screens like giant bats, the only noise breaking the silence is the squeaking of Adora' s shoes.

She regrets sneaking in immediately; without the strobes and the lack of natural light, she feels like she's wandering around an abandoned - *haunted* - warehouse, not a fancy stage like how it looks during the day.

Adora sweeps her phone out of her pocket to get some light - at the same exact time, someone switches on a light to Adora's left. Adora

yelps quietly and drops her phone but manages to catch it mid-air, pressing it to her chest with both palms.

It’s the corridor she took to follow Catra into the meeting room. Adora can hear her own heart beating in her chest as she stays in the shadows, suddenly feeling like she’s trespassing. No one told her it would be forbidden to come back to the stage after the day is over, but it’s not something people usually do, either.

Adora hears fragments of a conversation, and she takes a couple hesitant steps closer, still moving hidden in the dark.

Someone raises her voice;it sounds raspy and furious.

It’s a voice Adora knows very well.

Adora straightens and turns onto the corridor, still pressing herself to the wall. The light comes from the cracked door, a flipped switch inside the meeting room.

Adora gets just a little closer, her back to the door. She doesn't dare peek yet - she’s just trying to hear more-

"doing that. Reassign me, *right now* ."

Another voice cuts in. Adora's blood runs cold, nails scratching against the wall.

"You think you're a wildcat, but your voice is still a kitten's."

"Don't underestimate me."

Double Trouble sighs, exasperated. Adora takes her chance to turn towards the crack, pushing the door a tiny bit more open to see both figures inside.

Double Trouble is sitting on the sofa, casually leaning on the armrest. Their legs are crossed, their foot in the air bouncing up and down impatiently.

Catra stands in front of them, showing her back to Adora; her posture is guarded, hands in shaking fists.

" *Ya-wn* ," Double Trouble says, and raise their brows playfully. "A re you done yet? You didn't really say anything new that I haven't heard from you already. And," Double Trouble raises from the sofa elegantly, cupping Catra's chin, "we both know this isn't what we're here for."

Catra growls low and slaps their hand away.

With the same temper, Catra yanks them close and kisses them.

Adora gasps loudly, twirling to get away, and - *shit* - knocking on the door with her phone in the process.

Catra pushes Double Trouble away and Adora ducks, scattering away with bent knees.

Adora hears Catra's panicked, breathless voice.

"What was that?! Is someone there?"

"Mm, doubt it."

"Don't fucking mess with me," Catra snaps again. "Y ou didn't bring me here for this, you brought me here to-"

"Relax, kitten," Double Trouble purrs, their voice getting more and more quiet. "And make sure you learn to control your emotions for tomorrow."

Adora reaches the end of the corridor and staggers to her feet, trying to leave the building as quickly and quietly as possible.

Her heart is hammering in her chest, her breath coming out in hoarse gasps, her throat so dry and tight it hurts.

She takes a couple uncertain steps towards the trailer, then halts. She turns on her heel, feeling out her car keys in her pocket, hanging from the same chain she keeps the key to the trailer.

Her truck is parked near the gate. She tears the door open and slips into the driver's seat.

She stares at her phone still in her hand. She messes up her code once, twice. She gets it right. Unlocks it. Opens her texts.

To: Bow

Where are you guys at? I'm coming too

The diner Adora's friends are at is more like a bar that serves pizza; it's all dark wood and grey bricks, neon lights and loud music.

Adora arrives when there are still a couple slices left on the huge plates, so she snatches one as she drags a chair from the empty table next to her friend's.

She plops down onto the chair, greeting everyone, mouth full of a huge bite.

It feels like rubber to chew; tasteless, dry, hard to swallow. Adora puts the slice down and rubs the crumbs off her hand.

"See, even Adora arrived before them, and she didn't even want to come," Mermista grumbles, gesturing lazily towards Adora.

"I wanted to come," Adora argues, crossing her arms on the table. "Who are you talking about?"

"Hi, everyone!" Someone chirps behind them. Adora turns her head; Perfuma approaches their table, hand in hand with a tall, buff girl Adora thinks she knows from somewhere, but it doesn't click yet.

The new girl lets Perfuma go ahead and plop down onto a seat next to Bow.

"So sorry we're late. W e didn't look at the time," Perfuma says.

Mermista rolls her eyes.

"*Eew* ."

Perfuma ignores her, patting the chair next to hers.

"Come on, honey! Everyone, this is Scorpia," she keeps a pause to giggle, "my *girlfriend* . Scorpia, this is everyone."

Bow is the first one to rise from his chair and hold out a hand.

"W elcome to the team! It's so nice to meet you of ficially."

"A ww! The feeling's mutual, buddy. Come on, bring it in," Scorpia says and wraps him in a painful-looking hug.

Scorpia hugs everyone around the table - Adora snorting on a laugh at the look on Mermista's face - then lastly, reaches Adora.

Scorpia's expression changes immediately; her big grin drops, eyebrows furrowing.

Adora tries, confused:

"Hi, I'm Adora?"

"I know ," Scorpia says. She reaches out a hand.

"No hug? Okay. Uh. Hello." Adora takes the hand, shaking it a couple times. "Do we, uh- sorry , do we know each other?"

I heard a couple things about you."

"*Really?*" Mermista asks, eyes flaring up at the smell of drama. "From who?"

Adora shoots her a glare. Mermista shrugs.

"My best friend," Scorpia says, sitting back next to Perfuma. "*Catra*."

Adora seems to be the only one surprised at that. Somewhere at the back of her mind, a memory starts to form from the haze - Perfuma mentioning someone who's fond of Catra at breakfast. Didn't Mermista call them Perfuma's girlfriend?

Ugh, great. Said girlfriend is here to spend time with them and be part of their friend group while she absolutely despises Adora.

Adora fidgets uncomfortably, but hasn't given up yet; she tries a smile she hopes is charming enough, and mumbles:

"Okay, well, hah. Yeah, she's- She's not so fond of me, but don't judge a book by someone else's description of the cover, right?"

Scorpia actually laughs, surprising herself the most. She clears her throat and hardens her expression again, turning her attention back to the others.

Okay. That's a start.

Adora reaches for the slice of pizza again, taking another bite to do something with herself.

The conversation starts up again. Adora tries her best to focus on everyone talking, forcing the next bite down her throat.

She still hasn't gotten her appetite back.

An hour later, Adora bursts into the bathroom in the back of the bar, stumbling into a stall and slamming the door closed.

She takes a deep, shuddering breath, and starts sobbing uncontrollably.

She reaches for toilet paper blindly, tearing off a handful. She feels pathetic hearing her own whimpers and how she is choking on sobs so hard her lungs start to burn.

Adora muffles the noise with the back of her hand pressed to her open mouth, rubbing her face dry with the toilet paper. It feels disgusting and rough; Adora's skin warms up from the rubbing, painting it even redder.

It takes her a couple minutes to calm down, the urge to throw up those hoarse cries coming in waves.

Adora straightens and sniffles. She tears off another handful of paper and blows her nose, throws it into the toilet and flushes it.

She inhales. Exhales. Unlocks the stall and slips out, only to bump into someone she absolutely *does not* want to perceive her like that.

"Hi," Scorpia says carefully, drawling on her words like she would talk to a stray dog without a leash. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah," Adora says swiftly. "Yeah, I'm totally fine. Why wouldn't I be fine? Everything is fine."

"It kinda sounded like you were crying in there?"

Adora snorts and steps to the sink to wash her face as an excuse to not look at Scorpia.

"Me? Crying? Pssh, no. Nah, that must've been someone else."

"Okay, I'll just-" Adora sees Scorpia point towards a stall, shuffling away. She halts after all, her sigh short and annoyed. "Dammit, I

can't. You're clearly going through something and I may not like you, but this isn't right."

Adora opens her mouth to politely decline, but it turns into a growl of protest when Scorpia picks her up and plops her down onto the counter between two sinks so they are eye to eye.

"Talk to me, buddy."

"I- look, I appreciate you trying to help but"... Adora growls again, irritated by herself this time. She dries her face with the edge of her shirt and confesses as quickly as possible: "I have no idea what's wrong. I just... I had to let it out. I dont know why."

Scorpia hums, cocking a brow kindly.

"Looks like your heart already knows something your mind refuses to believe."

Despite feeling like shit, Adora grins.

"You already sound like Perfuma."

"Yeah, that was a direct quote from her."

Adora sniffs. She curls her fingers around the edge of the counter, hanging her head. Something breaks in her from Scorpia's surprisingly determined efforts to help, so she finds herself talking before she could even think about what she's saying:

"It's just that— I think it's just that I have this girl who I've been— uh. We've been. We've been baking cakes. Yeah, we've been baking cakes for a couple years now, and that's kind of, so that's all we do, but lately she's- she's changed the, the, the toppings. She changed the topping and turns out the cakes are even more delicious that way but she seems to think it wasn't a good idea and she's been ignoring me, and also, she has this other person she used to bake cakes with, and she wants to bake cakes with them again and they want to

bake cakes with her again and they've already started like… like. Mixing the bowl, and I thought I was fine with that since it's just baking cakes and nothing else, but she's so… so damn good. At baking. And maybe- maybe I'm not actually okay with that. Yeah. Yeah, I'm not. I don't— I don't want her to bake cakes with anyone else but me." Adora takes a breath for the first time since she started talking, looking up at Scorpia. "You know?"

If Scorpia wasn't absolutely sure that Adora was crazy before, by the look on her face, she has no doubt now.

Adora raises her hands, hopping off from the counter.

"You know what? I already feel better from you just listening to me. Thank you so much. Go pee."

And with that, Adora turns her back to Scorpia, skittering away.

She does feel lighter in her steps now; maybe it's the relief of crying and letting it all out, or maybe she wasn't lying - she does see things more clearly now.

She wants Catra to keep her whatever-they-are with benefits status only for Adora.

And with that, the perfect plan already starts to form in Adora's mind.

Now, she just needs to get Catra alone in their trailer and show her what she would be missing.

Catra hasn't been back for two nights.

Adora is starting to actually lose her goddamn mind. Catra is still there during the day; she's working on her scenes (Adora made sure she was not even close to the stage where her and Double Trouble

had their kiss scene), going to the cafeteria, chatting with Scorpia at MUAH, but she spends the nights somewhere else.

Adora doesn't want to know where.

Now it's the fourth day since the ominous Last Time, and Adora feels absolutely miserable. Sure, they've had months between sleeping together before, but that was because they couldn't even meet. Since this production has started and they've been stuck together, it felt so natural that they've been having sex more. It felt right. Needed.

Adora unlocks the trailer door with a sigh, stepping inside fully expecting to find it empty tonight, too.

She's wrong.

Catra is laying on her belly, propped up on her elbows on the top bunk with her back towards Adora. Adora can't see what she's doing but from the quiet rustling of paper, she must be reading something.

Adora closes the door a bit too loudly, so her presence is well known. Catra doesn't even flinch.

Adora feels her hands curl into fists.

Okay, this ends now.

Adora unzips her jacket and drags it off her arms, throwing it on her bed. She kicks her sneakers off as well, hands on the ladder - and starts to climb up to the top bunk.

Catra still doesn't move or look at her. She doesn't react in any way when Adora climbs above her, reaching for the open book in front of her. Adora closes the cover and pulls it away, tossing it down onto her own bed under them.

The book hits the blanket with a heavy thud.

Catra doesn't move.

Adora touches Catra's curls carefully, smoothing them behind her ear to see her face better.

"You've been avoiding me," Adora says, quiet but firm.

Catra scoffs and starts to stir, finally; she rolls onto her side, looking Adora in the eye with the usual challenging flames.

"Because we have nothing to say to each other. And I don't want to fuck you."

"Then why are you holding me?"

Catra snaps her hand back from Adora's waist like she touched fire.

"You broke a rule," Adora goes on.

"I wouldn't have to do it if you didn't fuck up so many takes. Someone had to fix the mess you made."

Adora narrows her eyes. She lays a little heavier on top of Catra, making her turn onto her back fully. Adora's fingers wander to Catra's jaw, stroking along the sharp line before cupping it.

"I still think you deserve to be punished for it." Catra's eyes darken. "I think"... Adora brings Catra's face closer, until she could count her freckles, "that it's only fair that I've got to break a rule now, too."

"Do you," Catra grumbles, but her voice barely has an edge. She fidgets a bit to feel more comfortable, her hands coming back to settle on Adora's waist and on her navel, fingers spread. "Let's say you have a point. Which one would you break?"

Adora doesn't have to think about it.

"*Make it quick*."

Catra exhales with an annoyed grunt, fingers twitching on Adora's shirt.

"Is that also my punishment?"

Adora grins, cocking her head.

"If that's how you want to take it."

Adora can see Catra swallow, her lashes fluttering. She goes a little rigid under Adora, but she tries to hide and ease it immediately with a roll of her shoulders. Adora props herself on her hands, putting distance between them.

"Talk to me."

Catra keeps quiet for a while, glaring up at Adora. Her gaze flickers around on Adora's face like she is looking for something.

If she found it or not, Adora cannot decide.

Still without words, Catra grabs a fistful of Adora's shirt and reels her back in, guiding her on top of her. Catra's hands come up to wrap around Adora's chest as she slips a thigh between Adora's legs pretentiously.

"Catra."

"Punish me," she says quietly. Her voice breaks at the end, a strange shine in her eyes is like a dagger twisting into Adora's chest.

Adora's throat tightens. She presses their foreheads together, the tips of their noses grazing.

"I'm going to savor you," she whispers, peeking up from Catra's lips to her eyes. "I can always punish you later. But right now-" Adora presses her body tight to Catra's, a hand in her hair and the other on her warm cheek, thumb pulling down Catra's bottom lip. "I'm going

to take care of you, spoil you rotten, and I'm only going to stop when your legs are shaking."

Catra's lips pop open. Adora kisses her, mouth closed, moving her lips gently. She takes Catra's upper lip between hers, adding just a touch of pressure, sweet and promising.

Catra makes a broken noise at the back of her throat, nose huffing. She claws into Adora's shoulders, who promptly ignores the wordless order and doesn't deepen the kiss just yet.

She hums a negative reply into Catra's lips, only parting to tilt her head to the other side. Her hand slides from Catra's cheek to her neck, stroking with just the tips of her fingers.

Slow kissing Catra in her own bed is not something Adora would ever imagine happening. She kinda feels like this isn't real, that Catra laughed at her face at the suggestion of breaking another rule and left for the night again, and this whole scene is just Adora's masturbation fantasy.

But Catra trembles under her now, which is very real, her hips bucking.

Adora's hand comes to grab Catra's hip, pushing her back into the bed and grounding Adora herself. She decides to spare Catra, though - she parts her lips, inviting, and lets Catra deepen their kiss, whimpering into her mouth.

Adora grins, trying her best to keep their kiss lingering and herself silent. It's never been harder to keep her mouth shut while being with Catra. Her hand slips under Catra's long-sleeve shirt, crumpling it up to her neck, exposing her heaving stomach and simple black bra.

Adora breaks the kiss, pressing her lips to Catra's cheek now, peppering the path to the hollow of her neck with little pecks. Catra's breath already hitches at every single one, her back curving under Adora.

Adora tightens the grip of her hand in Catra's hair, tilting her chin up. Her other hand draws gentle strokes all over Catra's chest and arms, and her kisses turn open-mouthed, then into bites, going down between Catra's breasts, along her navel, to the waist of her jeans—

"Cherry ," Catra gasps, voice high with panic.

Adora jerks up, sitting up on her heels and releasing Catra.

Catra is panting, the path on her skin Adora's lips followed is flushed.

"You can't touch me there with your mouth," she breathes hoarsely, referring to another rule.

"I know," Adora reassures her, softening her voice. "I know, I wasn't going to."

Catra nods sharply. Her glance is still shaky, a little hazy , and she doesn't say their code for Adora to continue yet.

Adora sucks her lips in. Maybe the sudden change of their usual power play was too much of a risk to take.

"Hey ," Adora whispers. Catra's eyes snap to her face. "Do you want to stop?"

"No," is all Catra says. Her breathing has eased at least, but she still looks conflicted; whatever wall she's trying to break through is still standing between her and allowing Adora to touch her again.

Adora's chest tightens painfully. She can't let Catra feel uncomfortable with anything. This was not supposed to go like this. She needs to fix this.

"Are you sure?"

"Yes," Catra hisses through gritted teeth, squeezing her eyes shut. "I'm just- *fuck* ."

"I would never do anything to you that you're not okay with," Adora says. "Tell me what you need, Catra. We can talk about everything I've been planning to do to you before we start again. Or..." Adora knows she's about to take another risk, desperately trying to find the right way to offer this. "We could talk, too. Like... you were talking to me before."

Catra makes a face, combing through her hair.

"Another rule to break?"

"Uhh, *you* broke it first," Adora jokes, pointing a finger gun at her. Catra mimics her grin, and something shifts in the air.

"You're so weird."

"Yeah." Adora stays put while Catra sits up as well, leaning on her hands behind her back.

Catra's eyes shine mischievously now, her grin melting into a smirk. She tilts her head to the side, her wild tufts curl in front of her face, eyes falling half-lidden before she looks up at Adora.

"What were you planning to do to me, Adora?"

Adora swallows thickly. The way Catra's eyes hold her captive now makes her cheeks warm up, and leaves her tongue tied.

"I'm, uh—I was. I was going to—um. So." She clears her throat.

"Mm-hm," Catra hums. She wraps her arms around Adora's neck, pulling her close, moaning into her mouth: "That's so hot. I'm so turned on."

"Shut up," Adora scoffs, laying back down with Catra, her hand on the small of Catra's back. Their clothes are rustling, the bed creaking under their weight. "I changed my mind. You don't get to talk."

"Too late."

"You're goddamn annoying, you know that?"

"Part of my irresistible charm," Catra sighs. Her hair flows all over the pillow like spilled ink, her hands on Adora's shoulders. "Come on. Humor me."

Adora wets her lips. Things have gotten even more surreal now; the way they're so close just for the sake of each other's warmth, how they get to joke and talk in a way they haven't before, Catra pulling her in instead of pushing away, agreeing to Adora's terms and playing *her* game.

Can Adora even do this?

"I was going to mark you," Adora says, her voice barely a whisper. "Kissing all over your body, avoiding all sensitive spots until every little touch feels too much. Drive you mad, make you whimper and writhe under me. I wanted to see you bite your lips to swallow my name you're not not allowed to say." She has Catra's full attention now, those pretty eyes with blown-out pupils latching onto Adora's. They make her find her voice, going on louder and rougher. "I was going to undress you with my teeth, grind on you slowly, kiss you breathless, make you forget everyone else—" Adora clips her words, unwelcomed images flooding her mind. She tried so hard not to think about *that*, but it might be too late now; she said too much, she's messed up again. Catra will never allow her to be this possessive, this desperate, she would never let Adora have her like that, this isn't what they're supposed to be—

"Okay," Catra says, hands still on Adora's shoulders, squeezing now.

Wait—

"Okay?"

"Yeah, dumbass," Catra giggles, and there's that adorable little tingle Adora has heard before but never earned, dripping down her throat like honey. "Don't get too cocky. I'll tell you if I want it harder. But"…

Catra drops her hands next to Adora’s ears and raises her jaw. "We can start things your way."

Adora's head feels so light, her heart beating so fast she barely hears Catra's words from the drumming noise echoing in her ears.

Adora grabs Catra's crumpled turtleneck with both hands, pulling it off her slowly, then she leans down for Catra's lips again. Catra goes numb under Adora's weight, giving in; she arches up, just to feel closer rather than seeking friction she knows Adora will not let her have just yet.

Catra's cute little noises of encouragement that she whimpers and gasps into Adora's kisses blur Adora's vision, making her feel giddy, her whole body burning so hot. She needs to grip the sheets for balance, rolling her hips down mindlessly.

They're still both fully clothed from the waist down, which burns Adora's skin even more - too rough, too tight, too itchy, useless scraps of fabric keeping them apart.

Adora deepens their kiss with another taunting wave of her hips and a squeeze of Catra's ass, holding her up.

Catra opens her legs wider. She crosses her ankles behind Adora's back, slips a hand on the nape of Adora's neck, her lips parting with a needy mewl and-

Adora's name spilling from them like a plea.

Adora freezes, her eyes widen. She draws back, breath coming out in a shaky gasp. She meets Catra’s eyes - shocked and round, just like hers - and whispers:

“Say it again.”

“Not a fucking chance,” Catra breathes weakly.

"Fine." Adora kisses her again, all tongue and teeth now, pulling back way too soon to tug on a fistful of Catra's hair. "I'll make you."

Catra cries out at Adora's teeth sinking into her neck. She claws at Adora's shoulders, nails coming up to her neck; Adora grunts around the bite, shoving Catra's hands back down to the bed.

She raises her chest, fingers curling tight around Catra's wrists. She shakes her ponytail behind her shoulder, scowling at Catra.

"I know what you're doing." Catra raises her brows questioningly , pretty face blank and innocent. "I know you're trying to rough me up so I'll forget about taking you slowly. Nice plan, but it wont work."

Adora's features shift into a playful grin. She sits up with Catra's legs still wrapped around her waist so she's practically sitting in Adora's lap. Catra narrows her eyes at her, and yet, she melts into Adora's touch when she places her fingers around the nape of Catra's neck.

Adora hooks her fingers into the high waist of Catra's jeans, yanking her close. "I think I figured out the perfect punishment for you."

Chapter End Notes

Hello I am Alive :'DDDD

Thank you so so much for your support on this fic, and for being patient with me!I do hope this chapter left you with a "ok, worth the wait"taste in your mouth, I promise I'll bring you Chapter 5 not-this-late. I am afraid to make any clearer promises.

Please consider saying hello to me on Twitter (I keep it 18+ so please have your age in your bio or I will block you), send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or anonymously on CuriousCat (where you can also leave me

prompts and suggestions for both art and drabbles!)
I love you all, stay safe, and see you next time!

Rule #5

Chapter Summary

5. This is just sex

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I know what you're doing," Adora says. "I know you're trying to rough me up so I'll forget about taking you slowly. Nice plan, but it wont work."

Catra forces her expression into a blank canvas, her heart hammering behind her ribs at the thought of being caught.

Fine, maybe she was. Maybe it's difficult to be with Adora right now - maybe it feels just as scary as it feels like fucking salvation because each stroke of the tips of Adora's fingers, each ragged breath burning on Catra's neck is a stab and a twist through her insides.

She wants more.

She wants to get out.

Adora sits up with her now, a palm on the nape of Catra's neck and her fingers hooked into Catra's jeans, bright eyes and bright teeth shining in the shadow Catra casts on her.

"I think I figured out the perfect punishment for you," Adora says with that stupid loopy grin that makes it sound like the least threatening threat. It's annoying. And endearing.

Catra leans into the touch, her spine curving towards Adora like flowers reaching for the sun.

"And what would that be?" She asks.

"Well," Adora swallows thickly, throat bobbing, "let's just say I'll need you to warn me when you're close to coming."

Catra barks a curt laugh. She grabs a fistful of Adora's shirt above her core, pulling her in.

"Are you seriously planning on edging me?"

"No?" A pause. "Yes." The crest between Adora's eyebrows deepens, framing the most perfect puppy eyes look Catra has ever seen on anyone. "Is that okay with you?"

"Yeah," Catra hears herself say. She's stroking Adora's shirt absentmindedly, playing with the fabric hoping that it would dissolve between her fingers. Adora wearing clothes is definitely more frustrating than Adora naked. If Catra needs to be edged for that sight, so be it. "I guess it fits into breaking rule four."

Adora dares to grin even wider at that, and says "Cool." *Cool*.

Catra wants to *scratch* her.

She swallows back that thought and tugs on Adora's shirt instead. Adora frees her hands and lets Catra undress her, slow and steady as Adora has done, too. Catra lets the shirt fall down onto the bed and presses her palms to the warm flesh of Adora's breasts peeking out of her sports bra. Adora's breathing falters, chest falling, and Catra presses on tighter.

Their eyes meet.

"So?" Catra urges, tilting her jaw. She leans close, but not close enough for their parted lips to meet. "Did you get scared because I said yes?"

Adora kisses her instead of giving an answer. Catra can't say she minds as Adora's tongue caresses her lips open, tasting her sweetly.

Catra lets her breathing slow down and her heart rate pick up, both so out of her control by now. Adora holds her tight and hot, a hand in her hair and a hand unbuttoning Catra's jeans.

Adora strokes Catra's ass so she'd rise from her lap and Adora can drag the jeans down on her thighs. Catra obeys, slipping them further down, shaking wild curls out of her face.

"Didn't you say you'd undress me with your teeth?" She asks, trying her best to play it flirty and not disappointed. Her stomach tightens at the thought that Adora's mouth is in the perfect position to nip at the sensitive skin above her belly button, and fuck, she leans in and does so-

"I meant your underwear," Adora whispers onto the faint bite marks, peeking up at Catra. "I want to see you naked."

"Only if you will be, too."

"Do you want that?"

Catra scoffs, throwing her jeans and sitting back into Adora's lap, arms wrapped around her shoulders.

"Do you think I've been fucking you for years because I think you're ugly?"

"Well, no, but-" Adora licks her lips, shuddering at Catra's fingers untying her ponytail and combing through her hair. "You never really said anything before..you know. The one in the meeting room."

Catra's face blooms with color, but her smirk stays unfaltered. Now she leans in to kiss Adora and leans back haughtily, bringing Adora forward and on top of her again. With their chests pressed together and Adora kissing her breathless, Catra gasps for air.

"You're such an idiot," she whispers between two pecks, cupping both of Adora's cheeks. She averts her gaze from Adora's eyes to

her lips as she says: "I think you're beautiful."

Adora's laugh is sweet and short. She gives Catra another short kiss on the lips before she goes back to caressing down her throat, her cold teeth making Catra shiver.

"I think you're beautiful, too," Adora sighs.

Catra's breath hitches and breaks into a wet, hoarse gasp in her throat. Adora is still so fucking slow; she had only just reached Catra's breastbone, nipping gently at her skin. It's not enough.

"Take them off," Catra pleas. She hates how desperate she sounds, how fucking evident it is in the weakness in her voice, but there's nothing she can do about it now.

Adora's eyes snap to her face. Her expression melts into something so, so fond and Catra burns under that gaze - gasoline to her flames as she swallows against the lump in her throat.

Adora keeps her promise. She uses her teeth to pull the straps of Catra's bra off her sharp shoulders; the pads off the curves of her breasts, leaving hot, open-mouthed kisses in their wake.

Catra's back arches as Adora's head descends on her body in a new path of bites, reaching the waistband of Catra's underwear. Her sigh warms the fabric in a sensation that shouldn't have such an effect on Catra.

Catra's breath stutters, her hand snaps to grab Adora's hair above her forehead subconsciously. Her grip eases as she tries to stay in control, but tightens again quickly. She squeezes her eyes shut.

"Can I?" Adora asks, her thumb stroking calming circles on Catra's thigh. "I'm just taking it off. I promise."

Catra exhales with a huff. She rubs her cheek with the palm of her free hand, growling:

"Fuck, stop being so- so *you* ."

"What?" Adora asks, confused. "What am I?"

Catra releases Adora's hair and opens her eyes. She props herself up on an elbow and draws her fingers back from the mess of Adora's fringe, curling them all except her index; she presses the pad of her finger to Adora's forehead, gently poking.

"Ridiculous," Catra says. Adora snorts. "Oh, that's not what you expected me to say, is it?"

"I genuinely don't know what I expected," Adora says, grinning. She brings Catra's knee higher so she can lean onto her inner thigh, nuzzling. She presses a kiss and peeks up from down there, her lashes tickling Catra, making her shiver. "So?" Adora hooks her thumb under the waistband. "Will you let me?"

Catra cocks her jaw .

Adora kisses Catra's thigh again, her palm caressing up and down her leg.

She asks, quietly:

"Just trust me, okay?"



Catra's throat tightens as those words rush through her nerves like lightning.

Trust me.

Of course she does. She always has.

2018 My

Catra was over this shit.

She's been attending casting calls every single day for two weeks now, her manager clearly not giving a shit about what she would be comfortable with. On the contrary, he's told Catra many times that she'll take what she's given or she should find another career she's actually dedicated to - unlike this one, apparently.

So Catra set her jaw and grit her teeth and tried her fucking best to sell herself in such breathtaking roles as *secretary for five seconds*, and *drunk college girl #3* , or the part she was trying to get now - *dead softball coach* for a shitty cop show.

This one, at least, was gay enough and the death scene seemed pretty intense. Catra could finally show her stunt abilities, trying to shift her path towards something new and far away from the purgatory of extras.

Obviously, they didn't care about any of that. Catra went in, said two lines, screamed once, and they thanked her languidly.

Catra was fanning herself with the stupid script as she slammed the door open a little too rough, nearly crashing into the next girl in line.

Catra growled, barely paying attention to her:

"Break a leg."

The girl huffed, offended.

"*You* break a leg," she said, grabbing the doorknob after Catra. She straightened her spine confidently, towering above Catra who was still trapped between the girl's chest and the door. Her voice sounded playfully smug then, with just a pinch of frustration like a flavorful spice. "*I'm* getting the part."

Catra finally looked at her. She shouldn't have.

That's a fucking Amazon .

Catra quickly ran her gaze along the girl's body, noting every honorable detail - the broad shoulders curved like marble, peeking out from a tank top that clung to the valleys of her abs; bright blue eyes shined like half-moons as her cheeks grew round from her wide grin;her hair flowing behind her , threads of gold.

The girl quirked a brow at Catra's silence, growing a little uncertain. She drew her hand back, giving Catra a clear path to leave if she wanted to.

She didn't want to. But she had to.

"Alright, hotshot," Catra purred and crossed her arms in front of her chest, twirling away on her tiptoes. Her eyes never left the girl's, whose cheeks got more and more visibly flushed. "Whatever you say."

Catra forced herself to leave the waiting room, closing the second door which put a very unnecessary distance between her and the hot stranger.

What the fuck was her problem, anyway? Catra was being nice. Well, for her it was very nice to wish her competitor good luck, and she just-

Okay. Wait. Wait a fucking minute. It couldn't be that the girl has never heard of that saying before, could it?

Catra's index finger hovered over the elevator button. She couldnt bring herself to press it; instead, she turned on her heel and leaned her back against the wall. She laced her fingers together behind herself and rolled her shoulders back. Something started to boil inside her veins, in the frantic beat of her heart.

It was crazy . Catra *knew* she was being crazy , but just five minutes later, when the girl stepped out of the waiting room again and their eyes met for the second time, Catra also knew that she had made the right decision.

The girl exhaled through her nose, thick brows furrowed. Hesitantly, she stepped next to Catra, and pressed the elevator button blindly as her gaze wandered down from Catra's face to her neck and chest.

"Hey , hotshot," Catra greeted her .

"Are you actually planning on breaking my legs?" The girl asked, clearly confused, eyes snapping back to Catra's face. "Are we taking this outside?"

Oh my fucking god.

The elevator doors opened with a loud ding and she stepped inside, peeking back at Catra over her shoulder. "You know I could easily take you, right?"

Catra slithered after her, lowering her voice into a raspy purr.

"You could, huh?"

The girl's face bloomed with color again. She licked her lips, staring straight into Catra's eyes.

"I'm just saying, I'm- I'm much bigger than you."

"You certainly are."

"First floor?"

Catra shrugged.

"Sure."

The girl pressed the F button, framed in a baby blue glow. The doors closed on them again, and the elevator started to descend with a little jump and shake that tugged on Catra's already aching core.

The girl was staring straight ahead now, her jaw set. Catra took advantage of the chance to look, musing over the girl's face; it was

evident that the girl felt Catra's gaze on her from the little winces she tried to hide by curling her hands into fists. Her lips were moving, too, like she was trying to either press them into a straight line or bite down on her lower lip.

Catra moved a tiny bit closer - just enough that her elbow brushed the girl's arm.

The girl choked on a noise. Catra could have sworn that she *heard* electricity cracking in the air, her hair rising on her arms.

The girl slammed her whole palm on the panel with a growl; the elevator stopped between two floors with a rough jolt.

Fucking finally, the girl twirled towards Catra, bright blue eyes gleaming. She reached her in the narrow space with one big leap, forearms thrown to the wall with Catra's head between them. She pressed her body closer to Catra, but not close enough for them to touch yet. She breathed out curt and loud, her pupils blown out as she was looking at Catra full of warm hope and excitement.

Catra grinned. She grabbed the girl by the belt loops and pulled her in, tiptoeing for her lips.

The girl tilted her head and craned her neck, kissing Catra like she was the first swallow of air after nearly drowning. Catra felt her shivering against her, her body burning hot.

Catra brought her even closer, and slipped a hand onto the girl's ass.

She gasped into Catra's open mouth.

"I haven't - *ah* - I haven't done this before," she mumbled between Catra's licks, lips parted and ready.

"Haven't fucked someone before?" Catra asked, drawing back cautiously. She was ready to step back and start the elevator again.

"No, uh-" The girl said hurriedly, clinging to Catra's waist. "Hooking up with a stranger."

Right. Catra hasn't, either, but she wasn't going to tell this random chick that. As far as this girl was concerned, Catra was the fucking *queen* of hooking up in an elevator with someone she's just met.

So Catra kissed her again, even deeper this time, an arm wrapped around the girl's neck. Her other hand was still on her ass; Catra slipped a thigh between the girl's legs and sunk her nails into her jeans.

The girl fucking whimpered now, getting more handsy as she followed Catra's lead to touch and feel more.

"When was - *oh fuck* - when was the last time you got tested?"

"Last month," Catra breathed. She pulled on the girl's dumb ponytail and kissed down her jawline now, reaching her neck to latch to.

The girl's knees grew weak under her, but she was still *fucking talking*.

"Y-you're not dating anyone, right?"

"Jesus *fuck*, no," Catra growled and bit the girl's neck hard as a warning. The girl rocked her hips forward subconsciously.

"*Oh my God—*"

"How can you be this annoying?"

"Annoying?" The girl parroted, offended. "I wanna do this right! And it's called being *respectful,* by the way. Have you heard about that—"

Catra brought the girl's hips forward again to silence her, muffling her whimper with another quick peck.

"*Listen* ," Catra hissed impatiently, drawing back just a little bit. The girl looked ruined already; her ponytail coming undone, lips flushed rosy and full. "Let me tell you how this is gonna go."

The girl's shoulders dropped. She was clearly calmed down by that.

"Okay , thank you."

"We're both healthy, consenting single adults so you're going to shut the fuck up, fuck me with your thigh, we both come, and then we leave. Okay?"

The girl nodded, her chest already heaving for what is to come.

"Okay ," she whispered and cupped Catra's cheeks softly. "I'd like that."

Great. Of course the hottest girl Catra has ever seen had to be weird. Of course she couldn't get someone who was quick and efficient; but one who pulled stupid shit like that, touching her like she was a fragile little thing when she's not—

The girl kissed her rough, teeth pulling Catra's bottom lip. (*Oh* .) Her hands slipped into Catra's hair, tugging with a little grunt Catra felt rumbling through her own chest.

Catra fumbled with her ripped leggings, pushing them down her thighs and over her knees along with her underwear, the girl leaning down with her so that their lips would never leave each other's.

Catra noticed that the girl's hands were moving, too, mirroring Catra's moves to lose her jeans and briefs. Catra sensed that the girl was going to want to stop and look, so she left her no time to do so - Catra's thigh was back between the girl's, dragging up with a slow wave of her hips.

The girl was, well, being really *loud,* and Catra found herself reacting to it in a way that was not exactly what she was used to. She knew

the girl could feel how drenched Catra was from how she was flowing down her thigh, and the sounds of the friction of their skin were making Catra lose her mind.

Catra threw her head back, her hands on the small of the girl's back and her ass (*round, rock hard and pretty pink like a fucking peach, and God fucking help Catra if she didn't want to bite into it*-). Without having to say or ask for anything, the girl's lips were on her neck, kissing and nipping not quite hard enough to leave a mark. Catra let her moans spill free from her mouth, melting into the girl's gasps in a strange, almost melodic harmony.

Catra's mind barely registered how warm the girl's body was, how wet she felt, how soft her skin and curls were as they crashed into Catra's thigh like waves. Catra didn't have to say anything for the girl to ride her harder, rough little thrusts feverish enough to bring Catra closer to pleasure without pain, the desperate wish to come together tugging on the strings of her heart.

The girl's palms cupped Catra's breasts and squeezed, needy but gentle, grunting at the sensation of finding her braless under her top. Curls of Catra's hair stuck to the girl's lips as she sucked on her throat, some fluttered free with every ragged breath she took.

Catra knew they were both close, which was a relief that still felt like bitter bile she couldn't swallow. She let the flow take her higher and higher, and the next growling bite the girl left close to Catra's ear made her come undone.

Catra's lungs rattled and her legs slipped further away. The girl held her through the aftershocks; she claimed Catra's thigh for a couple more rocks and she was coming, too, her whole body shaking violently as she was crying out and whining into Catra's neck.

There was a heartbeat of silence. Then, the girl nuzzled the spot behind Catra's ear, earning a gasping jolt.

"*Wow*,"she sighed.

Catra was already wanting more, the painful throbbing between her legs picking up again. She *hated* it.

With both of them breathing heavily, Catra managed to reach out from under the girl's body and start the elevator up again.

The girl's chest was still heaving and flushed when she drew back languidly, knees buckling under her. She kept her balance with a palm on the wall as she got some tissues out of the pocket of her hoodie.

She offered them for Catra.

Catra took one.

They cleaned up hurriedly, facing away from each other. Catra dragged up her leggings, peeking back over her shoulder.

The girl was holding the shiny tissue in her hand, dazed and unsure of what to do. Catching Catra's eyes, she quickly crumpled it in her fist, shoving it back into a different pocket than where she took it out from.

The elevator stopped with a little bump just when the girl opened her mouth to say something.

Catra slipped through the crack of the doors as soon as she was able to.

"Wait, wait," the girl shouted. She sounded a little raspy now, her voice breaking. "What's your name?"

Catra picked up the pace without looking back.

We both come, and we leave, is what they had agreed on - and that was exactly what Catra was going to do.

Didn't matter if she felt sick to her stomach knowing that she was never going to see her again.

2018 December

Catra was fucking wrong, of course.

She had just finished the last take of her first stunt job, and was walking off set. She felt energized, hyped up, every fiber of her body vibrating with excitement for finally being able to do the kind of work she's always wanted.

Her good mood didn't last long.

Catra came around a group of people chatting and giggling loudly. She growled as she tried to push her way through - the group fucking flooded the whole area in front of the door, and they were so lost in their own little world that they didn't hear Catra's annoyed "*excuse me*"s.

Fine. Catra shoved two people apart with her shoulders. The smaller figure puffed up immediately, shrieking:

"Hey , watch out!"

"You watch out," Catra snarled. "Some of us are working, and have places to be."

The girl's pink hair rose up until it looked like cotton candy. The kind-looking guy Catra also pushed away cupped her shoulder, squeezing. The girl grimaced, but closed her mouth, calming down immediately.

"It's okay, we did kinda stand in the way," he says, raising his eyebrows at Catra. "There was no need to push us, though."

Catra growled and kept walking.

"*Fine.* Sorry," she said, raising her voice as she moved away from the group. She only turned her head back, asking: "Happy now?"

A new voice cut through the whispered grumbling of the group, and Catra caught a glimpse of a golden ponytail behind the group.

"Hi, guys! Is everyone-" The voice faltered, melting into something mellow. "Wait, are you-?"

Catra turned back ahead and kept walking, shoving her hands into her pockets. Her body was set on fire, the vibrating excitement back in her muscles.

"No, I'm not,"she said, but didn't really know why .

Did she start to panic? She had no reason to.

Get a fucking grip.

Catra picked up the pace when she heard footsteps echoing behind her, the girl's voice following her like twirling smoke.

"Hey , wait," she begged, huffing desperately. "You don't remember me?"

I remember you at night when I'm trying to fuck my pillow like it's your thigh, wishing my hands were yours because they felt so much better on my tits than my own.

"Adora, where are you going?" The pink girl shouted pettishly. "We're not gonna make it back in time!"

Adora. The name suited her, in an annoying, pretentious way. Perfect, beautiful, alluring Adora who can do no wrong and who everyone *has to* love.

"I'll see you at the bar!" Adora yelled back. "I'll catch up soon I promise!"

Catra wanted to chew glass. She turned into the first changing room she found open, slamming the door against the wall.

The door closed, and it wasn't Catra's doing. She snapped, turning on her heel:

"Stop following me around like a fucking puppy ."

Adora's hand slipped off the doorknob, her ponytail laying flat on her shoulder.

"Y ou really don't remember me?" She asked, licking her lips. "W e… we did it in an elevator?"

Catra growled, hiding her flushed cheeks behind her palms. Her voice sounded muffled and weak.

"Don't be an idiot, of course I remember ."

"Oh. But you said-"

Catra dropped her hands, fingers curling.

"Because it's none of your stupid friends' business!"

"Hey , don't say that," Adora hardened her voice, the light in her eyes shifting. Catra's throat ran dry. "Y ou don't have to be an asshole about it."

Catra took a couple steps closer. Adora stayed put and raised her jaw , breathing in slowly.

Catra purred:

"I'm so sorry, *Adora.*" Adora's breath shuttered. "F or a moment there I forgot that *you* control what I say and do, and not me."

Adora huffed, offended. She leaned back against the wall, watching Catra approach with eyes cutting like knives.

"That's not what I meant and you know it. Why are you so hostile? We don't even know each other."

"That's rich coming from the girl who thought I was literally about to break her legs."

Adora's cheeks were burning. Catra took another step closer. They were just a breath away now; Adora straightened, swallowing, her lashes fluttering. Catra tilted her chin and let her lips part, captivating Adora's gaze.

"And I know your type," Catra whispered cruelly, her gaze resting on Adora's lips. "You always have to be the best at everything, don't you? You would do *anything* to please people - to make them like you - because you can't fathom the idea that someone isn't all over you."

"I just wanted to talk," Adora said, her voice controlled. "But clearly you're incapable of holding a normal conversation."

"You didn't want to talk," Catra said, cocking a brow. "You didn't follow me here and close the door to *talk*."

Adora snorted. It didn't sound convincing, especially with her hands visibly shaking to reach for Catra.

"Now who's full of herself?"

Catra was done playing. She slipped a hand on Adora's navel, slowly dragging her palm up between her breasts as she whispered:

"I'd rather be full of those pretty fingers of yours."

The reaction was instant and violent.

Adora growled, squeezing her eyes shut. She reached out blindly, warm palms clasping around Catra's thighs. She yanked her close to scoop her up and twirl her around, pinning Catra to the wall.

Catra caught her lips in a heated kiss.

Ten minutes later, Adora whirled to the side, her back hitting the wall next to Catra, close enough for their shoulders to touch. They were both panting heavily - Adora's hair flew free down her shoulders, her bare back and ass full of pink scratches, lips flushed to the color of blood.

After a couple moments of heavy silence, Adora swallowed and asked, still breathless:

"This is gonna keep happening, right?"

Catra's voice was not any better.

"Y eah."

"Should we. Should we talk about this?"

"Y eah. Uhh." Catra combed her hair back and pushed herself off the wall. She picked up her bra from the floor, pulling it around herself. Her eyes met Adora's. She was just staring at her. Catra asked: "Aren't you gonna be late for something?"

Adora jumped like she was stung by a bee, and leaned down to pick up her own clothes in a hurry.

"Shit, I'm late for lunch. Shit." She tilted her head up, blowing tufts of hair out of her face to look at Catra. "But then-"

"You know that little cafe down the street?" Catra put on her shirt, voice muffled by it. She could imagine how messy her hair must look. She combed through it when she noticed something on her arm and her voice grew a little shrill. "Did you rip this?"

"What?!" Adora asked, panicked. She straightened and shook her head to get her hair out of the way, wide eyes looking for what Catra

meant. Catra raised her arm, showing Adora the rip of the fabric by the sewing. "Oh my god, I'm so sorry , I can pay for it, I-"

"Nah." Catra picked up Adora's elastic and snapped it with one swift move. Adora choked on a noise. "Now we're even," Catra said sweetly.

"Are you serious?" Adora hissed, stumbling to get her foot inside her jeans. "What am I gonna tell my friends?"

"What, they've never seen you without your stupid ponytail?" The answer was written loud and clear on Adora's face. "Okay , that's *really* not my problem."

Catra finished dressing. She put a hand on the doorknob and tilted her head. "So? Y ou know Mystacor down the street?"

"Y eah,"Adora grumbled.

"Meet me there tomorrow at four. We're gonna need to set some ground rules for… whatever this is. And before you get your hopes up, it's not a-"

"Not a date," Adora said with a crooked smirk. "Don't worry. I had no intentions of dating you."

Catra turns the doorknob.

"Good, because this is *just* fucking. And that is a rule."

"W ait."

Catra opened the door but stayed put, waiting.

"Y our name,"Adora said. "Will you tell me now?"

Catra did.

She saw Adora's smile before she stepped out and pulled the door closed behind herself.

Now

Catra winces out of her shock when Adora kisses the inside of her thigh again, just a breath closer to her underwear.

Catra swallows. Adora is still looking at her with gentle eyes, waiting patiently.

Just trust me, okay?

Catra can't bring herself to answer, but she nods. Adora kisses her again, open-mouthed this time, her tongue stroking Catra's skin. She keeps her kisses heated as she reaches the waistband again, and this time, Catra doesn't stop her.

Adora's teeth graze Catra as she takes her underwear between them and pulls. Her hair falls between Catra's legs as she crawls lower, pulling them off her legs.

Catra whimpers.

Adora has done *nothing* to her yet and she's already a fucking mess - and she *stays* a fucking mess as Adora lays her weight down on her, covering her like a blanket. Catra cups Adora's cheeks and pulls her in for a kiss, and keeps her there for dozens more, melting on her tongue.

It's barely noticeable when Adora starts rocking her hips. It doesn't feel quite enough, either; it takes Catra a couple moments to realize what the problem is.

She slips her palms on Adora's ass under her briefs, pushing.

"Off," she commands between kisses, and Adora obeys immediately. "Your bra, too."

Now there's nothing between Catra and Adora's warmth as she grinds on her again with a thigh between Catra's, agonizingly slow, lips and chest never leaving hers.

All Catra can do is cling to Adora and follow her lead for god knows how long; with every deep wave of Adora's body, Catra feels the force of her resistance to give up control flowing out of her muscles. She doesn't feel where her warmth ends and where Adora's starts - her limbs are Adora's, her shine is Adora's, her gasps are Adora's, everything she has she gives her, and gets everything in return.

Adora tilts her jaw, kissing Catra's cheek.

"You're so wet for me," she whispers. "You feel so good like this, you pretty little thing."

Catra swallows a whimper, her thighs jerking. Her hands start to wander on Adora's body, stroking, worshipping, claiming.

Adora laughs softly at that, kissing her again, now closer to her ear.

"You like it when I talk to you like that, don't you? You like feeling how much you turn me on."

"Adora-" Catra gasps; it's a warning.

"*Fuck*," Adora grinds down harder, a hand furrowed deep in Catra's hair to keep a steady grip. "Say my name again."

Catra bites down on her lower lip, huffing stubbornly.

Adora just grins. She pushes herself up, switching positions; she brings one of Catra's legs up her shoulder, tugging her close until they meet halfway again. She starts riding Catra harder, her free

hand sliding onto Catra's chest. She flicks a thumb over Catra's nipple as she picks up the pace even more, fucking Catra into the sqeaking mattress.

Adora can barely speak through her own gasps as she says, hoarse and low:

"Don't forget your punishment. T ell me when you're close."

Catra throws her head back, her broken noises coming deep from her throat. She feels herself tense up already, and for a second, just one second, she wants to say fuck it to everything that Adora wants and says, but Catra opens her eyes and sees Adora hovering above her, beautiful, loud, perfect Adora-

Catra moans her name and "*close*", and Adora rises to her knees, leaving Catra teetering on the edge.

Catra's chest is heaving violently. She's sobbing without any tears, trying to grind up, desperate for friction.

"Y ou did so good," Adora says, soft hands stroking Catra's waist comfortingly. She keeps Catra's hips down, murmuring qietly: "Shhh. Y ou're such a good girl, doing what I asked of you."

Catra's body is in throbbing pain, Adora's words are nearly enough to push her over. Her voice is so high she can barely articulate it as she breathes, arching her back:

"Adora, *please.*"

"Please what?" Adora whispers, stroking Catra's cheek with her knuckles until she calms down. Adora leans down, pressing their foreheads together. "T ell me."

Catra curls her fingers around Adora's, eyes drilling into hers.

"Make me come or I'll cut your throat in your sleep."

Adora laughs heartily. It sounds too loud in the silence of their break, and yet, Catra finds herself grinning, too.

"You're unbelievable," Adora sighs affectionately, combing curls back from Catra's forehead and leaving a chaste kiss on her lips. "How would you like it?"

"Like you did before. Just don't stop."

"I won't," Adora says with another peck, straightening again.

It takes Catra less than a minute to come, writing under Adora when the second peak hits her harder than anything she has ever felt before. She is scratching Adora wherever she can reach; in return, Catra hears her own name spilling from Adora's lips, muttered under her breath like a prayer.

Adora cries out at every deep drag of Catra's nails, the rhythm of her hips furious; she curves her back so far behind that her hair almost reaches the mattress.

Adora's body jolts into spasms of pleasure, Catra's name erupting into a rough scream.

Adora's ass plops down, Catra's leg still thrown over her shoulder. The world turns quiet, too quiet and too cold.

Catra catches her breath, letting her arms fall down by her head. She feels like she's waking from a dream, and her brain is still a little hazy, leaving her unsure of what is real and what is not. Moment by moment, her vision clears up, and her mind too, memories flooding back - memories of all the dangerous mistakes they've made, memories of Catra going straight against everything she's ever told herself. They didn't only break their own rules - Catra broke every single fucking promise she made herself when she was young and alone and absolutely sure about how her life was going to go.

She was so much smarter twenty years ago than right now.

Catra draws her leg back, knees pressed to her chest. She hugs herself, trembling from head to toe.

"Catra?"

"This is over," Catra croaks, slipping to the wall and further away from Adora, who's panicked words wound Catra like daggers.

"W -what? What is? What do you mean?"

Catra feels her lungs tighten. It's suffocating to speak.

"W e're not doing this again."

"Catra, I didn't want to-"

"Stop talking," Catra asks, strangely quiet. "Stop talking. Leave me alone."

Catra squeezes her eyes shut, trying to focus on her own breathing - the air doesn't come - but Adora's broken voice is back in her ears, poisoning her.

"Catra, please."

Catra throws a slap blindly towards Adora. She reaches her and lands a hit *somewhere*, not hard enough to hurt, but hard enough to send a message. Adora gasps, wounded and weak.

Catra burrows her head between her knees and chest, trying to ease breaths and shakes. She feels the weight on the mattress shift as Adora crawls closer.

"*Leave me alone!*"

Adora's warmth is gone.

Catra doesn't know how long she has stayed there, but she's awakened by how much her neck hurts from the unusual angle. She didn't remember falling asleep at all.

She raises her head very, very slowly - the sun is gone, the trailer is wrapped in the silvery veil of the rising moon and the deep blue ink of the night. There's no noise coming from anywhere - no rustling of clothes, or quiet breathing.

Looks like she's alone. Just like she wanted, right?

Catra climbs off the bunk bed slowly and stumbles into the bathroom without flicking any lights on. She feels like she is hungover, barely able to stand as the room is spinning around her.

She turns the rattling shower on, stepping inside while the water is still ice cold, slowly warming up. Catra dunks her whole head under the stream; it flattens her hair over her eyes, dripping down from the tip of her nose and chin.

She fucked up, didn't she?

Catra leans against the wall of the shower. The cold from the tiles seem to sweep into her veins, making her shiver again.

"Stupid bitch," she mutters to herself, pushing the heels of her palms into her eyes. "You stupid fucking bitch"...

She spends the time in the shower sobbing quietly , her tears and saliva dripping into the water, mixing in the vortex of the drain.

Catra is lying awake in bed, her phone in her hand. She keeps twirling it between her fingers, tapping the home button every twenty seconds to check the time. It's not *that* late.

She pushes herself up into a sitting position, unlocking the screen and dialing.

Catra presses the phone to her ear so hard it aches.

It only takes two rings for Scorpia to pick up and yell into the speaker:

"Wildcat! I didn't forget, don't worry . I have everything in my bag."

Catra blinks in the dark.

"What?"

"Your laundry and necklace you left at my place?" Scorpia helps her out. "I called you about it this morning."

Fuck, Catra is slipping.

"Right, yeah," she mumbles, ruffling a hand through her hair. "Thanks."

There's a moment of silence. Scorpia asks, very gently:

"Is everything okay?"

"Yes. No." Catra gnaws the inside of her cheek. "I don't want to talk about it."

"Okay! Totally understand. We can talk about anything else. Umm," Scorpia makes some rumbling thinking sounds, then pops her lips. "Oh, so you're coming this weekend, right? Per can't wait to finally meet you, too. Like, she absolutely understood that you didn't want to tag along with me to meeting her group, especially with Adora being there, but--"

"Actually ," Catra cuts in, taking a deep, shuddering breath. "Maybe I don't feel like talking about anything. But. Yeah, of course I'll be there. She. She seems like a kind person. Do you mind if we... if we hang up now?"

"Whatever you need, Wildcat. You can call me back later if you change your mind. Take care, okay?"

"You too. See you tomorrow."

"See you tomorrow!"

As soon as Catra hangs up, the door starts jingling. Catra jolts up in bed, dropping her phone next to her and gripping the sheets. She feels blood rushing out of her face, her heart hammering in her chest.

Adora slips in as quietly as she can, fumbling in the dark. Catra is watching her lock the door and pull the key out, turning on her tiptoes, and she lifts her head, looking-

Looking directly into Catra's eyes.

They both freeze in place. Catra cannot be sure Adora even sees her yet, if her eyes had gotten used to the dark.

Catra swallows thickly.

She says, voice breaking:

"Hey , Adora."

Chapter End Notes

pops lips
Ssssso.

Thank you so so much for your support on this fic!I truly appreciate each and every one of you, and like,,, I'm sorry. But we know each other well enough now, don't we? :'D

Please consider saying hello to me on Twitter (I keep it 18+ so please have your age in your bio or I will block you), send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or

anonymously on CuriousCat (where you can also leave me prompts and suggestions for both art and drabbles!)
People leaving me CCs have inspired me so much, your ideas and big wrinkly brains are just so fucking precious, you really make me change things up a little bit and reconsider my approach, please never change.
I love you all, stay safe, and see you next time!

Rule #6

Chapter Summary

6. No commitments.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey , Adora."

Hearing her name, Adora nearly drops her keys. She hadnt seen if Catra was still in her bed or not, but then the darkness spoke in the softest voice and Adora's heart broke in two.

"I-I just ," Adora stutters, jngling her keys. She walks to the bunk beds and drops to her knees to pull out her suitcase from under her bed. "I just came back for my stuf f, I'll. I'll leave you alone soon."

Catra shuffles, the mattress creaking under her. It made the same noise when…

"Adora, wait."

So she does. Adora drops the suitcase back to the floor and rises to her feet. She tips her head back to look at Catra - now she sees her well, and she's so close above her, gripping the edge of her bed and leaning forward. She looks beautiful and ruined, mismatched eyes shining in the dark and a mess of her hair crowing her in silver moonlight. Her cheeks are puffed up so it looks like she has even more freckles peppering her face.

Adora wants to touch her.

"Stay ," Catra says, and Adora breathes out for the first time in what feels like forever, or at least since she had stepped inside. "It's your

trailer, too."

"Are you sure?"

Catra blinks, averting her gaze.

"Yeah."

Adora tilts her head. Her body feels too heavy to move, so she stays put. Catra is pulling her in like gravity she can't escape from, even when she doesn't look at her, even when she hates her the most in the whole world for ruining their relationship by being too selfish.

Catra breathes in.

"Look, I'm-" she says, too loud in the silence of the night, "I'm sorry. About earlier." Catra's hazy eyes find Adora's. Her pupils look like two dark full moons in rings of amber and blue. "I overreacted."

Adora's hand jerks to reach out and smooth a wild lock behind Catra's ear. She slides it on the frame of Catra's bed instead, inches away from Catra's fingers gripping the mattress. She doesn't draw away, urging Adora to speak.

"Catra, I didn't mean to make you uncomfortable with anything."

Catra laughs. It sounds like a wet sniff and a sharp exhale. She pushes herself back onto the bed; the distance somewhat clears Adora's mind from the thoughts of embracing her again.

"You didn't," Catra says, soft and reassuring. She fumbles with her blanket, covering herself up and getting comfortable. She turns to her side, facing the wall; but she peeks over her shoulder to say, "you did nothing wrong. Okay?"

Adora nods, unsure if she believes that. Her fingertips are tapping on the frame anxiously before she realizes it must bother Catra. She turns on her heel and flops down onto her own bed, arms and legs spread like a starfish.

She had taken a shower at her own place before she remembered that her overpacker ass left everything she owns and needs here at the trailer and she had to come back. Her heart is still throbbing in her throat, every fibre in her body is itching.

"Catra?" She whispers into the dark, quiet enough that Catra could ignore it if she wanted to.

She doesn't.

"Yeah?" Catra mumbles, voice heavy with sleep.

"What you said before… was it true?" Adora asks carefully, blinking rapidly to ease her burning eyes. Her voice breaks - it doesn't matter how hard she tries to stay collected. "Are we… I mean. Is it over? Between us?"

Catra stays quiet for a long time. Adora is sure that she either fell asleep or doesn't want to answer, when--

"I don't know." The bed frame creaks above Adora, Catra turning around. "I think.we both should think about what we want."

Adora's heart skips an agonizing beat, bile coating her tongue.

"Yeah. Okay," Adora says. Her throat feels too dry to swallow. "Goodnight, Catra."

Catra doesn't say it back.

Soon enough, Catra's breathing eases into a calm rhythm. She's snoring so quietly it's just a cute, low rumble like she's purring.

Adora only notices that she's crying when tears flow into her ears, cold and uncomfortable, making her shiver. Adora sniffs, drying her eyes with the back of her hand.

She's such an idiot. Of course she managed to confuse Catra enough that she doesn't even know if she wants to keep their sexual

relationship anymore. Catra must have realised what Adora had realised before, too - that she would need to keep her approach flexible enough for Adora to fit into her future.

Catra doesn't think she belongs there. And she's right.

Despite Adora's best efforts, she hadnt done a good enough job of convincing Catra to even *consider* Adora as a partner instead of her ex. She couldn't satisfy her, she couldn't keep her safe, she couldn't make her happy. All she did was fuck up by asking for too much too soon, scaring Catra and ruining Adora's reputation even more in her eyes.

Why would Catra think about Adora, anyway? Catra seemed to know exactly what she wanted, and she was always clear about those wants. If it wasn't for Adora, she wouldn't have any problems to deal with right now. She would only need to worry about how to get back with her ex, which seems easy anyway, and drop Adora whenever she feels comfortable. Because that's what they were - that's what they agreed on.

Adora had no right to mess with Catra's feelings like that only because Adora couldn't let her go. She's the only one who needs to figure out what she wants, and even then, it's not what she deserves.

Adora hiccups on a sob she tries to push deep, deep down. She turns on her stomach and hides her face in her pillow.

Shit. She feels *pathetic* .

Adora jerks awake as a nightmare spits her out; for a couple seconds she doesn't even know where she is, her mind expecting that she stayed home for the night.

Adora rustles with her blanket. Her throat is still dry, her chapped lips sticking together. She sits up and rests her feet down on the floor, her back craning forward.

The sink is running in the tiny bathroom. Adora hears the hair dryer turning on then, the closed door barely muffling the whirring.

Adora gets up and walks to the narrow kitchen corner. She pours herself a huge glass of water and chugs the whole thing, water pouring down her chin from the corner of her mouth. She's breathless by the time she finishes the glass but pours another half, drinking that too with her head thrown back.

Her rumbling stomach is even more bothered now, she feels the water sloshing around inside her.

Catra always takes so long to get ready, but she must have only washed her bangs because soon the dryer falls silent, and the folding door opens before Adora could run away.

Catra only wears booty shorts and a towel thrown over her chest to cover herself. She is in the middle of tying her hair up to a high ponytail when she notices Adora, halting in her step and in her motions.

Adora clears her throat.

"Hi?"

"Hey ," Catra says carefully, finishing her ponytail. She bites down on her lip. "Bathroom's free."

"Okay . Thank you."

Adora makes a beeline for the door keenly, while Catra is still standing there - they are doing that awkward stepping-out-of-the-way-but-not-at-all-coordinated dance where they end up closer and

closer. Every whiff of Catra's scent gets Adora more drunk, her insides forming an agonizing knot.

Catra twirls to the side, finally clearing the path with a faint smile.

Adora closes the door on herself, and takes a deep, deep breath. The whole room smells like Catra, a delicious whirl of her shampoo, body wash, lotion, deodorant, toothpaste and skin.

Adora turns the tap and splashes a good amount of cold water onto her face, only then realizing that she didn't bring any change clothes with her. She fumbles with the door again, a little frantic, and basically falls out of the bathroom.

Catra's towel is hanging from the bedframe now, her chest bare as she is leaning against the ladder and tapping on her phone. The screen paints her skin with a beautiful blue glow that curls with the curves of Catra's body like northern lights.

Adora snaps her head away, gripping the door with all her might.

"I- I forgot my clothes."

"Go ahead."

"Yeah. Uh."

Adora gets on her knees to pull some clean underwear, a shirt, and jeans out of her suitcase. Catra stays right where she is, and Adora could swear she feels her gaze burning along Adora's spine.

As Adora rises to her feet, smoothing her neatly folded clothes to her chest. She sneaks a peek at Catra; their eyes do meet, Catra's gaze snapping up from Adora's lips.

"What?" Catra asks raspily, dropping her hand with her phone in it.

"Nothing," Adora says, and skitters back to the bathroom.

By the time she comes out again, Catra is gone.

"Stay where you are!" Adora yells, hopping on top of a car and pointing a Glock straight ahead.

Catra's tiny figure is zigzagging in the traffic, Adora following her with the mule.

Adora shoots. The "bullet" breaks through a windshield and misses Catra, who knocks out a guy to take his motorbike. When she straps the helmet on, that's Adora's cue to jump off and chase after her.

The heavy traffic only slows Catra down, the bike roaring under her, wheels screeching the asphalt.

Adora cuts through it by climbing on and jumping off every vehicle in her path, nearly catching Catra. She reaches out for the collar of Catra's leather jacket right when the traffic clears up and Catra flees.

And, scene.

Adora only steps up to the table with refreshments on it after Double Trouble leaves with a golden cup of frappuccino that has their name on it in Swarovskis. So far she's been lucky enough to avoid them completely - Adora is terrified that she'd say something stupid, or too much, or both. She feels a little antsy, a little out of control, and her movements off screen are ragged, wide and intense like her arms are connected to a different brain.

Adora sniffs a whiff of something smoky sweet. She doesn't have to look around to know who is closing in on her.

Catra steps next to her and reaches for a water bottle. She doesn't look at Adora or even acknowledge her presence - typical for when other people are around.

Catra yelps out of the blue, and something (someone?) yanks her away from Adora's peripheral vision like she weighs nothing. Adora throws her own bottle away in fright, the cap flying off. She jumps out of the way of the pouring water and snaps her head up just in time to see Scorpia sway Catra's legs towards Adora. She gets to duck before disaster strikes, her ears ringing from Scorpia's delightful roar.

Scorpia sets Catra back down and grins wide.

"Phew, I've been looking everywhere for you! This road is *very long*."

"Did you bring it?" Catra asks, adjusting her top that had slipped high up on her stomach. Adora's eyes follow the hem of the top as it slowly covers Catra's toned curves and, with that, kills Adora's dreams all over again.

"Yeah! There you go," Scorpia says, picking up a paper shopping bag to push into Catra's hand. "I ironed out your shirt."

Catra's eyes squint into bright half-moons as she smiles.

"Thanks, Scorp."

"Don't even mention it. My door is always open if you want some distance from Ado—"

Catra clears her throat hoarsely, her gaze shifting to Adora in a quick second. Scorpia follows her stare, her own eyes widening and her shoulders popping up to her neck.

"Adora!" She yells a little too enthusiastically, voice breaking. "Hi, buddy."

"Hi, Scorpia," Adora says, going for a half-hearted little wave. "How are you?"

"Good, good. I'm good. How are you?" Scorpia's pupils are twinkling as she winks at Adora stealthily. "Figured out the situation with Cake

Girl?"

Catra, who has been rustling loudly and listlessly with the bag until now, jerks her head up and scowls.

"Who?" She asks, dropping her hands. She narrows her eyes, her glare darting between them.

Despite the furious lightning in Adora's eyes and rapid headshakes, Scorpia goes on joyfully:

"Oh, she's a girl Adora has been baking cakes with. But Adora wants them to be a little more than that, right?"

Catra's cutting eyes settle on Adora. Her voice is funny when she asks:

"Are you dating someone?"

" *No* ," Adora blurts, sounding almost of fended.

"But she wants to," Scorpia says, nudging Adora with her elbow. "She was talking about how this girl was so great at baking and how she didn't want her to do it with anyone else--"

"Thank you, Scorpia," Adora raises her voice until she is almost screaming.

Finally , Scorpia realizes her mistake. She sucks her lips in, breathing out an awkward little laugh through her nose.

"I mean" she says, "nothing? I said nothing? About anything?"

Catra is still looking at Adora. Her expression is blank and unreadable, but the shine in her eyes looks strange and so, so cold.

Adora swallows. She says, emphasizing the words carefully:

"I'm not seeing *anyone* . Really."

Catra scowls, her button nose crinkling.

"You don't owe me an explanation," she says, turning on her heel to walk away.

Scorpia waits until Catra is out of earshot, and turns to Adora with a loopy grin.

"Hoo boy, I've never seen her so angry." Scorpia shakes her head. "She *really doesn't like you* ."

Adora buries the stabbing pain in her chest and glares, giving Scorpia the dirtiest look she can manage.

Scorpia stares back for a couple long, long seconds, then pops her lips.

"Yeah, I'm gonna go after her. See you later!"

Scorpia scurries away, calling after Catra.

Adora breathes out slow and deep. She leans down to pick up the bottle that barely has any water left in it.

Somehow that feels like the perfect metaphor.

They do a couple more takes, each of them turning out worse than the previous one. Catra is struggling to strap the helmet on for a good minute before Double Trouble calls for a cut, and Adora had managed to slide on a car's hood so swift and uncontrolled that she plopped to the floor on the other side like a sack of potatoes.

After a good hour of retakes and suffering, the work day is finally over - for Adora, at least. She overheard Catra talking about another scene she has in this location, a couple of hours later.

This is Adora's chance to whisk her away and try to do some kind of emergency repairs on their crumbling bond.

That always went well before, and surely will go well now.

Adora swallows, looking around for Catra in the crowd. She spots her easily; Catra seems to try and get far away from everyone, making a beeline for an alley between two buildings that is at the edge of the closed-off for shooting area.

Adora quickly cuts through the same crowds. She doesn't call out for Catra but Catra still notices that she is being followed, because she picks up the pace, urging Adora to do the same.

Adora catches up right at the mouth of the alleyway, both of them right at the angle where shadow meets sunlight.

"Catra, wait," Adora whispers, reaching out for Catra's wrist to stop her from running.

Catra snaps her hand back before they could even touch.

"I told you not to touch me in public," Catra hisses just as quietly.

She turns to Adora and crosses her arms in front of her chest. Her lips are pressed into a straight line, her posture oozing confidence and fury. Adora could swear she hears electricity cracking through Catra's bones, her wild curls rising with even more volume than usual. Catra's eyes are cutting like the sharpest daggers, slicing straight through Adora's heart, which is drumming in her throat.

"So?" Catra asks, annoyed and impatient. "What do you want?"

"We need to talk," Adora forces herself to say, a little choked and desperate. "This whole mess is a misunderstanding, Scorpia didn't say exactly what I said."

Catra scoffs.

"I told you, you don't owe me an explanation."

"But I do."

"Why?" Catra loses her cool and raises her voice. Thankfully, the people they've passed before have started to leave, so no one actually hears them fighting. "Why would you owe me shit, Adora?"

Adora yells back, forgetting the whole stealth mission:

"Because you're *Cake Girl!"*

Catra's jaw drops, eyebrows furrowing. She takes a careful, threatening step forward;Adora steps back.

"What the fuck are you talking about? We've never baked cake-" Her eyes grow wide, realization is the shrill in her voice. "No. No, you fucking did not."

"Listen-"

"You can't let anyone know about us! That's the first fucking rule, and you just - you've-" Catra turns pale. Her arms unfold and fall down by her body lifelessly. "You fucking told my best friend that I'm good in bed."

"I didn't say anything like that,"Adora objects desperately , feeling her whole face in flames. "You're focusing on all the wrong details."

"Oh I'm so sorry, what should I focus on? The fact that you want to"… Catra bites back her words. She calms down a bit, apart from her still heaving chest and wildly shining eyes as she glares at Adora, her expression anything but tame. " *What* do you want from me, Adora?"

"I haven't said that I wanted to date you," Adora says reassuringly, feeling her own words tying agonizing knots on her insides. Her heart clenches at Catra snapping her head away at her words, not even wanting to look at her. This shouldn't hurt so much. "That's

something Scorpia took out of context, and she seems to be convinced it's a fact."

"Great," Catra croaks. "Are you done?"

Adora exhales with a tired sigh, a hand on the nape of her neck. Shit. She hates everything about this. "Listen, I think… we do need to talk about this whole thing. Us, I mean. Our relationship."

"Don't call it a relationship," Catra spits with newly lit flames of anger, turning back to scowl at Adora. "This *isn't* a relationship, and it's never been one. And you had no fucking right to talk about *my* sex life with *my* best friend, who, by the way, has the biggest fucking mouth out of anyone I know! So thank you so much for making my life so much fucking harder, again, because you never use your brain which you probably don't even have!"

Something snaps in Adora. Suddenly, it's easy to be just as devoured by fury as Catra is; Adora's whole body warms up to it, her hands starting to shake with it.

"That's enough." Her voice is trembling and loud; a thunder, the promise of a storm twirling close on the horizon. "I *will* call it a relationship, because that's what this is, whether or not you want to face the truth! We are two people sharing… some kind of a connection, whether you like it or not or want to accept it or not! Maybe if you stopped acting like a child throwing a tantrum at *everything* people wanna do for you, you'd understand how the real world works! And you know what, Catra?"

She towers over Catra, using her height to her advantage - and now she is the one walking towards Catra, forcing her to take little, stumbling steps back until her back hits the wall of a building, her tiny figure fully consumed by the shadows.

However small and vulnerable Catra looks right now, her eyes are still cutting bright and cold, her jaw raised high.

"Maybe I didn't have to talk about us with your best friend if you've ever, *ever* been available for that!" Catra's expression breaks. Adora landed a punch. "All you ever did was to deny and deflect whatever I said, rejecting all my attempts to talk to you about anything! What am I supposed to do when you're so hostile and closed off all the time? All you do is take what you want, whenever you want, and you give no shit about anyone else's feelings, do you?"

Adora pauses to breathe, but Catra doesn't answer. Adora doesn't need an answer, anyway; her skin feels way too tight and too hot, the buzzing in her mind sounds louder than her own thoughts, making it impossible to follow them.

Adora is done and over it.

"Forget it," she says, her voice low and toneless now. She puts distance between herself and Catra, who is still pressing herself to the wall, wide eyes clinging to Adora's. "If this goes on like this, don't bother thinking about what you want. Because I won't take part in this shit anymore."

Adora feels tears prickling at the corners of her eyes, stinging and heavy like her anger. This was not supposed to go like this, but all the bottled up feelings, all the rage and the disappointment and the pain is starting to feel like too much to handle.

Adora leaves with a lighter heart and a drumming head, and the worst part is - she feels no remorse for anything she had said.

She felt justified, for a moment. She felt like she had the right, and she's done playing Catra's game with rules she can't even follow. There's a limit to her respect and compassion when it was never met with anything but rejection.

Back when she met a girl she knew barely anything about at a cafe, Adora had no expectations. All she had known was that strange kind of pull with an unholy strength had sent her orbiting around Catra's presence like a moon. Catra's body and voice was salvation, she

was a drug Adora wanted and needed injected under her skin because without her warmth she was trembling, and without her voice the world was soundless. Catra always appeared like a mirage and while Adora was making steps to reach her, catch her, kiss her to reality, Catra never came closer.

Maybe Adora never had a chance. If it was Catra's cruelty or her own stupidity, she wasn't sure anymore. It didn't matter.

Adora can choose to leave with her head high, winning a war she lost all the battles to, or - she could stay and keep trying and compromising when she knows nothing would change. As humiliating as the second option sounds, Adora finds her mind gravitating towards that first; her addiction is strong and merciless. It will take time to wash Catra's toxicity out of her veins which has been poisoning her for three years.

Adora gets into her truck and slams the door on herself. She blinks her tears back, swallowing them;they burn her throat like acid.

She needs to hit something.

Catra won't come back tonight, Adora is sure of it.

With the keys in her trembling hands, Adora unlocks the trailer door. She is huffing, shivering under her big denim jacket from the cold sweat sticking to her skin. She's been going to the gym instead of spending her time alone in the sad little trailer that smells like Catra.

She had to come home, eventually; Adora makes a beeline for the bathroom to take a cold shower, the water prickling at her numb, aching muscles. By the time she finished working out she felt like she was going to collapse, but now her energy is back.

She needs to kill this annoying rousedness, this stupid rushing mind that won't let her be until she breaks.

Instead of changing into her pajamas, Adora puts her clothes back on, shoes and her denim jacket included. She slips her phone into her pocket and turns the lights off. Fiddling with the keys absentmindedly, she opens the door and hops down the first step of stairs--

And comes face to face with Catra, standing on the lowest step, wearing a huge backpack on her shoulders and a strange expression; Adora cannot immediately decide if she's terrified or arrogant, if the grimace that flashes her teeth is guilty or disgusted.

"Hey ," Catra says, her voice raspy but small.

Adora spits it back. It comes out colder than she thought it would, but it doesn't bother her. She buries her hands into her pockets, elbows wide out, and keeps walking, forcing Catra to walk back and twirl to the side.

Adora doesn't look at her.

"Where are you going?" Catra asks. She sounds more like herself now, gaining her confidence back.

It's harder to ignore her like that.

"I'm going on a walk," Adora barks, picking up the pace.

"Can I go with you?"

Adora snaps her head back, stumbling on nothing.

"What?" She asks, confused but still distant. She turns around, standing still. "Why?"

Catra swallows.

"I want to talk."

"You. Talk."

Catra opens her mouth to snap back, but she stops herself after a sharp inhale. She closes her eyes for a moment, breathing out.

When she looks at Adora again, Adora knows exactly what her expression means.

"I'm ready to." Catra slides a palm up on her arm, cupping her own shoulder. She adds, much quieter: "I think."

Adora's heart is thrumming. She feels a mischievous smirk tugging on the corner of her mouth, and her voice is breaking with suppressed laughter:

"I'm sorry , ready to talk about what?"

"What do you *mea-* oh." Catra blows a raspberry, smoothing a wave of hair behind her ear. "You're actually gonna make me say it?"

"Well I'm not sure I know what you mean," Adora pouts. "I'd love to know what it is before I let you pin me."

Catra blurts out before Adora even finishes her sentence:

"Our relationship."

Adora huffs, lips parting. She didn't actually believe Catra would say it, but…

"I'd like to talk about our relationship." Catra repeats, closing the distance between them, eyes never leaving Adora's. Adora's elbows drop, her posture breaking. "Okay?"

Adora's smirk melts into a smile.

"Yeah,"she breathes. "I'd like that."

After Catra locked the trailer door, she escorted Adora back inside a stage and up to the roof. She seems to be familiar with the route, like she had taken this path many times before.

They take the walk in complete silence, the only noise is some quiet clinking coming from whatever Catra is carrying in her backpack.

It feels nice, though. Serene. Catra doesn't radiate anything but warmth, and Adora would follow her to the end of the world.

At the top of the slithering staircase, Catra pushes on the heavy metal door that leads to the roof. Adora helps her without thinking, a palm by Catra's shoulder to push together.

Once the crack is wide enough, Catra slips through hurriedly and doesn't halt until she reaches the edge of the roof.

Adora peeks at the sky. It's dark like spilled ink, just a couple stars peppering it. Stars around here are so difficult to see; they have to fight and cut their ways through the smoke and the smog, just to twinkle for people who usually don't even bother noticing them.

"You coming?" Catra's voice shakes Adora out of her trance.

"Yeah, sorry," she mumbles and joins Catra by the cement rails.

She leans on them with her arms, propped on her elbows. She can feel Catra's curious eyes on her as she puts her backpack down carefully. The clinking grows louder.

"Do you have scenes in SFX makeup tomorrow?" Catra asks as she kneels next to the backpack and unzips it.

"Uh, no. I'm off tomorrow."

"Perfect."

Catra straightens, holding a bottle of Adora's favorite kind of beer in each hand. Adora's eyes light up, and she takes the one in Catra's

left hand.

Did Catra know? Or was it a coincidence? The faint smile Catra wears, and the kind eyes so focused on Adora's face when Catra gives her the beer make Adora wish and believe that she knew, because it would mean that she cared.

"How many do you have in that backpack?"

"I don't know," Catra mutters. Adora quirks a brow. "...Eight. I can't do this sober."

Adora snorts and twists off the cap. She raises her bottle to Catra, who follows her lead and clinks the necks of their beers together.

Catra leans on the rail as well as they drink a couple sips in silence. Adora promised herself to be patient and let Catra guide the conversation at her own pace, but now…

Catra seems lost. Adora can see that her mind is buzzing with zigzagging thoughts, and the twitching of her lips shows how more and more frustrated with herself she's getting. Adora knows a lot of Catra's faces, and this one, right here means "I won't ask for your help but I need it."

So, Adora asks gently:

"Can I ask you questions?"

Catra fidgets, burrowing her chin deeper into the collar of her leather jacket.

"Yeah."

"You don't have to answer any of them if you're not comfortable," Adora hurries to add. "And I'm. I'm sorry about earlier. I know I shouldn't have talked to Scorpia about us, and I shouldn't have yelled at you like that."

Catra shakes her head, taking another sip.

"Don't. You were right."

"Maybe. But I freaked you out first. I guess I was just"… Adora shifts her weight from one leg to the other. "I was so confused and frustrated with how things were going. It built up. And erupted." Adora glances at Catra, the silhouette of her profile gleaming silver. "Was it the same for you yesterday?"

Catra chews on her bottom lip first, eyebrows furrowing.

"Kind of," she says, the words rolling off her tongue carefully. "Look, yesterday was. It was a lot. For me. It's not something I've ever done with another person."

Adora tilts her head.

"What do you mean?"

Catra drinks a couple more gulps now. Adora mimics her, hoping it's reassuring enough for Catra to continue.

"I mean," Catra starts, emphasising every word, "this whole trust thing. What we did, it… it made me lose control, which is not something I've allowed to happen in a very, very long time."

Catra presses her lips together, overwhelmed.

"You don't have to tell me why."

"I want to. Just"… Catra takes a deep breath through her nose. "I grew up in foster care."

"Oh!" Adora breathes, perking up. Her reaction leaves Catra staring at her confused, so she goes on way too enthusiastically: "Are you an orphan, too?"

Catra knits her brows.

"Wait, you"...

"I grew up in the system - ever since I was a baby. Got passed around a lot." Adora laughs in embarrassment. "Eventually I got adopted at twelve, for the first time I mean, but... yeah. That's a whole other story. Um."

She doesn't want to say too much or take the stage from Catra now that she has finally built up the courage to talk about herself. She thinks she stops herself in time, hoping her intermission had not come off as invading.

Catra rests her cheek in her palm, fingers sliding between her waves. She drinks the last couple sips from her beer, knocking the empty bottle onto the rail.

"That sucks," she says quietly.

"It could've been worse," Adora says quickly. She finishes off as well, pushing herself off and gesturing at Catra's backpack. "Another?"

"Keep 'em coming."

Adora opens another bottle, holding it out for Catra first. All the while she gets her next drink ready and leans back next to Catra, Catra is already halfway through her second.

She breathes out, hissing from the fizz.

"And I'm not an orphan," Catra mutters hoarsely. "My mother gave up custody because she didn't want to keep me. Because I was *troubled*." She smacks her lips bitterly. "I was six."

Adora feels her heart drop down into her stomach. The light spring breeze turns cold, sending a shiver up her spine.

"Catra"...

"If you dare to say you're sorry-"

"That's not what I wanted to say ."

Catra looks at her challengingly.

"Then what did you want to say?"

I","Adora stutters. "I'm not sure yet, actually . Sorry. Continue?"

Catra huffs. To Adora's absolute dread, she spins with a palm on the narrow rail and hops up on it, sitting with her legs spread. Adora slips a palm on Catra's back instinctively, finding herself pressed to the outside of Catra's thigh.

Catra giggles kindly.

"Chill. I won't fall."

Adora draws back.

"Sorry . I just-"

"I feel more comfortable on high ground. It calms me down, to see everything from up here." Catra rests the bottle between her legs. "And I guess it puts distance between me and what's happening."

"Okay ." Adora turns to face the same direction as Catra, pressing the small of her back to the rail now. "So that explains why you monopolized the top bunk."

"Foster kid flare, you should know," Catra humors her back. "You take the best that you can get before someone else can."

"Fair ."

"Anyway ." Catra's tone changes back to the gravely, bitter one. "Yeah, so that's the root of that. My mother never visited me again. The last time I saw her was when I watched her leave me to rot from the window."

"She never even contacted you?"

"She sent me letters sometimes, saying how disappointed she was in me," Catra grimaces, rubbing her nose with the back of her hand. "That's it. I never got adopted. Never had anyone to trust or to rely on but myself. Everything I did and everything I achieved I did myself, so no one could take anything away from me ever again. If people don't need me, then I don't need anyone either."

Adora's throat tightens. Catra doesn't have to say anything else for her to understand. She feels something hot and bitter tug on the knot that already keeps her insides aching - it's the suffocation rage again, but this time, not because of Catra, but *for* her.

To ruin someone gorgeous like Catra is a crime in itself, but the person being her mother, of all people, is something Adora cannot even comprehend. She's never had a mother - not really - so to have what is supposed to be a sacred connection putrefy and break you apart from the inside is not something she can relate to. All she ever knew was how to disappoint the women who took care of her, and to be disappointed by them. Growing up without knowing her own parents, Adora had spent her childhood fantasising about her beautiful mother being full of love and joy, the only person in the whole world who would have loved her unconditionally if she had been given the chance by fate.

Looking at Catra now, how fragile and ruined she looks, and how deep her scars run under her skin, Adora realizes that she was wrong. Real mothers can be just as cruel as anyone else - and they are capable of anything.

Catra is looking at her strangely, mismatched eyes narrow and dark. She's finished her second beer, putting the empty bottle next to the previous one.

"So?" She asks, soft but challenging. "Do you know what you want to say now?"

Adora puts down her beer, too. She comes 'round Catra, stepping between her spread thighs. She keeps her eyes on Catra at all times - gentle, flickering with determination as Adora's hands come up by Catra's sides, caressing their way up to Catra's scapulae.

Adora pulls her in, hooking her chin over Catra's shoulder.

Catra's whole body goes rigid as she speaks through gritted teeth:

" *What are you doing* ."

"Better late than never aftercare," Adora whispers into her hair, breathing her in. Her fingertips stroke gentle lines on Catra's back, earning her a little shiver.

Catra grunts.

"Did I miss the part where we had wild BDSM sex?"

"I left you upset." Adora draws her in even closer, feeling the strain Catra's muscles easing up a bit. Adora keeps her voice gentle and low, rumbling in her throat. "I shouldn't have. You opened up for me, and I left you there scared and exposed."

"I don't need *pampering* , Adora," Catra says; she sounds a little breathless now, her resistance leaving her body as her temple bumps to Adora's.

"I know," Adora says. Her hand strokes its way up to the nape of Catra's neck now, her thumb circling with just a touch of pressure. Catra sighs, melting in Adora's arms.

"This is so fucking stupid," Catra growls. Then, with almost the same breath, she mumbles: "Pet my hair ."

Adora does. After the first couple strokes of Adora's palm, Catra's legs close around Adora's waist. Catra crosses her ankles behind Adora, her hands mimicking Adora's path, following her spine. Catra clings to her, nails digging deep into Adora's denim jacket. Some

locks of Adora's ponytail fall under Catra's hands, flowing between her fingers.

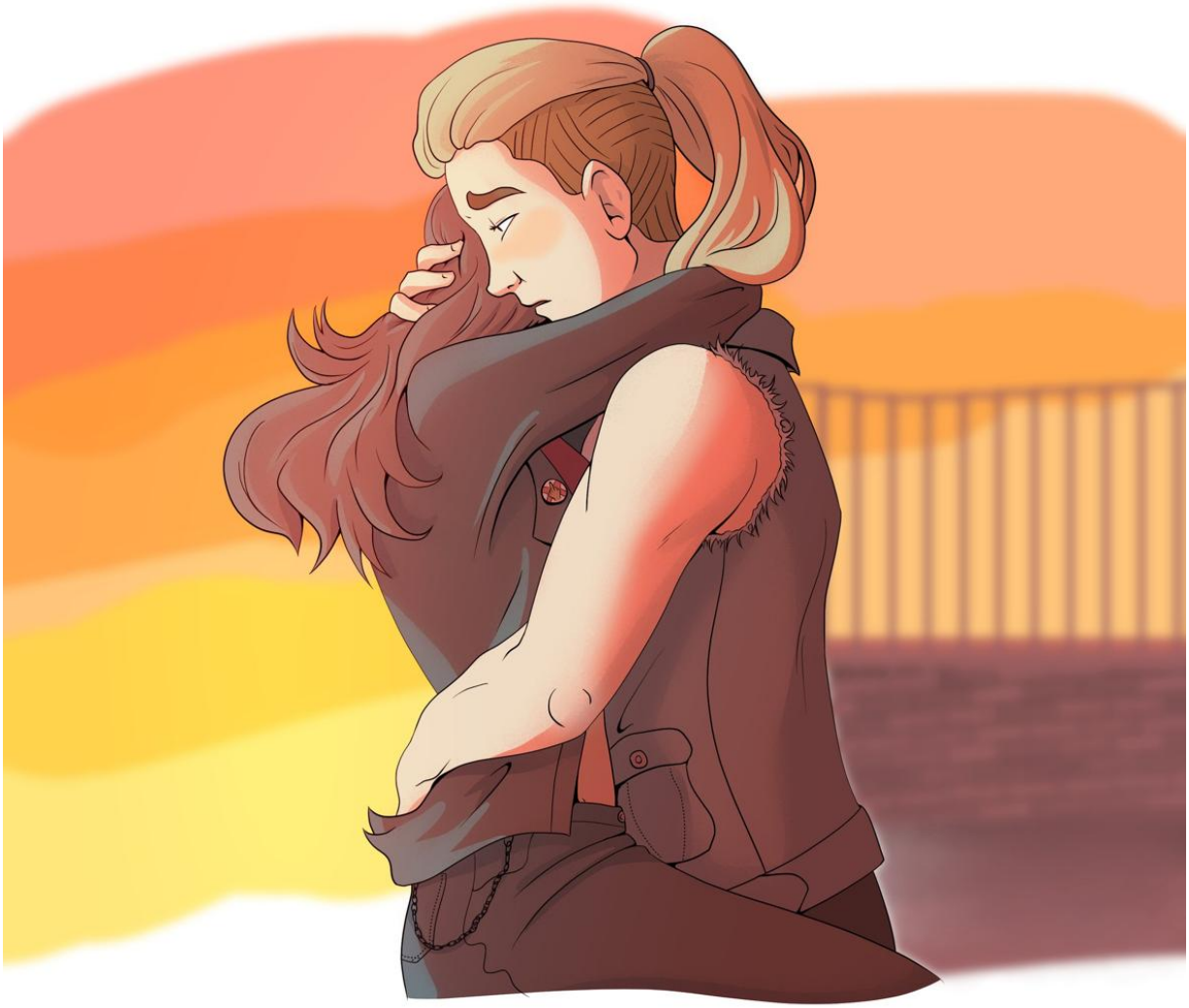
"You made me so happy," Adora goes on. She feels Catra's throat bob as she swallows thickly. "I asked you to trust me, and you did. You let me take you, and take care of you. It must have been so difficult, and I didn't even understand how strong you were."

Catra burrows her face deeper into the crook of Adora's neck. Adora can barely make out her words as she whispers:

"You're such an idiot."

Adora just laughs. They stay like that for a while, the minutes dripping into eternity in Adora's mind. Her whole body warms up to Catra, basking in the softest shivers and sighs her hands earn her. Adora can't tell the beating of their hearts apart, echoing and thrumming in every inch of her veins.

"I want to make you happy, too," Adora murmurs then, both hands cradling the back of Catra's head. She peeks up at the sky, at the struggling stars. "If you let me."



Catra doesn't answer right away. Adora gnaws at the inside of her cheek, trying to find the right words. It would feel wrong to expect Catra to keep sleeping with her. Being intimate with Adora caused her so much distress, but where they are right now, their previous qick hookups filled with frustration and anger wouldn't be possible either.

Catra doesn't want to sleep with her, and wants to date someone else.

There's only one path left for Adora to take to keep Catra in her life; to be able to take care of and protect her.

"I'd like to be your friend."

Catra jerks in her arms, her throat making a strange noise.

"... *Really*?" Catra sniffs, a little wet.

"Yeah," Adora says. Something twists into her heart like a dagger; she hides it behind a cheerful tone. "You can trust that I'm serious. I've known you for three years and you've *just* started being nice to me."

Catra leans back so she could look into Adora's eyes. She looks a little ruffled, her mismatched irises shining like sunlight trembling on water.

"Okay," Catra breathes, smiling faintly. "I guess we could be friends."

Only then, when Catra says it, too; when the burning, stinging pain in Adora's chest starts to make it impossible to breathe; when Catra hugs her again, squeezing close but it feels *different*; when Adora feels the first pearl of tear bubbling out and flowing down her cheek - that is when she realizes.

She wants Catra.

Just not like Catra wants her.

Chapter End Notes

Beautiful illustration by Emilee ♡

hank you so so much for your support on this fic, as always ♡ I hope you liked this one, not much has happened but hey, there's a change in the air for sure ;)

Please consider saying hello to me on Twitter (I keep it 18 so please have your age in your bio or I will block you), send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or anonymously on CuriousCat (where you can also leave me prompts and suggestions for both art and drabbles!)
I love you all, stay safe, and see you next time!

Rule #7

Chapter Summary

7. We are not friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Are you okay?"

Catra winces, her vision clearing up. She is staring at her reflection in MUAH, sitting in a costume she hates, waiting for a scene she has barely any role in.

She takes a deep breath through her nose, forcing a crooked smile on her lips.

"A w, are you worried about me, Sparkles?"

Glimmer scoffs. She releases a curl of Catra's hair that has been twirled around her finger. The curl falls elegantly and bounces back up like a spring, framing Catra's face. The rest of Catra's hair is up in a tight bun at the back of her head, straightened slightly and slicked back.

Catra can't fucking stand it, so she averts her gaze to Glimmer in the mirror.

"It's not like you to be quiet and not make any comments on my work." Glimmer grins, raising her brows. "Are you sick? Did you catch the common kindness?"

"I hope it's contagious. Y ou could use some of it."

"There she is."

Catra swallows. She cocks her jaw when Glimmer twirls in front of her with a liquid lipstick, dark and bold like blood.

Catra shakes the curl back from her cheek, shifting her face into a blank, expressionless canvas for Glimmer to work on. Glimmer doesn't move. "What?"

"Nothing," Glimmer says quickly, the tip of her nose dusty pink.

She applies the lipstick, careful and skilled, then gestures for Catra to pop her lips and tilt her chin up so Glimmer can see her work better.

"Okay, you're done!" Glimmer crosses her arms in front of her chest. "How do you like it?"

Catra stands up from the chair, letting her arms fall by her side, palms on the curves of her thighs emphasized by the cocktail dress that is worth more than everything she has ever owned combined. She tries to pull the ruffles and drapes down, but they slip up her thighs on their own.

Her neck and hands look like she robbed a jewelry store and hooked everything she could find on herself before escaping. Her face is heavy with makeup, a dozen shades on her lids, her features contoured into a different girl's. And that ridiculous updo…

"Hello?" Glimmer waves her hand in front of Catra's face.

Catra shakes herself out of shock with a roll of her shoulders.

"Yeah?"

"I said don't forget the shoes," Glimmer says, pointing down to the floor.

Next to Catra's chair is the pair of stilettos she is supposed to wear.

Catra grimaces, her upper lip curling. She plops back down on the chair unceremoniously, and crosses her legs so she can put the fucking shoes on.

Once she's standing again, ready to leave, she catches Glimmer staring at her once again.

"What?" She asks again, popping the T impatiently .

"Nothing!" Glimmer repeats, her voice shrill. "I just… I did a pretty good job on you. I hate to admit it, but... you really look gorgeous. Who knew you had *all…* " Glimmer draws circles with her palm in Catra's direction, "of this underneath."

Glimmer's words burrow under Catra's skin like little needles, stinging along her spine. Catra swallows thickly, trying to push down the urge to retch.

"Alright," is all she mumbles, taking careful steps towards the exit.

She's worn high heels before, but none of them were that *thin*, like a fucking needle she needs to balance on. This whole Desperate Housewife shtick is fucking infuriating, and everyone is staring.

Catra makes her way to the stage, followed by curious eyes and unwelcome compliments muttered under people's breaths.

Dee comes swaying in, just the last thing she fucking needs, and halts in front of her with a shit-eating grin.

"Look at you, Kitten," they coo, flicking their perfectly manicured claws. "Now *that's* what I call a Wildcat."

"Piss off, Dee," Catra grumbles, trying to drag her skirt down and failing again. Lights flash in her eyes, cutting cold and deep. "You're gonna pay for this."

"Oh honey, I have *nothing* to do with this," Dee pouts. "You've gotta file a complaint with our costume designer for making you look too

gorge'."

Before Catra would have the chance to do something she might regret - or potentially go to jail for - Dee is called away by the PA.

Catra is free to continue her shameful journey to the back of the set. They built the inside of a breathtaking rococo ballroom with a dance floor in the middle, crystal chandeliers hanging from the shortened ceiling, two marble staircases curling into each other, and long tables sinking under the weight of delicious-looking prop foods.

Groups of extras are lounging around already, all dressed up just like Catra. None of them look so out of place and lost, though; Catra needs to focus on her legs not buckling under her, her calves already straining with little pulses of spasms.

She maneuvers towards her spot she is supposed to stay at while Dee's character gives their big speech to the crowd at the top of the staircase they are slowly descending from. Catra is hidden most of the time;it's going to be up to the audience to notice her in the crowd of guests, so she comes around a table, slipping a hand on a gilded column, when-

Adora appears out of fucking nowhere, chatting loudly with Bow following suit. Catra freezes , her back pressed to the column so Adora almost walks straight into her, halting just one second before they would collide.

Adora yelps, stumbling a step back.

"Excuse me, miss-" Their eyes meet. Adora clips her words, her eyes growing wide and her voice shrill. "... *Catra?!*"

Bow's head pops up from behind Adora, and he gasps with his palms on his cheeks.

"Aww, you look so pretty!"

Okay, this is it. Catra is at her limit, this is the most embarrassing, humiliating fucking moment of her entire *life.* Her heart is pounding so fast and so loud she feels like she's going to have a heart attack.

Adora bursts into a curt laugh; loud, high and obnoxious. She slaps her mouth, trying to muffle the snorting chuckles that follow.

"Sorry ," she whimpers, eyeing Catra up and down. She chokes on another wheezing laugh. "What did they *put you in?* You look so weird."

Catra's consciousness falls back into her body like a heavy storm pouring down. Her mind clears up, her chest pulsing with warmth.

"Adora!" Bow chides, then adds quickly with a palm on Adora's shaking shoulder: "I gotta run, okay? T alk to you later."

Adora just nods, tears pooling at the corners of her eyes now. She draws her hand back from her mouth just to snort again, her lips trembling.

Once Bow is out of eyeshot, Catra carefully props a high heel up the column and crosses her arms in front of her chest, her posture easing up. She grins at Adora, a sharp canine sinking into her bottom lip.

"Let it all out,"she purrs, tilting her head softly .

"Sorry , sorry." Adora tries to collect herself again, taking deep breaths. " *Phew* . I'm just. Wow. This took me by surprise." Adora clears her throat, so her voice sounds less raspy from laughing so hard. "I mean, don't get me wrong, Bow's right, but… y'know. This isn't you."

"No, it's really not!" Catra throws her arms out and raises her voice, relief flowing into her words;she finally feels justified to be disgusted. "I feel so weird."

Adora curls her lips into a sympathetic pout, her eyes kind, and understanding. Her gaze wanders down on Catra's body again, thick brows furrowing in confusion.

"They made you shave, too?"

Catra groans, throwing her head back. "They waxed me into a fucking baby dolphin."

Adora quirks a brow. "Do you squeak when you walk?"

"...What?"

"You know, like"... Adora rubs the heels of her palms together, making high little squeaky sounds. *Ee-ee-ee*.

Catra scoffs, but it quickly turns into a hearty laugh.

"You're such an idiot."

Adora beams at her.

"But it works."

"What works?"

"I made you laugh."

Catra presses the tip of her tongue to the inside of her cheek, trying to control her stupid smile. Adora is still looking at her, the shine in her eyes warm like sunlight.

Catra's heartbeat is picking up again, echoing in her ears.

"I thought you were off today," she says offhandedly, hoping her voice won't break.

"I am," Adora says. "I just came in to meet up with Bow. I borrowed a book on woodworking from his brother."

Catra huffs.

"How much of a stereotype can you be?"

"Stereotype?"

Adora's genuine confusion makes Catra's cheeks burn.

"Forget it," she mutters, cocking her jaw.

"Um." Adora is chewing on her bottom lip. "Well, I'll. I'll leave you to work." She shakes the book in her hand. "I have a lot to catch up on."

Adora turns on her heel. Before she could leave, Catra's soft "*hey*" makes her pause and look back from behind her shoulder.

"Yeah?"

Catra hugs herself tighter, averting her gaze to the floor.

"...Thanks."

She hopes Adora knows what she really means by that.

Adora hums cheerfully.

"See you later, Catra."

Catra suffers through the hours of work - her legs are pulsing with pain and her hair feels *tight* and too heavy. She is getting more and more frustrated by Dee's theatrical acting with which they deliver their big speech.

Catra is convinced that their eyes find her in the crowd over and over again, checking how much she can take. Catra keeps her jaw high and her eyes wandering, pretending to focus on her work and not

noticing anything else around her. She is convinced that they can't even see her legs on camera, which makes the whole waxing thing even more obvious.

Dee is trying to finish her for not being instrumental enough in their plan, taking her apart with every little thing they know will make her uncomfortable. Stripping away Catra's agency was always Dee's favorite part of breaking her, and what they knew best.

Once Dee is finally satisfied with the scene and waves elegantly from behind the screen, sitting on their director's chair like a tyrant on a throne, Catra grabs the nearest surface - the edge of a table - and tears the stilettos off her soles. It feels like her skin is coming off with them, too. Catra cranes her neck and twists her ankle, and obviously: her heels are dripping with blood.

Catra grinds her teeth and hooks the heels of the shoes on her finger. She slithers through the groups of extras staying at set to chat and laugh, and she almost makes it to the end of the set when—

"Not so fast, Kitten!"

Catra halts with a low, rumbling growl. She turns around as slowly as she possibly can, giving herself time to turn her expression into something blank and unreadable.

"What do you want?" Catra yells back, not making any attempts to close the distance between them. If Dee wants something, they will have to come to her.

Unfortunately, they do come, smoothing their hair behind their ear. They are wearing an asymmetric black and green gown, a fur coat thrown on their shoulders leisurely, and a sadistic grin that widens with every slow step they take.

"We didn't even have time to catch up since our little rendezvous in the meeting room," they say with a pout, neatly shaved brows turning upwards. "I hope you've changed your mind since then."

"About what?" Catra snaps, grimacing. "That you're an asshole for what you've done there? That you had no right to mess with *my* part of our agreement?"

"I told you, Kitten, I wasn't sure that you had it under control," Dee drawls pitifully. "You've been so distraught, and I just wanted to help."

Catra's little laugh is tinkling cruelly. She leans forward, a hand on her hip.

"Seriously? That's what they call *acting*, Dee. I'm surprised you didn't realize." Catra tilts her head slightly, her crooked smirk grows as Dee's grin fades, swift and confused. "I thought you knew me *so well*."

Dee smacks their lips, curious eyes seeking answers on Catra's features. Catra withstands their gaze without blinking, her smile calm and her cocked brow arrogant.

Dee's voice drops lower when they speak again, the words rolling off their tongue carefully.

"Maybe I've misread the signs," they say, lifting a palm to their face and slipping their other hand in the crook of their elbow. They tilt their hips, flicking their fingers lazily. "I just thought that Adora—"

"Adora is *mine*," Catra cuts in, dropping the stilettos to the ground. She closes the distance between her and Dee, head lolling back to lock eyes with them. She curls her hands into fists, and her voice is threatening. "So leave her to me, and stop fucking up my process."

Dee gasps, offended.

Catra goes on:

"Your little fake kiss practice almost ruined everything. It took me *days* to fix your mess and get her back. If you keep touching my work, we're constantly going to be taking one step forward and two

backwards." Catra takes a deep breath, the tone of her voice and the light in her irises shifting. "You don't know Adora like I do. If you attack her in your usual ways, you're only going to scare her away. She is not like you and I."

"Alright, alright." Dee raises their palms, surrendering. "I hear you. I can take constructive criticism."

"Good." Catra kicks the shoes closer to Dee, and turns her back to them. "Get these away from me."

Catra walks away on bare feet, her lungs tight and full of air. She only breathes out when she's far enough that no one can hear it, feeling giddy and weak.

End scene.

Even though Catra was back in Wardrobe, finally alone and ready to leave work behind for today, she is feeling neither calm nor relieved.

The cocktail dress is attached to her skin so tightly that it has become a part of her; Catra hisses while peeling it off, trying to keep it intact. She didn't want anyone else helping her with it; getting rid of the dress and the whole role seems somehow sacred now, and intimate. Catra is flushed and sweaty underneath; the dress is back on the hanger. She is free to put on her own clothes, tight and short only where *she* likes them.

She destroys her updo too, throwing dozens of bobby pins onto the dressing table and trying to comb through the curly mess with her fingers. She will need to wash the chemicals out of it, first; too much volume created a nest on top of Catra's head, waves standing everywhere like fraying wires.

And she needs to do something with her breathing.

Fighting back was supposed to feel good. Standing up to Dee and finally manipulating the scene so *she* comes out on top is definitely a victory after weeks of losing to them. So why does she feel like choking on air?

It's fine. Everything is under control.

Catra leans on her palms in front of the mirror, hanging her head down.

Breathe in. Breathe out. Breathe in.

And the room is slowly spinning, and spinning, and spinning, and her legs are slipping.

Catra gets back to the trailer an hour later.

She feels her heels bleeding through her socks, her limbs feel heavy like lead is flowing through her veins.

The light is on inside. Catra finds Adora right where she assumed she would be; nose deep in the borrowed book, flinching when Catra closes the door with a jngle and a click.

"Hi," Adora says, loud and cheerful. It hurts Catra's ears. "You survived the day!"

Catra just grunts. She throws her backpack up the top bunk and twirls around to get a soda from the tiny fridge. Catra pops the bottle open with a hiss and drinks a couple big gulps, throwing her head back.

Adora says something else now, but Catra doesn't follow; every single sound is another needle under Catra's itching skin.

When she catches Dee's name in the twirling lace of words, she is done.

Catra slams the door of the fridge loudly, barking:

"Shut up!"

Adora bites her words. Heavy silence falls on the trailer, and Catra wants to cry.

"Sorry ," Catra whispers, rubbing her forehead with the back of her hand. She turns to Adora, eyes finding hers. Adora looks like she has been punched, irises shining and cheeks blushed pink. "I'm sorry."

"It's okay-"

"No," Catra laughs lifelessly, hiding behind her palm now. "Nothing is okay, but I shouldn't have snapped at you like that. I'm just really . Out of it."

Catra sniffs. She drinks another big sip that sticks in her throat, the fizburning and scraping down her pipe.

The bed creaks under Adora's weight as she stands up.

"What do you need?"Adora asks gently .

Catra shrugs. It still hurts to swallow.

"I think I.could use some time alone."

"Gotcha," Adora winks, unhooking her fanny pack from the bedframe of the top bunk. "I was planning on stocking up anyway. *Someone* ate all my string cheese."

Despite feeling like shit, Catra giggles.

"What are you accusing me of, exactly?"

"Y ou know damn well what you've done."

"I'm lactose intolerant."

Adora clasps the fanny pack around her waist and blows a raspberry, her voice growing shrill.

"No you're not!"

"Honest to fucking god."

Adora flashes her a toothy grin as she leans down to slip her sneakers on. Her hair falls down, threads of gold slipping from her broad shoulders.

"Knowing you, that wouldn't have stopped you anyway. You're not off the hook."

Oh, Princess. I don't want to be.

Catra winces at her own thoughts, placing the soda on the top of the fridge. She watches Adora leave and waves back, her own lips curling into a stupid smile to mirror Adora's.

The door closes, Adora's quick steps fading. Catra breathes out, bumping her forehead against the wall.

She needs a cold shower.

After dinner, Catra puts on a playlist of slow dark wave songs and turns on the shower. She didn't turn the lights on, and hung a hand towel in front of the narrow window to douse the sun until the phone screen was the only source of a dim, flickering light.

Being naked makes her feel too exposed now, bare and smooth like a plastic doll. She finds herself shivering, goosebumps peppering her skin like freckles.

She steps into the shower with one leg when the song playing grows quiet, and her phone pings with a notification. Ignoring it, Catra turns towards the wall and closes her eyes under the cool water.

She dips her head under the stream so the dozens of hair products Glimmer tortured her with will finally wash out.

Her phone pings again. And again - five times in the short amount of time it takes for Catra to finish washing and rinsing her hair until she can comb through the wet waves with her fingers.

Once she is out of the shower, shivering again in a towel wrapped around her, her phone disturbs the next song as well. Catra catches a glimpse of the notification flashing up; it is a voice memo from an unknown number.

Catra furrows her brows and dries her palms on the towel before taking her phone in her hand to check who is bothering her.

She opens a string of texts before the memo - it doesn't take her long to realize who they came from.

Unknown

Do you like salty snacks or sweets better?

18:55

I'm buying both just to be safe

18:55

The soda you were drinking is on sale!

18:59

You get a 12-pack, my treat. For the beers.

19:00

Do you ever get an urge to pour olive oil on yourself and see how far you can slide down the aisle?

19:04

Me neither :)

19:06

(▶ [redacted]) 0:13

19:06

Catra scoffs fondly. Her thumb hovers over the play symbol for a second before she taps on it.

Adora's whispering voice floods the narrow bathroom like hot steam.

So I remembered that I wasn't supposed to text you for two very simple reasons, one being you wanting to be left alone, and two, you never gave me your number. I hope it's okay that I got it from Scorpia. I mean I got it from Perfuma but she got it from Scorpia… anyway don't worry, I said I needed it because I left the trailer keys in my apartment. [Adora's voice softens.] *I hope you're doing a little better. I'll hang around here for a while, just in case. And stop texting you. Um. So yeah. There's a baby staring at me so I think it's time for me to stop talking to my watch. Or say something like* [Her voice grows playfully deep now.] *"Eagle one, I have found the frozen waffles. Permission to eat them cold." Um. Alright. I'll go. Um. Bye.* [

Catra can hear the smile that forms Adora's words.] *See you at home, Catra.*

Catra's heart is pounding. Her phone is shaking in her hand as she takes a couple steps back until her back hits the slippery tiles.

She feels… weird. The air is suddenly colder, or maybe it is Catra's body growing warmer; she definitely feels like her skin is burning as she unknots the towel on her chest. It opens like a cape, still stuck and held in place between Catra's scapula and the tile wall, its sides curling like curtains.

Her chest is heaving, slow and steady, her belly shaking with every little exhale.

Catra taps on the call icon next to Adora's number and puts the phone on speaker, slipping it onto the edge of the sink that's right next to her.

Adora accepts after two rings.

"...Hello?" She picks up, careful and uncertain.

Catra swallows thickly. "Hey , Adora."

"Oh good, it's really you." Adora chuckles. "For a second I thought I must have been texting the wrong number all along."

Catra lets her lips part, breathing in Adora's voice. Her eyes fall shut, her head tipping back until her neck strains. She lifts her left hand high, and rests her forearm on top of her head.

Her right hand starts wandering down on her navel.

Adora asks, after a moment of pause: "Y ou okay?"

"Yeah," Catra says, gentle fingertips slipping between her curls. They only left the hair between her legs, so she can feel herself like Adora has always felt her. "I just thought..." Catra wets her fingers with drops of water and shine, still stroking featherlight, "that it's easier to talk like this if you have so much to say."

Adora laughs, embarrassed and sweet.

Catra's fingers touch burning, throbbing heat, reaching lower. Her breath hitches.

"That wouldn't bother you?" Adora asks. "You said you needed to be alone."

Catra draws her fingers up and pushes her hips ahead, dragging the tip of her index right where she needs it most. She feels her rapid heartbeat throbbing in her flesh, a jolt of electricity tugging on her insides.

She gasps loudly.

"Catra?"

"I said I needed *alone time*," Catra says, a little breathless. She repeats the wave, raising on her tiptoes. She grips her hair with her free hand, pulling hard on the half-dry waves. "*Mmh*— Maybe I've changed my mind."

"Aww," Adora coos, and it's a delicious, low rumble that makes Catra grind up to her hand again, biting her lip to muffle a whimper. "You miss me so much already, huh?"

Fuck, you have no idea.

Catra's body has an even more violent reaction to Adora's smug voice than her cute laugh. Catra arches her spine off the tiles and let's go of her hair to reach for her phone.

The towel plops to the floor.

"Just talk to me a bit, okay?" Catra asks, a little more desperate than she planned to. "Like you were before."

"Talk about what?"

"Anything. Whatever you want. Tell me about your day."

"Oh, okay," Adora says with a confident that-I-can-do voice. "I think I have some funny stories from breakfast. You would've called me an idiot for it."

Adora goes on, and Catra mutes her mic. Relief is a loud moan spilling free from her lips, and a needy rhythm of her fingers circling. She can't decide how she wants to do this, all she is sure about is that she needs her free hand on her body, too.

She strokes up her neck, fingers wide open, her thumb right under her chin. Adora liked to cup her jaw and guide her eyes to melt into her gaze, so focused on reading Catra's pleasure from her face when words were forbidden. If she were here, if things were simpler, and different, she would be looking at her right now, azure eyes darkening into forest lakes, and it would have been okay to ask her to touch Catra more.

Catra's hand drops down, nails hooking under her collarbone to scratch the skin. She cups her breast then, squeezing harder than Adora would have with a hard nipple pinched between her fingers.

She presses herself back to the wall, her back slipping down with a screech. Catra drops to her knees on the towel wrinkling under her, spreading her legs wide. Some waves of her hair are still wet, sticking to the tiles like vines climbing upwards.



Adora's voice sweeps into her veins; Catra only hears the melody of her without words, so lovely with the loud laughs and how her tone lowers into a deep mumble when she is embarrassed.

The hand between Catra's thighs picks up the pace again, every rough little stroke draws broken whimpers out of her mouth. Her throat runs dry, her left hand comes back to grab a handful of hair right above her forehead as she is writhing desperately for *more*, more friction, more skin, more of Adora's ghost.

Catra wants Adora to hear her, watch her. She wants Adora here; her hands in the path of Catra's, her lips on her lips, to pull her hair and slip her fingers inside her, to suck and bite that spot behind Catra's ear only she knows about. To fuck her until she screams, then fuck her again, and again, leave her sore and whimpering, used and wrecked and spoiled.

And she wants Adora's arms around her, then - holding her tight, peppering her face with kisses and telling her that she…

Catra's eyes spring open as the first rush of pleasure strikes her. She arches her back to it, feeling warmth flooding every inch of her, her hand not slowing down just yet; her orgasm lasts long, and Catra needs every single second she can get with the phantoms of Adora's fingertips and her voice helping her through it.

Catra is breathing heavily, her legs slipping further away until she is sitting on her bruised heels. She feels her warmth flowing down, staining the towel. The pads of her fingers are soaked and pruny, webs of shine between them. Catra is staring at the wall in a daze for long, sober thoughts just crawling back into her head with little throbs of panic, like a migraine.

Fuck. Fuck—

"Catra? Are you still there?" She hears Adora ask on the other side of the line.

Catra tries to ease her breathing. She swallows big, exhaling through her nose as slow as she can. It only amplifies how her heart is still drumming fast in her ears.

Catra reaches up with her clean hand, fumbling for her phone. She clears her throat and unmutes herself, gripping her phone tight and says:

"Yeah. I must've put it on mute with my ear." Catra closes her eyes, her voice small. "You were saying?"

Friday rolls around quicker than Catra had even noticed. The last three days were all the same, melting into one. Their opposing work schedules didn't give them much time together during the days, so Catra spent the evenings with Adora in the trailer.

They were talking. A lot, actually. About everything. Adora isn't the type that loves to chat - not like Scorpia, who could go on for ten minutes without breathing. Adora appreciates the comfortable silence, too, just like Catra does. The shift in the atmosphere is palpable, and they both spend more time sitting on opposite sides of the tiny table instead of their beds, doing their own thing; reading, having tea, answering emails or just checking social media.

On Tuesday, they show each other songs from their terrible rebellious teenage years. Catra improvised a screamo cover of Adora's ridiculous, favorite country song, which made her laugh so hard she hit her head in the window frame. With tears in her eyes, she kept laughing, while Catra jumped to her and slipped a gentle hand on the hot bump growing quickly on Adora's skull.

That's when she touched her first.

On Wednesday, Catra was painting her nails which interested Adora in a way a slice of bacon would interest a golden retriever. So, after Catra's nails were dry, she got out her little bag of polishes - full of shades she doesn't even use but owns anyway - and coated Adora's nails with a baby blue while Adora read her boring passages from the woodworking book enthusiastically. Obviously, after Catra was

done with her perfect work, and Adora looked at her bright nails, she immediately whimpered "I don't like it." So, Catra cleaned them off.

That's when she touched her the second time.

On Thursday, they stayed up late chatting in their own beds. Or more like, Adora was trying to convince Catra that ghosts *are* real, and told her all these stories about the ghost of a little girl who lived under Adora's bed at her first adoptive parents' home. Catra believed none of it, but said nothing so Adora would share more little stories with her from her childhood. None of them were actually telling, but it still warmed Catra's heart to imagine little Adora with her chipped tooth and always bruised knees, terrified of the ghost under her bed; but instead of telling anyone, she carved herself a wooden sword she kept under her pillow just in case.

After Catra made a snarky comment about how a wooden sword would have definitely been helpful against a very real ghost, Adora kicked Catra's mattress from the bottom bunk. Catra took her pillow to throw into Adora's face in return, muffling her snorting laughs.

Adora didn't want to give the pillow back, so Catra jumped down, landing elegantly on her feet and wrestling Adora for it without warning.

Adora was a weak opponent, breaking under the power of surprise so Catra could easily snatch the pillow back, stroking Adora's arm in the process.

That's when she touched her the third time.

Now it's a warm Friday afternoon. Catra arrives at the trailer the same time Adora does, walking from the opposite direction. When she noticed Catra, she started jogging to catch up to her.

"Hello, stranger," Adora said, both hands in the pockets of her bomber jacket. "Looking for a place to stay the night?"

"You know, I was," Catra jokes back. "But turns out the only trailer I could find comes with an annoying blonde girl."

Catra unlocks the door and steps inside first, leaving the door open for Adora. Once they're both inside and Adora closes the door, she turns to Catra with a bright grin, hands on her hips.

"It also comes with lots of surfaces to use the blond girl o—" Adora's voice breaks into a whine, then fades away. Catra hears how she slaps her mouth, not believing what she'd just said.

Catra feels herself tense up, her waves rising from tension. Her cheeks are definitely flushed with color, hopefully hidden from Adora, who starts giggling awkwardly.

"Sorry ," she says, "Shit. That just came out of habit."

Like Catra in the bathroom, touching herself. Coming out of habit. Nothing more to think about, no reason to mistake that warmth and desperation for anything else.

So, Catra gathers herself and forces the most carefree, nonchalant tone in her voice as she asks:

"We never really talked about the rules, have we?"

Adora doesn't reply, so Catra sneaks a peek at her; she is chewing on her bottom lip, her gaze flickering around.

Catra turns to her, tilting her head.

"Adora?"

Adora blinks, frightened eyes finding Catra's. Her pupils had shrunk into needle-points, shoulders raised to her jaw defensively.

"Um"...

"We don't have to talk about it right now," Catra says. It would be better not to, honestly. Catra wants this as much as Adora seems to; they've fallen into a new routine without having to say anything. That should be enough. They both understand what's going on well enough.

"I mean," Adora says, slipping a palm on the nape of her neck, "do we even have rules anymore?"

"No, I guess not." Catra keeps her eyes on Adora's strained features, trying to figure her out.

She's never been a great help to anybody. Adora especially is kind of a mystery to Catra - she feels like she's known her her whole life, and she knows her *well* - Catra knows every single flinch of Adora's hands and lips, every tone of her voice, every gesture and every gleam in her eyes. Adora is oblivious, open-hearted and freespoken, and yet, Catra can't help but notice a wall she's built around her heart.

She's right behind that now, seemingly here but just out of Catra's reach.

And it fucking hurts.

"There's not much to talk about, then," Adora says, her voice and smile empty.

She walks past Catra to go to the bathroom. When she reaches out for the folding door, something crosses Catra's mind that might be the perfect solution to whatever Adora's problem is.

Catra leans to the ladder of the beds and suggests:

"So why don't you invite your friends over tomorrow?"

Adora halts, slowly turning her head towards Catra. She asks, quick and low:

"Wait, really?"

"Yeah." There's that loopy grin on Adora's pretty face, making Catra's heart skip a beat. Catra slides a hand on her shoulder. "I have plans anyway. They can sleep here too, I won't be back for the night."

Adora's expression breaks; it's just a shadow creeping through her features before she takes control of them again.

"Oh."

"That would be fun, right?" Catra tries.

She sucks so bad at this. Why is cheering people up so fucking hard? Catra is not good with words, and she can't exactly use what she is good with right now.

Being friends is weird. With Scorpia, it's easy - that girl is never feeling down, and even if she does, she simply shuts off and Catra doesn't have to do anything to…

Oh. That's bad too, isn't it? So Catra has never been a really great support, even for her best and only friend.

Adora has no idea what she signed up for.

"Yeah, it would be," Adora says, turning away again. "I'll tell Glimmer and Bow."

Adora pulls the door closed on herself.

Catra drops her hand and sighs deeply.

They spend the rest of the night more quietly than the ones before. Adora is working out, barely talking, and Catra sits at the edge of her bunk, feet dangling off. She tries to pretend she's working on her laptop that lays in her lap, but in reality, she can barely focus on anything when her eyes find Adora over and over again. She can't

look away from the curves of Adora's back, shining with sweat and flushed pink; her broad shoulders and strong arms, and her tank top clinging to her stomach so deliciously tight, leaving her soft chest exposed as she is doing pushups on the floor.

Catra's throat runs dry.

She can steal as many glances as she wants, because Adora won't look at her.

She doesn't get to touch her anymore.

"I'm just *saying*, if you wanna talk 'unusual food combos that actually work', you don't get to be offended by pickles and Nutella."

"We are talking about *unusual*, not *god's mistakes.*"

"Don't judge it before trying!"

"Just… tell me it's not what you're actually going to serve your friends."

Adora's reply is a loud, harsh *crunch* that sends shivers up Catra's spine. She almost messes up her eyeliner because of it; she drops back onto her soles from her tiptoes, dipping her brush in ink again.

"At least don't eat it while I'm still here!"

Adora's head pops up in the crack of the folding door, and in her hand, there's a half-eaten pickle with a dash of Nutella on top. She pushes it under Catra's nose; Catra jumps back with a little shriek, nearly falling into the shower.

Adora shakes the pickle in front of her like bait.

"Try it!"

"No!" Catra yells, but she can't fight the stupid grin that tugs so hard on the corners of her mouth it hurts.

"Just a little bite!"

"Get that shit away from me!" Catra hops into the shower, hiding behind the translucent curtain. Adora tries to draw the curtain away, but Catra clings to it tight. They're both wheezing now, tugging on the curtain like two kids fighting for a toy.

Adora is barely able to croak between smug, challenging laughs: "What, are you *scared*?"

Catra scoffs. "You wish."

"Prove it," Adora releases the curtain, taking a step back and holding up the Nutella-pickle like it's an expensive gem. "Take a bite of it, and maybe I'll believe you."

Catra pouts from behind the curtain, slowly pulling it away from her face. She cocks a brow at Adora, unimpressed but guarded.

"Fine," she grunts, tossing the curtain away now. She begrudgingly accepts Adora's hand which helps her out of the shower like she would step out of a limo at her first red carpet premiere.

"Your pickle, Miss Weaver,"Adora coos.

Catra flashes Adora the dirtiest look she can manage, snatching the pickle from Adora's hand. She keeps unshakable eye contact with Adora as she takes a huge, crunchy bite of the fucking Nutella-pickle.

Catra is chewing. And chewing. And chewing. She swallows big, still staring right into Adora's eyes shining bright blue and all too knowing.

Catra says:

"Oh, *fuck you*."

Adora giggles proudly. "I told you."

"How?!" Catra flicks the pickle at Adora's chest like a cigarette butt. The pickle bounces back, and Adora catches it mid-air. "Get the fuck out with your tasty ass Nutella pickle and let me finish my makeup."

Adora does as she is told, but she still says, right as she grabs onto the doorframe of the narrow bathroom:

"You're just mad I was right."

"Out."

Adora spins out with the tip of her tongue between her teeth, cheeks round and flushed from their scuffle.

Catra goes back to perfecting her wings, while Adora is fumbling around in the kitchen.

After not talking to Catra all last night, Adora woke up like nothing happened. Catra didn't understand, but felt thankful for it anyway; they didn't have to talk, and in the end, everything turned out great. Adora was over whatever got to her yesterday, and now they're back to their new routine that fills Catra's chest with more warmth than anything had before.

Which warmth is… more like burning, actually. And the smell twirling in the air is definitely.suspicious.

Catra had finished with everything except getting fully dressed, so she steps out, barefoot in her leggings and bra cautiously, and sniffs the air.

There's a loud beep, then a hurriedly whispered "*oh, shit*".

Catra asks, squinting:

"What are you doing?"

Adora winces, turning towards the microwave and showing her back to Catra as she hunches ahead.

"Nothing!"

"Adora, what did you burn?"

"Absolutely nothing. I have everything under control."

"Aha," Catra purrs, sneaking closer. "So those are *not* your little pizza crackers you've been talking about and messing with all afternoon, burnt to a crisp?"

"No," Adora whimpers.

"And it's *not* because you microwaved them for twenty minutes instead of two?"

Adora just makes another broken noise. She leans forward, her forehead hitting the top of the microwave with a hollow bump.

Catra is swaying closer, trying to force down her smirk.

"Okay hotshot, show me." Adora shakes her head, humming a negative reply. *She's way too cute right now,* Catra realizes with a little stab and a tug on her heartstrings. "Come on. Maybe I can help."

Without thinking much about it, Catra slides a comforting hand up Adora's shoulder and tries to draw her to the side so she can see.

Adora spins on her heel suddenly, yelping "no!" Her hands catch Catra by the waist and drag her away from the scene of the accident.

Catra finds herself propped up on top of the counter, Adora's hands on her hip and another cradling the back of her head so she doesn't hit it on the knobs of the cabinets right behind her. Adora is standing

between Catra's spread legs, her face is looming so close, eyes wide and shimmering.

Catra's chest tightens. Her mind doesn't know where her hands are, so focused on the warmth of Adora's breath on her face, the tight press of her thighs on hers, gentle fingertips flinching on Catra's skin, burrowing into her curls.

Adora blinks, and something breaks.

"Sorry." She is whispering for some reason, closing her eyes. "I just... I can fix this."

Catra doesn't reply. She wouldn't know what to say and she barely heard Adora anyway; her heart is too loud, drumming like rainfall on glass. She doesn't dare to move, either, scared of ending this, but even more scared of what she might do if she lets her body out of the iron grip of her shattered consciousness.

Adora stays there, too. Catra watches her lashes flutter as she peeks up again, meeting Catra's eyes for a split second - and whatever she saw in them must have been enough for her, because Adora tilts her head and leans in, the tips of their noses grazing slightly.

Catra's breath hitches. Adora halts; she's almost there, just a breath away, and she waits.

Catra closes the distance between them.

Adora's lips are soft like they've always been. It feels like an eternity since Catra could've tasted her; she is sweet and sour on Catra's lips, her touch buzzing like faint lightning of electricity.

Catra's eyes fall shut at Adora's gentle pecks. She kisses her back just as slow but more heated, smudging Adora's upper lip. Adora breathes out in little shakes through her nose, her whole body trembling.

Their lips pop.

Adora broke the kiss way too soon, drawing back. She stays where she was waiting for Catra's move, bumping their foreheads together delicately, and swallows.

"*Catra,"* she breathes, begging. Her voice breaks.

Catra doesn't move. With her eyes still closed and her head lolled back, lips parted in the middle, desperate and inviting, she prays to herself.

Don't ruin it.

After what feels like forever, Catra feels the light touch of Adora's fingertips on her cheeks; just the calloused pads, not daring to cup her face just yet. Catra presses closer, nuzzling into Adora's palm.

Please.

Adora captures her lips again, and Catra melts with a little moan, her spine straightening for a better angle. Her hand crawls up Adora's back on the curve of her spine, fingers curling around her silky ponytail. Adora pulls Catra closer by her waist, arms wrapping around her in a gentle embrace.

Their kiss deepens with Catra's guidance, opening up and tasting Adora between her lips. Catra can feel Adora's mouth curling into a smile under hers as she hums sweetly and kisses Catra back.

Catra loses count of the pecks and the licks, all melting into one delicious, intoxicating feeling of Adora. Neither of them try to take things further; their hands caressing each other never wander somewhere *meaningful*, only stroking along each other's faces and necks and arms, leaving goosebumps in their wake.

Adora snuggles closer, their heaving bellies crashing, swallowing each other's gasps for air.

It feels like falling into a daydream, flooding all of Catra's senses. Peach lights dancing on her closed lids, Adora's sweetness sticking to her lips like sugar, the melody of their kisses seeking more, their heartbeats throbbing in her ears, the softness of Adora's skin under Catra's hands.

There's so much pleasure and satisfaction in devouring each other unhurriedly that Catra didn't know before their last time breaking a rule. Her whole body is warming up to Adora, like their skin is welded by touch alone, healing their deep running scars, and Catra could stay here for all eternity if Adora wanted her to, if she ever asked her to, if she needed her, she's *ready…*

There's loud knocking on the trailer door. They flutter apart like petals in the wind, Adora stumbling a couple steps back and Catra throwing herself off the countertop.

"*Shit,*"Adora hisses, tittering deliriously . "Alright. They're here. Uh."

"Just go," Catra says quickly , hurrying away with the back of her hand pressed to her mouth. The sunlight has shifted from yellow to blue from Catra keeping her eyes closed for so long, getting lost in Adora's arms. "I-I need to finish getting dressed."

Adora makes a loud choking noise, making Catra turn back to look at her. Adora's expression is wild, thick brows furrowed and teeth flashing. Still, when she talks, her voice sounds more miserable than anything, without any fragments of anger.

"You *still* want to go meet them?!"

Catra knits her brows, too, and crosses her arms in front of her chest defensively.

"Yeah? I promised them like a week ago, of course I'm going."

Adora is standing there like Catra slapped her with every word she spoke, teetering at the edge of tearing up. Catra's throat tightens

painfully, confusion evident in her tone as she asks:

"Adora, what' s going on?"

Adora opens her mouth to speak. Before any noise could come out, the pounding on the door starts over again, but this time, Glimmer yells from the other side:

"Helloooo? Adora, are you in there?

Adora closes her mouth, the same empty smile painted on her face like yesterday.

"Nothing! I'm fine. Go on. I'm sure you don't want to keep them waiting."

She steps to the door then, inviting Bow and Glimmer in like nothing happened. Her voice is chirping again cheerfully as she wraps both her friends in a big, tight hug.

Catra greets them and quickly slips into the bathroom again, hoping the bile she tastes at the back of her tongue will dissolve before she throws it up. Adora and her friends are laughing so hard at Adora's failed attempt at making cracker pizza snacks - that Adora doesn't hide from her *real* friends, apparently - that they probably wouldn't even hear it.

Catra's phone is still laying on the edge of the sink, flashing up with a notification for a new message.

Scorpia

Are you ready, Wildcat?? 😈 Per and I are waiting for you at the gate!

19:15

Catra takes her phone into her shaking hands, trying and failing miserably to text back. It takes her a whole minute to type in a reply without typos that sounds like everything is perfectly fine.

i'll be there in 5. see you soon!

19:16

Chapter End Notes

I dont actually condone trying Nutella on pickles. But if you do try it please tell me how it actually tastes like, I fucking hate pickles so I wont do it myself.

Yes, this chapter was basically a love letter for the CC anon known as Grocery Bae who's headcanons and ideas always make my day and inspire me. Thank you for being amazing.

Thank you so so much for reading and following this story ♡ ✨ Your support means the world to me, I hope you enjoyed this chapter as much as the previous ones.

Please consider saying hello to me on Twitter (I keep it 18+ so please have your age in your bio or I will block you). You can send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or (even) anonymously on CuriousCat. I hang around there a lot so it's easier to reach me there than down here.
I love you all, stay safe, and see you next time!

Rule #8

Chapter Summary

8. We don't owe each other explanations.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's heart is still hammering in her chest as she laughs at her own kitchen failure. She hears nothing else coming from the bathroom, just the pinging of Catra's phone and the quiet rustling of her clothes.

It hurts to swallow.

"Sooo" Glimmer drawls between chuckles, bringing Adora back to reality, "normal pizza?"

"I guess we have to," Adora sighs, sliding a palm on the nape of her neck as she flashes a quick glance at the plate of catastrophe. "These seem like they're only edible once."

So Bow and Glimmer huddle up on Adora's bed, trying to find a restaurant to order from that doesnt take years to deliver to the studio.

Adora doesnt join them. She stays standing still by the microwave, the bathroom door hazy in her peripheral vision. She crosses her arms in front of her chest, nails digging into her flesh to ground herself somehow. She feels the pounding of her heart in her neck and, pressing her cheek to her bare shoulder, she finds her skin burning still.

Catra kissed her. *Catra* kissed her.

Sure, Adora started it, but she wasn't actually going to *do* it - was she? Adora doesn't even know what she wanted to do or achieve with all of that, let alone what Catra might have been thinking - if she had even been thinking at all. Adora wasn't, that's clear. When does she ever? Who the hell starts out fooling around with a friend and ends up making out with them pinned to the cupboards, trapped between their gorgeous thighs squeezing your hips just right to make you hear electricity cracking in the air like there's a storm coming, rumbling in—

"Adora! Hello?"

Adora winces.

"Yeah," she squeaks, pinching herself harder to keep focus.

"I asked if you want olives on yours," Glimmer says, scrolling on the phone in Bow's hand.

"Sure. Fine. Whatever you guys want."

"Pizza bread?" Bow chimes in. Glimmer gasps.

"Pizza bread!"

The rustling from the bathroom grows louder, and the folding door opens. Adora's heart sinks into her stomach. She doesn't want to look, but her eyes disobey her; she takes everything in slowly, lifting her gaze from Catra's combat boots to the ripped tights and jean shorts, to the cutest flash of bare skin between the high waist of the jeans and the bottom of the tube top with a cut that leaves very little to Adora's imagination.

Adora swallows.

Fuck, it would be so easy to drag that top down to Catra's navel and slip a palm between the warm swells of her chest; to scoop her up and shove her back on the countertop and suck a mark on her

breast, claiming her, just like Adora's hand could claim her between her thighs, stroking her to pleasure over and over again until she loses her voice and can't cry for Adora anymore...

Adora audibly whimpers, flames of a newly lit fire creeping under her skin. She tries to hide it behind a palm, fingers spread around her nose. What the hell has gotten into her? She's losing her goddamn mind—

Adora snaps her gaze up from Catra's body to her face, only to find more perfect little details there to be lured in by, and - Catra staring right at her.

"What?" Catra asks, raspy but careful. There's a tiny crest between her brows that Adora can't really figure out the meaning of.

Nothing is what Adora wants to say. What comes out is another squeak that barely resembles the word as she drops her hand back down from her face.

Catra's nose blooms dusty red. She shoots a quick look over to Glimmer and Bow, checking to see if they're catching on to anything. They aren't; they're talking quietly to each other, pointing at the screen to different topping choices, not paying any attention to Adora or Catra.

Catra grabs her leather jacket from the bedframe of the top bunk. Now that she's close, Bow looks up at her, smiling encouragingly.

"Are you gonna join us, Catra?"

Catra tries to stick her arm through a nonexistent hole in her jacket, struggling, mismatched eyes widening.

"Uh, no." She manages to put on the jacket, clinging to the collar with both hands. Her voice is small and husky. "I...I have plans."

Right… there it is. A stinging pain low in Adora's abdomen, burning like cinder because Catra looks so gorgeous for someone else. She had dressed like this for someone who took away her authority over herself by forcing her to get waxed, put her in a dress that looked nothing like something she would ever wear, heels she only got bloody bruises from. For someone who already broke her heart, someone who talks to her like garbage.

Someone Adora really, really wants to punch in the face right now.

"A w," Bow pouts, eyes flickering between Adora and Catra. Adora relaxes her hand; she didnt realize she had curled it into a shaking fist. "Maybe next time?"

"Shell probably have plans for that, too," Glimmer cuts in sweetly, resting her chin on the palm of her hand and cocking a thick brow at Catra. "Right?"

"*Glimmer*," Bow chides, bumping his elbow against Glimmer's forearm.

Glimmer huffs.

"It' s fine," Catra says. The corner of her lips curves into a faint smile, eyes cast down as she walks to the door. She turns the knob and pulls the door open with a creak. The chattering noise that pours into the trailer douses her voice into a quiet whisper as she turns her back to the three of them. "Y ou dont need to be polite. I know you dont like me."

"I like you."

Adora freezes at her own words she blurted out without thinking.

Shit. Shit—

Catra whips her head up but doesnt turn. Wild curls slip off her shoulders, falling behind her back, fluttering softly in the breeze that

freshens up the benign air. Adora can smell a whiff of Catra's spicy sweetness, intoxicating and alluring.

"I mean," Adora stammers, her mind hazy. "*We*. We like you. We all do. Sometimes. When you're not a brat. So."

Moments pass in dreadful silence until finally, Catra shows her profile and a crooked grin.

"Smooth save, Grayskull," she purrs, stepping out of the door. "Have fun, kids."

As soon as the door closes with a heavy click, Adora can feel Glimmer's sharp gaze searching her features.

"What, are you two close now?" She asks in a very telling tone that sends an uncomfortable shiver up Adora's spine.

Adora swallows before answering. What would Catra want her to say?

"Not really."

"Oh come on, Adora." Glimmer's voice is sharper than daggers now, cutting through Adora's chest. She pushes herself up from the bed, her head tipped to the side arrogantly. "*Smooth save, Grayskull*'," she parrots in a tone that doesn't resemble Catra's at all. "Did you forget how much of an asshole she is? Why do you let her mess with you like that? You can't really like her."

Adora snorts as a grimace pulls on her features. It only seems to anger Glimmer more, her voice growing shrill.

"Adora!"

That's enough.

Adora didn't mean to yell those words out loud. It doesn't matter now; the air grew cold, or her body was burning too hot, cradled in

the fire of rage that blinds and binds her.

Glimmer gasps, offended.

"Wait, are you actually mad at me right now?"

"So what if I am?" Adora snaps, leaping closer to the bed and, with that, Glimmer too. "What if I don't blindly hate the same people that you hate? I'm so sick and tired of having to explain myself to you and justify everything I do!"

"What are you *talking* about?" Glimmer raises her voice to match Adora's. "You've hated her for years! I've been listening to you complain about her since you met her!"

"Guys," Bow tries to interfere, his voice soft just like his touch on Glimmer's shoulder. Glimmer shakes him off, shrinking the distance between her and Adora.

"People can change," Adora says, firm and still too loud and high for her own liking. "What's your problem? I didn't do anything wrong."

"What's *my* problem?!" Glimmer stares right up at her, teeth bared. "You can't be mad at me for being confused when you're the one obviously keeping secrets from us!"

Adora's breath hitches as she takes a stumbling step back. She doesn't have much time to recover before Glimmer continues, more desperate than ever.

"We're supposed to be your best friends, and it's like we dont even know you anymore! And you're telling me that I should be okay with something you've clearly been hiding from us, just because you think I'm insecure?"

"I never said that!"

"We both know that's exactly what you meant," Glimmer's eyes are shimmering with tears she tries to swallow back. She plops back

onto the bed, blindly fumbling for Bow's hand. Bow squeezes her fingers, his thumb caressing her knuckles. Glimmer's voice turns quiet and sour. "You won't just win me over by blessing us with your presence after weeks of not giving a shit about all the hangouts we've planned. Do you really think I don't know where you go all the time?"

The lump in Adora's throat grows thorns.

Glimmer turns away, casting her eyes down.

"You come back here. To her."

"Hey now," Bow murmurs, slinging an arm around Glimmer's waist and pulling her close. "It's good that we're finally talking about this, but we should try and calm down, okay?"

Adora puckers her lips.

"Before we say some hurtful shit, you mean?"

"You know I'm right," Glimmer says. "I just don't know why you don't trust us anymore."

"I trust you," Adora says with a hand on her chest. She sounds just as desperate as she does frustrated now. "I really do, Glimmer. You're still my best friends, but I'm allowed to like other people!"

"Even if said person makes you *lie* to us?"

"No, she doesn't! Why don't you understand? She doesn't make me do anything that I don't want!" Adora lets her eyes fall closed and her voice turns quiet and strained. "Hell, it feels like she's the only person who doesn't."

Glimmer's laugh cuts through the air, shrill and cruel.

"Oh, so she's already *better* than us?"

"Glimmer , just— just listen! You don't know what you're talking about."

"How would I know if you dont tell me anything?"

Adora curls the hand on her shoulder into a fist and drops it by her side. She takes a deep breath through her nose, her brows furrowing.

She breathes out with the words, flat and defeated.

"Fine. I am keeping something from you. But I cant tell you what it is, and Im really, truly sorry for that. I still love you two, and everyone else, too. I never meant to make you feel like youre only second best after her, but... Catra…" Adora wets her lips. She takes a stumbling, insecure step towards the bed. Glimmer still doesnt look at her, but scoots over to give her room, so Adora throws herself down. The springs sqeak under her weight as she fidgets and stretches her legs, dropping her hands between her thighs. "It's complicated."

"With her? Shocking," Glimmer spits.

Adora scowls at her.

"See? I knew this is how you'd react if I said anything!"

Glimmer rolls her eyes.

"Fine, sorry. I just"… She growls, lolling her head back. She breathes out in a huff, her shoulders dropping. "Okay , you're right. I was being… insecure. I guess I'm just… confused by all of this. You never ditched us like this before and you didn't tell us anything about you guys becoming friends. I get it, fine, you can like whoever you want, message received. It's just… it's like you don't want us to know things about you anymore."

Adora softens her voice, leaning closer to Glimmer, hoping she'll look her in the eyes now.

Glimmer doesn't.

"Glimmer, it's not that, I swear." Adora tries to reach out for Glimmer's other hand that isn't held by Bow; she can cup it without Glimmer drawing away. Adora chooses her next words very, very carefully. "I didn't even realize how much I've been ignoring you. You're right, too. I was so wrapped up in trying to figure out where I stand with Catra. I haven't said anything because I don't know what there is to say. Not yet. I enjoy her company more now because we've gotten to know each other better and honestly… she's not at all as bad as I thought - as you still believe. If you give her a chance, I'm sure you'll start to like her, too."

Adora takes a break to breathe, contemplating what else she can share with her friends at this point. Rules thrown out of the window or not, she can't tell them that she's been sleeping with Catra for years behind their backs. She doesn't *want* to, either. She also doesn't want to clue them in to how she feels, and how she's been trying to win Catra's heart, not just her friendship. What they have is just for the two of them, and the blooming friendship is still so fragile, so uncertain, so in need of care. She has barely won Catra's trust, and she knows how easy it is to lose it with just one wrong move. Everything she's fighting for, everything she's achieved with stubborn patience and persistent care, can shatter in a second like a crystal vase dropped by a negligent hand.

So, Adora goes on, staring at her knees to stop them from bouncing:

"She's really kind, under that prickly shell. Sure, she's sarcastic and hot-headed and can be such an annoying brat, but... She's also funny and charming, hardworking and tough, and cool and beautiful, and with everything she's been through, trust me, it's a miracle that she has stayed so soft and gentle deep down. And once she opens up - once she opens her heart to you, it's impossible not to like her." Adora's hand twitches, laying on Glimmer's. "I can't not like her.

Whatever you want me to say, or feel, it's just not the truth. And I'm not sorry about that."

No one answers her for a long, long time. Adora peeks up at her friends to find them staring back at her with dumbfounded, but otherwise unreadable expressions. They share a quick look between themselves, pressing their lips together in the same grimace.

Adora's sirens are going off.

"Uuh."

"Okay," Glimmer says. "Okay, I… I get it now." She looks at Bow again, who clears his throat. Adora swears she can see shadows of the faintest blush painting his nose as he sneaks his hands back from Glimmer's waist and hand. "I think we *both* do."

"Yeah," Bow says, his voice breaking. "We, hah, we sure do. Everything's clear. You don't owe us an apology, Adora. Some things are difficult to say, when you're not sure how they'll play out." He pauses for a moment. "Especially if someone else's feelings are involved."

"Exactly!" Adora says with a relieved grin. She eases her posture, hanging her head, hiding behind her long ponytail and leaning her elbows on her knees. "Phew, I thought I was gonna have to talk for much longer. I was *not* ready for that."

She succeeded. She managed to tell the truth - at least the parts of the truth she was willing to tell, anyway - without having Glimmer and Bow figure out the other, way more embarrassing secrets she is hiding. She threw a bone out of the closet and kept the skeleton safe, and with that, her process of earning everything and anything Catra offers her, let it be trust, or friendship, or… maybe, hopefully, if she plays her cards right, something more.

"Hey," Glimmer's voice brings Adora back from her twirling thoughts. "I'm sorry for coming on so strong."

Adora smiles at her faintly.

"And I'm sorry for neglecting you guys. I will do better in the future, I promise." Adora's eyes light up as an idea sparks in her mind. "In *fact,* " she says, "what if I plan a weekend for us, like the one we had during the *Fall of Salineas* shoot?"

"The beach weekend?" Bow asks. "Ooh, I'm down."

"Me too!" Glimmer chimes in, finally finding her usual chirpy voice. "That would be so much fun! We can totally find a couple days we can all take off!"

"It's settled, then," Adora shoots a finger gun at them and takes her phone out of the back pocket of her jeans. "I'm texting the others. I can make a sheet to work around the date and I'll find a place we can rent somewhere around the coast, I know a couple sites to hit up and *oh*, I actually know a guy"—

"Adora," Glimmer says.

"Right. Right. I'll do that later. Just… okay." Adora sends the quick message in the group chat, then switches to the calendar app. "I'll set a notification for tomorrow so I won't forget. Annnd… done." She locks her phone and puts it on her pillow, screen down. She pops her lips, raising her brows at Bow's phone that he had also put down by his thigh. "Also, can we order food now? I'm starving."

The rest of the night goes as smoothly as Adora could have hoped. They settle for Chinese instead - it's kind of their comfort food after arguments, like a peace offering. Adora loves it. It calms her down, knowing that a chapter of their conflicts is fully finished, closed.

Conversation flows naturally, too; they avoid talking about sensitive topics (meaning Catra), and Adora can finally catch up on crew drama and everything her friends have been up to. The more she

hears, the more she understands where Glimmer was coming from; she did miss a lot of her friend's lives on set, and how they're doing in general. She realizes that apart from the very messy meeting of Scorpia, she has actually been pretty absent. She went to set, got through work, and came back to spend her free time with Catra while her friend group hung around the cafeteria. She learns about the programs Glimmer had planned to keep the group together. Adora's selfishness had deprived her of movie nights and bowling tournaments which she hadnt even seen the notifications for in the group chat because she forgot to read them after barely noticing them the first time.

She tries to swallow the guilt with the next bite of chicken and focuses on catching up instead.

She won't ruin another night with being so enchanted by Catra, she decides.

She lasts until the night falls and it's time for bed.

Adora lays awake in Catra's bed, and hopes that this is okay. She lent her bunk to Glimmer and Bow to crash in, but she didn't count on something very, very important; that Catra's bed - *surprisingly* - smells like her.

Adora grits her teeth. She pulls the blanket higher on her shoulders, which turns out to be a very bad idea. She is wrapped in a soft embrace that too closely resembles laying on top of Catra's warm body, the softness of the cotton just like skin on skin, warm and alluring. Phantoms of Catra's cute moans echo in her mind, the nails Adora digs into her shoulder to ground herself turn into Catra's claws, from which Adora *still* wears the pale pink scratches high on her thighs.

Their last time was… everything. Everything Adora wanted, everything she hoped for, and ultimately, everything she could have

fucked up. She doesn't know how much longer she can ignore the warm heat throbbing between her thighs, pressing them together too familiarly.

Adora stares at the faint blue glow pouring into the trailer from the window above the table. Catra probably isn't thinking of her right now. Is she trapped between someone else's thighs? Is she gasping into someone else's ear, gripping a sheet that doesn't belong to either her or Adora? Is she sighing *their* name, clinging to their shoulders, losing herself to the feeling of their love bitten under her skin?

Adora's insides twist into an agonizing knot. Why are these thoughts bothering her so much now? Her and Catra have never been exclusive. Adora never cared about who Catra had slept with in the months between them finding each other again. Just because Adora chose not to start any physical or romantic relationship with someone else since she met Catra doesnt mean that Adora had expected the same from her. Adora didn't choose to stay single because of Catra. Catra shouldn't, either.

Is this because Adora thinks Double Trouble is not a good person? Does she have a problem with them, specifically, or does she just have a problem with having a face and a name to associate with the idea of Catra having sex with someone else? Is it just too real, too palpable?

Adora felt so safe with what they've had for years, and this uncertainty, this feeling of Catra slipping away from her is too painful to bear. The more she realizes about herself - about what Catra truly means to her - the worse it gets, and she doesn't know how to stop it.

Will her original idea even work? Can she reel Catra back just enough so that she can touch her while Catra is dating Double Trouble again? Does Adora even want that? She thought she could settle for being Catra's friend and just be fine with it, but clearly, she's not. She would be, really, if Catra…

Adora touches her lips with the calloused pads of her fingers.

Adora's feelings for Catra are one thing. These she can control; swallow back down, keep them caged while Catra is around, and let them roam free once she's not, but…

Catra's softened features when Adora drew back after the first kiss *means* something. The way she let her lips part, how her eyes had fallen closed, her arched brows twitching in despair; the way she kissed Adora back, so slow and hot, savoring every drop of her like she could never get enough. Catra pulled her close and held her tight - Catra wrapped her legs around Adora and sighed so relieved at Adora's hand caressing her, almost like a sob.

Adora squeezes her eyes shut and bites down on her lower lip. The memories flood her just like the wet warmth between her legs. She flexes the muscles in her thighs, fidgeting uncomfortably on the top bunk.

Whether Catra is just playing with her or not… It works. Fuck, it works so well...

Adora breathes out as slowly as she can, and until her lungs and stomach strain. She keeps her eyes closed and her voice down as she tries to keep the mattress from squeaking from her movements. Her right hand slips down on her navel, under her shorts, fingertips burrowing under her briefs…

The bed under her is creaking, moving the top bunk too, Glimmer's shushing voice melting into a giggle. Adora gasps, her hand freezes right above the neatly trimmed hairline, her eyes springing open. She keeps the air in her lungs, afraid to even breathe out as she hears another sound that she can't confuse with anything else - a tiny pop, then another, followed by more giggles and murmured goodnights, and Adora's jaw drops open.

Now she understands everything.

The next morning, when Glimmer and Bow climb out of bed around noon, they act like nothing happened, and Adora is more than fine with that. They wash up quickly and change into fresh clothes, accept Adora's offer for coffee, and then they leave late in the afternoon.

Once alone, Adora goes on a jog to freshen up, and finally gets to work with the new fiery passion she had found in herself yesterday. After a quick cold shower she nestles into her bed with her laptop in front of her, her headphones on her ears, a big box of vegan ice cream by her side (just in case Catra wants some, too), and a fat spiral notebook in her hand.

"Okay," she whispers to herself, confidence in her tone and a focused crease between her eyebrows. She breathes in slowly, and exhales the same. "Let's do this."

Adora slams play; and so, she descends into five hours of constant concentration in a blanket burrito and twelve pages of hurriedly taken notes. She doesn't notice how fast the time flies, or how her hand had started to cramp somewhere around the 0:50 time stamp.

So far what she has gathered from all this research is this: keeping secrets about your feelings always fucks everything up, and of course, she would need a grand gesture to try and fix her own mess; she would need to be brave, face her truth and find her words. Adora would rather avoid the fucking up part - if that's even possible at this point - and it’s not helping that she only knows about her role in all of it for certain. Patterns of Catra's behavior are there on the screen, but some of her reactions fit nowhere in those narratives. Where does she go from here?

Adora winces at keys jingling in the trailer door. She slams the notebook closed and shoves it under her pillow right when Catra steps inside, bringing a whisper of a chilly breeze with her.

"Hi!" Adora greets her , almost screaming. "W elcome back."

Catra stares at her with eyes growing wide.

"Hey ," she says carefully and locks the door . "Y ou okay?"

"Y eah, sure." Adora blows a raspberry. "T otally cool. Just, uh. Chilling."

Catra smirks, finally, throwing her keys at a little table by the door.

"Aha," she purrs, squinting adorably as she steps in front of Adora and hauls her backpack up to the top bunk. Her leather jacket follows; she tilts her head then, curious eyes settling on the back of Adora's laptop. She opens her mouth, curling into an all-knowing grin.

"How was your date?" Adora blurts out before Catra could even start to speak. It came out of panic, and sounded just a touch sharp; so Adora clears her throat to soften her voice, averting her gaze to the crumbled blanket she pulls higher on her shoulder. Why is she doing this to herself? "It must've been going well if you stayed the night."

Catra's smile falls. After a couple of long, long seconds of silence, she asks with a breathy laugh:

"My what?"

"Y our"... Adora blinks up at her now, meeting Catra's confused eyes. "Y our date with Double Trouble?"

Catra crinkles her nose, her voice dropping low.

"What are you talking about?" She asks. Her features turn even more distorted as a thought crosses her mind, making her roll her eyes and cross her arms in front of her chest. "They told you that, didn't they? Adora, I *told* you to stay away from them."

"I know!" Adora says quickly. "And I do, they didn't say anything. Well, not now. And not this. It was before the whole trailer thing, anyway. It's just—" Adora clips her words, feeling her cheeks burn. It hurts to swallow as she gathers her courage; *keeping secrets never ends well for the protagonist.* She just learned that. Twice, if she counts last night's argument with Glimmer. "I know you didn't want me getting involved, and that's more than fair. But we're friends now, right? You can tell me anything, and I want you to be happy."

Catra's cheeks turn a little rosy.

"Okay, that's really sweet of you, but—"

"Wait. Hear me out," Adora asks gently. Catra sucks her lips in, and the blush on her face spills further. "It's true that they've told me that you two are exes and that you want them back, but I'm not blind, either. Don't just blame it on them, I mean." Adora takes a deep breath, her voice quivering at her last confession. "I saw you kissing them in the meeting room, too. I-I didn't mean to, I swear, I was just close by and I left immediately. Haven't seen anything else."

Catra's shoulders drop, her eyes fall shut with a sigh. She spins on her heel and plops down on the edge of Adora's bed, gripping the sheet. She stays quiet for a while, gnawing the inside of her cheek while Adora is waiting patiently, lips and throat dry.

Catra looks tiny, and conflicted.

"Okay, look" Catra starts, a little raspy, "you've got it all wrong."

"Uh. What do you mean?"

Catra combs through her curls with her fingers, smoothing her hair behind her ear. She rests her chin on her shoulder now so Adora can see her face better, but she avoids meeting her eyes.

"I don't want to get back together with Dee. I never wanted to." Catra scoffs softly and raises her head again. "Trust me, I'd rather eat my

own limbs than date that asshole again. That kiss was just practice for the scene where I poison them. They insisted, but... it didn't make the cut, obviously. And I only agreed to meet them because I had something to talk to them about, too."

Adora's chest hollows. She feels giddy like she stood up too quickly, her vision tipping the trailer to the side. Adora sinks her nails into the mattress to ground herself, stuttering, broken noises coming from her throat instead of sentences.

"But they— but I— but then— wait. Wait, wait." Adora unwraps herself from the blanket, puts her laptop aside and slides closer to Catra, dropping her feet on the ground next to hers. Catra doesn't draw away when the back of Adora's hand presses to her thigh. Adora leaves it there. "So why did you ask me to stay away from them? I thought you didn't want me ruining your chances."

Catra chokes on a noise.

"Jesus fuck," she breathes to herself, and pinches the skin between her eyes, massaging in little circles. "No, I just… *ugh*."

"Hey," Adora says gently. She slips her hand on Catra's shoulder, stroking encouragingly. Catra's eyes grow wide, gaze flickering between Adora's hand and her face. "I didn't mean to put you in a corner or force answers out of you. It's still none of my business, I know."

Catra titters. It sounds hollow.

"You're such an idiot. It's… it's not that," she says, her voice breaking. Her mouth twists into a painful little grimace and she cups Adora's hand on her shoulder, gorgeous eyes drilling into Adora's. "I told you to stay away because Dee is not a good person, okay?"

"Ah," Adora breathes out, still a little confused. Catra's words start to gain their real meaning in her mind, melting into something much

more flattering. Adora grins, cocking a brow at Catra. "So all this time, you were just trying to protect me?"

"Shut up," Catra grunts without edge, letting go of Adora's hand to punch her forearm playfully. Her features darken again, a shivering gleam highlights the difference of her irises. "Look, Dee is… their whole life is about figuring people out and ruining them. They're good at their job because that's what they do all the time - *directing* people's lives like it's just a movie, messing with their heads." Catra's tone turns sour. She sniffs and adds, much lighter: "I didn't want them to try anything with you because you're already a pain in my ass as you are. It's not because I like you."

"Right." Adora mimics Catra's playful tone, although she only feels heavier now.

There's a story behind Catra's words about her own experience with Double Trouble, and it's something Adora can't just let go of - but she has to. For now. Catra seems upset enough to not continue with this topic, and Adora won't pressure her. She sees how much strength it takes for Catra to open up and talk, still, and Adora is grateful for anything she is willing to give her.

Catra was protecting her even before they became friends, and Adora would do anything to protect her in return.

"And if you really wanna know" Catra says with a faint smile, "I've been at Scorpia's. She wanted me to meet Perfuma officially and spend some time with them. It was really nice." Catra is playing with the sheet now, grinding it between her fingers. "They … kind of invited me to that long weekend you're planning. Meaning I was there when you texted them, and, well. It was just by courtesy, and I "—

"Wait, really?" Adora's voice is high now, full of bubbling excitement. "Thank *God*, I'm so tired of being the ninth wheel." When Catra doesn't react in any way except for a cute and embarrassed grimace, Adora asks: "Will you come?"

"I guess I could," Catra shrugs, sharing a quick glance with Adora. She bites down on her lip, long lashes fluttering. She pulls her shoulder up; Adora's hair covers her even more now, flowing down like a golden waterfall. "Do you want me to come?"

"Are you kidding? Of course I do," Adora bumps their shoulders together. Her long ponytail falls on Catra's bare skin, making her shiver. " *I* wanted to invite you. I just didn't want to do it yesterday, because...u-um. Well..."

"It's okay," Catra says, looking away. "I told them that we're friends now, so it won't be weird."

Adora's heart skips a beat. Catra did that?

Before now, every little smile, every burning touch was just for the two of them to see. The thought that Catra might be alright with showing Adora affection in front of people makes Adora feel warmth flowing in her veins.

She barely finds her voice to ask:

"You don't mind that people know? Or see us together?"

"No?" Catra says, knitting her brows together. "Do you?"

"Of course not," Adora says, her lips curling into a wide grin. "Shit, I've been waiting for you to come around for so long."

Catra's eyes grow wide, her cheeks even redder than before. She looks so pretty now with her hair still messy from failed attempts to tame her bed-head, her tank top hugging the curves of her perfect form. She had washed off her makeup; her skin was glowing on its own, and - if Adora can let herself believe it - from Adora's words.

Don't stare, Adora tells herself, but she can't look away. She watches Catra's throat bob, gaze fixated on the hollow of her neck

now; beautiful lines darkening the shadows of all the perfect spots Adora knows can make Catra lose herself.

"What?" Catra asks, breathless.

"Huh?"

Catra's voice is silky soft and teasing.

"What are you staring at, dumbass?"

"I just zoned out."

"Right." Catra's eyes flare up dangerously, the flash of her sharp canines promise nothing good. "I think I know how to shake that off."

Before Adora could react in any way, Catra twists around and throws herself back on the bed, right towards the laptop laying there unprotected.

Adora yelps in shock, trying to snatch her laptop away from Catra. She is too slow; her arms cross in the air where the laptop was just a second ago as she falls down onto the bed helplessly, her face pushed into the mattress.

Catra moves smoothly again and dares to sit on Adora's back to keep her down, not giving a shit about Adora's muffled, laughing shrills of protest.

"Let's see," Catra drawls, raising her voice above Adora's. "What do we have here? I've been wondering what you were so occupied with when I came back..."

Adora squirms under Catra's weight, turning her head so she can breathe and glare up at Catra's pretty face.

"Catra, *don't*— "

Catra pouts.

"Aww, wait… this isn't porn, this is *much* worse. The blanket burrito, the ice cream, and now..."

This is when Adora's blood runs cold; realization is a lump in her throat she gulps against. She squirms some more, but Catra frees a palm, using it to keep Adora's head down, and to Adora's absolute *dread*, she goes on:

"*Ghosts of Girlfriends Past, What If, No Strings Attached...*"

Catra clicks her tongue.

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, praying to herself.

"Who hurt you?" Catra asks then, only half-joking. She slips off of Adora, back to the mattress but stays close enough that Adora still feels her warmth.

"No one. No one!" Adora says quickly and sits up, too, smoothing her ponytail behind her shoulder. Her voice only broke once. Success. "I just—I'm doing research, okay?"

"*Really*." Catra cocks a brow at the scene again. It makes Adora's whole face burn with embarrassment.

"Yeah, *really*," she snaps back. "I'm trying to get a role of the, the, uh, supporting best friend character in a rom-com after this gig, and it's just what I've always done before auditions. You can't know that because I've never told you."

"And the ice cream is just part of the method acting," Catra adds, getting a spoonful of it. She raises her brows at Adora with the spoon in her mouth, lips pressed into a cute pout.

Adora's posture eases up, her smile bright as she leans in.

"Exactly," she says, gently pulling the spoon out of Catra's mouth.

Something wild shoots across Catra's features; hungry, predatory, alluring. It disappears in a blink, burning into Adora's memory and dripping down between her legs, hot and heavy like melting steel.

Catra asks, her voice just a low purr:

"Can I join you?"

Adora took a much needed break to stretch while Catra slipped into comfortable clothes, munching on a sandwich Scorpia had packed her as a snack. Conversation is flowing between bites, successfully calming Adora's heart and core down - until Catra asks this question:

"Could you tame Sparkles after I left?"

Adora freezes with her arms in the air .

"It's okay." Catra sticks the tip of her tongue between her teeth. "I know I riled her up."

"Did you want to?"Adora asks carefully , lowering her arms.

"Maybe."

"Oh my god, Catra."

"What, I love how angry she gets. It's almost cute. *And* fucking hilarious."

Pain stabs through Adora's chest. Was that?..

"She's dating Bow," Adora blurts out, immediately regretting it. She slaps a hand over her mouth, eyes clamped. "Shit," she mumbles, muffled and strained. Her hand slides up her forehead, smoothing some loose strands of hair down. "I was not supposed to tell you that - even *I* shouldn't know . Please forget I said anything I just—"

“Wait, it’s not official?” Catra huffs, throwing the last bite of the sandwich into her mouth. She slithers to the bed then, climbing on top and plopping down with the cutest, tiniest grunt. “Seriously? Those two were obviously into each other since the day I met them. It's gross."

Adora drops her hand, quieting her voice into a conspiratorial whisper.

"I know, it’s crazy. They're like... the last two people who noticed out of everyone. It's like, how oblivious can you be?" Adora joins Catra on the bed, leaning her back against the wall and breathes out in a tired sigh. "I really don't know why they want to keep it a secret now. Well, they're not trying that hard to hide it considering they made out in my bed when they thought I was asleep.”

Catra laughs heartily, mumbling *holy shit* under her breath.

"You took the top bunk, then?" Catra catches Adora's eyes shining worriedly, and tilts her head with a soft smile. "I don't mind. It's not like you haven't been there before."

Adora's whole face is burning. Catra snuggles closer to her, getting under the soft blanket Adora had made herself a burrito with. Once comfortable, she throws the rest of the blanket over Adora’s lap, smoothing the wrinkles out nicely. She is definitely stroking Adora's thighs in the process, avoiding the eye contact Adora is very much seeking right now.

Instead, Catra leans back until their shoulders touch, and rests her head on Adora's like it was the most natural thing in the whole world.

"What are we watching?"

Thousands of questions raid Adora's mind all at once, each and every one of them like rumbling thunder and flickering lightning. What is Catra planning? Is she being intentional with these burning little touches? Does she also feel like her heart is beating fast

enough to lose its chains? Is she relieved that they finally see eye to eye about Double Trouble? Does she want this, right here, this whole cuddling under the blanket thing, or does she just want Adora to feel at ease? What is she *really* making out of Adora's sorry excuse of a movie choice?

Adora tastes metal on her tongue. She didn't realize how hard she was chewing on her bottom lip, how long she was being suspiciously silent, only wincing back to reality when the warm weight of Catra's head was gone.

"Hey ." Catra softens her voice, overruling the cacophony in Adora's skull. "Don't worry , I won't rat them out."

Or That. Right .

Catra's hand finds Adora's under the blanket, squeezing gently. Adora turns towards her, just barely, and Catra is so, so close she can feel her breath on her parted lips.

Catra whispers:

"I know a thing or two about secret affairs."

"You do?" Adora deadpans, getting more confused by the way Catra's nose crinkles with a smirk, lifting her brows suggestively. Realization is an awkward blush creeping right back under Adora's skin. "You do."

"Mm-hm."

Catra titters again, leaning her head back to the crook of Adora's neck.

"So, what are we watching?"

Adora pulls the laptop closer in front of them, bending the screen slightly. A movie is already open; Adora was just hitting play on the

next one in line when Catra came home, so they're only four minutes in. Adora's eyes latch on to the file name at the top of the screen.

Fuck.

"We can watch anything else, it doesn't have to be—"

"Nah," Catra cuts in, pulling her knees up to a more comfortable position. She tilts them towards Adora, Catra's thigh pressing into hers. "I'm fine with whatever you were planning to watch."

"Okay ." Adora swallows and slams Space.

Friends with Benefits it is.

Whatever the hell will that entail.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey I'm back
> Sorry for the lack of everything in this chapter, and of course for the wait. Thank you so much for your support of this story, it means the world to me. I hope you enjoyed reading this one and you will like the rest, too.
>
> Please consider saying hello to me on Twitter (I keep it 18+ so please have your age in your bio or I will block you). You can send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or (even) anonymously on CuriousCat. I hang around there a lot so it's easier to reach me there than down here.
> I love you all, stay safe, and see you next time!

Rule #9

Chapter Summary

9. Keep our personal lives separate.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra sighs, her back arching off the bed. Adora's curious lips are all over her face, leaving a burning path of tiny, fluttering kisses from her temple to her jawline, to the corner of her mouth.

Catra tilts her head so Adora's lips fall onto hers, earning a muffled, almost humming noise of pleasure. She presses on softly, parting her lips with just the tip of her tongue between them, waiting for Adora to open up and take.

Adora kisses her back, languid but deep; she lays her weight on top of Catra, pinning her to the mattress, covering her in warmth and the fresh, earthy scent of her body. Below their waists they wear nothing but their underwear, and above it Adora is dressed down to a tight sports bra; it gives her cleavage that is making Catra lose her fucking mind. Savouring her, Adora's hands are burrowing under Catra's shirt, her skin so soft on Catra's as she caresses along her sides, tapping on her ribs, cupping the perky curve of her chest.

Catra's breath hitches again, breaking their kiss.

Adora cocks her head, gorgeous irises drilling into Catra's. The blues of her eyes are bright like the burn of a flame closest to the wick. They make Catra lightheaded.

"Are you sure?" Adora whispers carefully, her lips barely moving against Catra's.

"Y es. *Yes*."

Adora kisses her again, and just a hint of her teeth is enough to send little shivers of anticipation down Catra's spine. Her hand keeps fondling Catra's breast, thumb circling over her nipple. Catra whimpers into her mouth and hooks an ankle over the back of Adora's knee, seeking friction.

Adora rocks her hips against Catra's wave, her sweet grunts dripping down Catra's throat like honey. She grabs Catra's calf to spread her legs wider before grinding down again, rolling in more forcefully.

Catra lolls her head back, lips still parted from their kiss. Adora latches to the sensitive skin of her neck immediately; they are both breathing heavily now, heaving chests crushing together as they claw and pull at each other, frantic, desperate, needy-

Catra's phone rings. She springs up to answer the call, feet dangling off the bed, not reaching the floor. Immediately, Adora crawls right behind her, her body pressing tightly to Catra's, and Adora brushes her curls behind her shoulder with the back of her hand. Adora's locks fall forward, tickling Catra's collarbones as she hooks her chin over Catra's bare shoulder and circles her arms around her waist.

"Hello?" Catra says, her voice jumping high.

"Hi, friend," Perfuma coos on the other side of the line. "Do you have a minute?"

"Uh"…

"It's… pretty urgent." Catra can hear the embarrassment in her voice, along with something she cannot name. "But it wont take long!"

Catra sighs, frustrated. She bumps her temple into Adora's.

"T wo minutes," she warns Perfuma.

"Great! So, do you remember what we've been talking about when you were staying with us?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, sucking her lips in as Adora breathes a faint kiss to her shoulder. The touch is featherlight, pampering. Catra's lashes flutter, fighting the urge to let her eyes fall closed. "Wait, which one?"

The voice changes in her ear.

"Your obvious infatuation towards Adora, coupled with an insuppressible desire that *will* make you lose control around her?"

Catra's mind goes blank, her body rigid like her blood was sucked out of her veins. Her heart is hammering in her chest, sending rapid pulsewaves up her throat as dozens of questions raid her mind all at once. She sneaks a peek at Adora.

Did she hear it through the speakers? What does she think of her now? Will she stop? Will she leave Catra alone again? Will she change her mind when they were so close to feeling each other again?

Adora's head is still bowed, lips moving slowly across Catra's skin. She peppers her shoulder with kisses, each one of them hotter and more urgent than the one before as she reaches higher on the curve that leads to Catra's jaw. Her hair covers Catra's chest now, silky soft and thin, shimmering gold.

"I-"

Adora exhales against Catra's pulse point, leaving an open-mouthed kiss there. Catra's whole body trembles, her free hand flying up to grab a fistful of Adora's hair at the back of her skull to keep her in place. Adora hums, joyful and smug, and sinks her teeth into Catra.

Catra jerks, leaning back into Adora. Her word is just a wet gasp:

"I-"

Those cold teeth are still pinching the skin of Catra's neck, pulling gently. When Adora releases her, it is just to latch onto another spot right under her jawline, Adora's tongue flicking out.

Catra swallows a moan, jaw clenching.

"Catra?"

Then, another voice:

"Wildcat, are you listening to Per?"

Catra opens her mouth to speak, but Adora is merciless. She reaches even higher, nuzzling the spot behind Catra's ear, where she knows she can make her come undone.

"I-Ill call you back," Catra babbles quickly, tapping on the phone blindly before letting it fall out of her hand.

She doesnt hear a thump as it drops down, but she doesnt give a fuck about it anyway, because Adora's arm is around her chest to pull her back on top of her. Calloused hands cup Catra's face and pull her in for a desperate, passionate kiss that drinks the air out of her lungs. Adora props a knee between Catra's thighs, urging her to move, and Catra does, gripping the pillow by Adora's ears as her hips set an erratic pace; shallow thrusts instead of elegant waves, knees slipping on the sheets. There's nothing between their dripping heat anymore, Catra's lips slipping over Adora's so fucking perfectly, and Adora's broken noises are so, so overwhelming.

"*Fuck*," Adora whines between kisses, dropping a hand from her cheek to grab Catra's ass, guiding her to ride her harder.

Catra grunts with Adora's tongue curling to her upper lip. Catra is close, she can feel it in every shuddering spark of pleasure that

rushes through her nerves as Adora captures her lips again, and she is so warm, and it is so sweet, and Catra feels so *safe*-

She chokes on a moan as her arms give up under her. She collapses on Adora's chest, hips still rocking, chasing pleasure; like this, she can hear Adora's rapid heart that beats for her, only her, and when Adora's arms wrap around her waist, and she pets her hair like she did on the roof, urging her to speak, Catra can't fucking take it anymore. "I lo-"

Catra jolts awake.

A melody grows louder, ringing in her ears. The light pouring into the trailer is dusty grey. It warms her cheeks like it should be a flaming orange. She blinks sullenly, trying to focus; she is alone in bed, but it's not hers - and the phone that rings an annoyingly cheerful alarm is not hers, either. Panic rises in her chest, like cold water pouring down her spine; she grabs the blanket to push herself up, shaking curls out of her face.

Someone grunts, and the alarm stops.

The light shifts as a figure climbs down from the top bunk, hopping to their feet. Catra breathes out curtly, but her heart won't stop drumming, and she has to squeeze her thighs together against the wet heat pooling under her.

The figure turns towards her, wearing a grey tank top, briefs and a smile brighter than the morning sun.

"Sorry," Adora whispers, like speaking in a normal voice would break the magic of dawn. "I didnt mean to wake you."

Catra furrows her brows, growling something unintelligible. She massages her whole face with both palms, trying to shake herself out of that fucking dream. When she spreads her fingers to peek out, feeling the heat of her own blush on her skin, she finds Adora staring at her with a tiny frown between her tilted brows.

“Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” Catra snaps, but she didn’t mean to. She swallows drily, and drops her hands into her lap. Her voice melts into something softer, almost pouty. “I just had a stupid nightmare.”

Adora blows the air out in a puff.

“I’m so sorry.”

“Yep, it was your fault,” Catra teases. It comes out a little dry, her tone flat. She quickly tries to recover her voice. “It’s fine. And I had to wake up anyway, so thanks for that.” Her eyes wander higher, releasing Adora. Memories of last night slither back into her mind; she agreed to join Adora for a movie, but… she doesn't remember anything about it. Had she fallen asleep immediately? “Did you sleep in my bed while I crashed yours?”

Adora slips a palm on her neck, an embarrassed grin plastered on her face.

“Yeah, I- I didn’t wanna disturb you. You seemed like you really needed that sleep, so I skipped the movie too, and let you have the whole bed. I switched the blankets, though. I know yours is thicker cause you hate the cold, so...”

“You could’ve stayed.”

Silence falls over the trailer, only disturbed by the annoying, constant dripping of the shitty tap coming from the kitchen sink. Catra doesn’t even realize what she has just said until her eyes fall on Adora’s face again, confused by the lack of an answer - and finds her starry-eyed, but utterly dumbfounded with a deep red blush creeping down her neck.

Shit. Catra made her uncomfortable, didn’t she?

That was the stupidest fucking thing she’s ever said. Fuck.

"I mean," she says quickly, her morning voice husky with sleep, "I just mean, I've slept in the same bed with friends before, it's not… It's not weird."

"Yeah," Adora chirps, clearing her throat. "Yeah, no, it's not weird. I've done that, like, *countless* times. Totally normal. It happens. It's a thing. A thing that friends do." She snaps her head away, nodding swiftly like she was trying to convince herself that she has dealt with the situation well. She points towards the bathroom then, determined. "I'mgonnatakeashower."

Catra parts her lips to say something, only to realize that she has nothing she could say. Adora practically *falls* into the bathroom, fighting with the folding door and cursing under her breath. She manages to get it closed, and everything stills for a moment.

Catra plops down onto her back with a curt sigh, arms crossed on her forehead.

The folding door creaks open. Catra winces, but stays laying down in the soft seas of Adora's pillows and scent, moving her head towards the noise. Adora stumbles out with her ponytail half undone, muttering sharply:

"My clothes. Forgot my clothes. Again."

Catra doesn't say anything to that.

"Action!"

Catra leaps towards Adora with a fist raised high. Adora bends her spine to avoid her right hook; in a second, she is already crouching, palms on the floor, a leg stretched straight to sweep Catra off her feet.

The choreography they've been practicing ever since they've started this job feels like it's a part of them now. Catra barely has to think about her next move when nothing is more natural than playing off of Adora's - she moves, Adora reacts. Adora glances at her, and Catra understands.

She barely notices when Adora grabs her by the waist. It feels like instead of taking control of the fight, she only suggests that Catra lets herself be picked up. Catra eases her muscles for her, her feet leaving solid ground as she is thrown over Adora's broad shoulder and spun around.

Adora drops her onto the mattress. Someone yells cut, and Adora's expression breaks into a smile immediately as she reaches out a hand to pull Catra up.

Catra takes her hand.

"Terrific," Dee's sharp, unimpressed voice cuts through the air. Catra winces, snapping her hand back like she had touched fire. "Go again."

"What?" Catra crosses her arms in front of her chest. "Why? It was flawless."

Dee puckers their lips. They don't even look at Catra; their eyes are on their nails as they scrunch their nose and say:

"It was as *thrilling* as nap time at a kindergarten. *Go. Again*."

Catra growls, but walks back to her spot. She catches Adora's kind eyes before the next take - the corners of Adora's mouth twitch into a quick, faint smile and she shrugs, barely noticeable. Catra sucks her lips in to not reciprocate so openly, but she can see that her smile reaches her eyes from the way Adora is beaming at her.

They go over the routine perfectly every time - and every single time, Dee is bored out of their mind, sending them back to where they

started. It seems like nothing could satisfy them now. Whatever Catra and Adora are doing, it only fuels their frustration with something Catra can't figure out.

Dee rises from their chair elegantly, hips swaying. They clap with only their palms touching.

"Let's take five, shall we?"

Catra knows what that means. She sits up on the mattress with her knees spread, elbows resting on them, glaring at Dee and waiting for their signal. Dee twirls around and leaves the set, but they don't look at Catra at all.

Catra's stomach twists painfully. She is breathing a little heavily, probably from the seven takes in a row.

What the fuck was that? Are they that mad at her? Catra didn't fucking do anything wrong - and if they think she did, why can't they just say it to her face? Are they seriously going to resort to the silent *treatment*? Dee has never done that to her before, and they've done lots of shit. There's no reason for them to try something new - especially now of all times. During their short-lived friendship and even shorter relationship, Dee has collected enough knives to hurt Catra with until the end of time. They know this. They know this very fucking well, so *why*-

Catra's fingers twitch, but she doesn't ball them into fists. She eases her breathing with a deep sigh, trying to shake off the nerves; she was prepared for another round of fighting with Dee, and that not happening has left her a little antsy. It's nothing - just old habits dying hard.

Catra staggers to her feet, without any help this time. Her knees are trembling emptily.

She spends the next four minutes in the bathroom, hiding from everyone - her reflection included.

Catra is fumbling with her trailer keys. Sport bags and backpacks are hanging from every inch of her arms and shoulders. She had just been home to pack for the long weekend with the help of Scorpia - and had done laundry as well - so she is coming back with even more stuff than the first time she settled in.

She pushes the door open just in time to catch Adora jump in shock, nearly dropping a big cardboard box. The box is opened only on one side, and Adora hurries to slap the flap down, crumpling it under another one.

"Hey ," Catra says.

"Uh, hi," Adora squeaks, still fighting with the box. A deep blush paints her whole face crimson, and she settles on just letting go of the box - which hits the ground with some strange clattering - and kicks it under her bed. She clicks her tongue like nothing has happened, an excessive grin pulling on the corners of her mouth. "Got everything you need?"

Catra cocks a brow, spreading her arms with the five hundred bags.

"What do you think?"

"I think that you're ready to leave the production and live in the mountains alone."

Catra scoffs a laugh. She shakes off all the straps, the bags piling up on the floor. She only now notices that Adora is dressed down to her workout clothes - tight shorts and a sports bra, pretty flushed skin glistening with sweat like beads of dew.

Catra's throat runs dry. She averts her gaze to the floor, crouching next to the bags to sort them out.

"Have you packed already?" She asks, even though she already knows the answer not only from knowing Adora for years now, but also from the huge travel suitcase and an equally overpacked duffle bag that is sitting on top of Adora's bed.

They're going for two nights.

"Yep." Adora moves her weights back to the corner where she keeps them, and comes around the sea of bags that are covering the whole floor. "Do you need help?"

"No, I've got it. You can get dressed."

A beat of silence.

"...What?"

Catra fights the urge to dive head first into the closest gym bag and stay there for all of fucking eternity. Why is she *like* this?

"What what?" She asks nonchalantly, folding her laundry on top of another bag. Her moves are a little erratic, sure, but she's had like three coffees when she usually just drinks only one cup in the morning.

"Whoa, Catra, I didn't know my workout clothes were so..." Adora props herself on an elbow in front of Catra, half-laying on her bags - a ridiculous pose, really. "*Distracting*."

Catra blows a raspberry.

"Shut up."

"Or what?"

Catra glances up, eyes drilling straight into Adora's. She can see Adora swallow big, the cocky grin melting from her features. This is *dangerous* - maybe not for Adora, but it sure as hell is for Catra. Last time one of them was shirtless, they were making out on the fucking

counter, which is something that they havent even acknowledged yet.

Did Adora seriously think that she was going on a date with Dee right after that? How did that even add up in her brain? Is that what she thinks of Catra? Well… Catra supposes that depends on what Adora has made up about her and Dee's relationship in her mind; whether they were just dating, or fucking, or seeing other people, too. Still, her reaction to Catra leaving for the night can only mean one thing: that Adora thinks Catra is just playing with her .

Catra blinks. Her eyes are burning. Lungs, too.

As much as that fucking hurts to think about, to be seen that way, it's better than the heartbreak the truth would bring. So… shell go with it.

"Sorry ," Adora mumbles, calling Catra back to the present. She shuffles into a more comfortable position, drawing back. She sinks to her knees on the floor, arms hanging by her sides. "T oo much."

God, it's not *enough*.

"Y eah."

Catra's chest aches at how Adora's expression changes at that. The light in her eyes is shimmering now, like sundrops in the water, her lips pressing into a straight line, and a frown springing between furrowed brows.

"It' s okay," Catra croaks, reaching out for Adora's hand soothingly. She stops herself right before they can touch, fingers curling towards her palm. "I said stupid shit, too."

Adora is chewing on her lower lip and doesnt look at Catra. Her nails are scratching the floor, anxious and absentminded.

“Hey .” Catra touches her now, wrapping her fingers around Adora’s wrist. The scratching stops, and Adora’s eyes find hers. She still looks like Catra had slapped her. “It’ s just..this is still new . Right?”

Adora doesnt reply, but she takes a deep breath. Before Catra can continue, Adora draws her hand back and staggers to her feet without looking at her.

“Adora?”

“Right,” Adora says. Her voice is chipper as ever, but her smile is empty - the same smile Catra has seen her wearing right after their kiss. “Ill just... go hit the gym instead, so I wont be in the way .”

Catra’s throat tightens. She wants to say something, anything. She wants to reach out and stop Adora, she wants to make her feel better, she wants to feel the warmth of her hand again. She wants to ask her to stay, but she cant.

The words dont come. Her hand doesnt move. She wants to break out, but she doesnt know how .

She will chase Adora away, just like everyone else.

“Okay .”

“Are you sure you dont wanna tag along?” Adora asks. “There’ s plenty of space.”

Catra glances behind her; Adora’s car is parked at the other side of the parking lot, Glimmer and Bow packing their stuff into the truck. She catches Glimmer’s eyes as she puts a holographic backpack between two packs of water. It's not her usual death glare, but not welcoming either. Confused, mostly; confused, and a touch embarrassed.

That might even be a good sign.

"Yeah, I'm sure," Catra says, looking back at Adora with a little shrug. "I promised I'd go with Scorpia. If that Jeep can even go that far without breaking down."

Adora adjusts an invisible baseball cap and flashes a bright grin.

"Well if it does and you need a mechanic, you know my number."

Catra laughs, crossing her arms in front of her chest.

"You're ridiculous."

"And a pretty good mechanic."

"Wow, is there anything you're not good at?"

"Adora!" Glimmer yells, gesturing towards Adora, then the truck. Adora snaps her head back and holds her hand up in a wave.

"Just a second." She clears her throat, cocking a brow at Catra. "I'd better go. I mean it, though. Call me if you need anything."

"Well be fine, Adora," Catra says, fighting the urge to roll her eyes. "But...thanks."

Adora's eyes shrink into half-moons as she grins, cheeks flushed pretty pink. She leans forward and lifts both her arms before they freeze midair, a lightning bolt of panic shooting across her features. Catra mirrors her moves unknowingly, which - for some reason - makes Adora draw back even more.

Catra drops her arms.

Adora raises hers again.

"Um."

"Adora!" Glimmer yells again.

"I'm coming!" Adora growls back through gritted teeth. She exhales quickly, trying to collect herself so she can look into Catra's eyes again. "See you in a couple hours?"

"Yep."

Adora nods, turning on her heel. She leaps to her truck with four huge steps, replying to Glimmer's rapid opinions with curt words, and sneaks one last peek at Catra over her shoulder before they all get in the car.

Bow catches Catra staring and waves at her. Catra waves back, and watches the truck come around the parking lot, rumbling towards the gate. Another car follows right after; Netossa's champagne beige Mustang.

A broad shadow crawls on the pavement in front of Catra, and a joyful voice roars:

"Your chariot awaits, Wildcat!"

Catra sighs, tugging on the strap of her backpack to pull it higher on her shoulder. She turns around, squinting up at Scorpia in the bright sunlight. "Where's your girl?"

"Already in the car. She said we should leave you and Adora alone for a moment?"

"Did she," Catra mutters, tipping her head to hide the color of her cheeks.

"I wonder why," Scorpia thinks out loud as they start walking together. "I mean, I know you two are friends now, but that doesnt mean you *need* to be left alo"…

Catra doesnt stop, but Scorpia does - and she grows suspiciously quiet. Even that wont make Catra slow down; she keeps marching

towards the Jeep with her head raised high and jaw clenched at the thought of that she might need to come up with some bullshit lie very quickly.

"Wait a minute," Scorpia mumbles, drawing out each syllable. Catra takes a deep breath through her nose until her lungs start to burn and her chest trembles, waiting for Scorpia to continue and say the words Catra never, ever wants to hear - "Did you two get into a fight already?"

Holy shit.

"Yes," Catra replies before Scorpia even finishes the sentence. "We did. You figured it all out."

"Wildcat!"

"What? It's all good now. It was just a stupid misunderstanding."

Scorpia clicks her tongue, but catches up to Catra again.

Catra rakes her headphones out of her pocket before she even gets in the car, not giving Scorpia or Perfuma any chance to interrogate her further.

Catra had dozed off during the car ride. By the time she stirs and opens her eyes, the engine is stopping with a cough and a wobble. She pushes herself away from the passenger door and blinks in the pastel lights to see where they have arrived.

While she was asleep, the whole sky had turned into pinks and violets, fluffy clouds lacing the colors together. The sun has barely tipped behind the horizon, beams dripping into the shimmers of the ocean. Catra pulls her earphones out and opens the door to the salty breeze, breathing in the balminess of the evening air.

"This place is *magical*," Perfuma sighs with her palms over her chest, delighted and amazed.

Catra can't argue with that. They are right by the seashore, surrounded by softly nodding palm trees and never ending fields of sand as white as shells, a tall wooden gate and pretty little ebony bungalows, and two fields far in the back.

Catra cocks a brow.

"What's this, a soccer camp?"

"You know, I think it is," Scorpia replies, popping the trunk open. "Adora said something about it when she sent the address." She looks up, eyes focused on nothing. "Or was it football? Lawn hockey? Sprint?"

Catra curls her upper lip.

"Sprint camps don't exist."

"I bet they do."

"There's no fucking way they do."

"Why not?"

"What do you think they're doing at a *sprint camp*? Don't say sprinting."

"Look at those gorgeous waves!" Perfuma chirps, not paying attention to anything Catra and Scorpia are talking about. She sits back onto her seat to untie her gladiator sandals and take them off even before they reach grass or sand. As her bare soles touch the ground, pure bliss washes over her features like sunlight.

Once all of them get their bags out of the truck, they follow the pebbled pathways. The paths are all narrow and curly, slithering all around the camp. Catra leads Scorpia and Perfuma towards one of

the broadest offshoots that ends at what seems to be the biggest building.

As Catra suspected, Adora's head pops up from behind the creaking wooden door.

Her smile is *dazzling*.

"You made it! Come on in, we've been waiting for you."

Catra ignores how her heart flutters in her chest, and steps up the stairs.

The campfire is cracking quietly when Catra arrives, but the conversation is loud and lively, and music is blasting from Bluetooth speakers.

Everyone seems to have calmed down after the huge fight in the dining bungalow where every couple tried to outbid the others for the biggest room. Catra stayed out the whole thing. It wasn't like she was trying to avoid conflict - she did quip some snarky comments to keep the fire going - but she didn't really care about the outcome. She doesn't give a fuck about how big her bungalow is or where it is located. The only thing she was going to fight for seemed to be obvious to everyone: since the whole group is made of couples except for Adora and Catra, everyone thought it was the best to put them together and keep them away from the lovebirds.

Catra is fine with that. She thinks she is fine with that.

She is used to the trailer now, and sharing her space with Adora. This shouldn't be any different. If anything, even though they've got the smallest living quarters - which is also the one furthest from the main paths, a little hidden behind the palm trees - it's probably the best option for the two of them. Catra doesn't need much space,

usually, and they both respect each other enough. Adora is a good roommate. She's fine.

So, *again* - this is going to be fine.

Catra steps over a log, bare soles sinking into the cooling sand. Perfuma was right. For the time being, the best idea is to feel the earth under their feet.

"I told you, I didn't believe that!" Adora snaps, her voice jumping high. She is sitting far from Catra, who has found an empty space between Spinerella and Seahawk.

"What did I miss?" She asks, watching Adora grow even more frustrated while everyone around her is crying from laughing.

"Mermista is telling the macaroni story. Again." Netossa says, handing Catra a paper cup. Catra sniffs it cautiously. "It's just water, kitty."

Catra glares, but takes a careful sip. She didn't smell anything, but it still could have been vodka. She doesn't know Netossa that well, but something tells her she shouldn't trust her blindly. The fact that it really is water - Catra continues chugging some more - is not a clear indicator that she was wrong, but what happens next is. Netossa's jaw drops to the floor, choking on a noise that is stuck in her throat. Spinerella, on the other hand, looks painfully smug as she pokes her wife in the ribs, and swirls a different cup in her other hand so the liquid inside sloshes around.

"*You*," Netossa breathes; she sounds just as impressed as outraged. She douses Spinerella's victorious giggles by capturing her lips in a quick kiss, then another one. And another one.

Catra sighs into her cup. She starts to understand why Adora was so desperate for her to come so she wasn't the only single person here.

Spinerella and Netossa have started making out on Catra's left, and on her right, Seahawk is way too interested in burning marshmallows in the fire, putting the whole stick into the flames. At least five of them. At the same time.

Looks like Catra will never learn what the infamous macaroni story is.

The wind is blowing softly, filling Catra's nose with salty whiffs of the sea. Adora's eyes find hers over the fire; as soon as they collide, Adora's expression melts like marshmallows on roasting sticks. Catra squints at her, and that seems to be enough for Adora to not give a shit about the others making fun of her anymore.

Catra rises to her feet with the empty cup in her hand. The coolers are right behind the logs Adora's circle is sitting on, so she comes around the fire from the seaside. The flames and Adora's eyes warm her up under her clothes, and Catra tries her best not to return the gaze.

She squats in front of a cooler, hiding behind the open lid. She pulls out a beer and stands, letting the lid fall closed on its own. Thankfully, Adora's attention is drawn to something Bow is talking about now, and Catra is spared. All she needs to do is quickly sneak right back to where she came from before those eyes can hold her captive again.

Her grip tightens around the bottle, cool condensation dripping down between her knuckles. She shivers in her leather jacket, pulling it tighter around herself with her free hand.

Catra steps over the closest log, sticking her leg right between Adora and Glimmer. They both look up at her, and make space for her.

Catra holds her cheeks to the fire cracking in front of her, and drinks.

Her chest warms up again.

As the moon crawls higher in the night sky - deep and blue like spilled ink, sprinkled with hundreds of stars - the drinks steadily run lower.

Catra is on her third beer, so she's a little warm and feeling just a touch bold when people start to couple up around her to dance. Of course, it wouldn't be them if what had started off as something nice and tame didn't end up turning into a bloodthirsty competition.

Netossa starts it. She was provoked by Glimmer, of course, who found it hilarious how Netossa had stumbled on a pile of sand during her famous move, which - as Catra learns - was what had made Spinerella go on a second date with her. Despite messing it up now, Catra sees the look on Spinerella's face when she grabs Netossa by her waist and pulls her close; she had no reason to worry about losing that love. If it makes Catra's heart soar, it must be true.

"Nice move," Glimmer comments. Her cheek was squished on Bow's bare shoulder, arms wrapped around him. "I see you're still falling for her hard."

Netossa bares her teeth, cocking a brow at the two of them.

"You wanna talk to me about *falling*, munchkin?" Even in the dim light of shadows cast from the campfire, Glimmer's face blooms with color. Netossa chuckles. "Trust me, in everything you're just trying your baby wings at, I'm already an expert. Dancing included."

Bow tries to maneuver Glimmer by twirling her away, but it doesn't seem to be working. Glimmer cranes her neck so she is facing Netossa at all times, purring a practically devious "prove it."

The whole group yells as one. More couples start to form around Catra, joining in the competition that somehow turned into everyone else's business. Catra can't help but scoff at the scene, a grin tugging at the corner of her lips. She knew that her friends were

idiots, but mixed with Adora's friends, chaos apparently ensues. Saying that Catra is not entertained - moreover, weirdly touched by this - would be a lie.

The rustle of clothing hits Catra's ears. She turns towards the sound, only now realizing that she is the only one left on the bench with a very fidgety Adora, who is chugging her beer like her life depends on it.

"No, babe. No fucking way." Mermista throws her hands up, walking away from the crowd towards the two of them. Seahawk is jogging after her with a broken expression. "Look, I love you, but you suck at this so much." She raises her voice then, looking back at the others. "Okay , listen! Im gonna be the judge, Seahawk's responsible for the music. After every song, one couple is eliminated."

Mermista drops her gaze. It meets Catra' s.

"Sucks to be single now, huh?" She crosses her arms. "Go alone if you want, judge allows it. Or dont. I dont care."

Catra rises to her feet, and shrugs her jacket of f.

"Who said I would be alone?"

Catra throws her jacket onto the empty log. Startled by the clinking noise, Adora looks up at her, lips parted and brows knit together.

Catra holds out a hand.

"Come on," she says and tilts her head to the side. "Y ou cant be the only one not dancing at a getaway that you planned."

Adora laughs; it's more like a soft exhale, but she does take Catra's offered hand, palm slipping into hers.

"Not fair," she says, turning on her heel. She walks backwards now, facing Catra and pulling her in. "I was just about to ask you."

"Sure you were."

"Is that so hard to believe? That's..."

"Uh, yeah." They are close to the others now, but closer to the sea. Catra stops Adora with a hand on her arm and another on her waist. She leans her head back so she can capture Adora's warm gaze. "You're the clumsiest stunt person I've ever seen. I highly doubt you're a great dancer."

Adora's hands cup Catra's hips, following the rhythm Catra dictates.

"Why did you ask me, then? Dont you want to win?"

Mermista announces that the next song will be the first round of the dance fight. Seahawk starts an easy, slow melody that melts perfectly into the one that was playing before; something upbeat but romantic, with a rhythm easy to move to.

Adora misses a beat, and Catra blows a raspberry. Adora frowns and pulls her closer, hips flush together so she can follow Catra's lead better.

Catra feels like she has swallowed the whole campfire. She masks the burning with a cocky grin.

"I can win this with or without you."

"So what am I doing here?"

"Eye candy."

Adora bursts out laughing. The first song comes to an end, and Mermista eliminates Scorpia and Perfuma. They dont seem to mind; the only thing *Catra* minds is that Perfuma shoots her a thumbs up and a smile that feels...invasive.

Maybe she's overthinking it. All Perfuma said to her when Catra was staying over could easily be applied to all her relationships in general

- Perfuma is a good listener, is all. It doesn't take much to realize that Catra has issues.

That fucking dream from the other day has really ruined her.

The next song is annoying. Seahawk seems to have no idea how dance fights work, because he chose an *even slower* one than before. This one starts with a struggling piano, and even more strained vocals from someone who believes that good singing is just yelling agonisingly. It's definitely not up Catra's alley, but looking around, she can see that neither Bow and Glimmer nor Spinerella and Netossa have a problem with adapting.

Fuck. Okay, maybe she didn't think this…

What?

Adora guides Catra's palm to the curve where Adora's shoulder meets her neck, then drops her hand to Catra's waist again. Her other hand finds Catra's and holds it up gently, and she leans closer, closer, closer-

Catra's temple bumps against Adora's, her breath hitching in the back of her throat.

"We're not losing now," Adora whispers into Catra's ear. "This one's mine. Follow my lead."

Catra can't find any words. She probably swallowed them along with the flames. She is grateful that Adora can't see her face right now as she twirls them as one, holding Catra as close as possible. Her foot slips in the sand. Adora makes it look much easier than it really is and, thankfully, the boldness that Catra had drank with the beers helps her follow flawlessly.

Catra didn't notice she was moving her thumb on Adora's neck, but the shiver that comes with it, and the curt exhale Adora breathes

onto her cheek makes her aware of the mindless strokes. Her face flushes.

"What' s the macaroni story?"

Adora snorts.

"Oh, no."

"I did you a huge favor by coming here."

"Oh, do you hate the beach? The fresh air, the gorgeous sea? Skies so clear you can see the stars?"

"I hate people."

Catra can hear Adora's smile in the way she forms the words.

"Y ou know, I dont believe that anymore."

"That' s called growth. And it deserves an embarrassing story that everyone else knows. How am I going to feel like I truly belong if you deprive me of the inside jokes?"

Adora turns her head, nuzzling into Catra's hair. Her voice is strained with a laugh she doesnt want to bark and her fingers twitch around Catra's warm hand.

"Okay , fine. So… a couple years back, when Glimmer, Bow, and I first met Mermista, she, uh. She basically tried to convince me that the holes in the macaroni are chewed out by these little bugs that-"

"What?"

"Just, just little bugs that live in the pasta factories, and they're trained to do that. And I-"

"And you"…

"I did not believe that," Adora insists, her voice jumping high. It hurts Catra's ear this close, but she doesn't mind. "I *really* didn't, but I also didn't want to be rude, so I just… I was just like '*oh, really, I didn't know that, that's so interesting*' but everyone was so sure that I actually believed her and now they find every single opportunity to bring it up again."

Catra hums. Her neck starts to hurt as she keeps her head high for Adora to lean against. She doesn't mind that either.

Her thumb strokes along Adora's pulse again, and she frowns.

"Why do you take that?"

The song is slowly fading, and instead of giving her a reply, Adora moves her hand from Catra's waist to the small of her back, following the valley of her spine.

"I'm going to dip you," she says.

Catra has no time to answer. She draws her right knee up instinctively as Adora lowers her torso in sync with the last note; Catra wraps both her arms around Adora's neck for balance, and to bring her down with her until Adora's hair almost brushes the sand.

Looming above her, Adora's face is hidden in the shadows. She is wearing an orange crown of flames that doesn't burn as bright as the whites of her eyes when she looks at Catra, pupils blown out and her gaze wide and wild like she is shocked by her own decision.

The burn is tugging on Catra's insides, more urgent this time. She doesn't dare to move the thigh trapped between Adora's, trembling with anticipation. The salty breeze that blows from the sea feels like a cold slap.

The song ends.

In the heartbeat of silence, Adora pulls back so hurriedly that she seems to forget that Catra is relying on her hold for a moment. She mumbles *shit* under her breath as she grips Catra's back and arm again before she drops to the ground, and helps her stand.

Then, Adora takes a step back and clears her throat. Catra's blood is drumming so loudly in her ears that she barely hears Mermista sending Netossa and Spinerella off of the makeshift dance floor.

"That's seriously not fair," Netossa huffs, gesturing towards the remaining contestants. "It's a couple's dance fight and the last four people aren't even real couples."

Catra doesn't fucking look at anybody, and she hopes that nobody is looking at anybody else, either. Especially not at her. No one should look at Catra, ever - in fact, they should just forget she's here. Ever said yes to joining. Ever existed.

"No overruling the judge," Mermista drawls offhandedly, before turning to Seahawk with a snarl. "And *you*."

Seahawk's voice breaks.

"Yes, dear?"

"Play something that they can *actually* dance to! Enough of the sappy stuff, I wanna see some serious moves for the finals."

Seahawk starts to babble something about how he was only trying to serenade Mermista because she is all he can focus on, which gives Catra enough time to get her shit together.

"Are you ready to get destroyed?" Glimmer taunts jokingly, calling Catra back to the present. Her and Bow move closer now that it's just the two of them. "Your little attempts were cute, but you don't have what it takes to go against *us*."

Catra cocks a brow at Adora, her lower lip pouty.

"Did you hear something?"

Adora crosses her arms in front of her chest.

"No. Did you?"

"Nah. Must've been the wind."

"I didn't know winds could get scared of losing."

"Such a special little glittery wind."

Glimmer opens her mouth, but before she could quip back, Mermista is announcing the last round. All focused on the competition, Glimmer and Catra turn their backs on each other so they have room to move.

Adora's hands find Catra's hips again, and she pulls her close with no hesitation.

"Are you ready?" She asks with a smug little grin.

Even if Catra had been contemplating whether or not it was actually smart to continue, she would be wrapped up in it again by now.

Catra cracks her neck and nods. Adora's stomach is warm under her palms; she is wearing a tank top so tight that Catra can follow the lines of her abs with the tips of her fingers.

The last song starts. Catra's focus shifts from Glimmer and Bow's first steps to only Adora. She starts moving, following the rhythm. Adora is only focused on Catra, too; she knows where to move from the tiniest pressure of Catra's hands on her body towards her desired direction.

Catra spins too close to the fire. It is no longer like she had swallowed the flames; the flames are swallowing her whole now. Will she light Adora on fire if she pulls her back?

Catra presses her palms to Adora's chest. It heaves under the touch, Adora's eyes shimmering with questions Catra doesnt want to answer right now.

Catra sinks into a squat, bringing her hands down Adora's front. Her eyes never leave hers, nails clinging to the wrinkles of her tank top. Adora bends her knees as well, lured by Catra like a moth to the flame. Catra springs back up again and curls a leg around Adora's waist. Adora grabs her thigh to keep her there, her thumb sinking into her skin.

The light in Adora's eyes changes as an idea crosses her mind. She puts her other hand on Catra's other thigh, patting it.

That's enough for Catra to understand. She clings to the nape of Adora's neck for balance and jumps, wrapping both her legs around Adora's hips tight.

Just in time for the bridge, Adora starts to twirl in place. Catra draws her hand back and cranes her spine as much as she can, relying on Adora's hands on her ass and the strength in her own legs to keep her suspended in the air, wrapped around Adora.

Catra's fingers touch the sand, drawing a circle, sending grains sparkling in the breeze like golden glitter. The world is tipped upside down, melting into colorful rays of light and dark and sounds she cant hear anymore as blood rushes to her cheeks and ears.

Someone's laughing. It's probably Adora.

She stops and brings Catra back up just in time to strike the final pose; Catra slips a hand on Adora's neck, and another one right under her ponytail. Adora keeps holding her, tugging her higher on her hips before they share a breathless grin, and everything stills.

Catra's consciousness comes pouring down like a sudden rainfall, melting her smile. The tip of her nose is almost brushing against Adora's, their bodies pulsing together, hot and aching. Catra can see

her own ragged breaths in the way Adora's loose hairs flutter around her face, her chest crashing into Adora's with every sharp inhale.

She swallows. Her throat is so dry that her lungs seize with the urge to cough.

Adora's eyes follow the bob of Catra's throat and grow into endless black holes of pupils alone. Her heartbeat is drumming under Catra's fingers feverishly.

Mermista's yell cuts through the heavy, humid air. Catra didnt hear what she had said, but Glimmer and Bow's victorious cheers make it obvious.

Adora eases her grip on Catra's ass, lowering her onto the sand. It's slow and gentle, her touch lingering as long as it can without drawing too much attention. Catra does the same as she draws her hands back from cradling Adora's head; careful fingertips crawl down Adora's throat, the hollow of her collarbones, over her shoulders and forearms where Catra dares to halt for just a moment.

Adora's muscles ripple under her touch. Catra feels goosebumps blooming and fair hair rising.

Their gazes meet again.

"Um"…

"I'm going to bed," Catra blurts. She smooths her hair back and softens her voice into a raspy whisper, then. "I'm… I think I'm done for the night."

"I'm sorry."

Adora's voice is strained, her words burrowing under Catra's skin like needles. She wants to lock their gazes once more, finding it harder to catch Adora's eyes when she turns her head.

"It's not like that," Catra says softly, her fingers curling around Adora's wrist.

Adora looks at their hands, then into Catra's eyes. Catra wonders how someone's expression can be so open, yet so unreadable - and what about it can make her core tighten into a twisting, throbbing ball of fire?

Mind swept blank by the way Adora is looking at her now, Catra rises to her tiptoes. She leaves a quick peck on Adora's cold cheek, keeping her lips there to whisper: "Thanks for the dance, Adora."

Catra squeezes Adora's hand before she lets it go and turns on her heel. She hurries towards the bungalow they share, saying her goodnights to everyone on her way. She can feel Adora's gaze burning into her back, so she quickens her steps, feet sinking in the sand before she can hop onto the pebbled pathway.

By the time she slams the bungalow door closed behind her and twirls around, she is out of breath. Her head is spinning mercilessly, her feet stuck to the wooden floor. With her knees empty and trembling, she can't force herself to take even one step further inside the room; she stays there with her back and palms to the door, frozen for fuck knows how long, but she can't fucking calm down.

The door disappears behind her. Catra yelps and tries to grab onto something before she falls out onto the veranda.

Her fist curls around nothing, but she still doesn't fall. Someone grabs her arm - a firm body presses into hers. Before Catra can blink, she finds herself pinned to the door that is now closed again - no, locked with a *click* - and something clatters to the floor. It's her leather jacket that she left on the log, but Catra doesn't give any shits about it when her wrists are caught in loose grips and resting by her ears, a warm huff of breath is ghosting over her parted lips, sharp hips rolling flush against hers, and *fuck* -

Adora leans down and kisses her.

Chapter End Notes

Jesus fucking christ here we fucking go it's 11:30 PM I've just got home from work I am so fucking tired but HWRE YOU GO FINALLY I'M SORR FOR THE EAIT

If you like what I do please consider saying hello to me on Twitter where I post art and shit about my fics, too, it's a fun time I promise. You can send me your thoughts about Break A Leg here in the comments or (even) anonymously on CuriousCat.
I love you all stay safe I love you I already said that THE LESBIANS ARE FUCKING AGAIN
or are they!
Okay bie

Rule #10

Chapter Summary

10No oral.

Chapter Notes

cw // mentions of drug use (edibles), vaguely implied past sexual trauma/abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora is kissing Catra.

Adora is kissing *Catra*.

She can hardly believe it.

Catra's lips are just as soft as she remembers; a hint of sweetness lies under the bitterness of the beer she drank.

Catra opens up for her, rising on her tiptoes for a better angle to deepen their kiss, and drags her tongue over Adora's. She hooks a finger into Adora's belt hoop and pulls her closer, her other hand sneaking around her hips to slip into the back pocket of Adora's shorts.

holy shit .

Adora's knees tremble, threatening to give up under her. Her whole chest is tight; a throbbing ball of fire, flames spreading across her ribs and melting into dripping lava. Heat pools in her core in an all too familiar rush, sparking whenever she is close to Catra.

And now, she gets to be as close as physically possible.

Adora cannot overthink this. She has no time. If she starts thinking, she starts talking; if she starts talking, she will ruin everything. Catra dictates a breathless tempo, urgent and electric, and Adora will not fall behind.

So she kisses, and touches, and holds. She pins Catra by one tiny wrist, letting her other hand draw back from her pocket and roam free on Adora’s back, black nails scratching curvy paths all over her skin. Adora kisses her like Catra could change her mind at any second, and she is determined to take as much as Catra will allow her to.

Adora laces their fingers together beside Catra's head. Her left hand disappears into Catra's wild hair, her fist firm around the waves as she tugs.

Catra moans into her mouth. Her eyes snap open, their kiss broken. Her gaze is so intense that the whites of her eyes are burning like fireworks, and Adora can hear their popping echoing in her skull.

There is a breath of silence. They both stay still. Adora is still terrified of ruining this if she says or does anything out of Catra's guidance and control. If they're really doing this - and Adora would give anything to really be doing this with Catra again - she knows that she has to let Catra make the decisions.

Adora had fucked up by being too much; taking too much, talking too much, asking too much. She had fucked them up with everything she thought would bring them closer together, what she thought was going to show Catra that she could trust her.

Something shifts in the air.

Catra’s chest is heaving, her pupils devouring her irises. She brings their bodies even closer and tips her head to the side. She tastes Adora between her parted lips, kissing her again in the same hasty, desperate way she started this. She pulls her hands free from

Adora's grip, sliding both of them up along her ribs, the swells of her chest, until Catra's palms are flat on Adora's shoulders.

Then, she shoves her.

Adora loses her balance, calves knocking into the bedframe. She falls on her ass and inhales with a sharp hiss. Her pain dissolves into aching warmth as soon as Catra crawls on top of her and steals her breath and thoughts with a kiss.

They flop back down on the bed, Adora pulling Catra into a crushing embrace. Catra presses even closer, hips rocking into Adora's in a desperate demand for friction.

Adora's brain switches off. She is not worried about anything anymore - not when she is in bed with Catra, not when she is being kissed and touched with the same inexplicable, burning certainty that she felt when Catra had pinned her to the wall of the elevator three years ago.

Her eyes are stinging with unshed tears of relief.

Catra still needs her.

Adora grabs her by the waist and flips her over to switch positions. Like this, Catra is laying on top of Adora with her back pressed to Adora's chest and her head lolling back to Adora's shoulder so their cheeks touch.

Adora cranes her neck to smear a kiss to Catra's flushed cheek, her lips lingering on her skin. Her hands come up to knead her chest; Adora crumples up Catra's shirt, exposing her heaving stomach.

Catra's spine curves and her throat tenses with a gasp, hot and heavy with desire. Her sqirming pushes her ass deeper into Adora' s lap.

It is not enough friction, but Adora is so far gone that she feels like Catra has just rocked into her without the layers of clothing between them. She burrows under Catra's jaw to bite into her neck, nearly breaking skin.

Catra cries out, her voice already rough.

Adora bites her again, gentler this time, nosing the spot behind Catra's ear that always makes her lose herself. Catra's sweet voice has an equally violent effect on Adora - she feels herself getting wetter, certain that she has soaked through her briefs by now.

They waste no time slowing down now. Catra is fumbling with the zipper of her shorts, trying to push them off her legs without losing contact with Adora's body rolling underneath her. In her struggle, Catra's hand slips off the hem, her sharp elbow drilling right into Adora's side. She doesn't even notice it, and Adora gives no fucks about the pain; air is already stuck in her lungs from touching Catra again, her blood thrumming under her skin.

Once Catra kicks off her shorts, Adora helps with her bikini, shoving it down her thighs. Neither of them cares about making it past her knees; Catra has already spread her legs for Adora with a pleading little moan, and Adora slips her hand between them.

Adora can't help but curse under her breath. If possible, Catra may be even more ready than she is, every inch of her curls heavy and wet.

Adora wants to slow down. She wants to savor this moment, wants to sink into Catra's warmth and fondle her until she doesn't know where her fingertips end and Catra's body starts. She wants to melt into her, become one with the heat, and never leave.

She wants to, but she can't. She has no patience for it.

Adora knows exactly how to touch her by now, and she *needs* to make Catra hers again.

Catra throws her head back, her moans even more strained now. Adora can't see her face, but the way her body is wriggling on top of her, how desperately her hands are clinging to Adora's hand on her chest, how needy and husky her wet gasps are, tells Adora that she hasn't forgotten a thing.

It doesn't make her smirk.

Nope.

Not at all.

Catra slams her hand down on the bed. The covers are ripping in her grip, and her other hand flies up to grab Adora by her ponytail.

"Harder," she breathes, voice breaking around a whimper. "Please, Adora, *harder*."

Adora's smirk disappears like it was slapped off her face, and she grunts.

Every inch of her flushes with a fever. It is flooding, roaring under her skin, in her veins, echoing Catra's words back to her. Her hand moves on its own, granting Catra her plea; she holds her close and kisses her everywhere she can reach, mumbling between gentle pecks and heavy breaths:

"I've got you, Catra. I've got you."

Catra whimpers again. It sounds like a sob is bubbling from her lungs.

It's coming.

Adora can feel it.

She feels it in Catra's shaking legs, in her curling toes and steel grip around Adora's messy ponytail. She feels it in the growing warmth of her body, the voiceless cries her throat is too raw to vocalize clearly.

She feels it in the air that's crackling with electricity, the scent of sweat and skin and arousal.

"Come on, Catra," she whispers again, keeping her voice low. "I've got you. I'm right here."

Catra shatters.

Adora doesn't let go. She stays with her through it all, holding, spoiling, worshiping, putting the pieces back together.

Catra comes down slowly, her body still twitching here and there.

Silence settles over them, heavy and uneven like the mingling breaths surging from their chests. Catra sinks her whole weight into Adora, swallowing against the dryness of her throat between gasps. Her grip goes slack, the backs of her hands flopping onto the bed wearily.

Adora leaves one hand between Catra's legs, the other on the swell of her chest, her thumb over a pebbled nipple. It's probably a horrible idea, but she doesn't dare to move a muscle. If she does, this is over again. She is certain of it.

Catra's breathing evens out after a few seconds, and she starts to stir. It is the sign for Adora to snatch her hands back, and she feels what she was fearing almost immediately; Catra has frozen against her from head to toe.

"Shit," Catra hisses, springing up from the bed. Her bikini is still somewhere in the middle of her legs and she almost falls over herself. Grabbing it, she pulls it up swiftly and turns on her heel. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. Fucking. fuck—"

Adora blinks. She had fully expected Catra to be angry with her, an unstoppable force of fury and regret. Instead, she sounds broken and miserable as she presses the heels of her palms into her closed eyes, sniffing loudly.

She is still mumbling apologies as she starts to flee.

Adora is in full blown panic mode in a flash. She cant stop herself from jumping up and blurting out: "Dont go."

Catra halts. She is still turned towards the door, trembling arms wrapped around herself tight, head hanging in defeat.

Adora licks her lips.

"Please, dont go," she repeats, softer this time. *Not again*. She reaches towards Catra, but doesnt touch her .

"Im so sorry," Catra croaks. Her nails are digging into her elbows, her skin turning white around them. Adora drops her hand. "This is all my fault. I should have never started anything."

"What?" Adora merely exhales the word, furrowing her brows. "Im the one who kissed you first. If you want to blame someone"–

"No," Catra cuts in softly and turns her head a little bit. There is a faint, sad smile tugging on her lips, and a lifeless chuckle slips out from between them. " *I* kissed you first. I started this, remember?"

Adora's jaw pops open, eyes wild and wide.

Catra is right.

Catra kissed her first, by the campfire, right in front of everyone. Then, she left for their bungalow, and Adora did the only logical thing and followed her–

Wait.

Does that mean?..

"W ell, do we *have* to blame someone?" Adora asks. She sounds a little too desperate for her own liking, and she needs to get a hold of herself. She cant slip now . Not when she is so close to scaring Catra

off again. If she does, shell lose her for good. I mean… was this happening really such a bad thing?"

"*Yes*," Catra replies without hesitation, like she might ask Adora if she was fucking stupid. It hurts. "Of course it was. This was a mistake. Were friends now, arent we? We cant… this should have never happened."

"What if"… Adora bites back her words, chewing on her lower lip. She wants to say so many things, all of them dangerous, and her brain is still full of echoes of Catra's voice and the feeling of slick skin between her fingers. "What if it wasnt a mistake?"

Her foolish bravery gives her one good thing: Catra is finally looking at her, even though *"are you out of your goddamn mind?"* is still written all over her face.

"Adora," she starts. It's a warning.

Adora ignores it. "I know where Im going with this, okay? Trust me."

The answer is silence, which Adora considers a success. She plops down onto the bed, and pats the mattress next to her.

Catra narrows her eyes, but walks up to the bed. She sits down as far away from Adora as possible, and crosses her legs.

It looks like she is actually willing to listen to what Adora has to say. It makes Adora tongue-tied, blood rushing out of her face.

"It's just. Ive been thinking. I think it's like"…

"Adora." Now her name is reassurance, rolling off Catra's tongue like a purr. "Just say it."

"Right. Yeah. Yeah." Adora takes a deep breath, her chest rising and falling with her shoulders. Once she calms down, every drop of uncertainty leaves her voice. "I think this was the logical thing to happen."

"*Logical?* " Catra repeats, almost grinning in shock. "Is that really the word you're going with?"

"Yes," Adora goes on, turning fully towards Catra. "Yes, I am. You know why? Because this - us - the whole thing started because we were physically attracted to each other, right? So it's not... You know. Of course we can't just forget three years in a couple days. It won't just disappear just because we became friends. We're still allowed to - to *feel* that attraction. We've been sleeping with each other for so long it became like, the very thing that we are to each other. No one could just forget it like that."Adora snaps her fingers for emphasis.

Catra sighs and licks her lips. It attracts Adora's attention, soaking up her thoughts like a sponge. "Fine, yes. That makes sense. But it doesn't mean we should just keep letting it happen. It doesn't mean that it's right."

"Well it's not wrong, either,"Adora argues.

"*Everything* is wrong with it!"

Adora clamps her mouth shut, swallowing her reply. Catra whips her head towards her; her eyes are wild, her mouth twisted, flashing teeth.

Adora's throat is burning. She keeps eye contact until Catra gasps, and looks away. Adora is not sure how she even finds her voice - or at least a tired, weak fragment of it.

"Is that what you really think?"

As it all sinks down on Catra, her gaze finds Adora again. Her eyes have widened even more, fear trembling in them. "I—"

"Hey, it's okay," Adora says. Despite everything, she tries a faint smile. She feels exhausted, blood turned to lead in her veins. "We never have to do it again, if you don't want to."

Catra swallows. She unfolds her legs and arms, and scoots a tiny bit closer on the bed. Adora's gaze shifts from her lips to her eyes, finding them burning bright in the dark.

"What do *you* want, Adora?"

The question hangs in the air; Adora's grasp of it is too weak to answer right away.

She wants so much, and deserves none of it.

She wants all her fantasies while fucking Catra to come true. She wants to be the person wishing her goodnight whenever she is going to bed, and good morning every time she wakes up. She wants to know everything about her, the things no one else knows. She wants to take her every night and take her out on dates after work, she wants to hold her when she cries and stay awake all night whispering about whatever.

She wants, she wants, she wants.

She wants *her*.

It makes it so hard to breathe.

"I want to make you happy," Adora says with a little shrug.

Catra's face falls.

Adora aches, her hand trembling in a fist.

She fucked up. It wasn't the right answer.

Catra crosses her arms across her chest, raspy voice turning sour. "So your plan was to - what? Just keep fucking me, but stay my friend, too?"

"No," Adora says. Catra's eyes flash. "Yes. Maybe. Ugh, look..." She slides a palm across her forehead, trying to massage away the

drumming headache her failure has cursed her with. "I just thought *maybe* it could work. We've been doing well with keeping our affair secret for years, and now we can actually have each other's backs. What's the harm in doing this just until we can adjust to being friends? We don't have to go cold turkey."

Catra scoffs at probably more than one choice of words there.

"You seem to have thought about this a lot."

Adora can't even blush at the accusation. She has given up on trying to defend herself.

"I've been thinking about this since we kissed in the trailer."

"That—" Catra chokes on her own words.

"Was a mistake. I know. But it happened, and at that point, I wouldn't have stopped if Glimmer and Bow hadn't shown up." Adora's brows twitch. "Would you?"

Catra clicks her tongue, burying her face into her palms so she sounds muffled.

"Look, I get it. Okay? I like having sex with you, *obviously*. If I didn't, I wouldn't have been fucking you for years. But I"… Catra lifts her head, sneaking a peek at Adora's tense features. Her whole face is cherry red, panic creeping into her tone. "What if we mess this up? I don't want to mess it up."

"You don't?" Adora asks, her shock genuine. Sure, Catra had let Adora be her friend, but she never thought… she never would have even wished that having Adora in *her* life meant anything to Catra.

"Of course I don't," Catra says. It sounds like a whine. "Adora, you're… Fuck, I don't know how to say any of this without hating every single second of it."

Despite everything, Adora's chest warms up again, and her loopy grin is back on her face.

"Catra," she singsongs, leaning closer to bump her shoulder into Catra's. "Are you trying to admit that you actually like being friends with me?"

"*No*, fuck you," Catra spits, then growls hopelessly. "Sorry. Reflex."

Adora snorts an ugly chuckle. It earns her a fist in her stomach, playfully forceless. She throws her hands up to surrender, still laughing to herself.

When she meets Catra's eyes, her smile melts; Catra's expression is serious again, the shine in her eyes solemn and deep.

"I don't have many friends," Catra says, her gaze shifting away before clinging to Adora's again. "I'm not an easy person to keep around. But the friends I have… yeah, I do cherish what I have with them. I don't want to fuck up what we have. I… I like being your friend. And I'm just… friends with benefits is such a weird concept to me. I was more than okay with fucking someone I didn't know much about, but I would never do anything like that with a friend. I can't afford to lose what I have with them."

Adora nods. Her chest is tight, her happiness bittersweet. As much as her heart aches for Catra's touch, her friendship is worth everything. Having Catra in her life in whatever way she allows her to is worth it; and Adora knows that she is more than willing to give up sex and sacrifice her attraction to protect that.

"I'm sorry," Catra says, and she sounds like she really is. "I just can't."

"Okay," Adora says. She puts a palm on Catra's shoulder, squeezing it encouragingly. "I understand. I'll never let this happen again, I promise."

Catra smiles at her, and sniffs. Adora can't see tears, but Catra does look like she is close to crying.

Adora has to fix this.

She wraps her arms around Catra's shoulders, pulling her in. "C'mere."

Maybe it's stupid, but she needs this, too.

Surely, she will be allowed to hug Catra later, but not like this. Adora allows herself this; this will be the only time she is not trying to hide her love for Catra. From now on, she will be good. She will disguise her heart and wear a mask - she will never speak of this again, never bring up sex again.

Never.

But right now, she scoots closer to Catra and wraps her arms around her. She lays her palms flat on Catra's back and waist, stroking gently. She presses her face into the crook of Catra's neck, breathing her in; her smoky scent is intoxicating as always, with a hint of campfire and sweat. It is swirling in Adora's head, daz ing her .

Catra eases her muscles with a sigh. She hugs back and pulls Adora even closer, clinging to her as tight as she can. Adora can feel her lips on her throat, careful fingertips caressing down the nape of her neck, crawling lower and lower in the valley of her spine.

A full body shiver runs through Adora, goosebumps blooming all over her skin. She hates how easily Catra turns her on, how little it takes until she can feel the needy throbbing between her legs.

Catra reaches the end of her spine, and sinks her nails into the small of Adora's back. Adora rubs her thighs together, biting her lip to swallow back a moan.

Shit.

She has to get out.

Adora draws back as much as Catra lets her - which is not a lot - and tries to fill the heady air with her babbling: "By the way , you know you were going to run outside without your shorts, right?"

Catra cocks her head. Her eyes are half-mast, not focused on Adora's eyes. Her lips seem to part on their own, her hands pulling back up to feel Adora's rapid pulse under her skin.

Adora goes on:

"N-not like it's a bad look for you, obviously" Catra leans closer, "I'm just saying it's pretty cold out now" – closer, "And I really don't want you to catch a co" – *Closer* .

Soft lips press into hers in a brief, searing kiss before they break apart. Catra stays near, the tip of her nose pressed to Adora's cheek. She sucks her lower lip between her teeth.

Adora squeezes her eyes shut.

"Catra," she whispers, not daring to raise her voice. "You just said" –

"I know what I said," Catra murmurs. Her thumbs are stroking along the sharp line of Adora's jaw . "But... I'd like to try . With you. Okay?"

Adora opens her eyes; the intensity of Catra's mismatched irises catches her off guard.

She is not an idiot. She is not going to ask questions right now. "Okay ."

Catra drops her hands to Adora's shoulders, guiding her to lay on her back. She comes down with her, crawling on top of her. Waves of her wild hair drop to Adora's chest, and her smirk is the most beautiful thing Adora has ever seen.

"And I want to return the favor ."

Adora barks out a laugh, her whole body burning with trembling anticipation. "Yeah?" Her hands come up to grab Catra by her waist, pulling her down until every inch of their bodies touch. Her hands are on warm, sunkissed skin, burrowing under Catra's shirt. "What do you have in mind?"

Catra hums, and tilts her head to the side. She is still smirking as she follows the curve of Adora's throat with her fingertip.

Adora shivers at the touch, barely catching what Catra is saying:

"I think I'm gonna make you cry with my tongue."

Adora blacks out.

She fully blacks out.

Her ears are ringing, her vision is fuzzy. Heat spreads under her skin from her head to her chest, she can feel her heartbeat pulsing slick between her legs.

Somewhere at the edge of her consciousness, Catra giggles. "Adora?"

Adora straight up *squeaks*. It resembles "yes?" closely enough for Catra to continue:

"Are you okay with that?"

"Yes," Adora cuts in before Catra could even finish. "Mm-hm. Yep. Yes, so much fucking yes."

"Good," Catra purrs, and captures Adora's lips again.

Adora lets Catra kiss her however she pleases. Even if she wanted to form any coherent thoughts, she couldn't.

She submits to Catra, sinking into the feeling of *her*.

Catra's hands are under her top, crawling up her ribs. Catra's thigh is between hers, teasing, rocking into Adora so softly there is barely friction for her to lose her mind to. Catra is in her head, and all over her, and Adora has never felt more alive.

They are still fully dressed, apart from Catra's shorts, but this is the hottest thing Adora has ever experienced. It reminds her of their last time; slow kissing in bed, savouring every second, every touch unhurried. Catra is careful with her but passionate, kissing her like she would have all the time in the world to do so, but she would still never want to stop.

Adora gets drunk on it quickly.

Before she knows it, Catra's clever fingers have crumpled up her shirt and dragged her sports bra down to kiss along the curves of her chest.

Adora arches into the touch, moaning faintly.

Catra's lips are gentle, the flick of her tongue playful - until it isn't. After not much warming up, she wraps her lips around the swell of Adora's breast, sucking a mark on her.

Adora's foot slips on the bed, kicking the air. "Shit–"

Catra hums into her skin, then releases her with a wet pop. There is no attempt to mask how fucking smug she already feels from just this one reaction. Catra's lips wander lower, leaving a curving path of burning kisses and faint bites all over Adora's front. Adora squirms at every single one of them, breath stuttering.

Catra's giggle is raspier, lower than before. She is becoming devious. "You're too easy."

"Am not!" Adora says. She aimed for her tone to ring as rightfully offended, but only managed "desperately horny." Even to her own

ears, those two words sounded like she was begging Catra to fuck her.

They definitely sounded like that to Catra's ears.

"Oh, *Princess*"... Catra drags her mouth even lower on Adora's navel. She hooks her fingers into the hem of Adora's booty shorts and briefs; Adora raises her hips obediently, and Catra pulls them off of her. She leans back down, her waves flowing over Adora's eagerly spread legs, her chin grazing Adora's neatly trimmed hair. Her lips move on Adora's skin as she speaks, right above the hairline. "You're not fooling anyone."

Catra sinks her teeth into Adora, hard.

Adora yelps. It quickly melts into an embarrassing moan, high and delirious. Her knees bend on their own, feet lifting into the air.

Catra doesn't stop; she bombards Adora with kisses and bites all over the edge of her hair, so close to where Adora needs her most, but never quite crossing that line. Adora feels Catra's silky curls and hot breath brushing her *right there* whenever Catra moves to a new spot to claim, but never her mouth.

It's infuriating. It's perfect.

It's pure torture.

"I thought you were an asshole before," Adora says between labored breaths. Her hands come up to thread between Catra's waves, their grip barely there. "Is this how you fuck someone you actually like?"

Catra latches to the softest spot of Adora's inner thigh, silencing her with a rough bite. It stings like a bitch and feels just as wonderful, and as Adora squirms again, she actually feels herself dripping onto the bed in despair.

Her voice cracks in her throat.

"Never said I liked you," is all Catra offers as explanation, raising her head from between Adora's thighs. She is squinting adorably, and the cocky smirk on her lips makes her even more irresistible.

Jesus *fucking* Christ.

Adora's brain cant come up with words anymore.

Well - not many of them.

"Catra.I"-

Adora feels the pad of Catra's thumb brush against her. She is so wet that it is all Catra touches. Catra pulls her hand back until the thick string of shine that connects them breaks.

Her eyes are burning in the dark, catching hers. "Adora."

Adora takes a couple seconds to just breathe, trying to gather herself.

"Thought you wanted to make me cry," she says then, propping up on her elbows. "But I guess losing to me doesnt bother you."

Catra barks a cocky *hah*, and sinks her nails into the meat of Adora's thighs to spread them wider.

"Losing? Really, Adora? Cause the way I see it..." Catra rests her cheek in her palm right above Adora's pelvis, blinking up at her slowly. "I could make you cry without even putting my mouth on you."

Adora's heartbeat quickens, her mouth dry .

She knows Catra is only teasing her. She *knows*.

"You cant be serious."

She doesnt sound like she knows.

"Aww, what's wrong?" Catra's thumb is caressing lower on Adora's leg, earning more hitched breaths and swallowed groans. She leans down, pressing a gentle kiss just a touch away from Adora's heat, to the deepest valley of the crease above her thigh. Her voice sounds muffled from down there, her grin evident in her tone. "To me, it sounds like you *are* close to crying."

"You are such a brat," Adora says through gritted teeth. Her arms are wobbling as they hold her torso up, her hands balling into fists.

Something dangerous flashes in Catra's eyes as she glances up and locks their gazes together.

"Oh, Adora. You have no idea," is all she says before her tongue flicks out, and she dives in.

Adora's arms give up under her, breaking their eye contact. She flops back on the bed, and at the same goddamn time, she slams her skull right into the sharp edge of the bed frame.

Adora yelps out in pain and pleasure alike, seeing stars for a second.

Hearing the loud knock, Catra does the worst thing that she possibly could: she jumps up on her knees, separating her tongue from Adora, and leans over her.

"Holy shit, are you okay?"

Adora just growls. Sure, the back of her head is throbbing with pain, but so is the apex of her thighs, and it is so obvious which one is more important right now.

Without a word, she grabs a fistful of hair above Catra's forehead and pushes her back down.

Catra takes in a sharp breath at Adora's roughness, inhaling with a dark chuckle. "Fuck, you're so needy."

Adora's blood grows cold.

She drops her hand, untangling it from Catra's hair and sucks her lips in.

Catra does what she was told, and puts her mouth back on Adora. Her voice is tolling inside Adora's chest like bells.

Adora is paralyzed by it.

There are no more sounds left to spill from her lips. No more reaching out, no more touching and asking. No more letting herself enjoy things. No more taking and taking and taking what she hasn't earned.

Is this selfish?

This is ruining their friendship… isn't it? This is the exact thing Catra did not want;the thing Catra asked her to never do again.

She just had to fucking hug her and make her change her mind, huh? She just had to force her to give it all up, to make her believe that Adora would be worth it. That they could do this - that *Adora* could do this.

She can't do this.

Adora is not worth it. Not for this, not for Catra's mouth, not for her friendship.

Not for anything.

"Hey."

Adora winces. Her consciousness returns with the soft, raspy voice that broke the silence. She blinks, and her vision clears up; Catra's gorgeous face is hovering right above her, her palms on either side of Adora's head to hold herself up.

Adora can still feel the frantic beat of her heart. Panic makes her chest rise and fall, rise and fall. If Catra asks anything about this, how can Adora give her an honest answer? How can she confess how much of a failure she is? How can she tell her that she has never been enough to be worth staying around? She cant have this conversation now - not now, not ever–

"Remember the time in the meeting room?" is what Catra asks instead, with her voice so, so gentle.

Adora swallows dryly. She tries to speak, but her voice doesnt come;so instead, she nods.

How could she ever forget that?

Catra's smile is dazzling, her lips glossy with Adora's shine. She shifts her weight onto her right arm, and raises her left hand to stroke a loose lock of hair behind Adora's ear. She strokes along her ponytail, then, reaching the hair tie that had slipped down to the middle of Adora's messy hair.

She pulls it out gently, stretching it between her fingers.

Catra's hips press into Adora's as she sinks down onto her, positioning herself to straddle Adora's waist with her knees.

She has Adora's full attention.

"You're still my good girl, arent you?" She asks Adora, tilting her head a bit like she needs reassurance.

Her words are daggers, stabbing and twisting right through Adora's core until they melt in the fire.

Fuck.

Fuck.

"Yes,"Adora says, finding her croaky voice. "Yours."

Catra's lashes flutter dreamily, her hand coming up to rest on top of Adora's still heaving chest. "Mine."

Adora is spellbound by her.

Catra draws back, slipping Adora's hair tie onto her wrist as she starts to comb through her waves, collecting them in her fist. Her eyes never leave Adora's.

"So you want to be good for me," Catra muses, looping her hair into a high ponytail. "You want me to have my way with you. You want to let me go back between those beautiful thighs of yours and eat you out."

Adora swallows again. *"Please"* almost escapes her.

"I really want that, too," Catra lowers her voice down to a whisper and leans forward, pressing her chest to Adora's. Her lips are just a breath away from Adora's, but she moves her head and presses them to Adora's jawline instead. "You taste so good, Adora. You're so soft, and sweet, and hot, and I can still feel you melting on my tongue."

Adora is shivering, almost feverish, and clamps her eyes shut. Her teeth clink together in a snarl. She has to cling to the bedspread tight with both fists so she won't grab Catra and claim her mouth in every single way imaginable.

Catra nuzzles against Adora's face and kisses her on the cheek. "Be a good girl and tell me what to do."

Adora breathes out in a gasp, eyes snapping open.

What?

"Tell me what I'm allowed to do," Catra goes on, leaving pecks on Adora's skin between sentences. "Tell me how I can make you feel good. Tell me where you want me, tell me how you want me."

It sounds so easy, when she says it like that.

"Cat—" Adora bites back her words before she could break. "I don't—"

It's impossible. She can't do this.

She can't do this.

Catra draws back so their eyes can meet.

Adora is drowning.

"I want you so bad, Adora," Catra says, her breath burning on Adora's lips. She grazes their noses together, perfect brows tilting up imploringly. "But I can't touch you without you telling me what to do. Good girls say exactly what they want - and you want to be a good girl, don't you? My good girl."

Warmth floods Adora's chest, flushing out the ice that had frozen her blood in her veins. She is breathing slowly and deeply. Determination hardens the moonlight in her eyes.

Catra is watching her. Adora knows that look. She knows Catra is not playing;she is not going to touch her until Adora tells her to.

Adora is losing to her, but it still tastes like victory.

Catra bumps her forehead against Adora's and closes her eyes. "Take what you want."

Adora cranes her neck, and kisses her.

The kiss is gentle, all things considered. Adora is burning with it, but keeps it slow; she digs her fingers into Catra's waist, pushing her down onto Adora's hips so that she can sit up with Catra still in her lap.

Adora deepens the kiss for a moment before breaking it. She finds Catra's gaze and holds it, breathing into the narrow space between

them: "On your knees."

Her voice is a little shaky, a little unsteady, but rough with something Adora cant name.

The way Catra's breath shutters – the way she is looking at Adora right now with those dark, dark eyes – is the victory she could have already tasted. Catra licks her lips and crawls off of Adora's lap and the bed, obeying without hesitation.

But Adora hesitates.

"Wait," she says, turning quickly to grab a fluffy, thick pillow lying on the bed. She leans forward and sets it on the floor, fluffing it up neatly.

"...What are you doing?" Catra asks.

"I want you to be comfortable," Adora says.

Catra's shoulders drop at the words, her cheeks flushing a faint rosy pink. She says nothing as she uses the pillow Adora placed in front of her to drop to her knees between Adora's spread legs. She sits back on her heels, palms flat against her knees, and lolls her head back to wait for further instructions.

Adora cant stop staring at her .

Catra is all sharp edges and soft curves, carved into perfection. Adora loves her heart-shaped little face, her cute button nose. She loves her lips, soft and plump, she loves her cheeks, peppered with freckles like faraway galaxies. She loves her thick curls, flowing ever so effortlessly elegant and yet untamed.

She loves her collarbones, loves the shadows they cast on her dark skin. She loves the hill of her chest that leads to perky tits, she loves the toned muscles on her belly, the dark, thick hair between her thighs–

"Take off your clothes," Adora hears herself say. Her voice has gained strength. "I want to see all of you."

Catra crosses her arms and pulls her shirt over her head. She unclasps her bra with practiced ease, pushing the straps off her shoulders. She rises then, and this time her bikini slides all the way off.

Her chest seems to be rising with rapid breaths, her neck and cheeks still flushed with color.

Adora follows her lead. It has started to be uncomfortable to stay in her tank top and the sports bra that is cutting into her skin, still dragged down to expose her chest.

Once the rustling stops, everything stills. Something has shifted in the crackling air, something intoxicatingly heavy and tense.

Adora weaves her fingers into Catra's ponytail, then lays her palm on the nape of her neck. She pulls her in slowly, steadily, giving Catra the chance to pull back anytime she wants.

She doesn't.

Her lips touch Adora's bristly hair, her breath warming up slick skin. Adora is dripping, her core is in an aching knot.

Catra peeks up at her. The tip of her nose is tilted up, pressed into Adora's mound.

Adora struggles to stay in her body.

"Your tongue," she says, voice quivering again. "Use your tongue on me."

"Good girl," Catra murmurs.

Adora moans before she even feels the soft pressure of Catra's tongue again. Her nails scrape against Catra's skull, fingers twitching

on their own.

Adora leans back, pushing her hips closer to Catra. Her spine arches back, hair flowing over the bed freely.

Catra tastes Adora slowly, carefully, seemingly paying attention to Adora's every twitch and hiss, and the way Adora is threading Catra's waves between her fingers. It feels overwhelming, and is not enough at the same time.

Catra's tongue circles. Adora's hips buck.

"Y our hands, too," Adora says between gasps. "Y our hands"…

Catra comes up from between Adora's thighs with a luscious, long lick. "What should I do with them?"

"I dont care," Adora says. "Anything. I just"…

Catra shushes her, pressing a kiss to Adora's inner thigh. Her lips are cold and wet. Adora shivers.

Catra rests her cheek on the sloppy kiss mark. "Be good for me."

"*Fck* ."

Adora doesnt mean to say that out loud. It doesnt matter .

She takes a deep breath.

She can be good.

She can be good for Catra.

So, she says:

"Massage my thighs. Scratch me. Pull me closer ." *ust hold me.*

Catra does. She does it all, and puts her mouth back on Adora, moaning faintly at the contact. Her previous exploratory leisure and tenderness has evaporated; she is eating Adora out with a kind of hungry intensity Adora was not prepared for.

Catra works with her tongue, and her lips, her nose, her chin, swirling and taking and kissing. She would bury herself into Adora if she could, and Adora feels all of her at the same time. Yet, every stroke is unique, sending a different tingle up her spine.

Catra sinks her nails into Adora's ass, and pulls her closer to the edge of the bed. She takes her leg and pulls it over her shoulder until Adora is almost sitting on her. With her other hand, she is massaging soothing patterns into the flushed skin of Adora's other thigh.

Something starts swirling inside Adora, ready to crash over her. She can't stop her body from floating towards release, or her mouth from running constantly.

"Oh, your mouth," she babbles with her grip tightening around Catra's ponytail, barely coherent. "Your fucking mouth, oh my god. Fuck, baby, you feel so good, so, so good"—

Catra whimpers.

Adora's orgasm comes out of nowhere, washing over her like a fantastic wave. It knocks the air out of her lungs and takes her voice with it, then pulls her body forward to crash into Catra.

Catra's hands come up to Adora's shoulders, squeezing gently. She is waiting patiently until Adora catches her breath, and straightens to reveal flushed cheeks and shining irises.

Catra meets her eyes. Catra's are glistening just like Adora's, and so is the bottom half of her face.

She is the most beautiful thing Adora has ever seen.

"Thank you," Adora says.

Catra scrunches her nose with a giggle.

Is it weird to thank someone for the single best cunnilingus of one's life? Probably. Adora is too blissed out to care, so she repeats it for good measure.

"My pleasure," Catra says. She doesnt wipe her face.

She rises to her feet while Adora flops back onto the bed, sore and totally spent. Before Adora could stop herself, her mouth forms another reqest:

"Come here, please?"

Catra's hesitation only lasts a second. She blinks at Adora like she wants to say something, but doesnt. She crawls up the bed and over Adora, wrapping herself around her body. She tucks her head under Adora's chin, nuzzling softly, nimble limbs entwining with Adora's. Her curls are still wet, crashing into Adora's bare thighs.

Goosebumps bloom all over Adora's legs.

Asking for things is pretty cool.

"Of course you're an after-sex cuddler," Catra mumbles into Adora's throat; the bitterness in her voice is more teasing than cruel. Adora can almost hear a smirk around the words.

"Busted," Adora says without even a fraction of shame. She slips a hand between the mattress and the nape of her neck. With her free hand, she runs her fingers through Catra's tousled hair, barely held back by the hair tie. She starts stroking her the way she knows she likes, and feels Catra's body sinking into hers with a sigh. "I told you, I'm not the hooking up type."

Catra laughs. It's one of her sweet, squeaky giggles that never fails to warm Adora's chest. "Right. I've noticed."

"No, I mean"— Adora licks her lips, desperately trying to find the right words and the confession she is allowed to make. "That's… you're"…

"I'm what?" Catra asks, humor hiding in her voice.

"Just. I. don't know . You're different."

Catra's gentle fingertips have been caressing Adora's sternum. Now, they stop.

Her voice changes, too.

"Different how?"

"I don't know," Adora repeats. She sounds miserable, even to her own ears. "All my girlfriends were my friends first, and sex has always been something… yknow. Intimate? I'm just used to being able to take care of the person after I make them feel good. So yeah, cuddling, kissing, touching after sex is just… it helps me to… come down? I don't know. It's part of the routine."

Catra keeps quiet for a couple of seconds. Then, she stirs and raises her head from the valley of Adora's shoulder, narrowing her eyes at her.

Adora parts her lips, cocking a brow questioningly. Before she can say or do anything, she feels Catra's hands cupping her jaw, and warm lips pressing against hers quickly and clumsily.

Adora doesn't even have time to close her eyes before their lips pop apart. Catra's lashes flutter open, beautiful eyes boring into hers. Her brows are still in a knot, a pout sitting on her lips like she would be asking *"well?"*

Adora is dreaming. She has to be.

"Wow," she breathes, like a lovesick, dopey idiot. She doesn't even regret it. This isn't real. Everything is possible.

Catra's whole face scrunches up, her cheeks burst into flames. When she speaks up, her voice is high, woven with panic. "I just– you just–you said kissing was part of your sex routine or whatever!"

"Yeah," Adora replies without taking a breath. Her eyes fall half-mast, her hand in Catra's hair cradles her skull, bringing her back. A dream. Adora pecks her on the lips, quick and soft. "Yeah." And again. "This is part of sex."And again.

Adora pulls Catra flush against her, capturing her lips in gentle kisses. She feels Catra exhale through her nose, and her throat makes a tiny noise.

Instead of pushing her away, Catra melts into her. She still has Adora's jaw cupped between her palms, fingers scratching her undercut behind her ears.

Adora got high once. It was the first time she, Glimmer, and Bow had hung out with Perfuma, and no one had told Adora that the brownies weren't the normal kind. So, she did the most Adora thing imaginable, and ate at least three of them, which – let's face it – was going to be an issue whether or not they were edibles.

She can't really compare that shitshow to what she is feeling right now, but there is something that makes it familiar. It is the loopy, bone-tired ecstasy that matches the confident certainty that everything is going to be okay.

It doesn't fade. Even when their lips pop apart for the last time and Catra breaks their kiss, it doesn't fade, because she drapes her arm over Adroa's shoulder and lies with her again.

Adora shouldn't ruin this, but if anyone could ruin it, it would be Adora.

She should keep quiet. She should hold Catra for as long as she is allowed to, not overstepping what she is already lucky to have. She should sink into this bliss, and let Catra's warmth lull her to sleep.

But then again–

Be a good girl and ask for what you want.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Oh my God"–

"Yes, I'm also a pillow talker. Suck it up." Adora swallows dry, gathering courage to ask quietly: "Why rule ten?"

Catra tenses in her arms. Adora eases her own hold, giving her an escape route. Catra doesn't take it, so Adora goes on, a little bolder:

"I just… I mean… you clearly don't have an issue with *giving* head. You're either a natural talent, or this wasn't your first rodeo, either." Catra scoffs. Adora believes she must be rolling her eyes, too. "That rule just... It always stood out to me."

"It's"… Catra sucks her teeth. All strength has poured out her voice, leaving it a quiet rumble. "Ugh, it's stupid."

"You don't have to tell me."

Adora feels Catra swallow. She fully expects her to keep quiet and avoid the conversation, but...

"My experiences are… different from yours," Catra says. Her hand comes up to Adora's throat, her thumb stroking along the sharp line of Adora's jaw. "Complete opposites. I've never had a normal relationship, a loving partner, any domestic shit like that. All I know is bad decisions, quick hookups, and wrong people."

Adora's hand twitches on Catra's back instinctively. Her nails are digging into her bare skin, dragging down the curve of her spine.

"Nothing bad happened," Catra hurries to add. The words sound sour in her mouth as she adds: "Not with this."

She takes a deep breath through her mouth. Adora cant see her face, but she assumes Catra is lost in thought somewhere Adora can't follow. She doesn't want Catra to be stuck there - she doesn't want her to have to go there ever again. She really, really fucking hates what Catra's words might imply, and it sets her chest on fire.

She needs to bring her back somehow.

So, she asks, carefully nudging:

"So is it a preference thing?"

It works. Catra shrugs, her throat makes a strangled noise.

"...yeah? W ell, no. Fuck, this is humiliating."

Catra cuddles even closer to her to hide. Adora really can't say she minds. She can feel the tip of Catra's nose pressing into the hollow of her throat, her silky curls tickling Adora's cheek.

Adora wants to say that's okay. She wants to remind her that she has always respected Adora's boundaries with penetration, and it's the same thing. She wants Catra to know that she would never, ever cross any lines like that even without a rule attached to it. She wants her to be able to trust her. She wants Catra to know that she would always take care of her.

She doesn't have a chance to say any of that out loud.

"I really don't mind going down on a girl," Catra says before Adora could open her mouth, grumbling with embarrassment. "But no one's...no one's gone down on *me* before."

Adora's jaw pops open. "*No* ."

"Yeah." Catra strokes up Adora's calf with the top of her foot. "Since all my hookups were... like that… I needed one thing to have control over. I needed to keep something for… for *someone* who isn't an asshole or whatever."

"Wait, huh?" Adora asks, confused. It takes her a couple moments of silence that Catra is not willing to break to catch on. "Wait, are you saying"—

"Don't say it."

"Aww, *Catra*"—

"Shut up."

"I can't believe you'd only let the love of your life eat you out, that's so romantic."

"Literally not what I said."

"You didn't have to. I was reading right between the lines."

"I regret ever talking to you," Catra says, then rolls on her back and sighs deeply. "So anyway . It's not like Ill ever get my pussy eaten."

Adora pokes Catra's shoulder. "Hey . Why would you say that?"

Catra laughs. It sounds hollow, sour. "Adora, you know me well enough by now. No one is ever going to love me."

Adora stays quiet for a moment; then she crawls out from under Catra, sits up on the bed and leans down to grab the pillow they left on the floor. She turns towards Catra – still laying there, cocking a brow – and slaps the pillow into her face with full force.

Catra's limbs fly into the air. She grabs the pillow Adora is still holding, pushing back.

"Adora, what the fuck?"

Adora doesnt let go of the pillow, and neither does Catra. They are both sitting on the bed now, scuffling like little kids. Adora would laugh if she werent so goddamn angry .

"Stop being a dumbass!" Adora raises her voice, shoving the pillow against Catra's face.

"What's wrong with you?" Catra asks, her voice squeaky with fury.

"What's wrong with me? What's wrong with *you*?"

Adora manages to snatch the pillow from Catra, just to fling it at her again. The pillow hits her in the stomach. Catra groans, and curls her whole body around it before Adora could take it back from her again.

"How can you say that?" Adora asks, still too loud and desperate. "How could you just sit there, looking absolutely perfect, and say that you're unlovable? Are you out of your mind? You're the most beautiful person I've ever met. You are so strong, and cunning, and smart, and funny, and I dont care how many layers of bullshit you want to mask it with, Catra Weaver, you're gentle and kind. So dont you dare look at me and say that no one could love you, when you have no idea how easy it is."

Adora's chest is heaving.

Catra is frozen, curled around the pillow. Her eyes are almost comically wide, her teeth glowing between her parted lips.

Adora swallows the panic that rises in her throat.

"Someone will go down on you," she says then, her voice tight and confident. "Trust me."

She sees Catra swallow, too.

Catra unfolds herself, and slowly puts the pillow back in its place. She is stalling.

Adora cant deal with the silence. "I'm sorry I yelled at you. And hit you with a pillow. Twice."

Finally, Catra laughs through her nose. "I've had worse."

She looks at Adora awkwardly, narrowing her eyes like she does every time she is thinking. It makes Adora grow cold and clammy like she is standing under a rain shower.

"I just—" Adora clears her throat, then starts again. "I hate when my friends talk badly about themselves. I got carried away. I'm sorry."

Catra's features tense before she relaxes again.

"It was sweet," she says, raspy and quiet. "Thanks for caring about that."

Adora shrugs. "Of course."

It is awkward again. Catra doesnt move to leave the bed, but Adora knows the time for cuddling is over.

"It's a shame" Catra starts slowly, considering every word she speaks, "that it's not enough to be loved." She holds Adora's gaze. "It needs to be the person I love, too."

Adora's throat is burning. She finds the words she wants to say, but she cant say them.

Asking for what you want can only go so far.

Catra rises. "I'm going to take a shower ."

"Okay ."

Once alone, Adora switches on the light. There is a dresser between the beds. Four drawers.

Adora unpacks her clothes. She doesnt need to. They are only staying for another night.

She circles around the room. There is not much to take in. Neat, small, empty.

Just like she feels.

*

When Adora awakes the next morning, she feels like someone hit her in the head with a hammer. She is groggy, her vision a little blurry.

She blinks the nightmares out of her eyes, and the view clears up. Catra is standing right by her bed, in front of an open drawer.

They look at each other.

"Hi," Adora says.

Catra's smile is melting Adora from the inside.

"Hey . Slept well?"

"Yeah," Adora lies, and throws the blanket off of herself. She sits at the side of the bed closest to Catra, and rests her elbows on her spread knees. "You?"

Catra shrugs. "Yeah."

Catra looks away. She starts gnawing at the inside of her cheek, fingers flexing where they curl into the drawer.

Adora cant take this. She has to know .

"Listen, I wa"–

"About last night"–

Adora clicks her jaw shut.

Catra does, too.

They stare at each other.

"Go on," Adora gestures awkwardly, trying to ooze confidence she definitely does not feel.

"About last night," Catra repeats, taking a deep breath. "I was just wondering if you were still okay with keeping that up."

Adora raises her brows.

"You mean"…

"I know you were the one who suggested it, but I just wanted to check if... If it's still something you'd be okay with."

"Would you?" Adora asks.

Catra smiles again. Her eyes are shining mischievously. "As a wise woman once told me, 'we don't have to go cold turkey'."

Adora snorts. Laughter bubbles out of her uncontrollably, pouring out with relief and the distinct aftertaste of disappointment.

She ignores the heartbreak, and laughs through.

"Yeah," Adora says, drawling the word from a chuckle. "She's right."

"She is. Sometimes."

Adora stands up and takes a careful step closer to Catra. She tilts her head, her tone shifting to serious, but kind. "Are you sure?"

Catra doesn't hesitate. "Yeah."

"So it's official," Adora grins, and raises a hand between them. "Friends with benefits."

Catra takes her hand.

"Friends with benefits. Until we get used to being just friends."

"Yes." Adora shakes on it, squeezing Catra's hand tighter. "Until then. And not a day longer."

*

Glimmer texts Adora that they are the only ones missing from breakfast. Catra still had to get dressed, so she sent Adora ahead.

Everyone is sitting at one, long table that is framed with same-length wooden benches. The kitchen connects to the bungalow at the other side, so Adora walks past the crowded table to grab a serving of scrambled eggs Bow has made, waving at everyone as she passes.

She comes back with a tray full of food and two cups of coffee. There are two empty seats at the end of the left bench, so Adora slides next to Perfuma and leaves the last seat empty for Catra.

"You look like shit," Mermista comments from across the table, eyes scanning all over Adora's face. "Let me guess. Couldnt sleep."

"Wow, detective skills,"Adora teases back.

Mermista grins.

"I keep telling them to keep it down, but at this point, lesbian sex is like, white noise to me."

Adora chomps down on a piece of toast with a loud crunch.

From the other end of the table, Netossa yells:

"I keep telling you, it's not us!"

"And I keep telling you" Mermista raises her voice with every word, "there is no other explanation. Last time I checked, you're the only two women here in a committed relationship."

"*We* are two women in a committed relationship," Perfuma huffs, gesturing between Scorpia and herself with both her palms up.

"Yeah, but you haven't fucked yet," Mermista says so casually, like she's talking about the weather. "It's obvious."

"Wow, you're good," Scorpia says.

"We're taking it slow!" Perfuma says.

"I'm just not ready," Scorpia adds solemnly.

"It's still not us." Adora can almost see the smoke coming from Netossa's ears.

"Process of elimination," Mermista says, crossing her arms on the table. "Seriously, if it's not you two, then who—"

"Hey."

Adora turns in her seat, her whole face brightening.

Catra seems to have appeared out of thin air, looking like a punk daydream in her tiny ripped shorts and loose tank top. She plops down next to Adora, scooting close to her. "What'd I miss?"

Adora's heart swells. She hands Catra one of the coffees. She made it just how she likes it; one sugar, double cream. Lactose-free, of course. Adora had packed a box of lactose-free stuff for her.

"Thanks," Catra mutters, smiling at her as she takes a sip.

She reaches for Adora's fork then, and dives in. Adora slides the tray closer to Catra, and spins it so Catra can take the other slice of toast she grabbed.

Adora leans on the table, resting her chin in her palm. Catra looks a little ruffled, but absolutely gorgeous. She must have had a difficult night, too. It was late by the time they stopped fucking and talking, and with how much Adora had tossed and turned, she imagines it wasn't easy to fall asleep next to her.

A fork clatters.

Adora winces, raising her head. Has no one said anything since Catra arrived?

That can't be true. She must have zoned out.

Catra looks up as well, ripping a piece off of her toast. She narrows her eyes suspiciously. "Why is everyone looking at me?"

Adora's gaze glides down to Catra's lips, and she grins. Her voice is wavering with suppressed laughter. "Probably because you have scrambled eggs on your face."

"Oh." Catra tips her pretty face towards Adora. "Where?"

Adora cups Catra's jaw so she can wipe the piece of scrambled egg off with a swipe of her thumb. Her touch reaches Catra's lips in the process. It takes an unholy amount of resistance to draw back, but Adora does.

"Thanks," Catra says again.

Before Adora - or anyone else - could say anything (*why does no one want to say anything?*), Catra's phone starts ringing in her pocket.

Catra takes the phone out and peeks at the screen.

“Shit, sorry,” she says, sliding off the bench. “It’ s my agent. I have to take this.”

Once Catra has left the bungalow and pushed the heavy door closed behind herself, Adora twirls back in her seat towards the others. She grabs their fork and lifts a huge bite of eggs to her mouth when she looks up.

Now with Catra gone, everyone is looking at *her*.

“...What?”

Chapter End Notes

Miss me?

Those who follow me on Twitter have already seen this coming. Those who are subbed to the story but do not follow me - surprise!I hope you felt excited the notification landing in your inbox. I know it has been a long time;I had other fics, projects, commissions, shit like that but I am *not* abandoning this story for anything. No matter how long it takes me to upload, I am finishing this, and my love for She-Ra and Catradora has never faded.

Since I last updated, I added a little extra story titled "Take Two" which you can find in the hilariously named Stunt Fuckery series. It is a oneshot smut with some background info and fun times and dynamics - essentially it is a deleted scene from Chapter 3, between the rooftop talk with Lonnie and the gym session with Huntara.

Thank you so much for staying here, thank you so much for supporting this story. I love all your kudos and subs and comments, thank you for your love and for your time.

Come hang out with me on Twitter, I'm usually nice. And I tweet lots of shit about my WIPs and stuff, it's a fun time.

Rule #11

Chapter Summary

11. We are not exclusive.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What the fuck do you want?" Catra barks into her phone, stomping further away from the dining bungalow.

The sun is crawling high on the horizon, hiding behind nodding palm trees. The soft sand is still cool under Catra's bare soles as they sink in deeper with every hurried step she takes.

"Aw, someone got up on the wrong side of bed," Dee purrs on the other end of the line. "What's wrong, Kitten? Aren't you enjoying yourself on the beach with your new friends?"

Catra halts in the shadow of a tall palm tree and slides a hand up the trunk.

"How do you know about that?"

"Don't worry your pretty head about it," Dee says dismissively. "I must confess, it was quite the surprise. Here I was, fully trusting that my partner in crime was doing her part, and then? What a ruse, Kitten. I feel betrayed."

"I told you, Adora is not like you and me," Catra says. "You can't manipulate her with money, fame, or fear. You have to go for her heart."

"Marvelous plan." Dee's voice grows high, before they drop it an octave lower to continue. "Except. Your last scene was a *mess*,

darling."

"No it wasn't!" Catra snaps, her voice wavering with fury. "We did everything perfectly. Then you gave me the fucking *silent treatment*, Dee. Am I supposed to just read your mind or what?"

"You know what I asked of you," Dee replies, simple and dry. "Don't tell me you already forgot *why* you're doing this. Is it time for me to refresh your memory again, Kiten?"

Catra's grip tightens around the phone, her fingers shaking. She loops her free arm around her waist, hugging herself tight.

She feels queasy.

"Fuck you," she spits. Her words don't hold any strength, tumbling off her tongue like she is throwing them up.

Dee sighs.

"That's always the easy way out, isn't it?" Their voice is rumbling down Catra's throat, suffocating her. "Turning against those who have done nothing but hurt you. People never really cared about you, have they? Your exes, your fake friends, your hookups, your bosses... your mother."

"Shut up," Catra says. She hates the way her voice breaks. She hates the way her body is frozen, she hates how she can't bring herself to just hang up and give no fucks about what they are saying.

She stays there, rooted to the spot, and listens.

She has no other choice.

"Face it, Kiten. Everyone leaves you. No one has ever thought you were worth keeping around. No one has ever cared about what you wanted."

"Enough."

"Blame it on us all you want, darling, it doesn't change who you really are." Dee pauses, waiting for more objections. Catra stays quiet. Her ears are ringing; all she can hear is the devilish grin around Dee's words. "You are full of anger and venom. You poison everyone around you, you drive them all away. But you already knew that, didn't you? You know that no one would ever truly love you like you loved them. That's why you moved in with me back then, isn't it? To leave that all behind? Your hometown, your enemies, your abusers. You agreed to *my* terms now because I am offering you exactly what you always wanted - an escape. The chance to be famous enough to be untouchable. To climb the ladder high enough that it doesn't matter what they are trying to do to you. How they try to control you, destroy you, tear you apart. You will be above them all. You promised yourself a long time ago that you would always look out for yourself, because no one else ever would. What would that little girl tell you right now, hm?"

Catra is breathing in and out in shaky sighs. Her heart is pulsing in her neck. She is trying to focus on the sloshing waves, but they all drip into cyan-white, gleaming shapes.

She is slipping.

She can't speak.

Dee chuckles at her silence. Something creaks; it's the sound of them moving in their chair to get even more comfortable.

"Do you really think she's any different?" They ask mockingly.

Catra squeezes her eyes shut before the welling tears bubble over, salty and cold like seawater.

"No," Catra croaks, defeated but stubborn. "I don't."

"Then why are you trying to fuck me over for her?" Dee asks, silky-sweet. "I'm not your enemy, Kitten. Why are you protecting her from

me instead of working with me? You know I would never lie to you. I pinky promised to help you get exactly what you want."

"You don't give a shit about what I want," Catra says. "You think Adora is the same as everyone else? So are you. You made sure I knew that."

"Are you still hung up on that?" Dee sighs again. "We were young, and you wanted the kind of friendship I simply didn't have the time for. I did my very best to help you. I gave you a chance to leave that sinkhole of a city, I gave you a place to stay."

"I busted my ass working three jobs to finally become independent while you were out all the time partying," Catra says.

"Networking," Dee corrects coolly. Catra is under their skin now.

"Right, whatever you want to call 'getting drunk on Catra's money and trying to fuck everyone you met."

"I knew you were jealous."

"I was fucking pissed. You used me, Dee."

"Ten, when have I ever said that we were serious?" Dee's voice grows quieter as they lean away from their phone for a quick exchange with someone. They couldn't give less fucks about what Catra has to say. "You were a lovely little plaything, but you are broken. And it's not me who broke you."

Catra's throat closes up. She bumps her temple against the palm tree and croaks: "No. But you didn't help either. You just kept me around until you figured out why I was fucking broken beyond repair, and used it against me to hurt me even more."

"I wanted you to see clearly." Dee sounds utterly bored as they sigh. Their voice strains, like they had thrown their head back. "Whatever. You'll believe what you want to believe. Just remember - right now, I

am giving you the future you have always dreamed about. A peace offering. Or an apology. Call it whatever you want. And in return, all I asked of you was to stoke the fire in Adora's heart that is so, so passionate about hating you. It's really not a huge, cruel favor to ask if you think about it."

Catra keeps quiet.

Dee keeps pressing:

"I'm not asking you to hurt Adora by keeping her away from the beautiful *mess* that you are, am I? You can still save her from yourself before you poison her too. She doesn't deserve that, the poor thing. It's an act of kindness, really." They pause again. Catra will not give them the satisfaction of replying. Dee smacks their lips. "Of course, you don't *have* to do anything. You know that, right?"

Catra scoffs.

"Right. You'll just keep trying to rile her up and get her so wrapped up in her own head that she doesn't even know who she is anymore. If you think I'll just fucking let that happen—"

Dee chuckles, cutting Catra off.

"What?" Catra snaps.

"Thank you, Kitten," Dee says. "That is all I wanted to know."

Blood rushes out of Catra's face. Fuck.

Fuck.

"You're wrong, though," Dee continues, their voice dripping like honey. "I would never ruin Adora. I quite like her, you know. I like her enough that I think… if you want to call it quits, then she deserves the truth."

Catra bares her teeth.

“What truth?”

“Well, you know” Dee drawls, “about the whole thing. Who you are, what you've done. How you lied to her and played her for fame and your own gain. Stuff like that.”

The sun breaks through the nodding palm leaves. It burns Catra’s skin like laser beams.

She swallows, gaining back the strength of her voice. She isn't given the chance to use it.

“It’s my word against yours. What would Adora think of you?” Dee muses, humming in thought.

Catra’s throat is burning, like she had swallowed the sunlight. She presses the heel of her palm to her eye, rubbing it rough.

She won't let Dee make her cry. Not again.

“Are you done?”

“Not even close. But I think I have given you enough to think about for today. Go back to your lovely friends, Kiten, and enjoy the sun. I'll see you soon enough.”

And with that, Dee hangs up.

Catra drops her hand with the phone in it.

She can't hear the rumbling of the waves over her heartbeat anymore. The whites and blues drip into each other as her sorrow bubbles up.

She lets the tears fall - but her expression doesn't break. She is standing there, in the burning sun and the cool sand and the salty wind, and her tears are streaming down her face, but she won't move a fucking muscle to show any emotion.

She *wont* .

*

Catra's mind is still in a blender as she is walking back to the dining bungalow. It feels like she left hours ago, but in reality barely ten minutes have passed since she got the phone call, mostly spent getting her shit together afterwards.

It is fucking unfair, how Dee still manages to grab and twist her where it hurts the most. It's fucking unfair that she knows they are not right, and yet–

Well.

Are they?

Catra takes the first step of the stairs that lead to the bungalow door.

Why would Adora trust her? Sure, they are friends… friends with *benefits*, now, but that doesnt mean that Adora has just forgotten everything that Catra's defensive, distant hostility has caused them over the years.

Adora is still afraid of coming close to her; Catra can see the fear in her. Adora is careful, tiptoeing around her, like she is afraid that Catra is going to explode at any minute, and everything would be back to how things were, because Catra has no self control, and she is not truly capable of change.

Maybe nothing has changed. Not really.

Catra doesnt expect that Adora's feelings have changed so massively over the past few weeks.

Catra's feelings havent changed. She feels the same way about Adora now as she has felt for a long, long time. All that has changed was her attitude, not her heart. The way she talks to her has changed, but not the words she has always wanted to say out loud. The way she lets herself softly touch her has changed, not the burning longing she is doing it with.

She just stopped lying to herself. Started "keeping her heart open," or whatever the fuck Perfuma said to her when Catra had stayed over.

Was it a mistake?

She takes the next step.

Catra let too many of her cards show, which wont just delight Dee, but inspire them to try and pull some new shit. She needs to be more careful about the game she is playing.

There is not a snowball's chance in hell that she will just give up what she has been doing to keep Dee away from Adora. She might need to take some slaps from Dee to make them believe that she is under their thumb again, but if that's the price to keep Adora safe, then so be it.

She's had worse. Hell, she's had worse from Dee back in the day. She can take it.

She takes the last step.

Adora is different. She has to be.

Catra has been stupid before, trusting people she shouldnt have, but there is one thing she has never felt for anyone else, ever in her life. Even in her naivest state and darkest hours, she never, ever gave her heart away to anyone.

She never wanted anyone. No one was worth it, that much she has always seen clearly.

Adora is different.

Catra walks to the heavy door on weightless feet, not making a sound on the creaky planks that cover the veranda. She hooks a finger in the pull handle and opens the door a crack when something stops her.

Adora's voice.

Adora's *furious* voice.

"Cant you just drop it?"Adora asks, slamming her fist on the table.

Several people start talking at the same time. Catra can't make out much of what they are saying;her focus is not on them, anyway .

Adora springs to her feet, and brings her hands to her ears to cover some of the noise while she yells over everyone: "For the last time, Catra and I are *just friends*, and nothing more - never have been, never will be!Okay? *Never*."

Catra's heart drops into her stomach.

She releases the handle and lets the door click closed. It swallows most of the ruckus, but she can still make out Adora's voice as she raises it with growing anger and frustration.

Catra has heard enough.

*

She doesn't even have to pack. She had only used the drawer to shove her backpack in, still full of clothes and underwear. All she has to do is drag it out, unzip it and throw it on the cold linoleum of the bathroom while she scatters her toiletries, brush and towels into it.

The towels are still wet, reminding Catra once again how little time has passed since she was so content while glued to Adora's side, sipping the coffee Adora had made just for her.

She rubs her eyes with a grunt. Fuck this. She won't cry again.

She meets her eyes in the mirror hanging above the sink. Her hair is curling all over the place from the humidity and her eyes are red, the bags under them endless and deep.

Catra sniffs with a grimace, looking away.

She punches the towel that got the zipper stuck, and zips the backpack up. She throws it halfway onto her shoulder, eager to just get the fuck out of this place.

She slams the door open so hard it bounces back from the wall, and she has to kick it again. The planks of the veranda cry out under her stomping soles.

Instead of following the curly paths, Catra cuts through the grass and makes a beeline towards the gate. She is still pretty far away when she notices that there is a familiar figure standing there, leaning against the huge wooden column.

Catra picks up the pace, dragging the backpack higher on her shoulder. She doesn't look at her.

When Catra passes by, Glimmer speaks up.

"I knew you were a coward."

"Shut up," Catra hisses, halting in her steps. She doesn't turn back. "Don't talk to me like you know me. You don't know anything about

me.”

“I know enough,” Glimmer says, pushing herself away from the column. Her voice matches Catra’s fury. “Adora is not the only one who had to put up with the pleasure of knowing you for three years.”

“Sparkles.” The nickname is a warning, and Glimmer ignores it.

“So what’s your plan? Hm? Running away isn’t going to magically fix everything for you.”

Catra turns back now, clinging to the strap of the backpack as she faces her.

“What do you even care?” She asks, quiet and cold. "You hate me because I'm an asshole. I'm aware. Don't need to make a big thing out of it."

"No, I don't *like* you because you're an asshole," Glimmer says, crossing her arms under her chest. "I'm going to *hate* you if you hurt my best friend. And not only that; if you break Adora's heart, I am going to make your life a living hell."

Glimmer comes closer and tries to tower over her on her tiptoes, wearing what is probably her most fearsome war expression, and curling her tiny hands into fists. She also thinks Catra has any power over Adora's heart, apparently.

It’s hilarious.

So, Catra laughs. "You think you're the first person to threaten me? You're not even the first to threaten me *today*." Catra cocks her head, and leans closer to Glimmer's face. Glimmer backs down. Catra grins. "Wanna ruin my life? Get in line."

Catra straighteners and turns her back to Glimmer. When she starts walking again, Glimmer follows her across the parking lot like a fucking shadow.

"So that's it?" She screeches. It hurts Catra's ears. "Seriously?"

"What do you want me to do?" Catra asks. "You're here to nag me, so clearly you know why I'm leaving." Her voice turns sour. "It's better for everyone if I'm not here."

"Catra—" Glimmer twirls in front of her, raising a hand to make her stop.

With a growl, she does.

"*What?"* Catra is yelling now, which is not a great look for someone who wanted to sneak out without being noticed. She didn't care anymore. Something has snapped within her, and she is done trying to chain it down. "No one wants me here! Not you, not any of your little friends, not Adora—" Her voice cracks, the words dying on her tongue.

Something shimmers in Glimmer's eyes. It painfully resembles compassion.

Catra snaps her head away so she doesn't have to see it.

"You know what my last fight with Adora was about?" Glimmer doesn't pause to wait for an answer. "How she's been ignoring all her friends just to spend more time with you. She organized this whole getaway because of that fight, and she *still* had to drag you along. So I can't fucking escape you."

Catra almost laughs, but settles for a breathy grin and a sniff. Glimmer is smiling, too. Catra is still not looking at her, but she can hear it in her voice.

"I'm pretty sure that if you had said no, she wouldn't even be here. Or if she were here, she wouldn't be nearly as happy as she is now. And yes, that was a really painful thing for me to admit." Glimmer moves to face Catra again, urging Catra to look at her. "Do one good thing in your life, and don't mess this up."

Catra takes a deep breath. Before she could say anything, she hears her own name coming from behind her; the first time, it sounds soft, questioning. The second time, it is desperate and confused.

Quick steps close in on the two of them, flip-flop sandals slapping the asphalt.

"Are you leaving?" Adora asks breathlessly, halting with a little, stumbling slide. "Wait. Why? Are you okay? What happened?"

Catra meets Glimmer's eyes.

"No," she says, raspy and quiet. "I'm not leaving."

Glimmer sucks her lips in to fight a smile.

Adora is yet to calm down.

"But... your backpack... I- I don't understand."

Catra's gaze falls on her now. Adora looks ruffled; her ponytail a little messy, her cheeks a little rosy, her eyes a little glossy.

Catra wants to kiss the trembles off her lips.

"I was just going to the store. I wanted to fill up on some lactose free stuff cause I forgot to pack my pills. Sparkles here offered me company."

Catra cant see it, but she can feel Glimmer rolling her eyes. It makes her smirk.

"Oh!" Adora's face brightens up. "I actually brought you a bunch of stuff, not just the cream for your coffee."

Where Catra's smirk melts, her face heats up. "You did?"

"Yeah." Adora bites her lip shyly, and reaches out a hand. "I can show you."

Catra releases the strap of her backpack and slides her palm into Adora's.

Adora's fingers clasp around hers, soft and tight.

"Sure, Princess," Catra says, making Adora's blush darken. "Lead the way."

As Adora pulls her along on bouncy steps, Catra twists her neck and looks back at Glimmer over her shoulder.

Glimmer puts her finger in her mouth, making a quiet gagging noise. Even the grimace can't hide her grin.

Catra sticks her tongue out at her.

For the first time since the phone call, Catra feels like she can breathe.

*

It's hard to breathe again.

The salty wind is blowing so hard that it covers Catra's mouth and nose like the palm of a huge hand, suffocating her. Her whole face is freezing into a desperate grimace, teeth clicking together. She wishes that she had worn anything else but her black chiffon capelet and ripped shorts over her swimsuit.

Catra's fingers curl around the railing so tightly that her knuckles are whitening. She tries to squeeze her eyes shut, but that only makes things worse when the floor bucks under her again, making her knees knock into each other.

She feels like her stomach is not where her stomach is supposed to be anymore.

"Fuck's sake," she grumbles to herself, trying to swallow the sickness.

"Not a fan of boats?" Adora appears on her left, sliding her hand on the rail right next to Catra's. Her voice is teasing, but the concern on her face is genuine. "Are you okay?"

"Mm-hm," Catra hums through gritted teeth.

A wave lifts the bow higher, and Catra yelps. She stumbles without moving her hands from the rail, knocking into Adora who wraps an arm around her waist instinctively and holds her close to her chest.

Catra looks up at her, eyes round and wide. Their faces are so close with Catra tucked right under Adora's chin; the warmth radiating off Adora's body is like huddling up by a fireplace against the cold wind.

If Catra craned her neck, their lips would meet.

If Catra had a choice, she would move.

Adora quirks a brow; it is clear when realization starts to pour down on her as her expression mimics Catra's.

"S-sorry," she says, pulling away quickly. "I just—yeah. Sorry. Um."

"It's ok—" The next wave pulls on Catra's stomach, hauling it up into her throat. Catra's eyes bulge and she lifts a finger, asking for time.

She is not going to fucking throw up right in front of the most good-looking woman she has ever known in her entire life. It's just not happening. Not now, not today, not after every nightmare scene she's gone through since breakfast. No.

Adora pouts kindly at Catra hanging her head, trying to hide behind her wild hair. Catra can't even imagine what color her face must be

by now, but it’s sure as hell nothing attractive.

Sickness washing over her (for a while) again, Catra raises her cocked jaw and breathes out in a huff. “*Jesuschrist*.”

“I’m so sorry,” Adora says, tilting her head. Her ponytail flows off her shoulder. The wind clings to it, flapping it above the sea like a flag. “I didn’t know you were gonna be seasick.”

Catra's nails are scratching the metal.

She is *never* letting this goddamn railing go.

“Why the hell did you all want to rent a boat to go to an island when the camp is *literally* right by the beach?”

Adora laughs, heaving a fist in front of her in a half-circle. “Adventure?” She asks in her best Seahawk expression.

Seahawk, obviously, is delighted by the fact that he can sail the boat all by himself.

He also steers like a madman.

“Can’t he just slow the fuck down a bit?” Catra asks. A pathetic whine is pulling on her words, but she can’t bring herself to care.

“I’ll ask him,” Adora says decisively, pulling away.

Catra whips her head back, following her. “Wait.”

Adora halts. She catches Catra’s stare.

Catra casts her eyes down.

“Stay,” she asks gently. “It…it helps. If you’re here.”

Adora’s smile is impossibly soft, her gorgeous voice hopeful. “Yeah?”

Catra shrugs, like she couldn't be sure. Like it wouldn't really matter.

Adora's smile doesn't fade. She encircles an arm around Catra's waist again, catching on quickly — probably for the first damn time in her life.

Catra bumps her forehead into Adora's sternum, breathing out shaky and slowly. She doesn't turn towards her, instead tightening her hold on the slippery rail. She keeps her eyes open, trying to sink into Adora's warmth. She focuses on their bodies touching - Adora's arm snaking around her protectively, Adora's hand and lips in her hair. Adora's fingers furrow deeper into Catra's curls, cradling her skull.

Everyone can see you. The others are right there is a thought that barely rushes through Catra's mind before she shoves it aside. So what? Adora made sure they all know that there is nothing going on between the two of them; and there isn't. Friends hug. Friends help each other when they feel sick.

Friends kiss into each other's hair as they pull each other closer, until every breath they take is a tight drag of chest against shoulder.

Friends want to die when their touch on each other's skin is too fragile, too delicate, like it means something.

Catra imagines that there is no swaying boat, just Adora and her; Adora rocking her in her arms, not the waves washing at them. Adora whispering into her ear, not the whistling wind.

And then, Adora is whispering into her ear. "Better?"

Catra turns her head, so her ear is pressed flat against Adora's chest. Adora's heart is deafening, beating to the rhythm of war drums. It makes Catra's own flare up, blooming red all over her body.

The others are laughing behind them. Their voices whirl into the whistles of the wind, and Catra's whole body tenses before she melts against Adora's chest again.

The Catra she has always been would snap and snarl, seething in her own furious pity, demanding answers.

But the Catra she is apparently becoming doesn't care if they are laughing at her or not. If being held by Adora is what it means to be the butt of the joke, she will gladly be it.

"Yeah," Catra says. She turns towards Adora now, nuzzling deeper into her chest like she wanted to hide behind her ribs. "I'm okay."

Trembling hands release the railing, and Catra wraps her arms around Adora, nails digging into the valley of her spine in a desperate attempt to bring her even closer.

She hears Adora's gasp, quiet and full of awe. The lump in Catra's throat grows thorns as she says, barely louder than the wind:

"Thank you."

*

They spend a whole day on the tiny island Adora had suggested for the group to go check out. It's pretty magical, despite the horrifying boat ride.

Catra thought that the seas couldn't have gotten any bluer, the sand any softer. She was wrong.

The camp they are staying at sits in a narrow bay, which makes it almost cozy; baby blue water and sand like golden flakes. Here, the waves are painted hundreds of shades - azure and cerulean and teal, wrapped in laces of foam.

They spend all morning hiking, climbing the highest cliff in the middle of the island. Seahawk and Adora started to race on the wide,

curving paths, shrieking and pushing each other like idiot kids. Pebbles creaking, sand slipping under their soles, and no railings around the edges, Catra is almost certain one of them is going to end up breaking their neck.

The others don't seem to share her concerns. Glimmer is the next one to join, then Netossa, Spinerella, Scorpia, and lastly, Bow, who is mostly yelling "stop" and "you're all going to die" instead of caring about the game itself.

After a couple twists and turns, the group runs out of earshot, and all the noise dies out. With a shudder, Catra is terribly aware of the fact that she is left alone with two people she barely knows. And she has a feeling one of those two people is not a fan of her at all.

"Idiots. All of them," Mermista breaks the silence, sneaking a peek at Catra. "Didn't you wanna go?"

Catra narrows her eyes.

"I'm not an idiot."

"You always want to win."

"I also value my life." Catra waits until Mermista rolls her eyes, but she seems like she got all of the answers she needed. "Why didn't you?"

Mermista smirks.

"I value my updo."

Despite herself, Catra laughs. "Bullshit."

"She's serious," Perfuma chimes in, walking up to them with her hands crossed behind her back. "Last time we went camping, Mermista left her scalp recovery serum at home. Seahawk had to take her home and drive her back in the middle of the night."

"I'm not an animal, Miss Shoes-Are-Like-Nooses-For-Y our-Feet."

Perfuma gasps, offended. "I never said that!"

"Really? I could've sworn that was your T witter handle."

Perfuma barks a little dismissive *ah*, and throws her hands up as she picks up her pace to leave them both behind.

Mermista watches her stomping away with a shit-eating grin, and for the second time since they've been on vacation, Catra wonders if she could actually do this - if she could be friends with Adora's friends.

Lost in that thought, Catra awakens with Mermista's curious eyes scanning her face and below.

"What?"

Mermista honest to god blushes, snapping her eyes away. "Nothing."

"What?"

"Nothing! I just—nothing. Okay? It's nothing."

"Right," Catra says, but she decides to drop it. Now that she is alone with Mermista of all people, she knows this is an opportunity that she has to take. So, she asks, as casually as she can: "Hey, so. How long have all of you guys known each other?"

They have almost reached the peak by now. Catra can hear the others' voices again, chatting and laughing somewhere above them. The path has disappeared under their feet, leaving flat, slippery pumice stone to walk on for the last thirty feet up.

"I dunno," Mermista says, grunting with effort. It's less strolling, and more climbing now, which she clearly doesn't enjoy as much. "A couple years, maybe two, three? I was kind of the last person they

recruited for their gay little troop. Like, apart from Scorpia. And now, you."

No matter how hard Catra tries to decipher Mermista's tone as hostile or disappointed, she just sounds… normal. It urges Catra to go on, and to ignore the promise of belonging that leaves her heart fluttering.

"Wow. How do you cope?"

"Ugh, it's like herding cats. You saw what happened. Whenever they're together, one of them - usually Adora, obviously - starts something *stupid* and then—" Mermista slips on a pebble, rolling off under her chunky platform sneakers. "Shit."

Catra grabs her by the arm, pulling her up. Mermista straightens again. Her butterfly sunglasses slipped to the tip of her nose.

"Thanks."

Catra doesn't let her go. Mermista's eyes grow a little wide, not hidden behind dark lenses anymore, but Catra keeps her smile radiant like the sun beaming down at them, her clutch on Mermista's arm firm but gentle.

"She starts something stupid, huh?" Catra asks, silky-sweet. "Like the macaroni story?"

Mermista laughs, throwing her head back. Her sunglasses slip back onto the curved bridge of her nose. "Oh my god, yes. You heard the macaroni story?"

"I did. It wasn't funny."

"What?" Mermista's grin stays plastered on. "Dude, come on. She literally believed—"

"Adora is not stupid." Catra can feel her smile fade and her fingers twitch. She doubles her efforts to curl her lips and keep her voice

light. "She's too kind. She will let you fuck with her at her own expense, taking all that shit if it makes you guys happy." *Now* she clutches Mermista's arm with a little more force, and tilts her head as she squints at her. "But I'm not kind."

Mermista yanks her arm back, and Catra lets her. Before she can say anything, the sound of quick footsteps distracts them both.

Catra turns towards the noise, and sees Adora slipping down the stones so casually like she was running around on a parquet floor in fluffy socks, still giving zero fucks about the possibility of breaking her neck.

How she survived being a stunt performer for so long remains a mystery.

"Hey, you're here!" She laughs, breathing a little heavily. Her cheeks and neck are adorably flushed, thin strands of gold have escaped her tight ponytail to flutter around her face. "Everything okay?"

From the corner of her eyes, Catra shoots Mermista a glance. Mermista is pouting, her blush is back, but she gives her a little nod. *Okay, fine, got it.*

"All good, hot–" Catra bites her words, crossing her arms under her chest. She tries to play off her traitor tongue like she just swallowed funnily.

"I won," Adora blurts out then, way too proud to notice anything subtle. Her eyes never leave Catra's, clinging to them like nothing else matters. "I reached the top first."

Catra laughs, shaking her head affectionately. She shrugs off the straps of her backpack, dropping them to the crease of her elbows so she can reach back and pull out a bottle of water. "Think fast, champion."

Adora bumps the back of her hand into the flying bottle, flipping it mid-air. She manages to catch it between her forearms as it dives back down. "Ha!"

"Can't lose today , can you?" Catra teases, pulling her backpack up.

Adora twists the cap off, trying her best to drink while she's grinning so widely her lips can't quite close around the mouth of the bottle. Water pours down on her chin, and Adora wipes it off with the back of her hand.

"Maybe I just want to impress someone so bad."

Catra clicks her tongue, crossing her arms. "I *knew* I saw some sparks between you and Seahawk."

Adora wheezes the ugliest laugh. "Yeah, you got me. It's him. It's always been him."

Catra is a sensible person, she thinks. She knows teasing, she knows jokes, and she knows facts about Adora; and factually, she is the biggest lesbian in the history of lesbians. And yet, completely irrationally, her chest decides to tighten, keeping her last breath of air in captivity.

Catra turns her head. Everyone is gathering on the other side with a better view, closer to the rumbles of the sea. Glimmer leans her head on Bow's chest, looping her arm around his. Mermista props her elbow on Seahawk's shoulder, and he tips his head to press a kiss to her hand. Netossa has her arm wrapped around Spinny's waist, holding her close. Scorpia and Perfuma are holding hands, fingers entwined.

With her head still turned away, Catra says: "Kiss me."

"I– w-what?" Adora sounds just as dumbfounded as interested. "Now? Right here?"

Catra turns back to her, and takes a step closer to feel the humid heat radiating off Adora's perfect body. Her stormy eyes are already on Catra's lips, pupils blown out.

Catra cant take any chances. If Adora rejects her now , she will die.

"Why? Are you scared?"

Adora leans down, and brushes her lips against hers.

It is barely a kiss. The pressure of Adora's lips is hardly there; a shaky, shallow breath slipping into Catra's mouth.

Catra is having none of it. She presses closer, the tip of her nose smudging on Adora's cheek. Adora makes a broken noise deep in the back of her throat, and it vibrates through Catra's whole body. Adora parts her lips to give Catra a kitten lick between hers, the tips of their tongues barely touching. Yet, Catra is burning.

Something slams to the ground with a heavy thud, then starts bubbling. Catra and Adora flutter apart, and Catra's eyes immediately latch to the source of the noise - Adora dropped the bottle of water.

"Shit," Adora hisses, crouching quickly . She manages to pick up the bottle with minimal waste, and starts brushing off the dirt.

"What are you two messing with back there?" Glimmer shouts, waving them over. "Come here, I wanna take a group selfie!"

"Sorry ," Adora shouts back. Her whole face is in flames. "I dropped my bottle."

She straightens. Their eyes meet.

"Um"…

"Let' s go," Catra says, snatching the bottle and the cap from Adora's hands. She drags her backpack down again, sliding the bottle inside,

now tightly closed.

She doesnt dare look at Adora as she walks towards the group and plants herself firmly by Scorpia's side on the far left. Adora's blush would be contagious, like her laughter; as soon as Catra feels her cheeks cool down, seeing Adora's pretty pink face would make warmth spill all over her again.

She forces herself to grin while they take the picture, but doesnt bother checking out how it looks while everyone else crowds around Glimmer. They end up taking six more, because everyone else has issues with the angle and how it makes them look, and Catra is smiling through them all.

The next two hours run past her in a blur. She keeps herself glued to Scorpia's side, the only person in the whole group who Catra doesnt feel threatened by. It is funny, actually; Catra's best friend seems to be the person who knows the least about her, thus making herself perfect for Catra to hang around. Catra feels the bile of guilt sticking to her throat because of it, but right now she cannot be bothered to be open and honest and vulnerable with Scorpia.

At first, she didnt tell her about Adora because Scorpia wouldnt have understood. She wouldnt approve of Catra fucking someone she claimed to hate, ruining her own chances at relationships. Catra has always been self-destructive, and every time Scorpia had stepped up to support her against her instincts, Catra had lashed out. She's never truly forgiven herself for that.

Now, she doesnt tell her about Adora because she wouldnt be able to lie about it anymore.

Catra blinks up to find Scorpia standing by Catra's beach towel, hands on each side of her hips. Scorpia is looking at her expectantly, and it becomes clear to Catra that she might have been talking to her this whole time.

"Sorry , what?"

"I said Fuma and I are going into the water, playing ball a bit with the squad." Scorpia throws her head to the side, pointing behind her with her chin. Catra follows the direction, eyes finding a couple people banding together with a beach ball: Perfuma, Seahawk, Mermista, and Glimmer. "You should come, too!"

Panic spikes in Catra's chest. Either she's alone again, or she has to go back to socializing with the people who she would rather stay far, far away from for a while.

She chooses the lesser of two evils.

"No, thanks. You have fun, though."

Scorpia tilts her head, short hair falling into her eyes.

"Are you sure you're okay there, Wildcat? You've been acting a little weird since—"

"I'm fine, Scorp," Catra cuts in a little sharper than she intended. She tries to soften it with a smile, hoping it reaches her eyes. "Seriously, don't worry. I'd just rather stay here and chill than take a beach ball in the face."

"Alright, whatever floats your boat," Scorpia says with her hands in the air, sounding cheerful again. "But join us whenever you want!"

"Okay."

As Catra watches Scorpia jog to the group, Adora walks right in front of her with Bow and Netossa.

Adora peeks over at her in secret, eyes widening as their eyes lock. Catra doesn't let her gaze go. She wants to, but she can't. She follows her with her eyes, just like Adora's whole torso twists as the three of them walk past Catra.

When Adora has to walk backwards to keep eye contact, she stumbles on a mound of sand.

Catra bites into her lip, stifling a laugh. Adora's whole face brightens, shooting her a little wave. Catra flicks her fingers back at her, and decides to spare her, turning back to the others playing in the water.

She doesnt get to sink into loneliness; her phone buzzes with a text, then another one right after.

Catra rolls on her side and grabs her phone, unlocking it with a click.

Her chest flares up like wildfire.

Thickskull

Meet me at the first intersection on the way up the hill in 15
Dont tell anyone!;)
14:57

Catra looks after Adora again. She can see her holding her phone with both hands, fingers drumming on the case. She is trying really hard to be an active participant in the conversation with Bow and Netossa; every second though, her pale lashes will flutter, glancing down and back up, down and up.

Catra smiles devilishly.

yeah?
what for?
14:57

Adora looks at her with the cutest pout. Catra grins even wider, shrugging.

Adora buries her face into her phone, and starts typing furiously.

I wanted to talk to you about something.
And take you somewhere. It's important.
Please?
14:58

Catra's stomach twists at those words, sinking like a stone. She hates everything about this, but she hates even more that she knows she wont be able to say no.

ok, fine. go ahead
14:58

Catra locks her phone and pushes herself up from the towel. She puts her ripped shorts back on over her swimsuit and slips her phone into her pocket. She walks to the seafront barefoot, and raises her voice.

"Hey Scorp!"

Mermista slams the ball right in front of Scorpia, splashing her from head to waist. Everybody laughs while Scorpia shakes her hair out of her face, and gestures towards Catra.

"Wildcat! Are you gonna join?"

"Not a chance," Catra shouts back, crossing her arms under her chest. "Come out here a bit so I don't have to yell?"

"Oh yeah, yeah, sure."

Scorpia starts walking through the waves, fighting to hurry with half her body underwater. Catra is waiting for her not so patiently; she can't stop her feet from tapping on the sand.

"What's up?" Scorpia pants as soon as she's close. She must see something on Catra's face that she didn't want to show, because Scorpia goes on: "Did something happen? Did someone hurt you? Do I have to fight?"

"No, dude. Nothing happened, it's fine. I just"… Catra takes a deep breath. "I just wanna be alone for a while. Nothing's wrong, I'm just… overwhelmed. I'm gonna go on a walk and I need you not to freak out when I'm not back soon, okay?"

"Yeah, okay," Scorpia chirps. Catra doesn't buy it. "But, um. When are you gonna be back?"

"I don't know. But it'll be in time for us all to go back to camp. Until then, as far as you are concerned, I'm fine. Alright?"

Scorpia knits her brows together. Catra can see that she wants to say something, but she licks her lips and settles for an "Alright."

Catra reaches out, and pats her on the shoulder.

"Thanks. See you later."

Back by her beach towel, Catra steps into her studded platform sandals, and hops onto the pebbled pathway again. She throws a glance towards Bow and Netossa;Adora is not with them anymore.

She starts following the curves, and tries to swallow the lump in her throat.

I wanted to talk to you about something.

Shit.

*

Adora is not here.

Catra huffs out a breath. She is standing in the shade right in the middle of the junction, all alone.

Fucking fantastic. It wasn't enough to rile Catra up with those cryptic ass text messages, now Adora won't even show up on time even though she was the one leaving the beach first, so she should already be her–

Long fingers wrap around Catra's wrist, hauling her into the shrubbery. Catra barely has time to squeak before Adora shushes her with a finger pressed to her smiling lips, her eyes sparkling mischievously.

"Fuck you." Catra lowers her voice into a whisper, but couldn't really explain why. With Adora's whole stealth mission, it seemed appropriate.

"I'm delighted to see you, too," Adora says, matching her voice to Catra's. "Are you ready?"

"Ready to be taken somewhere in the middle of an unknown forest after I told everyone else not to follow or look for me? Sure."

Adora's smile breaks into a full-blown grin. Catra cannot help but notice how she doesn't let her wrist go; instead, Adora slips her hand lower, curling her palm around Catra's and squeezing as she pulls Catra with her.

"Perfect. That's how I always wanted you," she says offhandedly, like it doesnt make Catra' s stupid heart skip several beats in a row.

Time to mask it the only way she knows how.

"Where the fuck were you anyway?" She asks while Adora is sneaking through the literal forest, not following the pathways anymore; instead, they maneuver between patches of wild undergrowth, trying not to make any sound. "We're like five minutes away from the beach, how did you make me wait for you?"

"I had to go ahead and check if everything's the same as I remembered. I wouldnt want to take you there and realize that the entrance crashed in or something."

"So that' s a possibility. Good to know."

"Oh, shush." Adora peeks at her over her shoulder, cocking a brow. Flecks of sunlight pepper her face as they break through between the evergreens. "Since when are you afraid of a little danger?"

Catra makes a face. "This is different from jumping out of a burning building."

Adora snickers, disbelief painting her tone. "How?"

"That, I'm more than familiar with. This is a fucking surprise. I hate surprises."

"You'll love this one." Before Catra could snap back once again, Adora comes around a wide tree trunk and halts with their fingers still entwined. "Here we are."

Catra peeks out from behind Adora, walking next to her. Adora's thumb is stroking her knuckles while she takes in the scenery laying before her: an arch of shrubbery is right in front of them, hundreds of greens twisting and writhing tight into each other like lovers.

Embraced by them is an open mouth of a tunnel that leads god knows where, its whole path guarded and veiled by nature.

It looks like a gate to another world.

It feels like pure magic.

Catra has a suspicion that Adora doesn't want her to just *stare* at the enchanted forest gate and compliment it.

She squints up at her.

"If something asks my name in there, I'm leaving."

Adora laughs and pulls Catra deep into the belly of the cave. "I'm tight with the Fae. As long as you are with me, you'll be safe."

"Are *you* one of them?"

That would explain how Adora has had an unexplained power over her ever since their second time, but Catra doesn't get an answer. The cave grows pitch black quickly, the darkness flooding her mouth, thick like lead. It gets harder and harder to swallow. Catra's pulse is roaring in her ears.

"Hey," Adora's gentle voice breaks through. She squeezes Catra's hand; Catra is just noticing how hard she was clinging to Adora's fingers, effectively cutting off her circulation. "We're almost out. I promise."

"I'm *not* afraid of the dark," Catra spits immediately.

She feels careful fingertips walking up her neck (which does *not* make her jump at first), her chin, settling on her lower lip. Adora's clothes rustle as she leans in, and brushes her lips against Catra's where she has marked her spot.

Catra doesn't remember how they got out of the tunnel, or how long it took them, but it only seemed like a minute in hindsight.

The next thing she knows she is standing in the middle of a small yet stateful sea cave. The sea is rippling into it through a wide slit in the monstrous cliff they had climbed before, the waves calming down as they roll in. By their feet, the water runs deep, licking at a flat edge. The air is less humid here, crispy-fresh and salty. The temperature has dropped a little; just enough to dry their sticky skin, but not enough to make them shiver.

Adora lets her hand go, gesturing for her to take a seat by the rim. She dresses down to her bikini as she does, so Catra follows in kind, slipping out of her shorts.

They sit side by side, dipping their feet into the sea.

"When I first got adopted," Adora starts without Catra having to ask anything, "my parents wanted me to play soccer, because that's what their daughter used to be good at, too." Adora pauses to swallow, casting her eyes downward. "They… they lost her the year before, so they adopted me, and sent me here for the summers, hoping I'd end up liking it, too."

Catra really, truly hopes that Adora knows that is *not* the reason.

She stays quiet.

"I didn't really find my place there. At camp. I was good, but not the way my parents expected me to be. I hated the pressure. They told me that Mara was an exceptional striker. I ended up a goalie. I knew I failed them." Adora is swinging her legs underwater, eyes focused on her toes.

Catra knows all the unsaid thoughts that are swirling in Adora's head right now. She moves her hand to Adora's bare thigh, caressing gently.

Adora lifts her head a bit, shooting her a grateful smile and a look that makes Catra want to wrap her in her arms and never let her go.

When Adora speaks again, her voice has gained strength.

"They took us here on weekends, when there wasn't practice. I started wandering in the forest. I wanted to be alone. I was thinking… I was just daydreaming about staying here, on the island. Building myself a little cot, living on berries, sleeping under the stars. And I stumbled upon this cave." Adora huffs an exhale. "What better way to disappear?"

Catra's heart shrinks. She scoots a little closer, feet kicking underwater, until her thigh touches Adora's and her shoulder bumps into her bicep.

"This cave became my home while I was here. I called it Crystal Castle, because when the sun sets, you can see it right through that slit—" Adora gestures towards it, "and the light makes the whole cave sparkle like the inside of a crystal. It's a special place." Adora takes Catra's hand from her thigh and laces their fingers together in her lap. Her eyes lock onto Catra's. "And my secret."

Catra nods slowly, taking everything in. Her eyes wander all over the cave, but they gravitate towards Adora over and over again.

"So you're saying… no one else knows about this place?" She asks, a little uncertain.

"No. Just me."Adora's smile is sheepish. "And now you."

Catra's mouth is moving faster than her brain.

"There's no way you've never brought girls here to seduce them."

"Seduce?" Adora snorts a laugh, and Catra's cheeks flare up. The shift in the air is immediate. "Is that how you see me? A *seductress*?"

"Shut up," Catra says, barely opening her mouth. She looks away, shoulders hunched.

"Aww, wait." Fucking hell, of course she keeps teasing. "Are you jealous?"

"I'm not jealous!" Catra's voice is echoing back off of the rocks, zigzagging through the cave.

"You're totally jealous."

"I'm not!Why the fuck would I be jealous?"

"Don't be embarrassed," Adora coos. She bumps her knee into Catra's and raises her other hand to cup Catra's cheek. "It's pretty cute."

"Cute my ass." Catra lets Adora guide her head, bringing them closer together.

"Your ass is cute, too,"Adora whispers into her lips.

Catra tries to scoff, but no sound comes out. Her eyes are not focused on Adora's eyes anymore, her jaw slightly tilted.

Before she can sink into the feeling, a thought knocks the air out of her lungs.

Adora did not bring her here just to show Catra her secret place.

"What did you want to talk to me about?" Catra asks against all her instincts, and draws back.

Adora's hand falls from her face, the playful gleam in her eyes fading. She sucks her lips in, gnawing on them. Her thick brows furrow, carving a deep valley into the middle of her forehead as she tries to phrase her thoughts. Seconds pass, agonizing and slow, spiking Catra's anxiety. Adora is playing with Catra's fingers in her lap, but even that doesnt ease it.

Then, Adora opens her mouth.

Catra squeezes her eyes shut. Let's just get this over with.

"Are you...are you having fun here?"

This is not the question that Catra was bracing herself for. Her eyes snap open. She replies, a little confused: "Yeah."

Adora's glance drops to their entwined hands. "Then why did you want to leave?"

"I didn't—" Adora looks up at her, head still bowed. For fuck's sake. "Okay. Fine. I wanted to. For a minute. I just..." Catra lets her voice die out, making a vague hand gesture. Her cheeks feel warm against the breeze, goosebumps crawling up her legs underwater.

"It's because of my friends, isn't it?" Adora asks, the corners of her mouth bowing wistfully. "Look, I get it. I know you don't really like people, or spending this much time with a group, I— I didn't think of that when I invited you here. I'm sorry. And trust me, I know my friends are a lot. They are a lot for me too, sometimes. They are curious and blunt and loud, and they mean well but sometimes - okay, a lot of times - they cross lines they shouldn't. They always do that with me, too, like even this morning… they just started pestering me about something that was none of their business and they just didn't fucking drop it so I just...I just lied to them. I had to."

Catra has been barely following Adora's babbling, but this – this makes her spine snap straight.

"Wait, you...you lied to your friends?"

Adora whimpers, scrunching her nose. "I know! I know, it's a shitty thing to do, but they always want to know everything. Even the things I'm not ready for them to know. I didn't know how else to make them stop."

Catra's chest is heaving. Her throat makes a gritty noise; wild, roaring laughter threatening to spill from her lips. She knows she will

not be able to swallow it back down, so she does the only logical thing that comes to her mind; throws her arms over Adora's back and shoves her right into the water.

Adora sinks with an echoing splash, and Catra starts laughing. It sounds just as delirious as she had expected, squeaky and loud and deliciously victorious.

Adora breaks to the surface with a wet gasp. Drops of seawater sit on her fair lashes and the tip of her gorgeously crooked nose. She is grinning, too.

"Oh, you little—Come here."

Before Catra can flee, Adora's huge palms curl around her knees and she yanks Catra in.

Catra's laugh chokes into a high little yelp, mouth and eyes screwed shut, and then she's underwater.

The water is cyan blue and opalescent, murmuring softly into her plugged ears. Adora's long hair tickles Catra's shoulders, and when she cracks an eye open she can see it flowing all around them like a golden fog. Adora is illuminated by bright, white sunlight, shining against the mysterious shadows. Her long lashes look translucent, her body is pale marble. She paddles herself closer to Catra, and captures her lips.

Catra smiles into their kiss.

Why was she ever afraid of the deep? Drowning feels lovely.

Adora's arm is around her waist now, hauling her up. Catra takes a deep breath as soon as she can, her lungs burning a little.

Adora swims closer to the edge with Catra in her arms, stopping when her forearm, sneaking protectively over Catra's back, hits the brim. Her hair tie keeps her wet locks together and tame, but the

same couldn't be said about Catra; her curls are all over her face, blinding her like a heavy velvet canopy. Adora's gentle fingertips are under them, smoothing them off of Catra's face.

They're both devoured by the sea now, chins dipping underwater with every exhale. Catra takes another deep breath, eyes finding Adora's. She grazes their noses together.

"I *am* having fun," she says, almost reverent. "And I'm staying. Okay?"

Adora's smile is dazzling. In her eyes, Catra can see the walls of the sea cave at sunset. "Okay."

Adora kisses her again. Her lips move softly against Catra's, savoring. Catra throws her arms around Adora's neck tight, cradling her head. Adora's undercut prickles her palms, drops of water flowing down Adora's cheeks land on the tip of her nose, and as she lets her lips part, she tastes salt and Adora's sweetness on her tongue.

A shiver runs through Catra. She opens her legs and wraps them around Adora's waist, pulling her impossibly close. The closeness makes Adora's jaw slack, breaking their kiss. Catra can feel her trembling against her, her breath burning on Catra's lips.

Adora presses her mouth to Catra's cheek, smearing a wet kiss there. She moves down to her jawline, peppering her skin with gentle pecks.

Catra's eyes fall shut, a sigh escaping her. She can feel Adora smiling as she tilts her head to lick along Catra's pulse, nosing the spot behind her ear.

Catra sinks her teeth into her lower lip. Fuck. Adora feels good – better than ever, even, floating Catra higher and higher so effortlessly, injecting herself into her veins.

She feels warm. She is melting, becoming one with the sea.

Adora's next kiss is open-mouthed and slow, teeth grazing Catra's pulse as she sucks.

Catra is not proud of the noise that escapes her.

"Careful," she gasps, nails scraping Adora's undercut. Adora groans against her neck. "If you mark me right now, I can't play it off like it's from someone else."

"So?" Adora asks. There is no edge in her voice.

"So, you're not being very subtle, handsome."

"I fingerbanged you in a literal closet once, I think we're way over subtlety here."

Catra bursts out laughing. Adora pins with her lips still moving along Catra's pulse. She leaves a kiss there before drawing back up to meet her gaze.

Adora's eyes are sparkling.

"Holy shit, I remember that," Catra says, shaking her head. "We were so stupid. People were walking *right* in front of us. It was like, what? The fifth time?"

"Fourth." Something flashes across Adora's handsome features, dimming her smile. Her ponytail is floating behind her like golden silk. "You were so mad."

Catra swallows against the lump in her throat and shrugs. "I was always mad."

"Not like that," Adora goes on, almost whispering. "Not like you wanted to set the whole world on fire and burn yourself with it."

Catra's lips part, but no sound comes out.

Adora doesn't need it. Water sloshes around her wrist, dripping off her fingertips as she raises her hand and cups Catra's cheek. Catra can barely breathe under the intensity of Adora's eyes.

"Not like you had nothing else to lose."

She didnt.

She leans into the touch, looking away before she gathers enough courage to face Adora’s eyes again.

"I'm not like that anymore,” she says, and desperately wants to believe it.

"I know,” Adora says, her thumb stroking Catra’s sideburns comfortingly. "But it wouldnt matter to me.”

Catra shivers against the water, Adora's words warming up her whole body.

With her free hand, Adora pulls herself closer to Catra, chests colliding under the ripples, and for a second, Catra thinks this is it. This is the most perfect moment of her entire life, even though she feels tender, raw; an utter fucking mess like Adora's voice has sliced her chest up and exposed her heart, thrumming rapidly behind her ribs like a caged animal. Ever since Dee had been dissecting her this morning, Catra has felt sunburnt; but Dee was brutal and violent in their ways, stabbing her and twisting, dragging, tearing her skin with their sharp words and no intention of putting her back together.

Then the talk with Glimmer, who knows more than she wants to say, playing to Catra's feelings that she never wants to say out loud. Mermista, who was watching her like a hawk, suspicious of every inch of skin she could see, looking for marks that Adora had left on her. Perfuma, with her little wink last night, and staying up with Catra all night the first time they met, reading her like an open book without Catra having to say anything.

Adora, bringing her to her secret place that no one knows about, admitting that she had lied to her friends, looking at Catra like she is the only thing in the whole universe that she cares about.

Adora kisses her scars while she tugs on them gently, exposing more and more with the softness of her fingertips and the silk of her lips.

Catra wants to run. She wants to stay. She can't do either, paralyzed by the way Adora is holding her, paralyzed by the way Adora tilts her jaw and presses a kiss to Catra's burning cheek, opposite to where her thumb still strokes.

Catra's throat makes a strangled, weak noise, and she screws her eyes shut. She feels Adora's breath on her face before their lips meet, softly and fully. She opens up for her, and Adora's lower lip falls between hers for the taking. When Catra nips on it, she draws a sound mirroring her own from Adora's chest.

Adora breaks the kiss with a quick pop, floating back.

"I– I didn't mean, like. Obviously it matters, because you should be happy. I want you to be happy. I just don't… care. I mean I care too, just. It– it doesn't bother me, because you are… you are you. *You* matter." Catra watches Adora's throat jerk, teeth nipping at her lower lip before releasing. "You matter to me."

Catra had been wrong before, because this is it. This is the most perfect moment of her life.

This is her Adora. This is her girl.

This babbling, beautiful goddess who doesn't know when to use her pretty little mouth for something else because she wants Catra to know, to truly understand what she means to her.

Adora is different.

Shaking off the paralysis, Catra slides her hands over Adora's back, pulling her flush against her. She brings their lips together, fingers skimming the metallic clasp of Adora's bikini. With a flick, it comes undone, cups floating to the surface.

Adora gasps into her mouth. "Do you want to?"

"No. Not here," Catra says between slow, innocent kisses. "I just want to feel you on me." Her eyes find Adora's, her fingers between a strap and Adora's round shoulder. "Is that okay?"

Adora exhales with a quiet, charmed laugh. Her eyes soften into half-moons. "Do you really have to ask?"

Her disbelief makes Catra self-conscious.

Catra clings to Adora's shoulder with one hand, her arm wrapped tight under Adora's; with her free hand, she unhooks the knot at the nape of Adora's neck and fishes out the bikini top from between their bodies. Blindly, she throws it somewhere behind her. The top lands on the rocks with a wet thud and a click of the clasps.

"Just wanted to be considerate, but fuck me I guess," Catra says with a quirk of her brow, and waits for no answer before capturing Adora's lips again.

Adora giggles into her mouth. Her sounds melt into tiny moans of pleasure as Catra's gentle fingertips brush across the curve of her chest, sparking goosebumps all over her skin. She drops a hand between their bodies, her palm warm and huge against Catra's stomach, her ribs, fingers slipping under her swimsuit cautiously.

"Dont ask," Catra whispers, barely recognising her own voice. She doesnt separate her mouth from Adora's, drinking from her like she doesnt know how to do anything else.

Adora's lips curl into a grin under hers.

I wasnt gonna.”

Catra’s one-piece is a deep V cut; it is no challenge for Adora to pull the suit open, hooking the hem tight around the underside of her breasts. Adora cups her then, taking Catra’s tongue in her mouth, and Catra loses herself right there.

It is easy to be taken like this. Too easy. To be cherished, to be spoiled, to be kissed with enough tenderness that it is positively lethal. Catra craves it like her lungs crave air even if it kills her inside.

She kisses back leisurely, hoping it might calm her roaring heart. All she can hear is the rippling sea and Adora's mouth moving against hers, all she can feel is Adora's warm skin against the cool water, wrapped up and all around her own.

Adora's body against hers feels exactly how it felt when they were kissing in the trailer, Catra propped up on the counter with Adora between her legs, where she belongs. She belongs in slow kisses and tentative strokes of her fingers down her chest. She belongs in magical places, secret sea caves and enchanted forests. She belongs in Catra's arms and Catra's bed, under her mouth and above her, and she belongs in Catra's heart.

She will stay there forever.

Panic strikes through Catra's nerves, ruffling her like an electric shock. She manages to drag herself away from Adora's giving lips. A big gulp of salty air gets stuck in her throat.

Adora barely notices, pressing closer where Catra is drawing back; Catra still kisses her.

She is *so* fucking stupid.

"Adora,"Catra breathes between deep, lavishing kisses.

"Y eah.”Her words are muf fled by Catra’s mouth. "Y eah?"

"What if we can never be just friends?" Catra finally forces out, panting, nails biting into Adora's shoulders. "What if we can't stop?"

Now Adora's lips freeze, sticking to Catra's for a moment. Her lashes flutter as she lifts her gaze, looking at Catra.

"Then we won't stop."

Adora states it like it's a fact. Like nothing is easier in the world. Like she couldn't even imagine another solution, like she's never thought about other scenarios. Like nothing in the whole world could change her mind about this.

Catra sneers, giggling. "You can't be serious."

Adora's expression breaks, and Catra hates herself. Adora's gaze flickers between Catra's eyes, her growing confusion fueling Catra's flames.

So she goes on, shaking on Adora's shoulders a little.

"What about everything you've told me about your love life? Huh? You want the slow burn romance, the loving sex, the fairytale fantasy of your One True Love who is caring, and kind, and treats you like a princess. You're all about that shit, aren't you?" Catra's desperation creeps up her throat and weaves between her every word. "You want disgusting domestic stuff, perfect date nights and PDA and a wonderful future together. Getting a dog, meeting the family, growing old together and never, ever getting tired of each other because they are the only one you've ever truly wanted. You're all about that, right?"

"I... I am."

"So what?" Catra asks with a scoff, feeling frantic. Her nails sink deeper into Adora's shoulders. She is pretty sure it is hurting her. Catra wants it to hurt. "Don't you want a girlfriend?"

Adora looks at her like Catra is breaking her heart. Like *Catra* is breaking *her* heart.

"I do."

Catra's stomach twists, Adora's words stabbing her right through the guts.

"Then you'd have to meet someone new," she says, trying and failing to hide the trembling in her voice. "What then? How are you gonna do that while we're doing this?"

Adora swallows, sucking her lips in. Slowly, she takes Catra's hand and brings her inner wrist to her mouth, breathing a kiss onto it.

"Catra," she says, quiet but firm. The sadness is yet to dissolve in her eyes, dark and deep like the ocean. She keeps Catra's palm pressed to her cheek, a hand on her hand to stop her from drawing away. Her skin is feverishly warm. "I don't want to meet anyone new."

Catra's free hand slips off of Adora's shoulder and splashes into the water. She opens her mouth, but doesn't get to say anything.

"We had a rule that I've never kept." Adora's eyes are piercing, baby blues shifting silver like a storm rolling in on a sweet summer afternoon. "We said we'd never be exclusive… but with you, I have been."

Catra's fingers twitch on Adora's cheek. Her chest feels tight, her voice a shaky exhale.

"What are you?"

"For the past three years, you're the only one I've been with. I've only slept with you, and even now"… Adora licks her lips, shrugging a bit. "You are the only one I want to sleep with. If you said you

wanted us to stop, and never do it again, I'd respect that. But it wouldn't change anything else for me."

Catra blinks rapidly against the burning of her eyes and the tears that threaten to gush forth. The back of her throat is too narrow to swallow.

Her voice sounds wretched, even to her own ears. "Adora–"

Another voice thunders down the tunnel, echoing off of the walls.

"Wildcat! Hello? Are you in here?"

Adora freezes. Catra, too. They stare at each other, eyes wide, blood rushing out of their cheeks. Heavy steps are thumping closer and closer, and in just a couple of seconds, Scorpia will be here, and everything will be over–

"Get down," Catra whispers, and Adora nods.

Adora takes a deep breath and sinks beneath the surface. Catra pulls her swimsuit back over her chest right in time when Scorpia barges into the sea cave and spots Catra in the water.

She breaks out in a bright grin, and waves. "There you are, hi! Man, I've been looking *everywhere* for you!"

"Why?"

Scorpia halts in her steps. From that angle, they might actually get lucky - she may not notice Adora's silhouette under the waves.

Her grin doesn't fade, just twitches. "Well, y'know. I haven't heard from you for a while, so–"

Scorpia's gaze shifts from Catra's face, latching onto something on the ground. Her eyes grow twice their size.

Catra follows her eyeline, and *fuck*–

"Why are Adora's clothes here?"

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck.

They forgot the fucking clothes.

"Who?"

"Adora's!" Scorpia leaps closer, and points at the scattered pieces of fabric. "Those are her shorts, right there— and her socks, her sneakers, and– is that– is that her *bikini top?* " Scorpia gasps dramatically, hands flying to her mouth that she just can't fucking stop running. She looks back at Catra. "Wildcat, what did you do to her?"

"Nothing," Catra snaps, raising her voice. Her cheeks are on fire. "What do you think I did, Scorpia? You sound like you think I killed her. The better question is why the fuck are you here when I told you that I wanted to be alone?"

Scorpia doesn't reply. She is staring at Adora's clothes again, the cogs in her brain whirring restlessly.

Catra is getting more and more heated, her veins flaring up and setting her on fire. As soon as she opens her mouth, Adora emerges from the water and gasps for air.

A lot of things happen in the next few seconds.

Scorpia yelps in shock. Adora slams her arms on the ledge, keeping herself up. It is clear that her chest is bare, but she doesnt even try to cover herself up. Instead, she shoots Scorpia an awkward grin, a wave, and a slurred "hi." Scorpia doesnt greet her back, instead, her eyes snap right back to Catra's. She is confused. Hurt. Disappointed.

And then there is silence.

Catra wants to be the one hiding underwater.

"Scorpia"—

"No." Scorpia's voice has dropped an octave, her cheerful tone replaced by something distant and monotone. "I get it."

"You dont get shit."

"And who's fault is that?" Scorpia still keeps her voice low, yet her words sting more than if she were yelling them. She whips her head to the side, not even wanting to look at Catra anymore.

Catra keeps burning with rage. It gets harder and harder to control, until her whole body is trembling with it and she is trapped inside the eye of a hurricane. She pushes herself out of the water, splashing it everywhere, and strands on the edge with her head high.

"Who's fault is what exactly?" She spits, crossing her arms around herself. "If you didnt fucking follow me in here, then"—

"Then you could have kept lying to me." Scorpia sighs, hanging her head. "Right. I know."

Catra's laugh echoes back from the walls mockingly. "I wouldnt have to lie to you if you would ever be a friend that I could actually trust." Scorpia gapes at her now, wounded. Catra doesnt care. She goes on, taking a step closer to her with every sentence she yells. "This is not about you. I lied to you because you never fucking listen to what I ask of you, you just ignore everything and go do whatever *you* think a good friend would do. I keep trying to set my boundaries with you and you fucking cross them over and over and over again, so tell me, why would I ever tell you anything? How can you possibly be this dense? You have no business being here, ruining something you shouldnt even know about. I asked you to not follow me, I asked you to leave me alone, and here you fucking are, and you have the *guts* to call *me* out? Why do you have to ruin everything?"

Catra is breathing heavily, her throat dry. She is staring at Scorpia without blinking, counting the times her chest rises and falls, rises

and falls, waiting for something - anything - to sink her teeth into and keep the storm alive.

Scorpia presses her lips into a straight line. Catra watches her shake her head ever so slightly, and turn on her heel.

Scorpia leaves without a fight, and it hurts so much more than taking a punch.

Catra's vision starts to blur, colors and shapes melting into each other. She blinks and sniffs against the tears, choking on a sob.

Adora sighs behind her. "Catra"…

"Dont."

She grabs her ripped shorts, pulling them up. Her phone falls from her back pocket, crashing into a puddle of seawater. She picks it up and slips it back in without checking if it still works. She finishes putting on the shorts, button by button. Then, her capelet. Then, the studded platforms.

Water splashes behind her as Adora climbs out too. Catra cant force herself to turn back to face her. She laughs again. It's hollow.

"Ive had enough of this fucking day," she says shakily, hoping it would be enough for Adora. "Im done. Im sorry. I cant… I cant fucking do this right now."

She hears Adora swallow. "Okay ."

"Okay ."

Catra leaves. Her steps make a disgusting squelchy noise as her wet feet meet the padded footbed.

Adora calls after her one last time.

"Will you stay the night at the bungalow?"

Catra slows down, but never stops moving. “I told you. I’m staying.”

That is the only thing Catra is certain about.

Whatever happens, she is staying with Adora.

*

Catra cant sleep. She is tossing and turning, every inch of her skin itching against the duvet and sheets. It would be easy to blame the heat, but that has nothing to do with anything.

It is all guilt.

Shit.

Catra kicks the blanket off of her and sits up on the bed. Her bangs are sticking to her face, her temples and chest damp with sweat. She rakes her fingers through her hair, getting stuck on knots she got when she let her hair air dry without plopping it.

She peers to her right. Her eyes are used to the dark now; she can see Adora laying on her back, clear as day - she has an arm thrown over her stomach, the other laying on the pillow by her head. Her chest rises and falls without a rhythm.

It’s a shot in the dark.

Catra whispers: “Hey , Adora.”

Adora’s head turns towards her immediately. Her eyes look huge and black in the dark. “Hi. Y ou okay?”

“I need to talk to Scorpia.”

Adora shuffles, the bed creaking under her weight. She sits up as well, leaning on her hands behind her. She says, carefully: "I think that's a good idea."

"But if I talk to her"… Catra pauses to swallow. "If I talk to her, I'll have to tell her everything."

Adora furrows her brows. "Okay."

"Don't you get it?" Catra's voice breaks. "I don't want to lie to her anymore. I– I can't lie to her anymore. But she can't keep a secret, and she'll accidentally tell Perfuma, and Perfuma might tell everyone else"–

"Hey." Adora's voice is smooth like silk, flowing between Catra's gnarled nerves to ease them. "I'm okay with that."

"Yeah? You are?"

"Yeah." Adora rolls her heels on the mattress, watching her toes bumping together. "I think. I think it's time I am honest with Glimmer and Bow, too. So if you talk to her… I will talk to them. It might be for the best, honestly. This has been going on for too long."

Catra rises from her bed, grabbing her chiffon capelet from the top of the dresser and lays it over her shoulders. She doesn't bother with stepping into her sandals.

She halts by Adora's bed, shifting her weight uncomfortably. She knows what she wants to do, but she doesn't know if she can do it.

She settles for a breathless "thanks," and slips out of the bungalow.

*

There is still light coming from Scorpia and Perfuma's bungalow. Catra approaches it on light soles, not making any noise as she climbs the wooden stairs and reaches the end of the veranda.

She takes a deep breath, and raps her knuckles against the heavy door. Three knocks, loud and clear, presented with flair and way more confidence than she actually feels.

It takes a while for the door to creak open. Catra already has her fist raised again when Perfuma's head pops up; her confusion softens as soon as she recognises Catra.

"I'll tell her that you're here."

Catra nods, and takes a couple steps back. Turning on her heel, she walks back to the stairs, and sits down on one. She pulls her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms around them. She rests her chin in the crook of her elbow and keeps her gaze on the black waves crashing into the shore.

You can't tell where the night sky ends and where the sea starts; both endlessly dark, shimmering with myriads of stars and reflections of pale moonlight.

The veranda starts creaking under heavy steps. Scorpia comes around Catra to sit down on a lower stair to keep their heights somewhat even.

It takes Catra several minutes, but she breaks the silence.

"I'm sorry."

"No– no, gosh, don't be," Scorpia says immediately, squeezing her eyes shut. "You were right. I was a bad friend. I didn't respect your boundaries and that is wrong. I just… Ah, I dunno. I wasn't thinking. I'm sorry."

"Still," Catra says, lifting her head to meet Scorpia's eyes. "I was an asshole to you. I said a bunch of shit I didn't mean. You are caring, and loyal, and you definitely don't ruin everything. I'm sorry I said that."

The corner of Scorpia's mouth curls into a little smile. "All good. And I promise, from now on, I am going to do my best to not cross your boundaries. I am going to take it very seriously, and actually listen to your every word, okay? Just tell me to back off, and I absolutely will. No questions asked."

Catra smiles back. "Thanks."

Silence settles over them; it is heavy and pitless like a lie. Catra shivers in the late night breeze.

"Sooo"… Scorpia drawls after a while, pursing her lips, "you and Adora?"

Catra startles, almost falling off the stairs. Scorpia does, too.

"Boundaries," Scorpia whines, hitting her fist to her forehead. "Right. Boundaries. I'm so sorry."

"No, I"– Catra clicks her tongue. "I actually wanted to talk to you about that. And why…why I didn't say anything before."

"Before?" Scorpia repeats, dark eyes growing round. "Wildcat, that… that wasn't the first time?"

Catra shakes her head rapidly. Fuck, this is humiliating. She unfolds her arms and sinks her nails into her knees to ground herself somehow, and starts gnawing at her lower lip until she tastes iron.

"We've been fucking for three years."

"You *what?!*"

Catra has to physically shush Scorpia, pressing a palm to her mouth. "Dude."

Scorpia mumbles something unintelligible into Catra's hand and Catra draws back.

"Sorry . Sorry!" Scorpia repeats, whispering this time. "I just… wow. I mean, wow. I just– I still dont know why you wouldnt talk about it, yknow? You never had an issue with talking to me about the girls you were seeing."

That is a kind way of saying that Catra has had a horrible tendency of fucking the same people she knew she really should *not* keep fucking. Catra is not the type to hook up with random strangers, much like Adora, but she is great at ruining her own love life by making the same mistakes over and over again.

But Scorpia is right - she knew about them all.

Catra breathes in.

"This is dif ferent."

Let's just get this over with.

"Oh." Scorpia is waiting for Catra to elaborate. She cant. Fuck, she cant. "Um. Uh. H-how exactly?"

Catra turns her head towards her. Seeing her face, Scorpia's breath hitches; compassion blooms all over her face, dressing her in the same expression that Perfuma had looked at Catra with.

She must look like absolute shit.

"Oh, Wildcat"…

"I'm in love with her." Catra's lip starts to tremble, so she bites down on it. "I'm in love with Adora."

There. She's said it.

And for the next hour, she says everything else that's been settled heavy on her chest. She answers all of Scorpia's questions (You love her? *Yes*. When did you know? *Immediately*). She tells her how they've started, how they've almost ended, how they've decided to be friends instead. How that failed. She tells her about the rules, about the talks, the laughs, the kisses.

She tells her everything.

She tells her everything, and Scorpia is listening to her without interrupting, giving her her full attention. It almost feels like Catra has opened the floodgates, and finally the truth could pour out; it is less of the uncontrollable, deadly tidal wave that she had been afraid of, and more of a downpour of relief.

"That's when you interrupted us," Catra wraps it up, resting her chin in her palm. "I was so angry because… well, now you know." She did not tell Scorpia why the sea cave was Adora's special place; just that it was, for a brief moment, only theirs. And they have already lost it. Catra doesn't understand why Adora wasn't *furious*. "She was just *so…* I don't even know. It was a clusterfuck. It's always a clusterfuck with her."

"Sounds like it," Scorpia whistles curtly. "I'm so, so sorry, Wildcat. You must be *devastated*."

"Still. I shouldn't have attacked you like that for it."

"Not about that." Catra quirks a brow at Scorpia. She looks absolutely mortified to continue, but forces herself to anyway. "Well, not about… obviously, I'm sorry about that, too. Just, y'know… why Adora was so convincing about the two of you at breakfast? This is the first time you have actually fallen in love with someone, and… she is in love with someone else. That must be heartbreaking."

Catra feels like she has been slapped. "Wait, who— what do you mean? Who the *fuck*?"

"You were there, Wildcat," Scorpia mumbles apologetically, making an attempt to touch Catra's shoulder. Catra draws away, her pulse roaring in her ears. Scorpia looks like she is about to cry. "I told you about Cake Girl."

Oh.

Oh.

Oh my fucking god.

"Yes," Catra deadpans, trying to ease the way her voice quivers. She can't start laughing hysterically, can she? "I'm devastated."

Scorpia pouts, her eyes actually getting hazy. Just for a second, Catra plans on being completely honest with her, but…

Fuck it, she is too tempted.

"So what do you know about Cake Girl?"

Scorpia's jaw pops open.

"Oh, I don't think I don't think I should…"

"It would help," Catra says, surprisingly not even lying. So far. "If I saw more clearly, maybe I could… plan accordingly. To get over Adora, I mean. I don't think it would be healthy for me to not try and move on, you know?"

Wow, Catra is a bitch. She will deal with that later.

Scorpia nods solemnly.

"Right. Yeah. You're right." She takes a deep breath to start, but puffs up her cheeks at the last second. Peeking over at Catra, she

says: "Promise me you won't freak out, though."

Catra makes the easiest promise of her life, and that finally convinces Scorpia to talk.

"Okay , well… phew. You remember the time Fuma wanted me to meet Adora and the group?"

"Y eah. So she was there?"

"Cake Girl? Oh, no. Just Adora. And, well, only a couple people of the whole team. I didn't pay much attention to Adora, because, you know"…

"Y ou thought I hated her and you're a good friend, yes."

"Y eah. But like… she was quiet anyway. Weirdly quiet, not talking to anyone else either. I thought it was just because I had scared her off, but then I had to go pee, and I heard someone sobbing in one of the stalls. Like they were gonna throw up at any moment, you know the one?"

"Y es, Scorpia, I am familiar with the concept of crying."

"Okay , yeah, I just– I just mean, it was breaking my heart, right? And so, I stayed around a bit until they came out and lo and behold, it was Adora."

"And she was crying about Cake Girl?"

"Y eah. And no. Well… she said something about Cake Girl's ex, I think? That was the main part. Adora wanted this girl, but she was getting back with her ex, and… oh my *God* ." Scorpia gasps theatrically, staring at Catra wide-eyed. " *O my God* , Wildcat."

Catra's face grows pale. "W -what?"

"That' s great news, isnt it?" Scorpia almost yells, despite Catra trying to shush her again. "M aybe Cake Girl is already back with her

ex! Maybe that' s all over!"

"Y eah, yes, she might be, but hey"… Catra slips a hand on Scorpia's shoulder, sqe ezing a little. She doesnt need the details Adora already told her. She needs something new. Something *more* . Something she was too scared to confess, apart from the crying. "Why dont we go back to the night at the bar, hm? Think. Did Adora say anything else about her?"

Scorpia hums, scowling in concentration. She almost looks cross-eyed.

God fuck, Catra's patience is running thin. It's late, she has had the longest day in the history of days, she is exhausted, and she doesnt have the time or the energy to pull every single piece of information out of Scorpia's mouth like it was her teeth–

"Probably not…" Scorpia clicks her tongue. "I mean, this is all I can remember. I don't think we could figure out who Cake Girl is, Wildcat. Adora was all over the place. She was clearly getting her heart broken, but she was like… determined to win this girl over? It looked like that was the moment she realized that she didnt want the relationship to be just baking. Or that she wanted to be the only one baking cakes with her? I dont… sorry, I dont really remember. I didn't even know Adora could bake. She doesn't seem the type."

"It' s okay, dude," Catra says, rising to her feet. "Y ou were a great help to get me over Adora. I feel so much better."

"Anytime, friend," Scorpia says, and she sounds so sincere that Catra contemplates telling her the truth again.

She swallows the words back and replaces them with a *goodnight*. They talk a little about silly things; sweet dreams and the ride back to the studio tomorrow, how they will see each other at breakfast, but it all sounds distant, distorted to Catra's ears like she is eavesdropping on herself from underwater.

On the short walk back to the bungalow, she puts the pieces together. She knew that Adora saw her kiss Dee on the night of the bar meetup, but not that she was feeling like shit the whole time. She was crying about it; about Catra kissing someone else, like it was breaking her heart. She decided that she wanted to be the only one who fucks Catra, or maybe… No, Adora told her on the day of the chase scene shoot that she never said she wanted to date Catra.

Did she never say, or did she never want to? And what's the fucking difference when they are only fucking each other, being best friends, kissing and cuddling without it turning into anything more, and Adora doesn't even want to date around because she has Catra?

That's what she said. She said that.

And here Catra is, in the cold of midnight, walking along the beach and still wondering if she has the strength, the courage, the *nerve* to let herself hope for the one thing she's ever truly wanted in her miserable little life.

Catra clicks the door open and closed as quietly as she can. She slithers under the covers with her capelet still on, and fidgets carefully to not make the bed creak too loud.

"Hi."

Catra lets out the breath she was holding in. All of that was for nothing, then. "Hey."

Adora turns towards her in the bed, cheek squished to the back of her hand on the pillow.

"Are you okay?"

"Yeah." They are still whispering, like there is something sacred between them that neither of them wants to break. "It went well."

"Good. Im glad." Adora pauses before she asks: "What did you tell her?"

Catra shrugs, closing her eyes with a content sigh. Her limbs sink into the mattress, eyelids heavy with the promise of a dreamless night.

"Everything."

Even the things you don't know anything about.

Chapter End Notes

OK Yeah I am aware half a year passed again but this fucker is 15k long so

God. Yeah. Hi. I'm exhausted. But I do hope you like this little surprise landing in your inbox, and I hope even more than you will end up liking this one and it does not disappoint. I love love LOVE your interactions here in the comment section or coming to me on my socials, please for the love of fuck yell at me because all I want to do is yell back at you. I need this, okay?

Since last time, we have playlists yay. Check them out on Spotify:
Catradora
Adora
Catra
Double Trouble

Come hang out with me on Twitter and Tumblr, I'm usually nice.

Rule #12 | Part 1

Chapter Summary

12. Keep things vanilla.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You've been fucking her for *how long?* "

Adora sighs, knocking the back of her head against the headrest.

Sure, she hadnt really expected this to go smoothly. She decided to have The Talk with Glimmer and Bow on the ride back to the studio so that they could have a private conversation and be alone with no one around to accidentally - or not so accidentally - eavesdrop on them.

What Adora did not account for, however, was the shrill octave Glimmer's voice jumps to when she is freaking out, and the narrow space of the cabin that they are locked in. She starts to worry that if she spills even one more secret, Glimmer will only be able to communicate with bats, or call back dogs.

The leather cover on the steering wheel creaks under Adora's grip. "Glimmer , please—"

Glimmer throws herself against the back of Adora's seat, shaking the whole truck with the impact.

She wags a finger at Adora accusingly.

"No, okay? *No* , because last time you told us that you *just* became close and, okay, we all already knew that you'd fall for her 'cause you're like, ridiculously easy to figure out, but—"

Adora starts huffing, almost choking on her own grunts in-between. She is aware that she sounds like an offended gorilla, but she cant help it when her whole body is up in flames of embarrassment and rage. "Oh, oh, oh, right, like you're not?"

"What's *that* supposed to mean?"

"Oh come on! I know you thought I was too stupid to figure out that you two are going to pound town. Well, I'm not."

Glimmer stutters on unintelligible noises.

"I'm!— We!" She whips her head back, nails still biting into Adora's seat. "Bow?"

Bow, bless his soul, has been almost eerily quiet since Adora had started her tale. His composure is admirable, and Adora hopes it is not just shock.

Now, he leans forward in his seat, peeking at Adora over the back of the passenger's seat. "How did you figure it out?"

"I—" Adora starts vehemently, already biting the first word. She lowers her voice into a deep grumble. "I heard you making out when you stayed the night at our trailer."

"Wow, you're right, so smart," Glimmer sneers, throwing her hands up.

Adora's jaw clenches.

"Okay, well— you know what? How's it any smarter to just make out when you *assume* someone's asleep above you? At least I didn't fuck Catra right next to you."

That is a lie, objectively, but no one really needs to know that.

"Oh my god, I didn't even think about that." Glimmer makes a noise between a gag and a growl. "You guys fucked in your bed before

that, didn't you? Please tell me you cleaned your sheets."

"If you really wanna know, we only fucked in Catra's bunk, so no, the only people doing the bedroom rodeo on that mattress were you and Bow." Adora flicks on the turn signal, and passes a long-distance bus a little too aggressively to be considered safe.

"We were just kissing!"

"That's not the point!" Adora is yelling now, too. She slaps the wheel, accidentally triggering the horn. Waving awkwardly at enraged drivers around her, Adora finds the speed limit again and forces her next words through a fake grin plastered to her face. "My point is, you didn't tell me anything either. I was just hooking up with a girl we all know, but you guys actually got together. And you didn't tell me."

The silence is a heavy scarf slung around Adora's neck. It is tight enough to suffocate her. She takes a deep breath and releases it with a sigh.

"I just mean… I told you stuff. I told you that I've been getting closer with Catra, even though I knew you would freak out and be rude about it. I told you that it's fragile, and I didn't feel comfortable sharing more. And what did you tell me?" The lump in her throat starts to burn. "You're *dating*. You two are my best friends, and you started dating, and you said nothing. Which is fine you know, I respect you not wanting me to know. It's not that, it's just— You don't get to bite my head off for not talking about Catra when you lied to me about yourselves, too. Okay? It's not fair."

For a moment, the quiet rumbling and clanking of Adora's truck is the only noise breaking the silence.

Behind her, Glimmer and Bow share a look; she can catch a glimpse of it in the mirror.

"Sweetheart?" Bow asks quietly, urging Glimmer to speak. Glimmer clicks her tongue. "You know she's right, too."

"Didn't you hear how she talked to me?" Glimmer stage whispers, firing up again.

"*She* can hear you," Adora cuts in dryly, matching Glimmer's frustrated tone. "And I'm not going to apologize when your childish grudge keeps scaring Catra away whenever I want to make a move!"

Glimmer's laughter is mocking and just a touch frantic.

"Oh, *my* childish grudge? So you not dating her yet is also my fault now, huh?"

"I'm trying my best, okay?"

"Yeah?" Glimmer chuckles. "Well, maybe your best just isn't good enough if you have to blame *me* for not getting the girl yet when you've been fucking her for three. Whole. Years."

Adora's chest collapses like Glimmer had slapped her. She tucks her chin downwards and stares straight at the road ahead. The rumble strips are dipping into each other, melting in front of Adora's eyes.

She blinks the tears back.

"Come on guys, you're best friends," Bow says softly into the pause. "I'm sure you didn't really mean what you've said to each other. How do you two really feel?" No one replies to him, so Bow goes on. "Adora? Is there anything you want us to know?"

Adora's mouth twitches. When she speaks again, her voice is rough with the memories of Catra slipping through her fingers. It's not only that Adora's own baggage is too heavy for anyone to deal with; she also brought more baggage to the table in the form of loud, nosy friends.

"Well, I want my friends to stop embarrassing me," she says. "You guys almost made Catra leave yesterday because none of you respect her boundaries or know how to take anything seriously."

"Oh, so *we* are embarrassing *you* ?" Glimmer clings to the backrest even tighter, her voice hurting Adora's ears: "You know damn well that wasnt what made her want to leave."

"Of course it was! You guys made her uncomfortable, and"—

"Oh my god, are you seriously this dense?"

"Hey! I'm not"—

"Who do you think stopped her from leaving?"

Adora swallows her retort. She blinks, leaving her mouth open as Glimmer's words slowly but surely drip down her throat.

"Me. She's a real piece of work," Glimmer scoffs, throwing herself back onto the seat. She crosses her arms, staring out of the window. "Look, I may not get what you see in her. I'll probably never get it. If you wanna sulk about that, be my guest. But you're my best friend. Do you really think I don't give a shit about your happiness?"

Adora licks her lips and blinks again, hoping it would ease the sting in her eyes. She meets Glimmer's death glare in the rearview mirror. "Thank you."

Glimmer makes a dismissive little noise, but the tip of her nose is dusty pink.

"Yeah, so you can stop the blame game."

Adora frowns a bit. "What blame game?"

Bow slides his palm onto the headrest of the passenger seat in front of him. "Adora, you do know why Catra really wanted to leave, right?"

"Of course I do, I just told you?"

"Oh my god," Glimmer hides her face behind her tiny palms.

"What?" Adora snaps again before she could stop herself. Not knowing what apparently everyone else knows pricks her in a certain way, and makes her blood burn. "Why did she want to leave, then? What did she tell you? And what made her stay?" She doesn't get a reply. Her voice wobbles in her throat. "Glimmer?"

Bow touches Glimmer's arm gently and she leans into his touch. She slides onto the middle seat, closer to him, and tucks herself under his chin to hide. She mumbles something so quietly that Adora has a difficult time hearing her over the clashing of the truck.

Maybe she wasn't supposed to hear it, anyway.

Bow reaches over and fastens the middle seat belt around Glimmer with a click. As he smooths a tiny curl of baby hair back from her forehead, he asks, gently: "Can I?"

Glimmer shrugs, nuzzling deeper into his neck.

Bow's fond smile fades as he raises his jaw and meets Adora's gaze in the mirror. Adora tears her eyes away so he cannot see how her heart clenches with bitter envy.

She did not expect that Bow's words would make her chest ache even more.

"Catra left because of what you said at breakfast about the two of you."

"What I…" Adora clips her words, biting down on her lip. Her palms grow clammy and cold against the wheel. Her voice sounds just as wounded as she feels. "She…she heard that?"

"Yeah. She came in when you said—"

"Yelled," Glimmer grumbles.

"that nothing happened between you two, and never will. Glimmer knew Catra was going to leave after that, so she decided to catch

her and talk to her for you."

Adora swallows.

She has dozens of questions left to ask, but inhales them all and keeps them in her lungs. Her brain is whirring like the engine of her truck, popping loudly in her ears. She remembers everything; what she had said, how small and hurt Catra had looked when she caught her by the gate, how she avoided telling Adora herself why she couldnt stay.

She says nothing else for the rest of the car ride.

No one does.

*

The sky is burning orange and angry red by the time Adora arrives at the trailer alone. She hooks all of her bags on her shoulders and arms and slams the door of the truck a little too hard, the whole car wobbling from the impact.

Then she has to put down half of her stuff to disappear elbow-deep into said bags, not remembering where she had put her keys. By the time she straightens with her keychain clinking in her trembling fist, blood had rushed to her face, her ponytail had come undone, and she just wants to fucking cry.

It only gets worse when she forces her way in, spilling everything down onto the floor and on top of her bed, and Catra peers up at her with a soft smile adorning her pretty face.

"Hey," Catra says, placing her mug back onto the tiny dining table.

"Hi."

Does she sound normal? She hopes she sounds normal.

Catra's brows furrow, just a tiny bit. "How did it go?"

How did what go? Adora wants to ask, but she swallows instead. Pretending to be an even bigger idiot than she already is probably is not the greatest plan she can come up with.

And she is grinning. Why the hell is she grinning? "Baaad."

"Oh," Catra breathes, rising to her feet. "Shit."

"Yeah." Adora is chuckling now, turning on her heel. She doesnt want Catra to see her red face and dull eyes and—

Catra touches her.

Her fingertips brush across Adora's forearm, curling around her wrist. So chaste, it is barely even a grip.

Adora's grin freezes on her face like a mask. She lets herself be turned back, now facing Catra but still avoiding her eyes. If she looked at those big, beautiful, mismatched irises right now, she would just shove Catra to the nearest wall and fuck her until she didnt feel anything anymore.

That is not how Catra deserves to be treated.

That is not how she wants her anymore.

And if— Adora is completely honest with herself that is not how she has ever wanted her.

Her grin starts to melt into a grimace, her breathing shallow.

Catra's other hand starts to wander up; up from Adora's waist, ghosting across her bicep and shoulder, the dip of her clavicle, crawling up her neck, over the sharp line of her jaw. Catra cups her

cheek, guiding her head down. Adora's gaze falls below Catra's eyeline, not focusing on anything. Her vision starts to shiver and blur.

Catra brings her lower while rising to her tiptoes and tilting her own head to the side.

"C'mere, handsome," she says, and that is it.

Adora collapses against her, chest heaving to keep in a pathetic sob. She hooks her chin over Catra's shoulder, burying her face in the silky curls that smell like lemongrass and summer. She throws her arms around Catra's lithe frame tight, anxious about hurting her but too far gone to do anything about it.

Catra's arms wrap around her waist, palms stroking up her spine and nails clinging to her shoulder and scapula; a heady attempt to crush Adora even deeper into her body. Her warm lips are pressed to the valley of Adora's neck, breathing feather-light kisses on her skin.

Adora shivers at every single one of them.

"I've got you," Catra whispers with her mouth on Adora's neck. "I've got you."

Her words pull the hiccuping sobs out of Adora's mouth. She is a lost cause. She sucks in painful breaths that rattle in her chest, and exhales with whimpers and silent screams that break apart in her throat. Her head is heavy, her body is a ragdoll, and Catra holds her safe.

Adora shatters into broken pieces of glass, shards drilling into her eyes, her heart, her head, leaving her to bleed, and Catra holds her safe.

It takes a while for the storm to pass. Adora is lost in the eye of it, sobbing into Catra's hair, soaking her pretty curls with her tears and saliva.

The thought of her ruining something so beautiful makes her tears swell up again.

"Okay ," Catra says while Adora takes a deep, ragged breath and her hold on Catra eases. "Y ou're okay. You did so well."

Adora whimpers in response. Her throat aches, her voice scratchy and rough, but her mind, ever so slowly, starts to still. Her knees feel empty, light, threatening to give up under her. There is a ringing in her ears, echoing back from the dome of her skull.

Her sigh rumbles through her chest and sweeps into Catra's.

Then, everything grows quiet.

Catra pulls back carefully and cups both her cheeks, thumbs swiping the tear streams on her flushed skin.

Just from that gentle touch, Adora wants to cry all over again. "I'm so "—

Catra's thumb is on her lips. "Shh." She reaches up to tuck some loose, wet tresses behind Adora's ear. Her hand comes back then, soft fingertips grazing Adora' s face like she is something fragile.

"Y ou're okay," Catra repeats, raspy voice wrapping itself around Adora's heart. Adora swallows. Catra's hazy eyes follow the movement. "T ell you what. Why don't you go and take a long, hot shower while I throw something together? I asked the catering staff for a bunch of stuff before we left. I can make us a kickass dinner."

Adora breathes out in a curt sigh, her heart swelling in her chest. Where warmth rises to her throat, panic does, too. "N-no, Catra, you don't have to"—

"I know ."

"Seriously , I'm fine."

"Adora." Catra's voice is nothing but gentle, but there is something in her tone Adora cannot resist obeying. "I want to. Let me, please."

Please. That's what it was. A plea.

How could Adora possibly say no to that?

So she nods, rewarded by the sweetest smirk that has ever played on Catra's plump lips.

Catra still hasn't drawn back. Her hands wander to Adora's neck, palms pressed warm against her pulse, thumbs resting on her jawline.

Adora's lips part on their own, tongue darting out to lick at the chapped skin.

For a second, Catra's gaze falls to Adora's mouth, her body bowing ahead. Adora gasps a surprised, very audible *"Oh",* waking Catra from her daze.

Catra pulls back with a flinch, dropping her hands like she has burned them.

Adora has ruined something beautiful again, and there is no one to blame but herself.

The rest of the evening passes in a blur. Adora showers. Washes her hair. Her face. Puts on boxer briefs and a gray tank top that clings to her frame like a second skin. She drinks the tall glass of cold water Catra hands her. Shivers when their fingers touch, sparks shooting through her nerves.

It may have been the blazing hot water of the shower, but she feels tender like a fresh bruise. Everything around her is overwhelming, lights and sounds are either too sharp or too blurry. She can easily sink into an unfamiliar warmth around Catra, safe and secure, and yet— from time to time, Adora finds herself squirming in her seat,

fidgeting with her cutlery, feeling restless. Powerless. Exhausted. It grows thorny weeds of guilt in her stomach, but then Catra speaks to her, and relief washes over her again at the first syllable.

Whatever is happening to her right now, it has never happened before. And no matter how hard Adora is trying to figure it out, as long as she meets Catra's eyes over the table, she loses all train of thought.

Only when Catra rises to her feet to take their plates, asking Adora if she wants seconds of her spicy chickpea bowl (she does), and Catra's eyes sparkle up with joy — only then, does Adora realize what this feeling is.

She is being taken care of.

*

Adora awakens with a knot deep in her belly.

It doesn't dissolve in the shower.

It doesn't dissolve during breakfast which she spends with Mermista and Seahawk alone.

It coils even tighter when she walks into Wardrobe. Glimmer is there, meeting her eyes in the mirror framed by bright lights.

"They need me on set," Glimmer says, turning her back to Adora. Her voice is chipper as always. "You can get her ready alone, can't you?"

The flushed MUA Glimmer leaves her with nods with zero confidence.

Adora swallows as she sinks into the seat. She says nothing to make Glimmer stop or stay, and she doesn't want to.

As much as she feels the bile of guilt burning the back of her throat, she refuses to forget Glimmer's part in the story. Sure, Adora may have been quick to judge and project the blame onto someone, but that doesn't excuse how Glimmer had talked to her. What she had implied.

How she keeps judging her for every single decision she makes, like Adora is a complete idiot who can't do anything right.

Adora blinks against the swelling tears, and aims her focus on the dresser in front of her. She stares at a round brush – or whatever the hell it is called – until everything else around her is covered in a thick dust of makeup.

*

On set, she calms down.

More or less.

Maybe it is the familiarity of the scene, or the distance it has put between Glimmer and her.

Adora adjusts her once sleek necktie that is flopping freely above her creased, torn suit. She is ready to tackle the fight scene with Catra that Double Trouble was so disappointed by before their weekend getaway (even if the nervous MUA definitely painted the splattered blood on Adora’s cheeks wrong). They didnt tell Adora specifically what their issue was, but displeasure was written all over their face; in the crinkles of their nose, their boredly cocked brow, and the tiny curl of their lips that gave them a constant look of disgust, like they had smelled bullshit in Adora’s acting.

Anxiety pools in Adora's stomach again, bitter and burning. She's never been good at figuring out what someone's issue with her was. She very much prefers to be told outright what she did wrong so she can figure out how to fix it. She doesn't mind yelling, she doesn't mind harsh criticism, she doesn't mind bluntness as long as instructions are clear.

With Double Trouble, everything is a game that Adora doesn't know the rules of, but is expected to play along anyway. Her insides form an agonizing knot at the thought of disappointing them again, and what that could mean for her gig. Or career, even. People talk. Who is going to give Adora another chance if she messes up the first role she's ever gotten that was more than stunt work?

A squeaky giggle shakes Adora from her thoughts. She blinks and turns her head towards the sweet sound, her lips already curling in response.

Her eyes spot Catra appearing between two black flags, talking to someone Adora doesn't know. Their style pretty much matches Catra's: all black and pleather. Their hair is cut short and dyed bright green, heavy makeup sharpening their features.

Adora's smile freezes.

They look like a parakeet, she thinks with a scoff when Catra punches them on the arm playfully. *Hey bro, the Black Parade is two buildings away* .

"Catra!"

Catra meets Adora's eyes between two bursts of fainting giggles. Her mouth is still curved into a grin when she bites down on her plump lower lip, raising her brows at Adora expectantly.

Wait. Did *Adora* yell her name?

Shit. Shit. She did not plan this far. She did not plan this at all. Why did she do that? What should she say? She has nothing to say. Besides, she is way too occupied with drowning in Catra's gorgeous eyes, the gleam in them almost electric as they cling to Adora.

Adora swallows, raising a hand.

"Hi."

She fights the urge to slap herself in the fucking face and settles for dropping her hand back by her side, fingers balled into a shaky fist. What the hell was that?

Catra's voice melts Adora's insides, washing out the bile of anxiety. "Hi, Adora."

Adora feels her features soften, her head tipped to the side.

In a split second, Catra's expression breaks. Her eyes find something behind Adora's back and widen in fear before she quickly takes back control. She tames her expression into something blank; a little arrogant, even, like nothing had happened.

Adora sucks her lips in. Did she do something? Did she mess this up after all?

She whips her head around, checking behind herself. There is nothing out of the ordinary there: lights, tripods, wires, cameras. There aren't many people present for their reshoot at this point; just the prop master making sure the rocks around their fictional cliffside are looking sharp, the gaffer giving out instructions to the camera crew standing around them in a loose circle, and the director lounging on their chair and scrolling through their phone while they pop their pink bubblegum.

Nothing that could have frightened Catra.

By the time Adora turns back, Catra and her friend are gone.

Adora heaves out a sigh. She walks to her backpack she had left under a table, and fishes her phone out to turn it off before she forgets. Again.

She swipes her thumb across the screen, gaze zigzagging between notifications to check if there are any that she should respond to immediately.

Her agent had sent her an attached link without any greetings or further explanation. It is no surprise; Adora has been under the care of Hope ever since she was 17, and the woman has never been the chatty type. She was just a legal guardian. An agent. Someone Adora could thank for her whole career. Someone who always knew where Adora messed up, what she should do next, what she should choose. Providing more than a link would mean Hope cared about what Adora thought.

She was never "mom." Never family. Never a friend.

Adora closes her eyes, and she sees Catra's face behind her eyelids; campfire caught on the tips of her wild curls, in the ambers and skyblues of her eyes as she dances, her thumb stroking the column of Adora's neck.

Why do you take that?

Cracking an eye open, Adora taps on the screen to leave the conversation. This could wait until she figures out what she wants to do.

Uhh.

What she wants to do.

She loves her job. She does. She wants to keep doing stunt work, she… she wants to choreograph. She wants to train. She wants to give back. She wants a purpose. She just wants to be happy. She…

Adora swallows, sliding a palm across her chest to feel the rush of her heart like a mere touch could calm it down. Her lashes flutter, eyes finding an empty spot on the tabletop in front of her to focus on.

She wants so much. It’s overwhelming. But that’s okay, right? She doesnt have to decide right away . She can choose her path later.

A lightning strike of panic shoots down her spine at the thought of getting to choose.

Choosing . It's a word that tastes like sugar on Adora's tongue, so sweet it might be just downright sinful. Is she even allowed to?..

Her whole palm vibrates as she gets another text. Adora starts chewing on her lower lip, her throat tight as she tries to swallow.

When she sees the name at the top of the conversation, her whole body relaxes.

Catra

storage next to wardrobe
2 mins
8:12

Adora’s stupid heart is already doing loops in her ribcage. She licks her lips, tapping on her keyboard while she feels heat licking at her jaw .

Just to confirm, is this because?..
8:12

because i want a taste of you
before weŀe up.
8:13

Oktnrwsy
Was
Omw
Yes
8:13

Adora clicks her phone locked and slips it back into her backpack. She springs up, bashing her knee right into the leg of the table. She feels no pain.

After a leap, Adora stops in her tracks, hopping in one place from all the pent-up energy. Catra said two minutes. She should wait two minutes. She can wait two minutes.

What the hell can she do for two minutes?

Sure, she doesnt know what she wants to do with her career, or with herself, or her future in general - but oh, she knows what she wants to do with Catra. Now, later, always, forever. If Catra ever wanted her back, Adora feels like she would be able to do just about anything on a scale of *figuring out what she truly wants* all the way to *killing God* . Hell, she could come back from the dead if it meant that Catra would be hers.

Adora straight up whimpers, looking around to see if there is a clock somewhere. There isnt, so she grabs the closest member of the camera crew like a normal person, and asks for the time. In her normal voice.

"Eight fifteen," the woman grumbles, barely peeking at her watch.

"Sharp?" Adora asks, bouncing on her heels.

The woman moves her jaw in another grumble that might as well be yes. Adora takes it, and starts to power walk towards the meeting room like a suburban mom who is late to her book club meeting.

Suddenly, she is there. She barges into the storage room like it is a cold lake and she is on fire. She tries to catch the door before it slams into the wall, but the door knob slips from her hand.

It doesnt matter; Catra appears out of thin air to catch it and slide the door closed. In a blink, her petite little body is flush against Adora's and all over her as she pins her down.

The fire inside Adora has just started to flare up when she feels Catra curl her fingers around the nape of Adora's neck, dragging her down to meet her lips.

Catra kisses her with urgency; it is different from how she had done it in the beginning. Adora still remembers Catra's fury that would sweep into her mouth like venom, all teeth and scraping nails which left marks for days. Adora used to tell everyone she had a cat to explain all the scratches.

Now, Catra is almost shy in her passion. She still dictates a rhythm that leaves Adora breathless, clinging to Catra's shoulder blades for dear life, but her touch is so soft it's borderline pampering, adoring every inch of Adora's skin that she can reach.

Adora's lips curl into a grin above Catra's, teeth blocking Catra's tongue from slipping into her mouth. She starts giggling uncontrollably.

Take that, parakeet.

"Something funny?" Catra asks in a sharp whisper. She brings a hand down on Adora's throat, applying little to no pressure as her nails bite into the sensitive skin there.

Adora's giggles die on a surprised, delighted gasp.

"No, Captain," she responds, her tone downright provocative as she peeks down to meet Catra's dilated pupils.

Catra closes her eyes, brows twitching.

"You're lucky you're hot."

"I think *you're* lucky that I'm hot."

Catra brings her mouth to Adora's jaw, pressing a slow, lavishing kiss on the taut skin there with just a hint of tongue. It leaves Adora's knees knocking together.

"That I am," she purrs, marking her way down Adora's throat with more kisses, each one of them more insistent and burning than the one before, and Adora falls victim to it. Catra seems pleased with her reaction. "Yeah, that's more like it."

A moan escapes Adora at the next kiss, somewhere between affirmative and pleading. She feels feverish now, blazing hot and trembling, even though Catra hasn't touched her anywhere below her collarbone. It doesn't seem to matter to her now; her body is craving this more than anything, just to be the center of Catra's undivided attention. Catra could just stand there and stare at her for ages, and Adora would be on her knees, begging her to never look away.

Catra's hips rock into hers, torturously slow. Adora can't help the high pitched sound that slips between her clenched teeth, nor her hips chasing Catra's. Her hands drop from Catra's back to her waist, fingers gripping tight enough to bruise. Catra is hot under her touch,

goosebumps blooming on her silky skin, and Adora's forearms, too, like they are contagious.

"Can I—" Adora sighs, choking on her words when Catra bites down the front of her throat, careful to avoid the blood splatters. Adora swipes her thumbs lower on Catra's body, following the sharp line of her pelvis. "Can I touch you, please?"

"No." Catra's fingers wrap around Adora's wrists, guiding her hands in line with her shoulders, and shoves them to the door. Their lips graze together, Catra's sweet but commanding words sticking to Adora's like dripping honey. "You're here to take everything I'm giving you, aren't you? So keep your hands there until it's your turn. Understand?"

Adora nods, fingers bending and unbending. Their restlessness is the only sign of Adora's impatience, riled up from being told that she is not allowed to do what she is really, really dying to do.

"Good girl." Catra captures her lips again, kissing her with all the desire *she* doesn't have to chain down. It would annoy Adora, if Catra's praise and lips weren't so velvety and addictive.

She kisses Adora deep and breathless. Nimble fingers are making their way to Adora's chest, sliding between her suit and button-up. Adora feels soft fingertips grazing her nipples over her clothing, and she arches into the touch.

"Fuck, Adora." As Catra continues her ministrations lower on Adora's body, she doesn't have to unbutton her suit, as it is already ripped for the scene. Adora hears the jingling of her belt, and a rush of cool air hits her newly exposed skin. Catra nuzzles into the crook of her neck, nipping along her pulse again. "The things I would do to you if I had more time."

Adora makes a broken, questioning noise. She is not capable of saying anything else since Catra's fingers have slithered between her thighs, prying them open.

"I wouldn't just take you by the wall, rushed and sloppy." Catra starts rolling her wrist in a shallow rhythm, barely touching Adora where she needs her. Adora's body already makes slick sounds at every grind of Catra's hand. She screws her eyes shut, her head knocking into the door to give Catra better access to her throat. "No. I would strip you naked on my bed and fuck you for hours until you lose your pretty voice."

"Catra," Adora gasps when Catra changes the pressure, keeping her pace.

"Mm?"

Lust has stripped Adora's voice of all softness. The muscles in her arms are cramping from keeping her hands glued to the wall, fighting against all of her instincts. "Keep talking. Please."

Catra laughs into Adora's throat. "Anything you want." She sinks her teeth into her skin, only releasing when Adora hisses a curse. "I would take my time with you. Make sure by the time I touch you, you're already soaked and shaking. But I wouldn't make you beg. It wouldn't matter. You know why?" Catra kisses her way up to Adora's chin, then uses her free hand to guide her head down so she can kiss her on the lips again. Their gazes meet. Catra's hooded eyes are shining mischievously, just like the crooked grin that appears on her face. "Because whether you begged for me or not, I would only make you come if I decided to."

Adora opens her mouth, but no sound comes out. If anything, that only seems to please Catra more because she finally, finally picks up the pace, and *fuck* —

Adora's cry fades into a desperate little whimper as she bites down on her lower lip, trying to stiffen some of the sounds that spill from her lips. It is to no avail. Blinding pleasure makes her jaw slack; her hips are moving on their own, fucking herself on the heel of Catra's palm.

Catra's fingers are back around her throat, guiding her head down so she can press a gentle kiss to the corner of Adora's open mouth.

"How do you want me, Adora?" Catra's hand crawls higher, focusing on Adora's clit with rough little circles of her fingertips, luring sounds from the back of Adora's throat that can only be described as desperate. "Do you like that?"

Adora nods again, squeaking something unintelligible. She feels herself starting to float out of her body, but she is still there, weak legs barely keeping her up, head so dizzy it's like her skull is stuffed with cotton candy.

"Do you want me on my knees for you?" Catra's words make Adora's blood rush into her ears, roaring like thunder. "I wish I could just bend you over and eat your pussy until you can't hold yourself up anymore. Or you could always pin me to the bed and fuck my face as hard as you want."

The noise Adora makes doesn't sound human. The world around her shrinks so much that nothing else can fit inside; just Catra. Catra's hands around her throat, moving between her thighs. Catra's lips sticking to Adora's cheek right next to her mouth, her breath and words warming her up. Catra's body pressed tightly to Adora's side, touching every inch of her she possibly could. Catra's voice burrowing under Adora's skin and nestling into her heart, weaving between her blood and bones.

"Tell me what you want, baby," Catra says, cupping Adora's jaw. "Let me give you everything."

Adora's breathing is just rhythmless panting by this time; she has no idea how she manages to speak when her hazy eyes meet Catra's again.

"Just don't"… Adora gulps for air, forcing the husky words out of her mouth. "Don't stop. Please don't sto– *ah*— "

Catra touches her mercilessly now. She knows exactly how to drive Adora mad, and she is not holding anything back; building pleasure hits Adora like rainfall, dripping down the small of her back, and she is absolutely certain that as soon as Catra is done with her, she is going to collapse.

"Close, aren't you?" Catra murmurs, striking eyes never leaving Adora's flushed face.

Adora hums, half-laughing and half-whining. She is going to snap at any moment now.

"So close," she says, her spine bowing off the door. "I'm so close, just don't stop now, please please please don't"—

Catra stops.

Adora crashes down from that sweet, sweet edge, every inch of her trembling. For a second, she doesn't even know where she is – and in the next, she is absolutely *livid* .

She can't imagine the look on her own face, but the way Catra's button nose scrunches up with a laugh, she knows she must let all her twisted rage show.

"What the fuck?" Adora asks, voice low and trembling. She doesn't care about being obedient anymore, dropping her hands by her body and balling them into fists.

Catra just keeps laughing. Adora catches a glimpse of shine as Catra raises her hand to her lips, licking Adora's pleasure from her fingers like it's a delicacy. It only makes Adora's blood boil more, threatening to catch the whole world aflame.

"Sorry , baby." Catra releases her fingers with a wet pop, tongue darting out to clean her lips. "We're out of time. Be a good girl and don't touch yourself until I can take care of you."

“Are you *serious?* ” There is no way Adora can control her voice now. Her body is thrumming with the feverish beat of her heart, and Catra has just kicked her straight from the gates of fucking heaven, and she just gets to stand there, looking absolutely adorable and heartwrenchingly hot while she is playing Adora like a fiddle? How’s that fair? “Are you fucking”— Catra rises to her tiptoes, pressing a silly, loud smack to Adora’s lips, “serious right now?”

Catra clings to the doorknob, flicking the lock open. She peeks back over her shoulder. A smirk hides in the way soft light gets caught in her beautiful eyes.

“Dead serious,” she says, and despite her playful features, she sounds like it. “Don't think I wouldnt know if you disobeyed. If youll be my good girl throughout the day, I promise you wont be able to stand after I reward you.”

And with that, Catra creaks the door open, and slithers out.

*

How Catra can act like nothing happened, Adora doesnt understand.

Adora is literally weak and giddy with a furious fever, and Catra is just standing there in front of her, calm and collected, born ready to reshoot their fight scene. The epitome of professionalism. There is nothing to read on her face, in her stance, even before Double Trouble calls action.

She is *such* a bitch.

Catra throws the first punch. Adora bends out of the way of Catra’s fist, trying to catch her eyes. Catra sees her death glare and, for a

second, it is almost like her mask slips off of her face; the corner of her lips twitch, fire blazing up in the darkness of her eyes.

Adora slams her hands on the ground a beat too soon, leg sweeping towards Catra. Her off-beat improv makes Catra stumble, her backflip wobbly. Smug satisfaction blooms in Adora's chest, breaking through the thick fog of fury like rays of sunlight.

Adora dashes at Catra, missing the next punch when Catra crouches. On her way to spring back, Catra pretends that her fist is colliding with Adora's jaw. As she stumbles backwards, Catra appears by her side and traps her in a tight headlock.

Adora snarls loud enough for the mics to pick up on it. She doesn't like this part at all; letting Catra win and be on top for even a second. She doesn't struggle much before she grabs Catra's narrow waist, pulling her over her shoulder.

Catra's unscripted yelp of surprise is like a taster of the reward Adora was promised. She knows she is a little more rough than she is supposed to be, but she can't help it; she is *so* fucking angry with Catra for pulling the orgasm denial card, she just can't express it in any other way without bursting into tears.

Adora tightens her grip on Catra's waist and slams her into the thick mattress with a bestial, growling yell she didn't even know she was capable of making.

"Cut!"

Catra's back is bouncing off of the mattress, the force of Adora's throw leaving her to fly above ground. Her eyes are round and glassy, her mouth agape as she huffs quick, heavy breaths.

Adora's chest is heaving, too. Her ears are ringing before a cheerful, drawling yell cuts through it.

"Bravo!" Adora peers up and catches Double Trouble sliding two slender fingers across the underside of their jaw. Their grin is all teeth. "Good job, ladies. This is *exactly* what I've been waiting for."

Adora takes another deep breath. Catra had pushed herself up to a sitting position, leaning on one arm behind her and throwing the other over her pulled up knee.

Catra shoots her a breathless grin and a quick wink.

Despite everything, Adora grins back.

*

Adora is yet to calm down.

She decides to grab a plate of food before she hangs up her bodyguard suit for the rest of the day, hoping it will ease her overstrung anger. With their fight scene finished and finally approved, there is only one scene left for Adora and Catra's story, scheduled early Wednesday morning.

Until then, Adora is free. And after that…

Adora is fighting with the aluminum plates that got stuck, all stacked on top of each other. Shaking them furiously, she manages to peel one up for herself and starts circling around the long tables like a bird of prey, trying to swallow the bile that scratches at her throat.

The night after tomorrow, Adora will pack her bags and drive home. She already has opportunities to take – well, texts about opportunities she still hasn't responded to – and life will go on. Her career will go on.

What will happen to Catra and her after the shooting is done? Would Catra want to keep hanging out with Adora's group like she did when she tagged along for the weekend? Will she be the new addition to their queer little circle, growing closer to not just Adora, but to Adora's friends as well? Will she text Adora? Will she call?

Will she even miss her?

Adora piles an ungodly amount of fruit on top of the bagel she had previously snatched from the table, and turns around with her wobbly masterpiece. She scans the room then, trying to find a familiar face.

It only takes her a couple seconds to spot a sandy blonde head. She makes a beeline for the table; her footsteps make Perfuma look up from her phone, a gentle smile stretching on her thin lips.

"Adora, hi! Come join me."

"Yep, I was just about to." Shit, her *blatantly ignored* needs are still making her snappy. She needs to get a hold of herself. She slides into the seat next to Perfuma's, and bangs her plate onto the table. Her voice is dripping sweet. "All alone?"

"Not anymore," Perfuma says, squinting at Adora kindly. She shakes her phone between her fingers. "I'm not actually working today. Scorpia just finished at MUAH and I thought I'd drop by to spend some time with her. *Hurry up and wait* is always better with company."

Adora hurries to swallow the multiple pineapple slices that she has shoved into her mouth so she can offer: "If you want me to go..."

"No, no." Perfuma wraps her slender fingers around Adora's wrist before she could move. "You don't have to go."

"Don't you wanna be alone with her? She's your girlfriend." Once again, Adora kinda pronounced *girlfriend* like she might make a bitter mockery out of Perfuma's relationship. In her current state, she's

lucky she found the only friend she has who refuses to show how ridiculously easy it is to vex her.

Perfuma shrugs, wearing a tight smile, and sweeps her hair behind her shoulder. "I'll have enough time to spend with her alone once we're not working 16 hours a day."

Right. After production wraps up for them all.

And *some* of them will get to live happily ever after with their dream girl, who probably doesn't decide to just stop touching them right before they could finally get the orgasm of their lifetime. O rejoice. Joy, sunshine, rainbows.

Adora swallows big, trying not to choke on fruit juice. "So have you like.talked about how you're gonna keep in touch?"

"Oh yeah, constantly." Perfuma chuckles, crossing her arms on the tabletop. "Actu ally, we found out that we only live fifteen minutes away from each other, so – I can't wait to take her to my home and see hers, too. I'm sure her home is just as cheerful and full of good vibes as she is."

Adora's scoff ends on a snort. She tries to hide it behind a fake cough.

She just can't stop thinking about how adorably disgusted Catra would look if she had heard "good vibes".

Perfuma's brows rise. "Are you alright?"

"Y eah, just.yeah. Swallowed funny . I'm cool. Fine."

Perfuma makes a face, but doesn't push it. Well, she doesn't push *this* topic. "What about Catra?"

Adora freezes with half a peach hanging out of her mouth. She sucks it in with rapid little movements of her mouth like a rabbit and wolfs it down so she can speak. "What about her?"

"*Well*," Perfuma pokes Adora's arm with her elbow. "Are you guys going to keep in touch, too?"

Adora glares at a slice of kiwi like it has killed her entire family.

"We're not girlfriends."

Perfuma just laughs, shaking her head. "No, silly, I mean… you keep in touch with your friends, right? Now she's your friend, just like me and Scorpia."

"Eeh," Adora puckers her lips.

Perfuma's voice grows higher.

"Scorpia is warming up to you! She was just… a little distant with you at first because you and Catra couldn't even stand each other back then."

Well, newsflash, Adora can't stand Catra Weaver right now either.

Heat is still throbbing between her legs, insistent and stubborn. Her whole body feels too warm, her skin too sensitive to the touch, to the buzzing light of the fluorescent lamps above her. It would be so easy to just lock herself in the trailer and rub one out. Or two. Whatever helps.

But no – Adora, being the biggest dumbass of all time, still wants to be good for Catra. She wants her praise, her proud smile, her reward, and yes, even her torture. Adora's cotton candy brain is still full of Catra like she is the only flavor she knows. She isn't even sure that she could come from a hand that isn't Catra's, even if it is her own. Even thinking about her wouldn't help now. No, that only helps when Catra is out of her reach, and Adora doesn't know how many months it is going to take to see her again. If she is ever going to see her again. Back then, every time they were together could have very well been the last, and Adora had grieved over and over again until she couldn't even count the cracks on her heart.

Is that how it’s going to feel again?

Adora crosses her legs under the table, thighs shut tight. “Can I ask you something?”

If Perfuma didnt take it well that Adora decided to ignore her qestion and change the subject, she doesnt show it. “Sure.”

“I have”… Adora chews on her lower lip while she tries to find her words. “There’ s this… there’s a girl.” She peeks up at Perfuma, who nods at her encouragingly. “How did you tell Scorpia?”

“That you have a girl?”

Adora narrows her eyes at Perfuma. She knows she isnt asking because she doesnt understand - she wants Adora to actually come out and say it.

Fine.

“That you wanted more from her.” Perfuma tilts her head. Shit. “That you have feelings for her.”

God, please let that be enough. Being this open makes Adora nauseous.

Perfuma hums in thought. She straightens her arms on the table, entwining her fingers and twisting her wrists.

“Well… it wasnt easy.” She chuckles to herself. “We barely knew each other, you know? I kind of just… gathered all my courage and asked her out one day."

“How did you know she'd feel the same?"

“I didn't." Perfuma makes a vague head gesture. “Not for certain. I just decided to go for it because… I figured it would be worth it. Even if she rejected me, I knew giving it a try with this girl would be more than worth it, you know? I owed it to her, to myself, to be honest. To

live my truth and not be afraid of what I want." She looks at Adora with a strange, amused smirk like Adora has just missed a joke. "Of course, it would have been easier if we had history."

"It would have?" Adora asks, unsure she can believe it.

"Having history is always easier. It just is. You already know each other well enough, so there are more clues to figuring out how the other person feels. Some people don't communicate with words, but by their actions. They tell you how they feel by how they act around you, what they give to you. They make you feel special, like you are all they care about in the whole world. They see you like no one else does."

Adora swallows, poking at the bagel that has become completely soggy and disgusting under all that fruit. "What if it's… bad history? Like really bad. ugly. history. Just the worst."

"Then they've seen the worst of you, and *still* chose you. Don't you see how wonderful that is?" Perfuma slips a hand onto Adora's shoulder, squeezing gently. "Adora, you've had three years of bad history with this girl, and she's still around, *and* giving you hope that this could be more. You have to believe that means something."

That. actually makes sense.

Huh. Wow.

Adora opens her mouth to thank Perfuma when a thought crosses her mind. She frowns, leaving her mouth agape. "Wait, I never told you how lon—"

"Hi, gang!" Scorpia yells right behind Adora, making her jump in her seat and hit her plate further towards the center of the table. "Oops, sorry buddy. Didn't mean to scare ya."

Adora grumbles something unintelligible while Perfuma springs to her feet to wrap Scorpia in a big, tight hug. Scorpia hugs her back,

lifting her off of the linoleum which leaves Perfuma giggling in delight.

When they share a quick kiss Adora turns away. She doesn't need to see that, and they definitely don't need to see what kind of face Adora makes when she sees anyone else but her getting the love that she's been craving.

Scorpia plops down into the chair in front of Adora, taking the seat on Perfuma's other side so she can hold her hand and play with her fingers on the table. "How's everyone? Whatcha talking about?"

"Girl trouble," Perfuma says at the same time Adora goes "the weather."

Adora narrows her eyes at Perfuma, who sucks her lips in and gives her guilty puppy eyes. "Yes, girl trouble… in this weather. You know… the, the rain." Adora blows a raspberry. "When a cloud gets her wetter than you do, right? Oh Jesus Christ." Adora hides her burning blush behind both palms, making a noise like a dying animal. "Please forget I've said anything, this is *obviously* not what we've been talking about."

"Ohh, is this about..y'know."

Scorpia doesn't say anything else, so Adora needs to peek through the cracks of her fingers to watch her make the strangest goddamn motions with her arms.

"What are you doing?"

"Baking!" Scorpia snaps in despair, massaging the air more vehemently. "I'm clearly baking!"

Adora matches her voice to Scorpia's. "Why the hell are you baking?"

"Cake Girl!" Scorpia drops her hands to the table, opening her palms so her fingertips all point towards Adora. "Is this about Cake Girl?"

It takes Adora a second to remember her horrendous analogy, and the way she had tipsily sobbed all her sorrows to Catra's best friend of all people. Her blush spreads further, her fingers raking down her face until they get caught on her jaw.

There's no escape now, is there?

"Yep," she sighs, defeated. "It's about her. I was just asking Perfuma what I should do abou"—

"Forget her," Scorpia cuts in loudly, eyes round like a madman's.

Adora drops her voice. "Wait, what?"

"Just forget her!" Scorpia huffs the words out as she laughs, fidgeting in her seat. "I mean— It's been way too long to get stuck in an impossible relationship, friend, it's time to just– just move on. Dont you think that if something was ever about to happen with her, it would have already happened?"

Adora casts her gaze downwards.

Shit. That makes sense, too. If Catra really wanted the same thing as Adora, she would have already made her move. Adora might be a coward, scared and confused, but Catra is nothing like her. Catra is bold and confident. She always tells it how it is, she doesnt take any bullshit, and she doesnt care what anyone else thinks about her.

If Catra wants something, she already has it. Anything Adora thought she saw in Catra's eyes, heard behind her soft words, it wasnt Catra's way of showing that she might feel the same way about Adora.

If Catra wants someone, she probably makes that perfectly clear. She has never been burdened with the devastating weight of failure

and rejection, unlike Adora.

Why would Adora ever think she was worth it?

"One new, right?" Scorpia's voice breaks through the thick mist of Adora's consciousness.

Adora blinks slowly, meeting Scorpia's still too round eyes. "Sorry, what?"

"Just a thought!" Scorpia says, holding up both hands.

"No, I mean." Adora leans her forehead on her palm, elbow slipping on the tabletop. "I didn't hear you, sorry."

"Hey, hey, keep your chin up." Scorpia leans into Adora's personal space over the table, tilting her head at her. "Love's out there for you, okay? Why don't you just start looking? Why don't you just leave Cake Girl alone and find someone who's closer to you, hm?"

The thought of Adora giving up Catra just to throw herself at some random new girl is honestly worse than five orgasm denials in a row.

Call her an idiot, but she just can't see herself being with anyone else. If she can't be with Catra, Adora is going to be alone for the rest of her life, and she is ready to make peace with that.

Adora leans back, and crosses her arms in front of her chest. "I– I don't know."

"Like, I don't know, this is just a thought, totally random, never crossed my mind before, how would you feel about someone you work with?"

Adora shrugs, pouting like a sulking child. She catches Scorpia glancing towards Perfuma pleadingly.

"I– I'm so confused," Perfuma admits softly, putting her palms together and lifting them to her lips. "I'm sorry, I thought I knew what

we were talking about, but"…

"We're just saying" Scorpia starts very slowly, urging Perfuma to agree with her, "that if you wanna give love a chance, you might find it *closer* than you think. Right?"

"Right," Perfuma says.

"Right," Adora says bitterly, throwing her head back. "So your advice is that I should just"… She snorts, barely believing she is saying this, "start dating someone on set right now?"

"Maybe, yes!" Scorpia is actually yelling at this point. Several heads turn towards her in the cafeteria, but she is completely unfazed by it. "I mean, it's not a bad idea!"

Apparently her enthusiasm is contagious, because Perfuma starts losing her indoor voice, too.

"It's not a bad idea at all!"

"You can start with someone from, like…mmm…the stunt group?"

"Or , or, someone who you have most of your scenes with."

"Yes! Or who you spend most of your time with, because you're *stuck together*."

Perfuma frowns. "I thought we didn't want Adora to get stuck with someone."

"Y-yes and no~~W~~e don't want Adora to get stuck with someone like Cake Girl, who doesn't have any feelings for her *at all*. If it's the other girl we are talking about, totally not thinking about anyone in particular, then yes, she should absolutely start there."

Perfuma raises her jaw, eyes sparkling. "Ohh, yes. That makes sense."

"If she were, I dunno, getting stuck with someone in a space that's, say, smaller than a house but bigger than a car… like, I don't know, a trailer, that would be"…

"That would be great!"

"That *would* be great!"

"Ideal."

Scorpia snaps her fingers at Perfuma, grinning so wide that her nose crinkles. "Ideal," she repeats, slamming the table with her fist. "Yes. Heard that, buddy?"

They both snap their heads towards Adora, watching her with expectant, bright eyes.

Adora wants to throw up.

"Okay , I have to go," she mumbles, rising from her chair and kicking it out behind her. She grabs her plate where the sad, soggy bagel is still swimming in fruit juice. "Thanks. For everything. Ill"… Her mouth twitches. "I'll think about what you said."

*

Adora is definitely not thinking about what they've said. And she did have enough time to think about it: several hours in the gym, trying to kill her burning arousal, then drowning it in the shower.

(Nothing helped.)

She knows Perfuma and Scorpia want to push her towards Catra, but what they dont know is that Catra is also Cake Girl. If they say "yes, absolutely go for it" when it's Catra, but are against it with all

their might when they know the *actual* story behind their relationship, that could only mean one thing.

If they knew everything, they never would have said that Adora has a chance.

Glimmer knew. She knew, and she said it was all Adora's fault that she still hasn't made a move that *worked* .

Adora opens the door to the trailer, keys jingling in her hand. Once inside, she drops her bag on the floor and bumps the back of her head against the closed door. Her eyes slide shut, a sigh escaping her.

Something touches her.

Adora yelps, grabbing the *things* that have sneaked up her shoulders: they are Catra's tiny hands.

"Well, hello to you, too," Catra says, amusement evident in her tone. Her eyes are gleaming playfully as she sweeps her gaze over Adora's body.

"Oh," Adora exhales, her whole body deflating. She releases Catra, dropping her hands by her sides to hang aimlessly and turns her head away. "Sorry ."

For a couple moments, Catra doesn't reply. Adora can hear the rustling of her clothes as Catra takes a couple steps back.

Adora is chasing her away again.

Her lungs start to burn.

"Hey ," Catra calls gently, the rasps in her voice comforting like creaking footsteps in fresh snow. "Are you okay?"

Adora hums, nodding her head.

"Adora." When she doesn't get a response, Catra's throat makes a strangled noise. "Look, I'm… I'm sorry…"

That makes Adora turn back towards her, just to stare.

"I didn't mean to be cruel. It wasn't supposed to be… ugh. I just wanted to tease you a little. We never have to do it again if you don't want to, and I realize I should have asked you first."

"Are you talking about?"

"What happened before the shoot." The shimmer in Catra's eyes is trembling as they get wetter. Catra blinks to chase them away, but they don't go anywhere; they just squeeze Adora's heart. "I… fuck, I'm sorry. I'm so sorry."

"Catra, no." Adora can't hold herself back anymore. She reaches out to take Catra's wrist, pulling her close. Catra comes willingly. "That's not it. It's okay. I'm sorry."

Catra laughs. It sounds just a touch wet. "What the fuck are *you* sorry for?"

"I don't know!" Adora snaps, but she is laughing, too. "For making you cry?"

"I'm not crying."

Adora scoffs kindly. She releases Catra's wrist just to slide her palms onto each side of Catra's neck, slithering under heavy curls.

"Alright, Miss Tough Bitch," she says, thumbs stroking behind Catra's ears.

Catra giggles again, finally sounding like herself. "Fuck you."

"I'd love that, actually."

Catra's eyes meet hers, and suddenly everything seems way less funny. Catra's hands come up, slender fingers curling around Adora's wrists. The way her thumbs stroke the sensitive skin above her veins makes Adora shiver from head to toe.

Before her brain is fully wrapped in a thick haze of lust again, Adora says: "It wasn't you. I mean it. I didn't actually mind the denial part. I know I was angry, but I"… Adora feels blood rushing up her neck. "I really, really liked it."

"Yeah?" Catra asks quietly. Her eyes are shining differently now; they are more striking. Sharper, as they watch the blush crawl higher on Adora's skin.

"Yeah." Adora presses a quick kiss to Catra's forehead. She draws back afterwards so she can get lost in those mismatched irises that make the words drip down her throat. "I like it when you're in complete control of me. I know you wouldn't do anything to me that I don't like. I trust you." Adora catches Catra swallowing big before glancing away for a second. It urges Adora to say more. Be more vulnerable. "It feels good that I can… I can turn my brain off when I'm with you. I can finally stop thinking. I know I'm safe to just *be*, even when you tease me. It's… it's almost like"… Adora takes a deep, ragged breath, forcing herself to not break eye contact. "It's almost like you like me as I am."

Catra's pretty lips part. Her tongue darts out to wet them, long lashes fluttering as her gaze drops to Adora's mouth. "I do like you as you are."

Before Adora could even comprehend what she just thought she heard (because there is no way Catra just said that), Catra rises to her tiptoes and kisses her.

Adora melts against Catra, so it is easy for her to usher Adora back to the wall of the trailer, and pin her again; this time, with the promise of giving Adora everything.

A flood of relief races through Adora’s veins. She was such an idiot before. Maybe other people dont believe that she should go for what she wants, but who cares what they think? Who cares if Glimmer thinks Adora messes everything up? Who cares if Scorpia thinks if something more was going to happen between them, it would have already happened?

They only know parts of their story. They know the surface, they know an old story that is no longer true. Adora told Scorpia about Catra when she thought Catra wanted to get back with her ex, before they even became friends, before they became… whatever they are now. Catra said she had told her everything, but that could mean anything in her book. And Glimmer - Glimmer was angry with Adora. She'd always said the cruelest things without thinking when she was mad or felt hopeless, hurting people without meaning to.

None of their opinions matter. Not now, when Catra’s soft tongue teases the seam of her lips, and her tiny hands have already unbuttoned Adora’s boyfriend jeans and let them pool at her ankles.

"Have you been a good girl for me?" Catra whispers with her lips on Adora’s, tongue caressing them open with a flick. "Did you behave?"

"Yes," Adora sighs, chasing after Catra's lips and pressing a firm kiss to them.

"Mm-hmm." Catra draws back with a pop, teeth sinking into her lower lip. "Let's see if you're telling the truth."

Catra's hand slips under the elastic of Adora’s boxer briefs.

Adora hisses; Catra’s fingers are ice cold, but warm up quickly to the throbbing heat she finds between her thighs. Fingertips glide through slick folds, and Catra echoes Adora’s quiet moan of pleasure.

"You were," Catra says, voice dripping with overjoyed pride. Her lips stroke along Adora’s strong cheekbone, leaving kisses in their wake.

"Such a good girl, you deserve your reward. Can I give it to you now? Would that be okay?"

Yes , Adora wants to say. What escapes from her throat is a broken *please* .

Catra kisses her again, her hand stroking Adora gently. The pleasure they lure out of every inch of Adora's body cocoons her with electric warmth, sweet and buzzing.

Catra didn't order her to keep her hands away this time, so Adora cups Catra's cheeks to keep her close as they kiss. Velvety curls are trapped between them, tickling Adora's knuckles, and Catra huffs into her mouth contentedly.

At Adora's touch, she presses even closer, kissing Adora like she is someone worth worshiping. Catra's mouth moves devotedly against hers, savoring every second like she'd never want to separate herself from Adora.

It burns something deep inside Adora's belly, erupting from her throat before sinking into muffled words. "Will you miss me?"

Catra pulls back just enough to respond, already breathless: "What?"

Adora kisses her. Her hands are roaming wildly over Catra's body, clinging to her wherever she can; pulling her close by her hips, grounding herself on sharp shoulders, resting on the soft swells of Catra's ass.

"Will you miss me?" She asks again, trying to ease the desperate break in her voice. Catra is still touching her, tender and persistent, and it is so hard to focus but Adora needs to know. "After we both leave...will you miss me?"

Catra's eyes are round when they meet Adora's, her pearl teeth flashing behind her lips.

“Have you ever missed me?” Adora chokes on her words, gasping between them when Catra starts touching her with more intent, as if that were her answer. “When— *mmh* ~~w~~hen we havent seen each other for months?”

Catra whines her name like it's a plea to stop. She hides in the crook of Adora's neck and bites down on her hard enough to leave a blooming bruise. Her hand finds the breathless rhythm that always works for Adora, her hips chasing friction for themselves on Adora's bare thigh.

Adora is going to fucking lose it. Her hand drops to Catra's hips, slithering under the loose cotton of Catra's shirt to touch dewy skin. With her other hand, she grabs a handful of Catra's wild hair at the base of her skull, tugging her back to meet her eyes. Catra releases her skin with a growl, sending a stinging pain through Adora's nerves. She is still fucking herself on Adora's thigh through her jeans, just as frantic and desperate as Adora feels.

"Tell me," Adora begs, swallowing her *please*. Her moans have chiseled all softness from her voice, and Catra's eyes darken dangerously.

When Catra's lips press bruisingly against hers again, Adora thinks she won't get an answer. She tries to accept it, kissing Catra back as messily as she is being kissed. Catra's hand adds more pressure between her thighs, and Adora breaks the kiss with a pathetic whine.

"I will," Catra rasps then, so quiet Adora can barely make it out over the drumming of her heart in her ears. Their noses brush when Catra kisses her briefly once, twice, clever fingers never stopping. Adora starts to get light headed again, pressure building in her chest like a balloon close to bursting. "I always have."

That's all it takes.

Adora feels her pleasure release, washing over her from her giddy head to her curling toes. All she can do is breathe in sharp gasps

and tighten her grip on Catra's body to ground herself somehow.

Her breathing is still ragged and uneven when Catra's circles slow down, but don't stop.

"I'm going to make you cum over and over again," Catra says, pressing her own flushed cheek to Adora's so she can whisper into her ear. "I'm going to fuck you until you cry. I'm going to put my mouth on you and show you how grateful I am for you being my good girl. Tell me if I can."

Adora whimpers. It's not enough.

"Color, baby," Catra kisses the spot right between Adora's thick brows. "Tell me your color."

Adora's grip tightens around Catra's hair, tugging her to her mouth again. She breathes her reply between graceless kisses she smears over Catra's lips. "Lime. Lime. Please fuck me again."

"I will keep going until you tell me you can't take it anymore," Catra reminds her. "If you can't talk, pinch me to stop. Okay?"

"Okay. Yes. Okay."

With the taste of her Chapstick still sticking to Adora's lips, Catra sinks out of sight, and brings Adora's briefs with her.

Fuck, did she mean right th—

Adora feels the tip of Catra's tongue dipping into her, and her knees knock together unconsciously. Catra is having none of it. With a quick kiss to the goosebumps peppering her thigh, Catra pries her legs open, leaving Adora no choice but to give up everything for her.

Adora's knees are trembling so hard the fear of falling crosses her mind before she loses grasp on her sensibility. Like a heavy, black veil has fallen between her and all she is terrified of, Adora's mind slips into a deep slumber, leaving only her senses awake.

And oh, all Adora senses is Catra; Catra around her, Catra below, Catra nestling inside her chest. Catra's soft tongue teasing her open, electricity crackling along her spine. Catra's hushed, vibrating whispers of encouragement and praise, siren songs of worship and devotion. Catra's hands under the curves of Adora's ass, kneading, scratching down her sensitive skin.

What is Adora so afraid of? She has already fallen.

Everything that is not Catra's tongue between her thighs evaporates into mist. That sweet, giving mouth is all Adora knows of the world, and it's grounding to keep her hand in Catra's untamed hair not to pull, just to feel.

Catra starts to follow a smooth, practiced pattern that leaves Adora's lungs burning. The gentle flicks of Catra's tongue takes her higher and higher, like a soft blow of air to a feather, and Adora is soaring.

She makes no sound when she comes. All she can hear over the ringing in her ears is how her back hits the wall, and her legs drop to the linoleum. Catra has taken all of her strength and Adora is only somewhat grasping the fact that she is now laying on the floor. One moment, Catra's hands are around her back and the nape of her neck, protecting her from hurting herself, and in the next, the wet pressure is back between her thighs, ravenous but gentle as ever.

It is absolutely blinding. Adora's whole trembling, dead-beat body is consumed by fire. Pain sweeps between waves of pleasure, sharp and maddening like a fresh wound bleeding. When she comes again, she tries to inhale but her lungs rattle without letting any gulps of air inside. Her face is wet, her core in piercing pain like the strain in her body would have started eating its way out.

Her hand drops to Catra's shoulder, and she pinches the skin under the collar of her shirt.

Catra lets up immediately, but the world keeps spinning. She draws back, letting the air cool Adora down, and crawls over her without

touching her at all. Adora's body is still twitching, her back arching off of the floor and her legs kicking out, occasionally brushing Catra, but she is too exhausted and far too gone to care.

Catra's murmured words are all that reach her, stroking Adora's soul. "There you go, baby. You're okay. It's okay. You did so good, you were so perfect."

Adora exhales with a raspy sob, only now realizing that she's been crying for a while; tears stream down her flushed face, pooling in her ears, fresh and dry paths curl all over her cheeks. When she licks at her chapped lips, all she tastes is salt.

"Shh, it's okay." Catra's voice is closer now, quietly rumbling still. "My handsome girl. God, you're perfect. You're so perfect, you're a fucking dream."

Adora's next sob is more like a scream, slicing her throat open like a knife. Her chest collapses, affection overflowing at Catra's words. She opens her eyes, trying to blink away the tears, but the world is dripping. Her hands come up from the floor, the backs of them bumping into Catra's *something*, and Adora hangs on for dear life.

Finally, Catra cups her teary cheeks. "Breathe, baby. You're okay. I'm here." She leans down, curls falling around Adora's face. She presses a kiss to Adora's forehead. "Can you stand?"

Adora makes a repining little noise, tears waning.

"You're gonna catch a cold on the floor," Catra chides, kissing her temple now. "Don't you wanna cuddle me in your soft, warm bed instead?"

That gets Adora's undivided attention. Whatever face she is making, Catra laughs at it, affectionately mocking.

"Come on."

Adora puts her palms on the floor, trying to find the strength that is still pouring out of her. She is a little shaky, but manages to sit up, tangled in the briefs and jeans caught around her ankles. She tries to kick and shake them off, grumbling when there is still no escape.

Catra mumbles something under her breath, chuckling to herself again. She lifts Adora's legs up, pulling her clothes and shoes off, and presses a little kiss to Adora's knee.

Adora finds enough strength in herself to respond; she leans in and captures Catra's lips in a sweet, closed-mouth kiss. When their lips pop apart, Catra presses them together briefly again.

"*Bed*," she says, assertive but not unkind.

Adora scrambles to her knees, hoping it would be easier to get up like that. As she lifts her head to stare towards her goal, something catches her eye; something that she has long since forgotten about. A cardboard box shoved under the lower bunk, which she had opened without permission and hid quickly when Catra almost caught her.

She has to come clean about that sooner than later, and she will. But right now…

With Catra's hands around hers, Adora stands. It takes nothing but a couple uncertain steps to reach her bed and plop down onto it with a hoarse sigh, her messy ponytail flooding her pillow. She sinks into her mattress like a warm bath, strained muscles easing up.

Catra crawls by her side, takes the edge of the blanket behind Adora and covers her up from the waist down where she is bare. Adora is not going to move to release the bit of blanket that she is laying on, so part of her thighs are not under it; without a fight, Catra slides closer and covers Adora's skin with her body.

They are laying silently, watching each other. Catra looks beautiful; otherworldly so with her shiny lips and cute baby hairs sticking to her

forehead, and she is so close that their noses are almost touching.

True to her word, Catra wraps Adora in her arms, squirming a little higher so Adora can tuck her head under her jaw. Catra starts stroking her hair slowly, patiently. Her fingertips sink between sweaty mops of Adora's hair, scratching her scalp, and she leans her head on top of Adora's.

Adora hugs her back, nuzzling even closer, and everything stills.

*

When Adora opens her eyes it's dusty blue outside, but Catra is still there.

"Evenin'," Catra whispers, stroking her fingertips down Adora's cheek as she lifts her head from her chest.

Adora hums happily before an anxious thought sails in. "Did I crush you?"

"A little," Catra admits, pulling her arm out from under Adora's shoulder and flicking her fingers. "How are you?"

Adora grimaces. "I'm sorry."

"Don't be," Catra says, leaving no room for carrying-on. "You okay?"

Adora hums again. She can't help the dopey grin that stretches on her lips. "*Okay* is kind of an understatement."

Catra looks proud, the rosy blush on her nose a little shy. "You need to hydrate," she says, moving to pull away.

Adora clings to her even tighter. "No."

"Yes, you do."

"No, I– yes, I know. I just"… Adora sniffs, not daring to finish her sentence. She doesnt have to.

"You are such a baby," Catra says, crinkling her nose. When she catches a glimpse of Adora's features, she quickly adds "I like it," sealed with a kiss. "And I promise I will come back to cuddle, but I dont want you to get a headache. Okay?"

Adora swallows. Fine. Her whole mouth is dry, from the roof of her mouth to her tongue that sticks to the inside of her cheek like a sponge. "Mkay."

Catra smiles and hops to her feet. She is still wearing all her everyday clothes. The shirt is wrinkled, her ripped jeans a little crooked. Adora hopes she wasn't feeling too uncomfortable laying down with her for god knows how long, especially with Adora crushing her.

As if Catra had heard her, she unbuttons her jeans and slides them down her legs. Her top is long enough to cover her up to the middle of her thigh, but Adora catches a glimpse of her bikini-cut underwear and the gorgeous, thick curls peeking out from behind it. On second glance, Adora notices a wet patch where the dark purple cotton has soaked completely black.

Her mouth is not so dry anymore.

Catra saunters back to bed with a huge glass of cold water in her hand, and Adora feels like she should just pour it on her head instead. Struggling into a sitting position, she thanks Catra, and lifts the glass to her lips. Her teeth clink against the rim, hands a little shaky.

"I'll be lucky if I recover before our last scene," Adora jokes weakly between gulps. Catra laughs anyway, plopping down next to her on the mattress. "You really did a number on me."

Catra pulls her legs up and crosses them. Their knees bump together.

"Oh? Is overstimulation not in your field of expertise?"

"You can say that." Adora puts the glass down on her leg and taps a rhythm on it with her nails. She avoids looking at Catra. "You… actually do a lot of things to me no one's ever done before. Things I never thought I'd be into."

Catra shifts. "Is that a good thing or a bad thing?"

Adora meets her eyes, catching the worried look that crosses her features. "A good thing," she hurries to add. "I told you, I trust you. I think I just mean… Im not as experienced as you are. I havent tried lots of the things you do to me, good things, things I really enjoy. I guess I usually have a pretty straightforward way of having sex, but with you… I dont fall into habits, I dont focus on following a routine, I just.am. Having fun."

Catra's brilliant smile is back. She bumps Adora's knee with her own again. "Well I am pretty fun to fuck, if nothing else."

"You are so much more."

Adora swallows her whimper. She feels like she crossed a line, especially with the way Catra's smile melts into parted lips, so she lifts the glass back to her lips and drinks the last couple gulps in one go.

She leans forward to knock the glass down the floor and dries her mouth with the back of her hand. While she is down, she notices The Box again, practically screaming "perfect transition."

"Speaking of," Adora starts, slipping off of the bed and bending down for her boxer briefs. "I, uh. I actually have to tell you something."

"Okay?"

Adora shimmies into her boxers, then crouches in front of her bed. She pulls the box out, rising to her feet. She clears her throat, hoping that the flames she feels all over her face are just from leaning over, and will soon fade away.

"I opened your package," Adora jabbers, like what she had done would be more acceptable if she confesses quickly. "I really, really didn't mean to, but it had no sender or recipient, or an address, or– or anything, really, and I didn't know what it was and when I went to open the door no one was there so I didn't even know if it was mail, or delivery service, and I'm so, so sorry." Adora sucks her lips in, brows tipped up, and pushes the box expectantly towards Catra. "I'm sorry."

Catra is staring at her like Adora has grown a second head.

"I didn't order anything."

"What?"

"I didn't order anything. Why did you think it was mine?"

Adora laughs. She sounds just a little frantic. "Well it's definitely not mine, I'll tell you that much."

"What the fuck does that even mean?" Catra asks, rising to her feet as well. Adora's blabbering didn't only confuse her, but must've raised a little anger as well.

Adora really can't blame her.

"Can you just–just take it, okay?"

Catra snatches the package from Adora's hands and drops it down onto the small dining table. She keeps staring at Adora, not watching what she is doing as she rips the top of the cardboard box to shreds.

Once she is done, Catra haltingly looks away, peeking inside, and then–

Her whole face grows pale before a rising fury calls for her blood again, and her features grow stiff. Adora can practically see her vibrating with anger. "Fucking asshole," she snaps, slapping the nearest chair with the back of her hand.

The legs of the chair fly up, then hit the linoleum with a hollow knock. It echoes in the silence of the room.

Catra looks like she might burst into tears at any moment. It makes Adora's chest ache.

"Do you know who it's from?" Adora asks carefully.

"I—" Catra's eyes grow round when they find hers for just a second, her chin wobbly. She hugs herself, nails sinking into her elbows. "Y-yeah. It's.it's a stupid gag gift. Don't worry about it, okay?"

Catra looks so small, and Adora doesn't know what to say.

When Adora doesn't know what to say, her mouth tends to say things regardless of her brain's contribution. "They're pretty useful for a gag gift."

Catra's eyes widen even more, rings of her irises fully visible. Adora watches Catra's pretty lips pop open with growing hunger, her stomach churning.

Catra says nothing, just stares at her with so much intensity Adora feels its weight inside her chest. At least it looks like she has calmed down; from Adora's words, she's found a new way to feel hot in her face.

But she is still not saying anything.

Fuck.

Does Adora have to?.. Okay. God, this would be so much easier if Catra was wearing anything more than her underwear and a shirt. Okay.

"Do you… um… would you, like"… Why is it so hot in here? "Is it something you would…hypothetically , I mean"…

"You wanna try them?"

Oh thank fuck .

Adora's cheeks are burning, but her voice has gained strength. "Y— yes. Yes, I do. I really do. But only if you want it, too."

Catra hums, like she'd have to think about it, but Adora knows what those hooded eyes mean. Her gaze lingers on Adora's body, then on the content of the box, then Adora again. There is the tiniest dimple in her cheek as she smirks, perfect brows raising.

"Have you been thinking about this?" Catra asks, her tone sultry-sweet.

There is no use lying now, is there?

"I have."

"How long?" She walks back to Adora and stretches her arms so she can cling to the bed frame on either side of Adora, caging her in. The back of Adora's head knocks into Catra's bunk, her breath stuttering. "Were you thinking about it when I told you to wait for me? Even longer?" The sharp gleam in Catra's eyes cuts Adora's chest open. Her next word is just a breathy laugh. "What? Cat got your tongue?"

"Since I opened it," Adora blurts out, shoulders slumping. "When you came home with the bags you brought for the weekend, I panicked because that's all I could think about."

"I remember that," Catra says thoughtfully, tilting her head. Her sharp canines sink into her lower lip as she grins up at Adora. "You were so weird. I cant believe you were just horny ."

Something breaks in Adora at the joke, leaving her laughing. "Shut up. It's not easy to stir up casual conversation when all you can think

about is”—

Adora bites back her words at the right time, but Catra is not having it. She leans closer, hot breath whispering across Adora’s lips.

“Is. What?”

“Fucking you deep while you keep me on a leash.”

Catra pupils bloom right in front of Adora’s eyes, like two dark flowers. She licks her lips, the motion itself captivating, and drops her hands to free Adora. When she takes a step back too, Adora knows that teasing is over - this is now a real conversation, and it’s wild, and unthinkable, but Catra might actually be willing to make her wish come true.

Catra is edging her with every second she is not saying yes outright, and it makes Adora’s head spin again.

“You want to wear them both?”

“I thought that would be best,” Adora shrugs like this is just something casual that crossed her mind, and not the outcome of several sleepless nights where she imagined scenario after scenario with Catra starring in her fantasies. “You know my boundaries about penetration, and I’ve worn a strap before, so it’s nothing new. And I really don’t mind the collar, or submitting myself to you. I didn’t think it would be something you’re into, giving up control like that. And I would never ask you to.”

Catra sucks her lips in. Something Adora cannot name flashes through her features, a little sorrow and solemnity that dims her smirk. It only takes a second for her smile to recover like nothing happened, and she jauntily says:

“Okay.”

Adora almost chokes on her spit. “Okay?”

"Okay . We can do that. Tomorrow?" Catra asks like they are just discussing a work lunch. She walks back to the box, toys clattering as she reaches in. She pulls out the collar and the short leather leash clasped to it; the leash is hanging from her curled index finger, the collar open, spinning in slow circles, and Adora is staring at the changing of the material like it is hypnotizing her. Fur, leather, fur, leather.

Catra laughs. "Adora?"

"Y -yeah. Yes. Tomorrow. Sounds good. Tomorrow sounds good."

"Good," Catra repeats, pleased, and fiddles with the collar. "You said you've used a strap-on before, but have you ever worn a collar?"

Adora shakes her head. "Not yet. Just...not opposed to it. At all."

"Still," Catra purrs, squinting like this was the response she was hoping for. "If you've never worn it before, I can't just put it on you when we do it. I want you to be a little familiar with it, to know exactly what feels good and what's uncomfortable."

Adora holds her breath.

"I really think we should practice."

Fuck . Adora can't believe this is all it took; her toes curl into the floor, her fingertips tingling with anticipation. As arousal crawls back into her core, the throbbing shifts into borderline agony again - as much as it kills her, there is no way she can take more right now.

"Not like that, dummy. Don't worry," Catra says, easily reading everything from Adora's face. "I was thinking more like… we could wash up, put on some comfy clothes, have a nice little dinner, and *then…*" She comes closer, slipping the collar around Adora's neck without buckling it. "We can see how much you can take. Fully clothed, completely innocent, just so I won't accidentally hurt you tomorrow. How does that sound?"

"Perfect," Adora sighs, beaming down at Catra. "It sounds perfect."

She tilts her head and captures Catra's lips before she realizes that *casual kissing* has never been on the table.

Catra moans in surprise. It only takes her a second to recover, kissing Adora back and wrapping her arms around Adora's neck to pull her close.

Thankfully, she has forgotten, too.

HEY ALL, THIS IS NOT PART 1 OF CHAPTER 12 SINCE IT'S LONGER THAN SHIT, I DECIDED TO GIVE YOU TWO BOOKS.

PART 2 WILL BE POSTED HERE I WILL EDIT THIS CHAPTER FOR THE LINK FOR THOSE WHO HAVE SUBBED TO THE STORY, BUT THAT WILL BE DELETED LATER.

THANK YOU x

Chapter End Notes

God I hope you enjoyed reading as much as I enjoyed working on this, I love this stupid story and these stupid lesbians. Thank you so fucking much for all the support, kudos and comments and bookmarks, they make my entire life.

Since last time, we have playlists yay. Check them out on Spotify:
Catradora
Adora
Catra
Double Trouble

Come hang out with me on Twitter and Tumblr, I'm usually nice.

End Notes

Hello and welcome to another modern AU. :'D If you're new around here, welcome, if you're not new around here, hi friend! Thank you all for joining me on this, I truly hope you've liked the first chapter of breaking we're-only-having-sex rules, horrible puns, ridiculous banter, insane denial, and much more. Please leave me a comment if you do, I love hearing from you and it makes my day and inspires me a bunch.

I love you all, stay safe, and cool, and come hang out with me on Tumblr or Twitter it's a fun time and I love talking to you. ♡

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